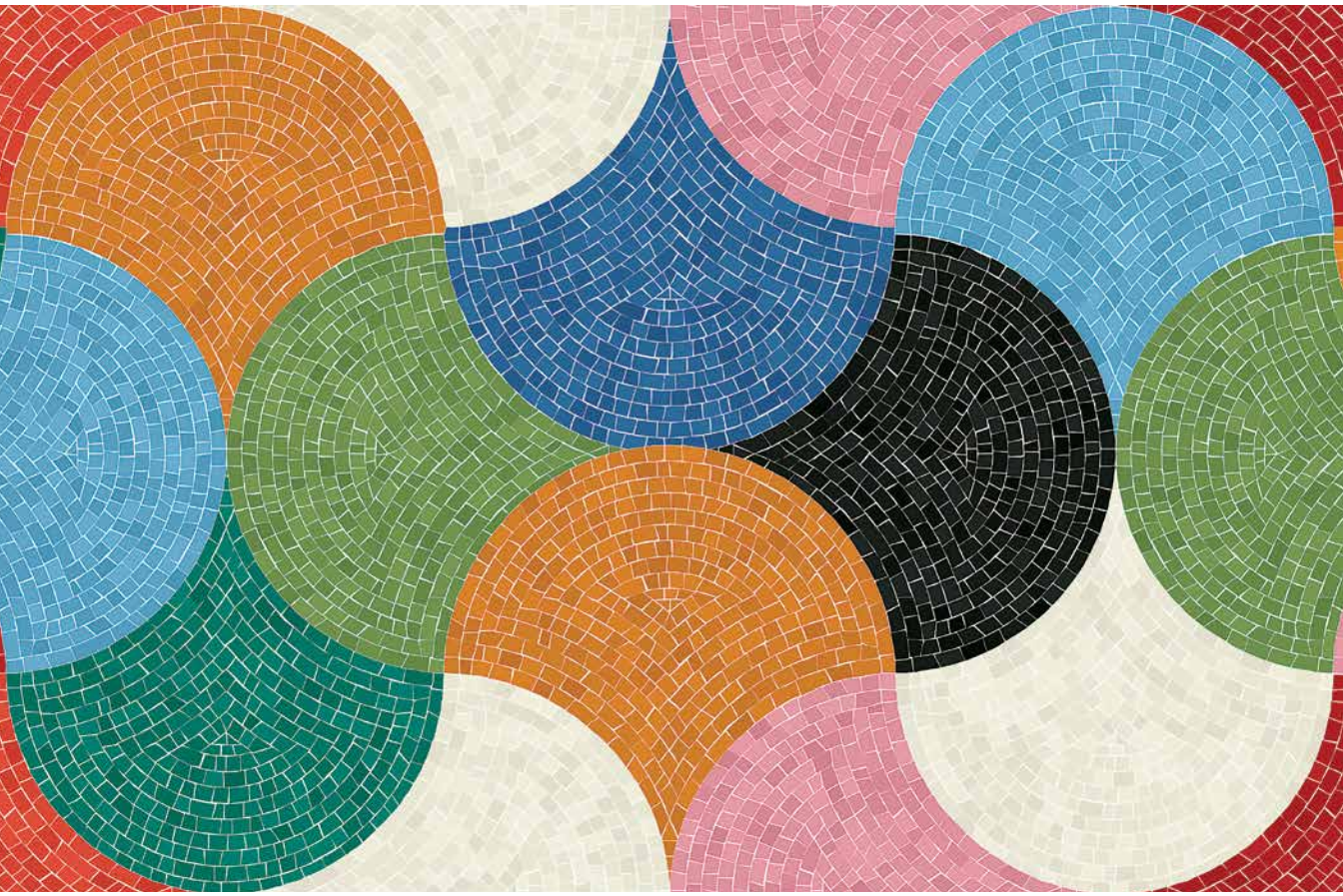
edited by **Annie Bélanger, Jennifer A. DeVito,**
and **John J. Meier**



INCLUSIVE LEADERSHIP

in Academic Libraries



Inclusive Leadership in Academic Libraries

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ISBNs
9798892553346 (paper)
9798892553353 (PDF)

Library of Congress Control Number on file.

Cover design by Alejandra Diaz. Text design and typesetting by Karen Sheets Design in the Minion and Proxima Nova typefaces.

♾ This paper meets the requirements of ANSI/NISO Z39.48-1992 (Permanence of Paper).

Printed in the United States of America
30 29 28 27 26 5 4 3 2 1

Inclusive Leadership in Academic Libraries

Edited by
Annie Bélanger, Jennifer A. DeVito, and John J. Meier

Association of College and Research Libraries
A division of the American Library Association
Chicago, Illinois 2026

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Preface

We, the editors, first came together as members of the Inclusive Leadership Subcommittee of the New Roles for a Changing Landscape (NRCL) committee in the Association of College and Research Libraries (ACRL). Promoting inclusive environments in libraries, both for users and for employees, is an important component of the mission of the NRCL committee. To begin our exploration, we partnered with undergraduate students to create a bibliography about inclusive leadership, in and outside of libraries.[1] Following this process, our group drafted a definition for "inclusive leadership" inspired by the Center of Creative Leadership:

> Inclusive library leaders are individuals who are aware of their own biases, actively seek out and consider different perspectives to inform their decision-making, collaborate more effectively with others through cultural competency, and center empathy and compassion in their approach to leadership.

Developing skills in inclusive leadership is one step toward fostering workspaces that are diverse and equitable. We acknowledge that libraries are evolving and, as such, so are library leaders, both formal and informal. Inclusive leadership incorporates empathy and the knowledge that one person does not hold all the answers to encourage openness and communication. Inclusive leaders acknowledge that every person brings different perspectives and skills to the workplace. It further articulates that leaders exist at all levels and demonstrate their leadership through behaviors and actions.

In order to introduce this concept to ACRL membership, we held a webinar inviting four academic library leaders to react to the definition and share some of their professional experiences. We also invited feedback on the definition and bibliography from all ACRL members for a two-month period in early 2023.[2] Through this process, we discovered a wealth of knowledge and diverse lived experiences in libraries that needed to be surfaced and shared with the profession. We considered first publishing an ACRL library guide, acting as a toolkit, before deciding on an edited volume where we could invite stories and expertise from across the field.

Our Process

In creating an edited volume, our intention was to collect the current understanding of inclusive leadership in academic libraries and share lived experiences of library professionals.

We wanted this volume to explore the different themes contained in the ACRL definition of inclusive library leadership as well as the application of these themes to practice and lived experience. This volume brings together the theory and the practice of inclusive leadership.

As a way to model inclusive leadership in the editing of this book, we contacted some leaders in the field of inclusive leadership to write chapters and put out a call for proposals for case studies. For each, we prioritized diverse voices, including offering editorial support for newer authors. Each author was encouraged to include a brief statement describing their positionality to help the reader understand the lens through which the piece was written. We also asked authors to include specific examples of tools or techniques that you can use as a leader in whatever context you find yourself. This volume contains perspectives from library professionals and college students from across the country and Canada.

The book is organized into three sections: Setting the Stage, Concepts and Practices, and Living into Inclusive Leadership. The first section is composed of chapters only. In the second and third sections, we have paired each chapter with case studies that exemplify the main theme(s) it covered. Here is an overview of the volume's structure to help you navigate the content.

Part 1

Part 1—Setting the Stage introduces inclusive leadership along with frameworks to contextualize later chapters.

- Jolie O. Graybill and John J. Meier start by discussing why inclusive leadership is important to libraries.
- Thomas L. Dickens follows with an overview of the six signature traits of inclusive leadership through a lens of racial equity.
- The last introductory chapter comes from Christina Fuller-Gregory and Mark A. Puente, who talk about the ACRL, Association of Research Libraries (ARL), American Library Association (ALA), and Public Library Association (PLA) joint Cultural Proficiencies in Racial Equity (CPRE) framework.

Part 2

Part 2—Concepts and Practices covers themes from the definition.

- Annie Pho's chapter examines incorporating compassion, care, and empathy into one's leadership practice, using the lens of feminism, critical librarianship, and critical race theory. Veronica Arellano Douglas and Mea Warren's case study shows this in practice as they explain how an inclusive leadership approach was used at the University of Houston Libraries to create a Teaching & Learning department.

- Peter Anderson talks about Emotional Intelligence. He explores the underlying concepts as well as ways to develop and grow emotional intelligence skills. Boutsaba Janetvilay shows many examples of these concepts and of active growth.
- Robyn Andrews and Jennifer A. DeVito explore the connection between humility, inquiry, and inclusive leadership, while Michelle Hendley's case study demonstrates how communication and collaboration facilitated a successful migration project.
- Continuing the theme of communication, Meghan Musolff and Jeff Witt's chapter discusses how professional and organizational values can be utilized in communication to strengthen inclusivity. Jermal Alleyne Jones presents a case study that highlights the importance of conversation and communication in the workplace to create shared approaches toward living a value of inclusion.
- Ken Irwin and Elizabeth Kerr take a holistic approach to inclusive leadership with their chapter on systems thinking. Combined with Jen Froetschel and Peter Cohn's case study that re-envisions the academic search process, the pairing demonstrates the systemic impact that inclusive leadership can have.
- In their chapter "Collaboration, Engagement, and Decision-Making: A Path to Compassionate Relationships and Empowerment," Vanessa Seals and Annie Bélanger discuss the role collaboration and engagement have in inclusive leadership, showcasing tools and framework. Regina M. Beard provides a real-life example of how a self-described "late-career librarian" adopts inclusive leadership into their practice.
- Shannon D. Jones closes out the section on concepts and theories with her chapter on compassionate care in the workplace. Lisa Kallman Hopkins, Dawn M. Harris, and Bridgit McCafferty showcase how empathy and compassion can be employed in the workplace, and Gricel Dominguez discusses reflective practice as a way to support an empathic and compassionate work environment.

Part 3

Part 3—Living into Inclusive Leadership has authors writing about putting inclusive leadership into practice and providing examples of how it has been done in various academic libraries.

- Elizabeth L. Wallis' chapter explores cultural humility and continued learning as components of inclusive leadership, while Russell Michalak showcases a case study in inclusive leadership through onboarding student workers.
- Aisha M. Johnson, Shaundra Walker, Tamika Barnes, and Tina D. Rollins provide an intersectional overview of inclusive leadership as black women leaders in libraries through their chapter. Through their case study, Elise Ferer, Sharon Bunch-Nuñez, and Richie Sebuharara examine aspects of inclusive leadership effective in working with student employees.

- Lorin Jackson reminds us of the importance of self-care and reflection in the practice of inclusive leadership. Tatiana Usova emphasizes community-building with her case study on reciprocal mentoring. Courtney L. Young and Martin L. Garnar close out the book with a dialogue-style case study about their experience in library leadership roles at liberal arts institutions.

We hope that you will find this book useful for your leadership practice. We invite you to dive deeply into the concept of inclusive leadership by exploring the variety of frameworks and concepts. We encourage you to integrate aspects that resonate into your ongoing leadership development and explorations.

Annie Bélanger, Jennifer A. DeVito, and John J. Meier
April 2025

Notes

1. Annie Bélanger, Jennifer A. DeVito, John Meier, Bruna Ngassa, Christina Prucha, and Morgan Taulbee, "ACRL Inclusive Leadership Annotated Bibliography," ACRL New Roles and Changing Landscapes Committee, Inclusive Leadership Subcommittee (updated January 4, 2023), https://scholarworks.gvsu.edu/library_reports/33.
2. Annie Bélanger, Maisha Carey, Jolie O. Graybill, and Elaine Westbrooks, "ACRL Presents: Inclusive Leadership" (webinar, ACRL, Chicago, IL, February 7, 2023), https://acrl.ala.org/acrlinsider/acrl-presents-inclusive-leadership/.

PART 1

Setting the Stage

CHAPTER 1

Why Is Inclusive Leadership Important?

Jolie O. Graybill and John J. Meier

"Inclusive library leaders are individuals who are aware of their own biases, actively seek out and consider different perspectives to inform their decision-making, collaborate more effectively with others through cultural competency, and center empathy and compassion in their approach to leadership." —ACRL Definition of Inclusive Leadership[1]

Introduction

Libraries are forever in a state of change and evolution. We are affected by social movements, cultural norms, political climate, and economic forces. The pace of change is increasing with each passing year, causing shifts in both our communities and our work. In this context, library leaders must find a sustainable path forward for themselves and the organizations they steward. We believe that inclusive leadership encompasses many of the most effective techniques of self and organizational management while also holding true to our values as library workers.

The landscape of the library workforce is changing through shifts in the nature of our work, the career paths of our employees, and the varied identities they bring to our organizations. The demographics of the USA are changing at an increasingly rapid pace, affecting libraries in very different ways, depending on their geography and history. While many historically marginalized groups are underrepresented in the library field, the identities represented among our coworkers are increasingly diverse. The expectations of the most recent arrivals to the job market are significantly different than the previous generations. Partly due to the COVID-19 pandemic, the prevalence of remote work expectations and the importance of employee wellness have increased. While inclusive leadership will be important in all professions over the coming years, we will focus on our context: academic libraries.

As you read through this book, think about your own lived experiences and reflect on what has supported your success as an employee and as a leader. As humans, we model our leadership behaviors on the different types of management and supervision we have experienced in our lives. We have also reflected on our journeys.

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Positionality Statements

Jolie

Jolie is a white, Native American (Wyandotte Nation), cisgendered woman. As dean of libraries at a mid-size research university, Jolie acknowledges the positional power and advantages that come with that role in the typical, predominantly white culture.

John

John is a white, cisgendered, temporarily abled man. He is in a heterosexual marriage with a blended family of three children. As a tenured department head at a large research university, John acknowledges his positional power as well as the advantages white supremacy culture afforded him. What does inclusive leadership mean to me?

Jolie

My lived work experience included three different careers: art direction, university extension work in the 4-H arena, and academic libraries. The two earlier careers—art direction and university extension work—informed the direction I've set for myself in academic libraries. Specifically, I experienced several versions of bad or ineffective leadership in these earlier careers. When I started in my library program, I knew why it was academic libraries for me, I knew why I was focused on library leadership, and I knew why inclusive leadership, although it wasn't named inclusive leadership at the time, was important to me.

John

I have been on a path to leadership for over a decade, but one moment in that journey changed my perspective significantly. After completing the Intercultural Development Inventory, I was confronted with evidence that I was not as far along the spectrum of cultural understanding as I assumed. This was an enlightening experience, and I carry it with me as a reminder to be humble, listen, and ask questions.

Why Inclusive Leadership? Why Now?

Now is always the right time for change and for bending the arc of history toward justice. Compassion and empathy have been shown to be more important than efficiency; equity is more effective than equality. People have been asking for leaders with these characteristics for a long time, but the COVID-19 pandemic really highlighted the importance of inclusive leadership. When leaders who don't use inclusive practices were confronted with the need to

adapt during the worst days of the pandemic, it was much more difficult for them and their organizations to move in a new direction

There are so many people involved in our libraries, coming from so many more places, and this important work can help us to make our organizations the best they can be. It is also important to create a culture of shared ownership with our coworkers by identifying and utilizing the strengths of all members of the organization. Everyone brings different strengths that they've developed on their own paths and lived experiences. Knowing, understanding, and identifying members' strengths and how they can impact, propel, contribute, and relate to the identified organizational goals is crucial.

Organizational culture change is the goal. While we start with self-awareness and encourage self-care, inclusive leadership is ultimately about how you, as the leader, use your positional power to affect your organization and employees. Even something as "small" as nonverbals or how you handle brief interactions can set the tone for an entire organization. Say "hi" to people every day, talk to everyone regardless of their job or status in the organization, and be vulnerable with your own challenges and failures.

Leading Self

Before you can lead others effectively, it is important to understand yourself more fully. Inclusive leadership spans self-awareness, professional development, and intentional action. Inclusive leaders cultivate awareness of their own history and positionality in society and organizations. We include a few tools at the end of this chapter that can help with introspection and self-assessment, particularly in the areas of equity and leadership. Inclusive leadership can also be an approach that integrates with multiple leadership styles. As a library leader, you may embrace both a visionary leadership approach and cultural humility. These are practices that can intertwine. Think about your own values and your leadership vision as you reflect on how you can integrate inclusive leadership approaches.

Leading Others

Inclusive leaders lean in with curiosity toward understanding other identities, cultures, and lived experiences. They get proximate to the challenges of historic injustices and toxic workplace culture. It can be uncomfortable work, but those with positional power can affect positive change for the greater good. Who else can modify a biased hiring process? Which de facto process keeps differing viewpoints out of an organization? When systemic problems persist, those with a holistic view of the library should be able and willing to disrupt systems of oppression.

The myth of the individual leader who can solve all an organization's problems hurts both libraries and their administrators. Effective leaders inform their decision-making through multiple perspectives, and the more diverse individuals a leader surrounds themselves with, the more viewpoints they have considered. This approach also builds critical buy-in for those

decisions to be implemented rather than trying to force through changes that will face resistance, either explicit or passive.

Leading through inclusion can create an environment where you get the best of everyone, prevent burnout, and improve both recruitment and retention. Many people often try to change their organizational culture through recruitment, but without a welcoming workplace, those new hires will simply leave. Belonging is a term to describe the feeling a student or employee has, which allows them to learn and work without the cognitive load of feeling unwelcome. This can manifest in avoidance, imposter syndrome, and other negative experiences that cumulatively become an exclusionary environment. Instead, through inclusive leadership practices, we can create libraries of belonging and a culture of caring.

Creating an Organizational Culture of Care

Humility and empathy are important to leadership and the ability to understand and share the feelings of others. To be an effective, inclusive leader, you should try to understand the reactions and feelings of others as if you were in their situation. Each person's lived experiences and context are important influences that affect interactions and approaches to work. Cultural competency training and other self-education can improve empathy and understanding. Decisions should be made considering the disparate impacts on both employees and patrons.

As an inclusive leader, you should do what is best for the entire organization, not just what is best for you. Past leadership "wisdom" put a primacy on the leader; they were at the top, so they were considered the most important. Approaching leadership with a sense of humility, through an inclusive lens, shifts that balance to what is best for the whole organization—meaning every person within the organization. Inclusive leaders should look at how they can have an impact on the entire organization and the effects of their actions. If you want employees to perform at the highest level, they need to feel valued, welcomed, and that their viewpoints are considered in each situation.

Effective communication is one of the best ways to discover and connect with your employees. It is important to talk with folks throughout your organization, cutting across organizational hierarchies. When you make it a habit to talk with everyone, putting in the hard but important work to learn about your colleagues and their lived experiences, you build the foundation for a culture of care in the organization. As leaders, in whatever capacity, you set an example for others in your organization. People see what you do and hear what you say, and it impacts not only that interaction but also builds or erodes the organizational culture.

It is important to have a growth mindset toward your own leadership skills and training. Creating a purposeful plan for professional development will help you focus on your areas of most need while also balancing and timing opportunities to reach specific goals.[2] Many librarians focus on training to attain a management position yet get bogged down in the day-to-day grind after promotion. It is as important, if not more, to continuously identify improvements

and knowledge gaps that would benefit from lifelong learning. An inclusive leader will regularly reflect on their cultural understanding and current management best practices to better connect with their employees and communities.

Literature Review

Leaders can have an incredible impact on the morale of library employees, setting an example through effective or toxic leadership. Academic librarians most often leave their current employers due to dissatisfaction with the library's leadership or negative experiences with their supervisors.[3] To reduce burnout and improve retention, we should act with transparency whenever possible, empower employees, and support them on a career path within our organizations.[4] We must act to dismantle systems of oppression in our organizations. Black, Indigenous, and people of color (BIPOC) in libraries are disproportionately affected by these inequitable systems, are more frequently the target of discrimination,[5] and are more susceptible to burnout and departure. Inclusive leadership therefore strikes directly at the most problematic organizational and personnel issues facing academic libraries today.

Inclusive leadership is both a unique and critical skill that leaders can employ to grow the organization's ideas and diverse talent pool. Most organizations have performance as a marker of success. The route to increased performance hinges on not only employees feeling included but also receiving fair treatment and respect. Another big motivator for employees is the narrative and behavior of their current leader. A leader's words and actions can matter, motivate, and make employees feel included. With that groundwork in place, employees are more likely to participate, collaborate, and volunteer. These all positively impact organizational performance.

Research from the *Harvard Business Review* found that six traits were shared by leaders who practiced inclusive leadership:

- **Visible commitment.** Leaders demonstrate an authentic commitment to diversity while challenging the status quo, holding others accountable, and making diversity and inclusion a personal priority.
- **Humility.** Leaders are modest about their capabilities, admit mistakes, and create space for others' contributions.
- **Awareness of bias.** Leaders show awareness of personal blind spots and system flaws, and they work hard to support and ensure a meritocracy.
- **Curiosity about others.** Leaders demonstrate an open mindset and curiosity about others, listen without judgment, and use empathy to understand others.
- **Cultural intelligence.** Leaders are attentive to others' cultures and adapt as needed.
- **Effective collaboration.** Leaders empower others and pay attention to diverse thinking and psychological safety while focusing on team cohesion.

DEI needs to be visible and both a personal priority and an organizational priority. "A leader's awareness of personal and organizational biases is the number one factor that raters care most about."[6] It was most significant when coupled with humility and empathy. Using these approaches dramatically increased feelings of inclusion. In the HBR article, the 360-degree review tool discussed in this article was able to demonstrate that a leader's awareness of personal and organizational biases is the most important factor identified in the feedback.

Being your authentic self does not mean you shouldn't take input from others to identify your habits or "blind spots." Sometimes you can get this from one-to-one conversations or colleagues who help identify your strengths and weaknesses. The perceptions of others are usually different than the self-reflection, and it can be much easier for them to see. It is hard to observe yourself in an objective way. It can be helpful to develop a diverse, personal advisory board—a trusted group who will be honest and "talk straight" to you on personal behavior. This can be outside of your organization, which might be better since you have no positional power over them, or it could even be your family or a non-library network of colleagues.

Here are some self-reflection tools to support personal growth:

- **Harvard Implicit Bias Test.** This self-assessment is often one of the first recommended for revealing implicit, unconscious bias. Often, the most difficult initial barrier to understanding the biases we have is denying their existence. We can learn about our blind spots and assumptions, which can inform how we approach learning with humility. There are multiple tests based on bias toward ethnicity, race, gender, disability, and many other topics. Each is free and only takes about ten minutes to complete. https://implicit.harvard.edu/implicit/takeatest.html.
- **Intercultural Development Inventory.** This self-assessment on intercultural competence is not freely available, but many colleges and universities have purchased the service. It takes about fifteen to twenty minutes to answer the fifty-item questionnaire. The results are shared with the individual in the form of a report that shows an estimate of where they are on the continuum of intercultural competency: denial, polarization, minimization, acceptance, and adaptation. For large enough groups, a qualified administrator of the instrument can lead a discussion of how to interpret and make a plan based on the results. https://www.idiinventory.com/.
- **Emotional Intelligence (TalentSmartEQ).** To center empathy and compassion as an inclusive leader, it is important to understand your emotional reactions and those of others. This self-assessment gauges the different aspects of your emotional intelligence, which is the ability to perceive, express, and regulate emotions. The four skills this test measures are self-awareness, self-management, social awareness, and relationship management. This particular test is restricted to those who have purchased the corresponding book. The test consists of twenty-eight questions and takes about ten minutes to complete. The resulting report gives you focus areas to work on, such as active listening and reading the room. https://www.talentsmarteq.com/.

Team-based Tools that the Reader Can Use to Support Growth in Their Team

- **DiSC** is a personal assessment profile tool designed to help improve teamwork, communication, culture, personal development, and productivity using four main personality profiles of dominance, influence, steadiness, and conscientiousness. An important outcome of this tool is that it helps coworkers understand each other better while developing an understanding of one's personal work styles in comparison to team members' work styles. https://www.discprofile.com/what-is-disc/disc-styles/.
- **The 360 Evaluation** is an assessment tool that pools in-depth feedback by gathering input from an individual's direct reports, peers, and manager(s) using a confidential, anonymous process. This gives the team members the opportunity to gain insight or build self-knowledge from how other team members from different levels (and those who work around them) view their work interactions, strengths, and weaknesses.
- **StrengthsFinder (now known as CliftonStrengths)**, developed by Don Clifton, focuses on the science of identifying a person's strengths rather than focusing on a person's weaknesses. Specifically, StrengthsFinder can easily identify what a team member does best naturally, provides personalized results/reports for current teams and organizations for maximum potential, and helps develop members' greatest talents into top strengths while building a team with complementary strengths. https://www.gallup.com/cliftonstrengths/en/252137/home.aspx.

Conclusion

The point of inclusive leadership is to consider all the people in your organization when making decisions. It is a person-driven, human-focused leadership approach that will be more effective in the long run as it creates and sustains an environment of inclusion and belonging. To get started on the path of inclusive leadership, begin with self-reflection, move into deliberate professional development, and, most importantly, act with empathy and intentionality. Approach the rest of this book with humility and an open mind. The investment of time you make will hopefully transform the ways you approach your everyday interactions.

Notes

1. Annie Bélanger et al., "ACRL Inclusive Leadership Annotated Bibliography," *Library Reports and Communication* (2023): 33, https://scholarworks.gvsu.edu/library_reports/33.
2. Jennifer A. DeVito, "Managing Your Career: Creating A Leadership Development Plan," in *Critical Library Leadership: Managing Self and Others in Today's Academic Library*, eds. Kristin Henrich and Cinthya Ippoliti (Chicago: ACRL, 2024).

3. Amanda Foster Kaufman, Amy F. Fyn, Millicent Weber, and Christina Heady Kaufman, "The Dysfunctional Library and Academic Librarian Turnover," in *Libraries as Dysfunctional Organizations and Workplaces*, ed. Spencer Acadia (Oxfordshire, UK: Routledge, 2022), https://doi.org/10.4324/9781003159155-2.
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5. Kaetrena Davis Kendrick and Ione T. Damasco, "Low Morale in Ethnic and Racial Minority Academic Librarians: An Experiential Study," *Library Trends* 68, no. 2 (2019): 174–212, https://doi.org/10.1353/lib.2019.0036.
6. Juliet Bourke and Andrea Titus, "The Key to Inclusive Leadership," *Harvard Business Review* (March 6, 2020), https://hbr.org/2020/03/the-key-to-inclusive-leadership.

CHAPTER 2

The Inclusive Leadership Framework and Advancing Racial Equity

Thomas L. Dickens

Positionality Statement

In approaching discussions on inclusive leadership and antiracism, it is crucial to understand the perspectives that shape my insights. I am a Black, cisgender, heterosexual, temporarily non-disabled man. Acknowledging the challenges of systemic racism faced by Black individuals, particularly in the United States, higher education, and libraries, my experiences reflect the impact of racial bias and discrimination both personally and within my community.

While my primary racial identity is Black American, I recognize the importance of including other communities of color and intersecting forms of oppression in antiracism dialogues. I actively seek to educate myself and amplify the voices of these communities.

Naming my privileges as a cisgender, heterosexual, temporarily non-disabled man is also important. LGBTQ+ and disabled communities experience discrimination in ways that I do not. Their perspectives are vital in discussions of intersectionality and antiracism, influencing my perspective on racial inequities in library settings.

My lived experiences, moving between predominantly Black communities in my personal life and predominantly white institutions in my professional life, shape how I view inclusive leadership. These experiences have pushed me toward intentional approaches in addressing racism within frameworks, both professionally and personally.

In pursuit of a more equitable and just society, I am dedicated to challenging my biases and actively participating in efforts to dismantle oppressive systems. Stating these identities, I aim to provide insight into how my lens interprets discussed frameworks, fostering dialogue and a collective understanding. My hope is to foster dialogue and collective understanding. I welcome diverse interpretations and am eager to learn more through open discussion.

Introduction

My introduction, in 2017, to Deloitte's inclusive leadership framework reshaped my understanding of leadership dynamics.[1] This tool, designed to challenge conventional leadership

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styles, opened up new conversations with leaders across various parts of my career. As I engaged with this framework and others, such as the Intercultural Development Inventory,[2] I recognized a clear gap. While the traits outlined in these models aligned with the experiences of privileged identities, they did not fully address the unique experiences and perspectives of historically marginalized groups, particularly people of color, both as leaders and team members.

For example, when I facilitated discussions on inclusive leadership, traits such as courage, bias awareness, and cultural intelligence often revealed a lack of clarity regarding accountability. Who should take responsibility for intervening in bias incidents? Who is expected to adapt to others' cultural norms? That ambiguity can reinforce existing inequities or encourage conformity in the name of inclusion. It raised questions for me about how the framework could genuinely support diverse identities in positions of power.

Despite these limitations, the inclusive leadership framework can be a valuable tool when used thoughtfully and critically. Its structured approach to traits like collaboration and cultural intelligence provides a foundation for meaningful dialogue and reflection. However, to maximize its potential, I believe it should be supplemented by frameworks like critical race theory (CRT) to take systemic inequities into account and offer tools to address them.

In this chapter, I will explore the six signature traits of inclusive leadership through the lens of racial equity in library spaces. By incorporating insights from CRT, I aim to demonstrate how leaders can adapt this framework to confront and dismantle systemic inequities, ensuring it becomes a catalyst for genuine inclusion rather than an instrument of conformity.

The following sections will analyze the traits of inclusive leadership—commitment, courage, cognizance of bias, curiosity, cultural intelligence, and collaboration—alongside core tenets of CRT, including structural racism, interest convergence, whiteness as the norm, the power of counter-narratives, intersectionality, and critiques of colorblindness. This exploration will underscore how CRT principles deepen and enhance the practical application of inclusive leadership traits, providing a richer and more impactful framework for addressing racial inequities.

Ultimately, this chapter seeks to offer actionable insights for leaders at all levels, equipping them to navigate and mitigate racial disparities within their environments with greater awareness and effectiveness.

Commitment to Recognizing Structural Racism

As we think about the inclusive leadership framework, the discussion often starts with the signature trait of commitment. This trait is about knowing your values and how they align with inclusivity. Your commitment should include reflection on personal and team values and clearly and authentically articulate the value of diversity and inclusion. Treating this as a business priority and advocating for the allocation of the appropriate resources to promote diversity and inclusion is an indication of the level of commitment.[3]

Leaders must be committed to disrupting oppression, particularly racism in all its forms, to advance racial equity within our organizations. By integrating elements of CRT into the inclusive leadership framework, leaders can deepen their commitment to identifying and addressing systemic and structural racism. In the context of libraries, this requires recognizing how historical and ongoing inequities have shaped policies, practices, and access to resources. While libraries have made significant progress in understanding that racial disparities extend beyond individual attitudes or behaviors, the work of dismantling systemic racism is far from complete. This involves critically examining structures such as collection development, hiring practices, outreach efforts, and the organization of knowledge itself, all of which can perpetuate inequity if left unexamined. Remaining steadfast in viewing racism through a structural lens ensures that libraries continue to evolve as equitable and inclusive spaces for all.

In practice, this commitment can be demonstrated by embedding antiracism into the core values of your organization, adapting actions and behaviors to meet the diverse needs of those you serve, and prioritizing antiracism both personally and professionally. Leaders must also articulate the value of antiracism to their teams, fostering a shared understanding and collective accountability. These efforts should center on uncovering and addressing the deep roots of structural racism, including the policies, practices, and systems that perpetuate inequity. By working collaboratively to dismantle these structures, leaders can create lasting change, setting the stage for courageous conversations about how interest convergence impacts organizational priorities.

Courage to Examine Interest Convergence

When I have conversations about what organizational leaders can do to foster an inclusive environment that disrupts racism and white supremacy, the need for courage is often the focus of the conversation. This trait includes "the courage to speak up—to challenge others and the status quo—is a central behavior of an inclusive leader, and it occurs at three levels: with others, with the system, and with themselves."[4] I like to think of this as a combination of bystander intervention and being willing to have a high degree of humility to learn from others. Engaging in the space of not always having the answers can be difficult for leaders at times, but this level of vulnerability is essential for creating an inclusive environment.

As we think about how this trait can work to create a racially equitable environment, we not only want to think about how we need to have the courage to disrupt individual and systemic instances of racism when we see them, but we also have to have the courage to know that when you challenge the system, the system will push back when it believes our work is not in the "best interest" of the dominant group. "Best interest" is in quotation marks because this is arguable and often lacks representation from dissenting voices within that community. In the case of racial equity, this refers to people who are not a part of communities of color.

In critical race theory, this is known as interest convergence, which theorizes "there will be no racial progress unless the interests of the marginalized align with the interests of those

in power."[5] This theory stems from the notion that there is little incentive for large swaths of our nation to eradicate racism because of the benefits that it provides for those in power.[6] As of spring 2024, we see several examples of how this concept plays out in higher education institutions. One striking example comes from the University of Wisconsin System, whose board has approved a plan for $800 million in state funding in exchange for cutting DEI (diversity, equity, and inclusion) programs across the system.[7] While this story has a lot of details and nuance, it remains a good example that when the interests of historically marginalized groups are perceived to diverge from the interests of the groups with the most social power, those with power and privilege will no longer work to overtly meet the needs of the communities that often need these resources the most.

It is essential for leaders committed to racial equity to challenge the status quo individually and at the systemic level. It is equally important to understand the system that we operate in, which has its foundations in racism and other forms of oppression and often will not tolerate going against the interests of the majority. If it did, this work would be easier and more accessible. As you work to create more racially equitable spaces, it is crucial to understand and articulate how this work benefits all. In practice, this is questioning the status quo, holding others and yourself accountable for racially exclusive behaviors, challenging systems and procedures, admitting mistakes, and accepting feedback.

Cognizance of Whiteness as the Norm

The third trait in the inclusive leadership framework is cognizance of bias, an awareness of your biases and those baked into the systems in which you are connected. One common misconception in response to this trait is the desire to be bias-free. Striving to become "bias-free" is impossible; our brains use biases to make sense of the world around us. To keep up with the mountain of information presented to us every minute, our brain engages in System 1 and System 2 thinking. System 1 thinking is "our brains' fast, automatic, unconscious, and emotional response to situations and stimuli. This can be in the form of absentmindedly reading text on a billboard, knowing how to tie your shoelaces without a second thought, or instinctively hopping over a puddle on the sidewalk." System 2 thinking is "the slow, effortful, and logical mode in which our brains operate when solving more complicated problems. For example, System 2 thinking is used when looking for a friend in a crowd, parking your vehicle in a tight space, or determining the quality-to-value ratio of your take-out lunch."[8]

We overwhelmingly engage in System 1 thinking unless forced or practice doing otherwise. This automatic way of thinking leads to bias, particularly if it is connected to how we always do things. To get out of this, we must be aware of our biases and the biases our systems uphold.

To work toward racial equity, we must reflect on how we, and our systems, uphold a culture of white supremacy. In the book, *The Diversity Gap: Where Good Intentions Meet True Cultural Change*, Bethaney Wilkinson describes white supremacy culture as "a political, economic, and cultural system in which white people overwhelmingly control power and material resources."

In this system, "Conscious and unconscious ideas of white superiority and entitlement are widespread, and relations of white dominance and nonwhite subordination are daily reenacted across a broad array of institutions and social settings."[9]

When working to become more cognizant of the biases you hold and that are present in organizations, reflect on how you may be contributing to a white supremacy culture. While only non-POCs can benefit from a white supremacy system as a community, anyone can, and often does, uphold various aspects of white supremacy culture.

So, how can you become more aware of the biases you hold that counter a more racially equitable environment? In workshops, I often present self-assessment tools to help individuals identify where they might be in their journey toward dismantling oppression. These tools can be valuable for understanding personal growth and areas for improvement. For example, the Intercultural Development Inventory,[10] the Implicit Association Test,[11] and the Diversity to Liberation Assessment[12] provide insights into individual biases and perspectives. For organizational contexts, tools like the Cultural Proficiencies for Racial Equity: A Framework by the American Library Association (ALA) and the Association of College and Research Libraries (ACRL)[13] can help map out where an organization stands and offer guidance on actionable steps toward equity. While specific tools may not be included here, seeking feedback from marginalized groups and engaging critically with these assessments are crucial for an honest evaluation of one's position and progress.

Scholars Tema Okun and Kenneth Jones highlight fifteen values of White Supremacy Culture in the book *Dismantling Racism: A Workbook for Social Change Groups*.[14] Understanding these values can also be a beneficial tool in identifying how you, your organization, or the systems you are connected to uphold aspects of White Supremacy Culture. Okun and Jones state that these values are:

- perfectionism
- sense of urgency
- defensiveness
- valuing quantity over quality
- worshipping the written word
- believing in only one right way
- paternalism
- either/or thinking
- power hoarding
- fear of open conflict
- individualism
- believing I'm the only one
- believing progress is bigger and more
- believing in objectivity
- claiming a right to comfort

Any of these tools can be helpful if used in isolation, but I have found the most success in doing this work in a community, also known as collaborative learning. Learning from others and sharing wisdom has been instrumental in identifying blind spots and growing in this work.[15] Collaborative learning can take various forms, such as cohort experiences or working with an individual who can serve as an accountability partner. Engaging in this work with members of various communities is an essential aspect of the following trait of being curious about counter-narratives.

Curiosity of Counter-Narratives

Some leaders approach the work connected to being inclusive as a burden. It can feel overwhelming and requires disrupting your norm or the status quo. In my experience, people with the most success in this area approach the desire to be an inclusive leader with a high degree of curiosity and want to know more about others and how you, as a leader, can do better. Deloitte describes the signature trait of curiosity as "an open mindset, a desire to understand how others view and experience the world, and a tolerance for ambiguity."[16]

This trait is engaging in lifelong learning, seeking out different voices, dealing with ambiguity, and understanding that there is rarely one correct answer to cultural conflicts. More importantly, it is the desire to continue to seek out counter-narratives.

In the CRT framework, counter-narratives are the objective in intentionally seeking out historically marginalized perspectives that run counter to the dominant narrative.[17] In the article "Acts of Disruption for Liberation: Counterstories, Accessibility, and Accomplices," Nicollette Davis talks about the importance of this tenet. "Counter-storytelling is an act of resistance and pushes against the white, able-bodied, heteronormative ideals that are often hyper visible. Solórzano & Yasso define it '...as a method of telling the stories of those people whose experiences are not often told (i.e., those on the margins of society). The counterstory is also a tool for exposing, analyzing, and challenging the majoritarian stories of racial privilege. Counterstories can shatter complacency, challenge the dominant discourse on race, and further the struggle for racial reform.'"[18]

How can leaders engage with counter-narratives regularly and appropriately? People can begin by looking at what they are currently engaged in—books, movies, TV, music, art, politics. Look closely at what voices are represented and centered in those various aspects. What type of conversations do you have with family and loved ones, and what narratives are missing in those engagements? From a team or organizational perspective, this includes what voices are missing from the creation of systems, policies, and programs. For example, many libraries still struggle to promote indigenous authors, disabled scholars of color, or Black LGBTQIA+ voices in their collections and programming. Some libraries are taking a hard look at aspects of their organization and services, such as their collections, to ensure other narratives are being presented and bringing in the voices of their diverse communities. Others engage in equity lenses, a series of questions for teams to consciously think about the voices at the table and how to bring those stakeholders into the conversation.

Equally important to the ways that we engage with counter-narratives is our motivation. The wrong motivation can cause more harm than good. For example, I attended a professional event with other organizational leaders interested in advancing DEI efforts in our various organizations. In one of our sessions, a few colleagues from LGBTQIA+ communities shared past experiences with interview processes. They highlighted how they pay attention to code words and actions to determine if the place will be safe for them to work there. A few attendees sought to hear more about the codes these colleagues would seek. Other colleagues interjected that people should not have to share those codes with us because we

are not members of those communities, and they have codes for a reason. These codes exist to help marginalized communities protect themselves in environments where harm or exclusion is possible or likely, and it is not their responsibility to disclose them for our convenience. It is interesting to see who is walking the walk instead of just talking the talk. If we are doing the work, we will be setting up these environments in the right way so that they will feel safe. If not, these places will remain unsafe. This pattern appears in racial equity work as well. People of color and other marginalized voices are often expected to explain their experiences for others rather than leaders doing the work to understand the dynamics at play for someone to feel safe and included in a space.

In the above story, knowing the codes will only circumvent our curiosity or need to immerse ourselves in various communities. Our motivation to do this work should not be to figure out how to improve our recruitment and retention strategies (even though that would be a good outcome). The motivation should be to be better people and organizations, which will translate into our work and the spaces we create for others. Curiosity is not only a feeling. It is ongoing practice that requires us to continually seek new perspectives, reflect on our assumptions, and stay open to learning and being uncomfortable.

Cultural Intelligence and Intersectionality

The fifth trait in the inclusive leadership framework is cultural intelligence. While discussing inclusive leadership and antiracism, this trait generates the most contention and, I believe, rightfully so. There are a few points in this trait that, if someone does not understand fully, engaging in this practice can cause more harm. Moreover, some components of cultural intelligence ignore power imbalances across racial identities in the United States and other Western societies.

As described by Bourke, cultural intelligence is the desire to learn about other cultures, understand the differences and similarities of one's cultural background, and demonstrate the ability to adapt one's behavior in cross-cultural encounters appropriately. People sometimes use other terms, such as cultural competence and cultural humility, to describe this type of understanding and interaction across cultures. While each of these terms has its unique definition, some use these terms interchangeably. Since we are working specifically with the inclusive leadership framework presented by Bourke, we will use the term cultural intelligence.

The description of cultural intelligence by Bourke does not address the power imbalance between people of color and non-POC from the perspective of Western societies. In doing so, it can make it difficult for all these communities to understand how to appropriately engage in certain aspects of this trait, such as adapting to others, gaining cultural knowledge, and sharing cultural knowledge. As we think about utilizing this framework to address racial inequities in our organizations, we will need to do so by understanding white supremacy culture and how this culture impacts different racial groups. When increasing your cultural intelligence in

this way, it is also vital to begin taking an intersectional approach to developing your understanding of the cultural background of others under a white supremacy culture.

Incorporating an intersectional approach enhances the practice of cultural intelligence by recognizing the interplay between race and other axes of oppression, such as gender, class, and disability. Intersectionality, as defined by David Gillborn, highlights how multiple forms of inequality and identity interrelate in different contexts and over time.[19] Intersectionality is often confused with how all our identities interact, which is the presence of our various identities without regard to inequality within each of those communities. For example, Black women have intersecting forms of oppression of racism and sexism, often called "misogynoir," whereas my identities of being a Black, cisgender-heterosexual man interact but do not have intersecting forms of oppression. These identities still shape how I am able to move through the world, but they do not create intersecting forms of oppression in a way that intersectionality describes. Understanding the difference between intersectionality and interacting identities is a critical concept to understand in professions like librarianship, as intersectionality will be misused and weaponized to oppress marginalized communities further.

By engaging with cultural intelligence through an intersectional lens, leaders can deepen their awareness of how cultural backgrounds and intersecting oppressions influence individual experiences. For example, understanding intersectionality allows leaders to design recruitment practices that account for barriers faced by individuals with intersecting forms of oppression. This practice aligns with the inclusive leadership traits of commitment and curiosity, encouraging leaders to foster environments where diverse perspectives are valued and respected.

While the complexity of intersectionality can feel overwhelming, it underscores the importance of cultural intelligence as a practical tool for leaders. Richard Delgado highlights this feeling in his work, "Rodrigo's Reconsideration: Intersectionality and the Future of Critical Race Theory," by stating, "Intersectionality can easily paralyze progressive work and thought because of the realization that whatever unit you choose to work with, someone may come along and point out that you forgot something."[20]

Delgado points out that identity categories are infinitely divisible. Delgado's insight is not to dismiss intersectionality, but to caution using the term so broadly that it loses its power to illuminate the nuance of oppression. So, the uncritical use of intersectionality could lead to the paralysis of important work amid a mosaic of never-ending differences. In contrast, I want to return to a more foundational understanding of intersectionality. This is a tool of critical race analysis and intervention. To understand how racism works, we need to appreciate how race intersects with other axes of oppression at contrasting times and in different contexts, but we must try to find a balance between remaining sensitive to intersectional issues without being paralyzed by them.

While the complexity of intersectionality can feel overwhelming, it underscores the importance of cultural intelligence as a practical tool for leaders. Instead of striving to understand every nuance of identity, leaders should leverage inclusive leadership traits such as commitment and curiosity as a way to appreciate the ways intersecting forms of oppression exist. Working to increase your cultural intelligence by incorporating an intersectional lens leads

to cultivating environments of learning, humility, and adaptability. This approach effectively empowers organizations to leverage diverse talents and perspectives, fostering inclusion and innovation.

Furthermore, as we increase our cultural intellect, we should be curious and explore work and scholarship by learning from scholars and colleagues with these intersecting identities. Exploring different scholars in feminist theory who are people of color and queer will provide deeper insights into how we can construct a more racially equitable profession. Scholars and sources, such as WOC+Lib, the Combahee River Collective, bell hooks, and Audre Lorde, are good starting places. Using an intersectional approach to raise our cultural intelligence better positions us and our organizations to build effective teams to address challenging and complex issues, as highlighted in the following signature trait: collaboration.

Collaboration as a Critique of Colorblindness

Collaboration is the sixth and final inclusive leadership framework trait. Utilizing this trait creates teams that make people feel like they belong and have unique skills contributing to the team's success. Collaboration entails assembling a team that offers diverse perspectives, creating a safe environment where all members feel they can contribute adequately, and creating an accountability structure for team members to work through those differences.[21]

As we think about collaboration to advance racial equity, leaders must understand the importance of having a diverse team, especially in terms of racial identity, to address complex problems and discover new and creative solutions. CRT helps drive this point home with the tenant critiquing colorblindness.[22] As we think about constructing teams, our society has taught us to ignore one's identity background in the name of "equality." However, this approach promotes a misguided perception of equality and limits the ability of the assembled team. Embodying this trait is a commitment to understanding that a color-blind, neutral approach continues to benefit the oppressor and never the oppressed. This work is also a commitment to understanding that diversity in terms of identity and thinking, coupled with an elevated level of cultural intelligence, is valuable to team dynamics. Deloitte highlights this by saying, "For inclusive leaders, diversity of thinking is a central ingredient for effective collaboration ... they understand the demographic factors that cause individuals and groups to think differently, directly (for example, educational background and mental frameworks) and indirectly (for example, gender and race), and purposely align individuals to teams based on that knowledge."[23]

Coalition-building across communities has been critical in making significant strides for human rights in society. Recognizing that our freedom and liberation are bound to one another has led to communities having the necessary collective impact on advancing initiatives like voting rights, immigration rights, the right to an education, and more. In libraries, we see changes in collections development, improved subject headings, hiring practices, and other areas because people have been mindful of representation.

How does it look to ensure that diverse racial identities are appropriately represented in teams? The first piece to understand is your motivation and the environment that you are creating. This understanding should also be juxtaposed with recognizing the invisible labor, or cultural taxation, POCs often take on in our organizations.[24] Having diversity for diversity's sake while still leaning into white supremacy culture will produce more of the same, or worse. In The Diversity Gap, Wilkinson says, "If your pursuit of racial diversity is about dignifying people and disrupting racism, keep going. If this is about appearing relevant, stop now."[25] If you are engaging in the other traits of inclusive leadership (commitment, courage, curiosity, cognizance of bias, and cultural intelligence), creating a team with appropriate representation to accomplish goals and move the organization forward positively should follow. Collaboration that honors racial diversity strengthens an organization's ability to recognize inequities and create solutions that genuinely advance racial equity.

Conclusion

The inclusive leadership framework is valuable to help leaders create a more welcoming and inclusive organizational environment. However, it is crucial to recognize that this framework has limitations and gaps, particularly in addressing the needs of historically marginalized identities. When using frameworks to foster an inclusive and equitable environment, it is essential to supplement them with other tools, such as CRT and other anti-oppression theories, to comprehensively understand how to approach an environment that engages in antiracist practices. To strive for inclusion, anti-oppressive frameworks such as CRT must be actively used to avoid reinforcing the same systems and outcomes we are looking to change.

As we think about building organizations and teams for inclusion, we must remain vigilant and explicit in our efforts to center and elevate the voices and experiences of historically marginalized communities. In advancing racial equity, these are the voices and experiences of people of color, internally and externally.

Leaders can do this work by committing to understanding and dismantling racism that is embedded in the systems we are connected to, having the courage to design and protect resources that may not explicitly benefit the interests of non-POCs, becoming cognizant of how we uphold elements of white supremacy culture in our organizations, being curious of discovering narratives that run counter to the dominate narratives that are readily available to us, taking an intersectional approach to increasing our cultural intelligence of how our systems impact people of color, and creating collaborative teams that are intentionally diverse in thinking and identity.

In addition, fostering inclusion requires a continuous commitment to ongoing education and self-reflection. Leaders should actively seek out opportunities to deepen their understanding of the complexities surrounding equity, diversity, and inclusion. This may involve conversing with individuals from diverse backgrounds, attending workshops, and staying

informed about current social and cultural issues. Furthermore, leaders must be willing to acknowledge their own biases and be open to learning from their mistakes. By cultivating a culture of continuous learning and humility, leaders can contribute to a more dynamic and responsive approach to inclusion that evolves alongside the changing landscape of societal norms and expectations.

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CHAPTER 3

Building a Racial Equity Framework

Christina Fuller-Gregory and Mark A. Puente

Positionality Statements

Mark A. Puente

My name is Mark A. Puente, and I serve as associate professor and associate dean for Organizational Development at the Purdue Libraries and School of Information Studies. I am of Latino heritage with familial roots in parts of Central and Eastern Mexico. I grew up in a working-class family in San Antonio, TX, and identify as part of the LGBTQ community. I am an able-bodied, cisgender male. I approach this work leading with equity but understanding the limits to empathy. That is, although I can get proximate to, I can never fully empathize with the experiences of those whose racial/ethnic identity I do not share. In fact, no identity group is monolithic, so even those who share my heritage may have different experiences as they walk through this world. I engage in this work with the hope that humility and authenticity are my guides and that I can leverage the advantages that I have at my disposal, whether given or earned, for the good of those with fewer privileges and advantages.

Christina Fuller-Gregory

My name is Christina Fuller-Gregory, and I am the assistant director of libraries at the South Carolina Governor's School for the Arts and Humanities in Greenville, South Carolina. I am a cisgender female of African American heritage. I am the descendant of slaves who worked the land in both North and South Carolina. I have a complicated relationship with my Southern roots, all at once questioning how I could still reside and make my life in a part of the country that saw such little value in my ancestors and proud of the intricacies, traditions, and teachings that this legacy has given me. I am a librarian, the daughter of a librarian, and the niece of librarians … we are readers, learners, teachers, and writers. I approach this work with a desire to be a cog in the mighty wheel of social activism, social justice, and social change.

Introduction

In August of 2022, the American Library Association (ALA), the Association of College and Research Libraries (ACRL), the Association of Research Libraries (ARL), and the Public

Library Association (PLA) published a joint framework on racial equity within the library and information profession. The document, "Cultural Proficiencies in Racial Equity (CPRE): A Framework," was developed by a joint task force of member representatives from the four sponsoring organizations. Supporting the task force members were staff of those four organizations who held responsibilities or served as liaisons to association boards or leadership groups for diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI). By August 2022, the respective boards of directors for each of the associations approved and endorsed the CPRE Framework (hereafter referred to as the Framework).

The publication and endorsement were the culmination of almost three years of coordination and advocacy, originally initiated in conversations between association leaders at the time: Jody Gray, director of the ALA Office of Diversity, Literacy, and Outreach Services (ODLOS), and Mark A. Puente, senior director of diversity and leadership programs for ARL. It was during the ALA annual meeting in Washington, DC, in 2019 that Gray and Puente approached the executive directors of the respective library associations with a proposal to fund and co-coordinate the effort. This was during a time within the United States and Canada when perspectives and attitudes regarding DEI were shifting dramatically. The long-held belief was being challenged that the "problem" of diversity in the profession would be solved by simply recruiting more minoritized/racialized people into the field. The literature being published in the field about DEI efforts was being critical of strategies that approached the work through a deficit mindset—that the problem is with is with the skills, competencies, or behaviors of minoritized individuals entering the field. They are unprepared, lack professional polish, and just need to be mentored properly and taught the craft of assimilation or code-switching to be successful and retained in the field. In addition, the world had yet to experience the collective trauma of 2020, a year that saw efforts to engage in critical conversations about race and racial equity become mainstream. It was also before calls for change following the senseless murder of George Floyd and the glaring health disparities for minoritized/racialized communities due to a global pandemic became too loud to ignore.

In the fall of 2019, a call was issued for participation in the task force, using the communications platforms and mechanisms of all four associations. Early on, we recognized that deciding on membership of the task force would be extremely difficult given the number of noted experts and thought leaders in the DEI space across library and information science (LIS) sectors. It was important to us that the group reflect board representation of race/ethnicity, gender, geographic location (inclusive of Canadian professionals), and library types. It was also important that there be representation from LIS education on the task force. This goal ended up being more challenging than anticipated, as two of the task force members were employed in public libraries at the time of recruitment and selection but transitioned into positions in academic libraries during the timeframe of the project. This meant that academic libraries were overrepresented in the constitution of the task force. Nevertheless, we felt that there were enough members who, at that time, were either then or formerly employed in public libraries that those interests were sufficiently represented.

As with many things, the global pandemic shifted our anticipated timeline and design for completing the work. Plans to build community within the task force and to dedicate in-person

brainstorming and writing time to develop the Framework had to be reimagined and reconfigured. The task force was never able to convene in person, even after the final draft of the document was completed. Our vision for creating a roadmap for the drafting of the Framework required that we divide task force members into several working groups, including:

1. **Survey development group.** This group developed and administered a protocol to collect data on the racial equity efforts of public and academic libraries, their employees' perceptions of those efforts, as well as employees' experience with racial equity and inequity within their organizations.
2. **Data and competencies group.** This team researched existing racial equity frameworks from a variety of professional sectors as well as noted developmental (i.e., training) programs in racial equity concepts and practices.
3. **Taxonomy group.** Together, the taxonomy working group established and defined the vocabulary that would be used in the Framework.
4. **Framework development group.** Informed by the research efforts of the previous three groups as well as other internal and external stakeholders, the Framework working group was responsible for the drafting of the CPRE Framework.

Although the working groups focused on varying aspects of framework development, they were each connected by collective throughlines. Those throughlines were rooted in an understanding that the Framework needed to speak to the longstanding lack of representation of Black, Indigenous, and people of color (BIPOC) within the profession. Honoring these throughlines meant that the Framework spoke to the evolving needs of those communities in public and academic spheres, challenging the reader to think critically about how social systems advantaging those who identify as white have been sustained for centuries.

The implications of failing to consider the historical legacy of advantage for people from majority identities are broad and deep, affecting almost every area of the LIS practice: collections, cataloging and metadata (descriptive practices), public service (reference, teaching/instruction, and programming), archives and memory work, etc. The aforementioned throughlines also exist in the inclusive leader's ability to acknowledge and repair oppressive structures and systems in the LIS profession. This work starts with the asking and answering of questions to help the inclusive leader think critically about what reparations could be. The questions shared below were developed to support inclusive leaders in thinking more critically about their efforts.

Questions for Inclusive Leaders

1. How does the inclusive library leader commit to understanding how library practices, policies, and cultures can lead to different experiences and outcomes for those whom the profession serves as well as those who are employed within it?
2. How should the inclusive library leader determine and engage appropriate stakeholders in developing a strategic vision for their mission and ensure that those affected by the

realization (i.e., making the vision concrete) are an integral part of implementing that vision?
3. What approaches can be taken to help extend and build on the leader's existing proficiencies in racial equity to help sustain and cultivate the compassion and understanding needed to lead inclusively?

At this point, it may be helpful to outline the distinction between the concept of "cultural competency" (an explicitly articulated component of inclusive leadership) and our intentional use of the phrase "cultural proficiency." The group that developed the Framework was intentional about using the term "proficiency" as the word "competency" can sometimes connote an ending point, as in a set of skills or characteristics that render one effective at a task. By contrast, "proficiency" implies a level of skill that provides room for growth, extension, and adjustment to the mindset or behavior as perspectives and understanding change. It was our vision that proficiencies would be imbued with a sense of cultural humility—the perspective that acknowledges that this work is ongoing and requires life-long commitment, and that it is most effective when addressing power imbalances in social systems.[1]

The Framework

The framework comprises four intersecting concepts, the integration of each, and underscores its importance to promoting the holistic examination of how these concepts impact and inform both the LIS profession and the inclusive leader. The four frames are:

Frame 1: Addressing and Interrogating How White Supremacy, White Privilege, and Racism Show Up in Libraries

Foundational in its structure, frame one asks that readers begin by developing their understanding of the "core ideas around racial equity."[2] Readers are encouraged to do this through a number of methods, including a critical examination of the history and language of white supremacy, evaluating this information and its impacts on their beliefs and behaviors using the practice of self-reflection, and broadening their understanding of racial identity through the lens of a competency continuum. Using self and organizational assessments as starting points prepares the reader to discover greater interconnectedness between their journeys and the practices shared in frames two through four.

Frame 2: Accountability, Assessment, and Implementation

Acknowledgment without accountability often prevents the creation of lasting systems of change for racialized and minoritized populations. This frame encourages an examination of organizational, structural, and individual accountability in the LIS profession, and serves as a broad-spectrum examination of the many behaviors and biases that inform our approaches

to people, policy, and procedure. Frame 2 calls in organizational behaviors that are contradictory to inviting a more diverse, experienced workforce, asking for those in the LIS sector to consider how power, privilege, and racial inequity inform systems ranging from hiring, recruitment, and advancement to strategic planning. It asks that individuals acting as allies authentically engage in this work, not only holding space for minoritized and racialized populations, but also that they consider the ways in which they create space. It does so with the understanding that the accountability needed to create space and hold space both require a tremendous amount of commitment, effort, energy, and time.

Frame 3: Building Cross-Sector Cultural Proficiency—Influencing and Effecting Change in Other Professional, Civic, Political Spheres

The question of who we serve is tantamount to who we are as culturally proficient LIS organizations that center racial equity. Frame 3 is a shift from the understanding and acknowledgment of Frame 1 and the recognition and awareness required in Frame 2. It asks that we use this knowledge of systems of oppression and our roles in these behaviors to identify those partner relationships with those who will work alongside us in our efforts to address and redress racial inequity. For us in the LIS sector, this comes with a requirement to turn outward to build connections and solutions with those organizations that have a shared vision, mission, or goals for their service to minoritized or racialized populations.

Frame 4: Antiracist Leadership

Leadership cannot occur in a vacuum. Leaders in the LIS sector are uniquely positioned to "serve as exemplars to other professions in building and sustaining antiracist climates, cultures, and practices, but must commit to the work of internal and systems change in the process."[3] Frame 4 underscores for the LIS leader that in order to effectively practice antiracist leadership, they must openly, actively, and unapologetically oppose systemic oppression and racism. This requires LIS leaders to act as advocates of antiracist practice both in their individual organizations and as member volunteers of the larger institutions of the American Library Association (ALA) and beyond.

In drafting the Framework, we recognized that it was meant to offer a suggested approach to developing and implementing a mindset and an operational commitment to racial equity. It acknowledges that this journey is, by necessity, first a personal one that requires an understanding of historical and social events, policies, and norms that have created our current landscape. It requires that the inclusive leader recognize and understand the ways in which systems—at micro, meso, and macro levels—have created and sustained disadvantages for communities of color. Finally, it challenges the reader to contemplate and to contribute to social movements that will help dismantle and rebuild the systems that are leading to differential outcomes for racialized/minoritized communities. Although, as stated in the Framework, the document itself cannot provide the exact steps needed for liberation of communities of color, it can act as an impetus for change, providing libraries and those in the LIS profession

with a set of foundational guidelines that can (and should) be used to inform their approaches to people, policy, and procedure. These actions can include both individual and team-focused strategies for personal growth.

Learning Resources

We underscore the need for personal growth by sharing a comprehensive list of inclusive leadership resources that will enrich, empower, and embolden both the leader and their teams as they grow in their antiracist practice. They include:

Peggy McIntosh's "White Privilege: Unpacking the Invisible Knapsack."

This piece was first published in *Peace and Freedom Magazine*.[4] McIntosh is the co-founder of the SEED Project. In the publication, she poses a series of questions that help the reader reflect on the many ways in which white people are beneficiaries of social systems that were constructed and maintained mainly for them. The examples posed range from the mundane or seemingly simple to issues of much more grave consequence. "I can choose blemish cover or bandages in "flesh" color and have them more less match my skin." "If a traffic cop pulls me over … I can be sure I haven't been singled out because of my race."

The Coalition for Diversity and Inclusion in Scholarly Communications (C4DISC)

C4DISC has developed a series of "toolkits" to help advance issues related to racial justice. Their "Toolkits for Equity" (c4disc.pubpub.org/toolkits-for-equity) were created for various audiences and contexts and offer both theoretical and practical guidance and information about how to create more equitable and inclusive environments for people from minoritized/racialized backgrounds. The "Antiracism Toolkit for White Allies"[5] is rich with historical information about how advantage was created for people from majority populations since colonial times in the United States, and recommendations for what white allies can do to counter the effects of inequitable systems, policies, procedures, and norms. Although the series focuses, to a great degree, on racial inequity in the scholarly publishing industry, its suggestions are broadly generalizable and are appropriate for many professional and geographic contexts.

The Social Action, Leadership, and Transformation (SALT) Model

The SALT Model offers a framework for inclusive leadership that acknowledges and seeks to counter oppressive systems, with the goal of advancing social justice. The model, authored by scholars/practitioners at the University of Michigan's National Center for Institutional

Diversity and Indiana's National Institute for Transformation and Equity, offers seven elements to social justice leadership that, according to the model, require a persistent centering of equity in the work. The model urges leaders to take a critical approach to understanding the intersections of "systemic oppression, power and privilege" with culture and identity.[6] Doing so is a prerequisite for cultivating inclusive and socially just organizations and societies.

Tema Okun's "Characteristics of White Supremacy Culture"

Originally conceived and published by Okun and Kenneth Jones in 2001, the framework provides definitions and examples of the thirteen characteristics that can be harmful to BIPOC or others from marginalized identities, as they are often not articulated, negotiated, or in any way critiqued.[7] This framework provides a set of tools that can be used for reflection and evaluation on personal, interpersonal, and organizational levels. Within this framework, there are a number of suggested antidotes to countering white supremacy culture. Many adaptations to this framework have been developed and published, such as a distilled and accessible version created by Partners for Collaborative Change.[8]

There are many related tools that can be used for assessment and reflection by leaders who are committed to building an inclusive practice. However, it will be important for the leader to identify those tools that best speak to both their desired goals for their inclusive leadership journey and their individual leadership styles.

Conclusion

Inclusive library leadership extends beyond cultivating empathy, addressing biases, or leveraging diverse perspectives. For leaders, it entails recognizing both the inherent challenges and opportunities of holding positions of power. Leadership may occur within environments shaped by complex histories or in communities where conversations about race and racial equity are neither systematic nor welcome. Conversely, leaders may find themselves supported by staff and colleagues eager to collectively engage in equity-building work.

Regardless of the context, inclusive leadership begins with a foundation—a framework that fosters understanding of the past, acknowledges its impacts on the present, and inspires actions toward a more equitable future. The CPRE Framework acts as a foundation in mapping the path forward for diverse libraries with a diverse workforce. It is a resource to support public and academic libraries in building inclusive cultures. While it provides guidelines for the development and implementation of organizational policies and professional practices, it does so with an understanding that the scope and impact of an approach to addressing and redressing systems of racial equity can (and should) be defined by the organizational contributors to the work.

Notes

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PART 2

Concepts and Practices

CHAPTER 4

Leading With Empathy and Care

Applications of Intersectionality and Feminist Theory in Library Leadership

Annie Pho

Care, compassion, and empathy are values that are often not explicitly celebrated nor centered in leadership practices. It takes a lot of effort, intentionality, and hard work to be an effective leader, especially in libraries where there are multiple layers of hierarchy. As leaders, there can be a constant push and pull from higher administration and the team that you supervise. At times, it is hard to appease either side, especially if you want to center specific frameworks that are core to being a feminist and critical librarian. Much of this chapter focuses on how to take theoretical frameworks from feminism and critical race theory and translate them into pragmatic academic leadership approaches. Within the library and information studies (LIS) scholarship that focuses on critical librarianship, feminism, and critical race theory (CRT) literature, there is a strong critique of specific neoliberal trends in higher education and the pressure that those trends put onto academic librarians to be more cost-effective in how we approach services like teaching and reference.

Compounding this, libraries have faced so many challenges over the last few years. Many libraries had to close during the COVID-19 pandemic and had to examine how they are complicit in major systemic issues like racism and ableism. These concurrent events have weighed very heavily on library workers, but especially those who are from traditionally marginalized backgrounds. As empathetic leaders, it felt too hard to ignore the fact that the people who make the library operate are human and need support during really difficult times. The pandemic made clear the inequities in our society and provided library leaders with a challenge to make hard decisions about services while also balancing the safety of their staff. At this point, libraries have reopened and resumed in-person services, but there's an opportunity to act upon learned lessons from the pandemic and bring a sense of empathy, compassion, and caring to make sure leaders center doing what is just and equitable.

When folks ask how to ensure that things remain equitable and fair, and how to approach library leadership with a feminist lens, I think back to what my guiding principles are. I'm grateful for all the time and training I was able to do that allowed for some key reflection early in my career so that I could be the leader that I am today. I try my best to center feminist approaches and, more specifically, intersectionality. This is a framework that applies not only to managing a team of people but also to how I approach my work with students, faculty, and staff. I identify as a Vietnamese American woman. I was raised by refugee immigrant parents

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and raised with English as my second language. My positionality informs so much of my work and my leadership style, so I think it's important to state my identities. My earliest feminist memories are of my mother telling me as a child to make sure I got an education so that I could be independent and take care of myself. I credit my mother for instilling feminist values in me at an early age, even though she wouldn't call it that or identify as a feminist. As I learned more about what it means to be an Asian American woman and a feminist, I've incorporated it into my everyday practice as a librarian and leader. Empathy, compassion, and care are all values that I circle back to when I am making decisions, and while it seems counterintuitive to tell someone how to care about people as a leader, I hope the tools in this chapter can make these values actionable.

Applying Intersectionality and Feminist Theory to Libraries

What does gender or feminism have to do with library leadership or libraries? It is my belief that it has everything to do with the gendered and racialized history of libraries and is connected to how our work is perceived. It also illuminates the profession's systemic and persistent issues around how library work is valued in our communities. bell hooks defines feminism as "a movement to end sexism, sexist exploitation, and oppression."[1] The frameworks that inspire my leadership praxis come from feminism, critical race theory, and, more specifically, concepts from Black feminist scholars. Understanding these frameworks has the potential to shift how library leaders make decisions and show more care for their workers. At the core of these concepts, community, equity, listening, understanding positionality, and consensus-building are key to making a more equitable and inclusive workplace. This section provides a very brief overview of intersectionality, ethics of care, and relationality and their connection to leadership. There is a rich body of scholarship within the library and information science field that goes into much more depth about how these feminist theories can be applied, which I am grateful for because it has shaped my work. For the purposes of this section, I intentionally resist the cis-heteronormative ideas about gender as a binary; rather, I will use this as an opportunity to think critically about the gendered behaviors and roles we traditionally assign to specific groups of people. bell hooks has advocated that feminism is for everybody in our best interest, so we can work toward a better future in our work.

The demographics in the field of librarianship historically have been (and still are) predominantly women who are white. Scholars like Suzanne Hillenbrand[2] and Shana Higgens[3] have explored the connection between librarianship's gendered history and continued challenges with the lack of resourcing, pay, and respect librarians receive. Taking a feminist lens shows how we can work on addressing the gender inequities that exist and embrace the communal and relational aspects of our work. Higgens digs more deeply into these issues by encouraging librarians to embrace some of the feminine approaches to librarianship that focus on care, maintenance, and service work—labor that is often not valued in academic libraries. Advocating for this type of labor, which is hard to measure using quantitative metrics, is actually a

path forward for the field to create something new. A more practical example of this is looking at annual reviews or promotion processes for academic librarians. A librarian can take a quantitative approach and list how many classes they have taught or how many research consultations they have provided; however, what is harder to communicate using the metrics we typically use to measure success is the amount of labor it took for a librarian to find inroads with their faculty and to market and promote their expertise and services to students. Sure, the amount of time could be counted, but how do we measure the emotions that came up during that process—the frustration of hearing a "no" or the feeling of pride when you have really connected with a student and felt like you helped them? Those stories are harder to tell, and yet so much of that relationship-building is crucial to our success as librarians. The work of Anastasia Chiu, Veronica Arellano Douglas, Joanna Gadsby, Alana Kumbier, and Lalitha Natara[4] on relational-cultural theory (RCT) and LIS highlights the importance of relationship-building and centering community. They explain that RCT as "connection is at the core of human growth and development," and their research explores RCT's connection to librarianship. A main takeaway from their work is how "centering relationships and connection in library work, though complex and difficult, can be a transformative practice," which more library leaders can try to not only encourage but also make space for their staff to build community and relationships. What is sometimes perceived as trivial or not crucial to the workplace is actually central to keeping staff engaged and sustained and contributes to higher staff morale.

Understanding racial dynamics should be part of every library leader's priority, and so often leadership is unwilling to address or acknowledge how race impacts the experiences of BIPOC librarians, library staff, and students. The tenets of CRT, including "racism is ordinary" and counter-narratives, are also important for us to incorporate into our work because this is also how we move forward to make true progress.[5] Additionally, intersectionality is also central to understanding how dynamics and relationships between people are connected to systemic issues of oppression and marginalization. Intersectionality, a concept coined by Kimberlee Crenshaw, looks at how race, gender, and other forms of identity intersect and shape the experiences of Black women and women of color (WOC).[6] She also points out how identity politics in movements like feminism has left out women of color, and that intersectionality provides a framework to talk about these gaps. It is incredibly important for the library field to understand these frameworks since we still struggle to hire and retain BIPOC library workers. The research I have done with Rose Chou examines how intersectionality impacts women of color (WOC) librarians and shows how many WOC are called to do so much invisible and emotional labor, such as serving on diversity committees or being tasked with additional racial affinity work, often because they are the only person of color in their libraries.[7] Many women of color talked about how rewarding this work was when they were able to connect with students or patrons who shared their background, but they also mentioned how their library supervisors did not often recognize how time-consuming this work was in addition to their full-time workload. Other negative experiences also came up; for example, WOC were constantly questioned about their credentials or their authority, which led to low morale and burnout. Kaetrena Davis Kendrick and Ione Damasco delve even further into the role of burnout in

academic librarians of color, showing how racism and low morale in library workplaces have adverse emotional, cognitive, and physiological impacts.[8] Seeing how these things manifest in libraries for BIPOC librarians helps build more awareness of how the needs of library staff will differ depending on their positionality. Library leaders should be aware of these dynamics in order to support BIPOC library staff and community members.

Now that these concepts have been introduced, we can discuss how they can shape leadership approaches to being empathetic, compassionate, and inclusive. The role of management and leadership means being an advocate for the people in our units and working within the traditional hierarchies of a library, striving to do the best we can to provide a platform and space for the librarians and staff to express themselves and do the work that they find meaningful. Part of taking a feminist approach to leadership is doing what is possible to flatten the hierarchies and providing avenues so that every person in the library has a voice. Being a feminist leader isn't always about being the loudest person who is front and center, getting all the accolades and attention. A feminist leader lifts as they climb by providing opportunities for their staff to succeed and find fulfillment as much as possible. This can take many forms, such as collaborating on presentations or projects, connecting librarians and staff to campus opportunities, sharing scholarship information, and highlighting the work accomplishments to library administration who may not otherwise be aware. In my own experience, I worked with a library staff member who mentioned that it was her goal to publish at least once before she retired, but she didn't have the chance to do so on her own. I collaborated with her on writing a case study for a book chapter on a major innovative project we had developed together. I tried my best to listen to her personal goals and do what I could to help her achieve them. Making these critical connections is an act of care and a way to empower library workers to have more agency over their own work.

Relationships are a significant part of the work that we do as librarians, whether it's with our community or within our workplaces. As leaders, it's important to highlight the relationship and community-building that folks do and regularly acknowledge and validate that hard work. It's important to me to also show appreciation for everyone's contributions. One way to do that is to schedule regular check-ins to keep communication open. This is an opportunity to tell that person how their work is connected to other work in the library and share their accomplishments with the wider community. There are times, as a middle manager, when it is necessary to articulate how much effort goes into relationship-building to library and university administration who don't see the full impacts of day-to-day activities of library departments. For example, my department is in charge of organizing the library's welcome week event, and library administration was invited to stop by, and they saw that over a thousand first-year students stopped by the event. While it's impressive to write that statistic down in an email or report, it's even more impactful when administrators can see the excitement of the crowd and how library staff are actively welcoming the students. A strong library community can help build coalition in difficult circumstances, so leaders should do what they can to also allow their staff to bond and connect with one another. Library leaders tend to have a zoomed-out view of the work that happens in a library, so connecting librarians and staff to

other folks who might be in alignment is also a way to build relationships outside of your own department or division.

The personal is political, and people who work in libraries are impacted by political events. The last few years have been full of tragic events that have directly impacted BIPOC and marginalized communities. Recognizing the humanity and showing empathy for the people who work inside the library is important in addressing issues of low morale and burnout. Library workers may be impacted by current events like hate crimes, pandemics, natural disasters, and sometimes silence or lack of acknowledgement adds to their pain. There were times when I went to work feeling heartbroken about current events that impacted my communities, and no one at work acknowledged the events or asked how I was doing. These kinds of silences make library workers feel invisible when they are grieving extreme acts of hate within their communities. Reflecting on our feelings during those incidents, we encourage leaders to acknowledge acts of harm and encourage staff to take time if they need, or offer support if they need to talk. Showing compassion in these circumstances can mean understanding positionality for how some actions and events impact people in different ways.

Leaders are often tasked with decision-making and policy-setting that can be painful and stressful if the decisions negatively impact staff. Other times, decisions are made to hopefully improve workflows or make people's lives easier. This process is not intuitive, and the default mode is patriarchal, top-down decision-making—something that contributes to low morale and staff anxiety. Taking a feminist approach to decision-making can make even hard decisions a little bit easier by giving staff transparency about whatever the issues are and gaining consensus and feedback to make decisions that directly impact them. Sometimes this can take the form of calling meetings to hold space for staff to debrief or process difficult news, or communicating your own insight into a particular issue. It is important to communicate often and listen to what the team is saying. Leaders must be clear about what can and can't be done in difficult circumstances. Feminist leadership aims to give people agency in creating their own work realities by providing transparency that allows people to understand what decisions need to be made and what has to be done.

Self-Reflection Tools

Taking the time to reflect on your value systems and what contributes to your vision for empathic, compassionate, and equitable leadership can help you center these things as you move forward as a leader. These articulations can be revisited when you have new initiatives, difficult decisions to make, etc. Below are some reflection questions to help you bring in more compassion and empathy.

Leadership Journey

- Reflect on your positionality and how you identify (race, gender, sexuality, class, etc.)
- What is your first feminist memory? How has that shaped who you are today?[9]
- What is your personal journey to leadership, and how did your positionality show up throughout your journey? Were there people who supported you throughout this process? What elements of their mentorship have inspired your own approach?
- In relation to your identity, consider the aspects that are privileged and reflect on how this may have positively impacted your leadership journey.
- What areas of identity or bias do you need to better understand and further build empathic, compassionate, and equitable leadership?

Team-Based Tools

These tools are small gestures to help build a community culture of mutual support. Embodying ethics of care can take the form of small acts of affirmation, feedback, and connection. You can introduce these to the communication plans of your team as a way to facilitate more community, transparency, and care.

- Cultivate a culture of transparency and affirmation.
  - Create weekly "check-in" and "check-out" points. At the beginning of the week, team members post or share what they are working on for the week and any special events or things they want to promote.
  - At the end of the week, team members post their highlights of the week and share gratitude and appreciation for colleagues. The team can then affirm what the person has achieved or is proud of.

- Create opportunities for team bonding and relationship-building.
  - Host a team retreat so staff have a chance to get to know each other outside of the building.
  - Celebrate every win! Shoutouts and celebrations for milestones and accomplishments are small ways to build community.
  - Actively listen to your staff and find opportunities for them that align with their goals.

- Practice tenets of "slow librarianship."[10]
  - Create periodic times throughout the year where there are no (or extremely reduced) meetings to allow for library staff to work at a natural pace.[11]
  - Changing work culture at a structural level to facilitate slow librarianship is a way for library leaders to model an ethic of care.

Conclusion

Cultivating compassion, care, and empathy in libraries takes intention, reflective practice, and listening. Libraries and library workers face a myriad of challenges in the workplace, but centering feminist praxis is a way to combat low morale and systemic conventions that continue to marginalize people in the workplace. Taking inspiration from feminist theory and critical race theory, there is hope to push back against systems that replicate themselves in libraries to create more equitable and inclusive spaces, especially for BIPOC and traditionally marginalized library workers and our communities that we serve. We can build toward an equitable workplace by finding ways to build up and strengthen our relationships, being transparent about the work we are doing and decision-making, and showing compassion for workers.

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CHAPTER 5

Case Study: **Building Toward Community**

Collaborative Processes in a Teaching and Learning Department

Veronica Arellano Douglas and Mea Warren

This case study examines the collaborative, inclusive processes used to create and sustain a new Teaching & Learning department at the University of Houston Libraries. We are two women of color who manage a diverse department of six librarians at a minority-serving institution (MSI). Inclusivity in leadership is critical in such a setting, for the good of our team, ourselves as managers, and our campus community.

As department head and assistant department head, we wanted to create an intentional culture of learning and collaboration, one where each librarian in our department felt supported, heard, and valued. With these goals in mind, we initiated a series of group activities that allowed us to model group collaboration early in our department's inception. Through these processes, we created an inclusive departmental foundation built on shared values, a solid community agreement, joint purpose, and a consistent approach to teaching.

Positionality Statements

Veronica

I've been teaching in academic libraries since 2007 but did not become a manager until well into my career. Instruction librarianship isn't always thought of as a path to leadership, but so much of the work of teaching in libraries translates to management and supervision. Empathy, listening, visioning, and problem-solving are all a part of the instruction librarian's toolkit. These skills served me well as I transitioned to an instruction coordinator and supervisor position in 2018, and later a department head role in 2021.

Mea

I started as a science liaison librarian in 2015 and always looked to learn about leadership through professional development programs like the Minnesota Institute for Early Career Librarians and the American Library Association Emerging Leaders program but was never fully sure I would be a leader. Our libraries' reorganization in 2021 presented an opportunity to become a manager and assistant department head, and I saw it as my chance to put skills I learned into practice.

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Institutional Context

The University of Houston (UH) is a Carnegie-designated R1 Institution with over 46,000 students located in Houston, Texas. UH is a designated Hispanic-serving Institution (HSI) and an Asian American and Native American Pacific Islander-serving institution (AANAPISI).[1] About 45 percent of students are first-generation college students.[2] UH Libraries is a member of the Association of Research Libraries, with a total staff of 109 FTE, including forty-seven librarians spread across five libraries (one main and four subject libraries).[3]

In fall 2021, the UH Libraries underwent a significant restructure, which included the dissolution of the Liaison Services department, elimination of the libraries' subject liaison librarian program, and the creation of three new departments: Research Services, Collections Strategies & Services, and our department, Teaching & Learning (T&L). Some of the former subject liaison librarians, as well as a small instruction librarian team, were moved into the T&L department. Additionally, two new-to-the-institution librarians were hired in fall 2022 and summer 2023, completing our department staffing structure of eight librarians: department head, assistant department head, four teaching and learning librarians, and two student success librarians. The T&L department is responsible for integrating information literacy into curricular and co-curricular learning experiences for both undergraduate and graduate students at UH.

Setting a Foundation

As the new T&L department leaders, one of the first things we realized we needed to do was create a sense of community in our department. Liaison Services was a large but cohesive department, and many subject librarians felt a strong connection to their liaison identity and departmental colleagues. Although librarians were excited about their new roles in T&L, we wanted to honor their previous experiences and make sure they felt connected to their new colleagues and work. This required a substantial amount of time and effort to set a necessary foundation for our work together in terms of purpose, the work itself, values, and ways of working together. To figure out how to work best together, we began by creating a community agreement. A community agreement is a shared agreement between people (can be learners or colleagues or group members) about how we communicate, interact, and relate to one another. They help foster a sense of connection, create accountability when needed, and provide a foundation with which to communicate through disagreement and decision-making.

Using gradients of agreement as our voting tool to reach consensus, we set out by asking department members (including ourselves) the following question: What do you need from every person in this group to collaborate effectively, feel empowered and supported, and do your best work?[4] We asked our team to share their thoughts via Google Jamboard, then discussed this brainstorm as a group to clarify existing ideas, discuss gaps, and surface which ideas people were most passionate about. It was also a good opportunity for members of the

department to dialogue with one another and learn more about each other's professional needs. Then we, as department leaders, reviewed the Jamboard, created preliminary categories of responses, discussed them with the department, and made changes at their suggestion. Together as a department, we drafted statements for a community agreement based on the brainstorm statements and categories and asked members to vote on what was most important to them. We then created a draft, voted, made necessary changes, and ultimately adopted a living document that would inform the way we worked together and treated one another. One of our student success librarians creatively used Canva to give each of us a printed and laminated version to place in our offices as a daily reminder of how we work with each other. We hold a yearly review of our agreement, where any member of the department can suggest changes or initiate discussion. We also do a special review when a new librarian joins our department so that they can make suggestions for changes to the agreement. The community agreement has changed a bit since its creation, with new statements added by new and existing department members. Department members also collectively decided to add a section on what to do if one of our agreements is broken to ensure accountability within our department.

It was important to us that everyone in the department shared a common purpose, vision, and values that would inform our work. As department head and assistant department head, we shared a draft of our departmental purpose from the proposed restructure documentation, the teaching philosophy from the previous Liaison Services instruction team, and our current roles and responsibilities as outlined in our new position descriptions. We asked questions about what our department members liked and wanted to keep, what we wanted to change, and what was missing from the documents. Based on that feedback, we then created a departmental purpose, philosophy, and learning outcomes document that would guide our work, incorporating both curricular and co-curricular information literacy approaches, a statement on collaboration with faculty and staff, and our approach to assessment. All of these documents directly impact our day-to-day work and decision-making.

Sustaining Our Inclusive Culture

The work of creating an inclusive, collaborative department doesn't end with foundation-setting. We must create, implement, and revise structures and processes that ensure that librarians feel supported, informed, and able to contribute to the department's work. To do so, we embrace the following values in our work culture: collaboration, communication, and celebration.

You can't command people to be collaborative, but you can model, encourage, reward, and set expectations for working with others. We have adopted a group approach to departmental goal-setting each year, wherein all department members share ideas, opportunities for new projects, and issues of note from the previous year. From these shared comments, we then develop a set of departmental goals that inform individual librarian goals. We discuss individual goals at several department meetings, encourage librarians to team up with colleagues

with similar ideas for accountability and support, and make sure we all know what we are working on. Throughout the year, as department leaders, we model, encourage, and facilitate asking for help. We all seek and offer feedback on any piece of work—lesson plans, conference proposals, writing, learning object creation, etc. Librarians are encouraged to co-teach and co-plan classes, workshops, and programs, and peer observation of teaching is a necessary part of our onboarding process and continued professional development. Librarians will often observe their colleagues teaching new classes or trying out a new activity. They also use observation to better understand how to teach research within a particular subject area that may be unfamiliar to them. We've set an example of asking for help with complex research consultations, before, during, and after meeting with researchers. In short, we acknowledge that as a department we have a variety of experiences and expertise, and when we work together, the work we do is enhanced.

We've also built a solid sense of trust in our department based on frequent communication and information-sharing. The UH Libraries holds biweekly leadership meetings with all department heads, associate deans, and the dean, after which department heads are given a meeting summary of items discussed to share with their respective departments. This may include library policy changes, university business, or general updates. Department heads are encouraged to discuss this summary with their teams and hold space for comments, concerns, and questions. As Teaching & Learning department leaders, we then hold weekly department meetings where any member of the department can add to the agenda, ask questions about library leadership meetings, and make announcements. We meet one-on-one, bi-weekly with the librarians we supervise, focusing on their goals, professional development needs, and day-to-day work. These one-on-one conversations are critical to building trust with the individuals we manage and staying tuned in to the work of the department. We can then facilitate communication between upper administration and the librarians in the department, which is critical in hierarchical library structures like ours. We consistently ask our department members for feedback about policies and information coming from administration, and more critically, take those questions and feedback to our associate deans and dean. We have a solid feedback loop that ensures librarian concerns and needs are heard at all levels of leadership. It is the department head's responsibility to bring questions, concerns, and comments to their associate dean, who will share what information they can, and bring these comments and questions up to the dean when needed. Together, the associate dean and department head are responsible for revisiting these questions and concerns and continuing to share information with the department. While not all departmental concerns or suggestions can be implemented or acted on, it is important for the department head to offer explanation, clarification, and feedback from administration.

Once a month, we switch out our department meeting to a longer "learning session," wherein different members of the department teach others about an idea or practice of interest to them. These learning sessions are an informal way for librarians to communicate their professional interests and learn from one another. Additionally, we have a dedicated Microsoft Teams space where we frequently communicate both formally and informally. Department members

use the space to request support with classes, ask questions about a research consultation, and post calls for proposals or professional development opportunities. It is also frequently used to ask quick questions about events happening on campus, where to go for lunch, or what new media (TV shows, movies, podcasts, music, etc.) people are engaging with. It's a great way to stay connected, given the flexible nature of our work environment, where some members of the department may be on-site or at home on any given workday.

Lastly, it is important to celebrate all the work that we do. We make it a point to host individual birthday celebrations throughout the year and have a team-building party at the end of each semester, complete with food and games. At the end of the academic year, we create personalized awards for everyone in the department to show our appreciation for one another and the work that we do. Each week, at the end of our departmental meetings, we leave time for "kudos and good things," where we all have an opportunity to thank and congratulate one another on all kinds of accomplishments, from a spectacular conference presentation to a great co-teaching experience. We also share moments of joy from our day-to-day lives and celebrate the good things that have happened to us throughout the week.

These practices, when viewed holistically, have shaped our department into one that is inclusive, collaborative, and responsible to not only students and faculty but to one another. Members of the department understand and value the work of their colleagues. They have a shared purpose and approach, and an agreement to work together in a respectful, empathetic way. Yet they are all individuals who carry out their work differently and make an effort to learn from one another. We recognize that all workplaces and colleagues are different, but through our work with our department, we have identified a few organizational considerations that can be useful for implementation in other environments.

Considerations

Many organizations and leaders use the term "inclusion" without explicitly defining it. In some contexts, it's used alongside diversity and equity efforts, which are usually outward or public-facing rather than directed at the working environment and library workers. When working with a team, it's important for all workers to have a shared, explicit understanding of inclusion. In our case, inclusion is about members of the department being heard, respected, and treated with empathy. We want to remove barriers for our colleagues so they can fully participate in the work of the department and libraries. This includes ensuring that members of the department are given the opportunity to share ideas and feedback in multiple modalities. To give them time to reflect before important discussions, we often create online spaces where department members can share thoughts anonymously and asynchronously, followed by discussion of the ideas they connect with during the meeting. Librarians are encouraged to offer and ask for feedback in group meetings, one-on-one, and via email, so that everyone can choose the communication channel with which they are most comfortable. Although we are back to work in the library building, we continue to hold department meetings online, knowing that

colleagues may be working offsite for a variety of reasons, and we offer to hold individual meetings in the format that our colleagues prefer. Without these necessary accommodations, we would not be a truly inclusive department.

It's important to note that, as department leaders, we want to model the collaborative processes we have instituted in our department. As head and assistant head, we collaborate on decisions, goals, and activities that contribute to the current and future work of our department. We teach, facilitate research consultations with students and faculty, and make it a point to co-teach and co-plan workshops with those we supervise. We value their expertise and experience and want to demonstrate that through our actions, not just our words. We also make it a point to include our colleagues, when appropriate, in scholarship and service opportunities so that they can continue to grow as professionals. This shows our librarians that we practice and gain valuable insight from demonstrating the ideals we've created for our team.

Creating these ideals, ensuring inclusion, and modeling these behaviors were imperative during a time of change for our library. At the time our department was formed, we had a new dean, interim associate deans, and new departments. Although we were in a period of transition, we had the full backing and support of our dean and associate deans to take the initial time needed to set a foundation for our department. They recognized that to create a cohesive department that worked well together, we needed the first few months to engage in intensive professional development, learn how to work with one another, and ensure that we shared a common vision and purpose. We encouraged department members to take advantage of the library's generous professional development funding and learn from one another as they gained new skills teaching in a variety of disciplines. Team-building is often thought to be one of the most important first steps in creating a new department or unit, but what we found was that ensuring our team felt supported to do their jobs and could work well together were the most critical first steps in creating a cohesive team. Through our training, community agreement, and early projects, we learned to trust one another as colleagues and then wanted to celebrate the work we did as a team. Without administrative support, this would not have been possible. We jokingly talked about "flying a plane while we were building it," but the metaphor was true! The work of our department never stopped, but we were able to limit our work to essential tasks so that we could form a cohesive unit. In doing so, this created a sense of stability and peace for department members during a time of change. It also gave T&L department members a greater sense of autonomy and responsibility. Our administrative team was and continues to be a model for giving department leaders the time and space to set their team up for success.

Conclusion

Creating a new department is not easy; however, engaging in collaborative foundational work with all department members creates a blueprint for the department moving forward. When librarians know they have direct influence on how their department operates, they have

greater trust in leadership and investment in their work. They know that they are never alone in anything they may face at work and have the support of both colleagues and supervisors. This creates a healthier work environment where all department members, including those new to the organization, can contribute their ideas and expertise. We hope that other libraries can model collaborative leadership of their own to build a stronger sense of community and care within workplace structures.

Notes

1. "Table 312.40. Enrollment and Degrees Conferred in Degree-Granting Hispanic-Serving Institutions, by Institution Level and Control, Degree Level, and Institution: Fall 2022 and Academic Year 2021-22," National Center for Education Statistics, accessed July 25, 2024, https://nces.ed.gov/programs/digest/d23/tables/dt23_312.40.asp; "Table 312.60. Enrollment and Degrees Conferred in Asian and Pacific Islander-Serving Institutions, by Institution Level and Control, Degree Level, and Institution: Fall 2022 and Academic Year 2021-22," National Center for Education Statistics, accessed July 25, 2024, https://nces.ed.gov/programs/digest/d23/tables/dt23_312.60.asp.
2. Elvia Limón, "First-Generation Future," University of Houston, accessed November 10, 2025, https://stories.uh.edu/fm22-first-generation-future/index.html.
3. Cherie Turner, UH Libraries Assessment & Statistics Coordinator, Microsoft Teams message to authors, January 9, 2024.
4. Bethany Prykucki, "Gradients of Agreement Can Help Move Groups Forward," Facilitative Leadership, December 12, 2018, https://www.canr.msu.edu/news/gradients_of_agreement_can_help_move_groups_forward.

CHAPTER 6

What Is Emotional Intelligence?

Peter Anderson

Positionality and Intersections

I wish to acknowledge that my perspectives on emotional intelligence (EI) in the workplace (and connected concepts—e.g., emotion) are influenced by my privileges as a middle-aged, straight, white male and my North American-centered experience of work, both as a professor in the humanities and now as an organizational development consultant and executive coach. I strive with humility, but from a position of disproportionate power and security, to be an anti-racist and LGBTQIA+ ally in spaces where the experience of the same workplace culture is very different for some and where dialogue among team members is charged with unequal personal risk. My perspectives are further informed by higher education research on human and organizational psychology, which tends to focus on hetero-normative and PWI subject groups or on organizations outside of North America.

Introduction

The kinds of things we generally talk about in the field of EI boil down to the human capacity to be self-aware, to be socially aware, and to self-regulate. While the capacity for awareness and regulation, and the experience of emotion, are common to all human beings, our ways of understanding them are not necessarily shared across different groups: cultural and gender difference, neurodiversity, and lived experience shape our perception of and valuation of behaviors and traits differently. Even the vocabulary of emotion is significantly varied across linguistic and ethnic groups. For these reasons, bringing intention and awareness to understanding and working with the emotional experience of workplaces is a fundamental, inclusive leadership skill.

While the terms and approaches I discuss in this chapter are driven by modern workplace concerns, they are fundamentally connected to all the other parts of our lives. The concepts and practices of EI can be applied wherever and whenever people take an interest in the impact of one person's behavior and experiences on another. I encourage people to make their own meaningful connections between modern concepts of EI and their own traditions and experiences because these concepts are just one way to describe something that is part of humanity's

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long encounter with trainable awareness and the factors that influence how we make decisions and take actions.

Libraries are very complex work environments, and many library staff in the organizations I've worked with are expected to shift quickly between modes of interaction or between work tasks. Human beings don't slough off our brain states or experiences as quickly as work like this requires. We carry cognitive and emotional context between tasks. In my organizational mindfulness work with teams, we construct shared processes and practices that mitigate this reality. But on the individual level, one of the great benefits of emotional intelligence skills is that we can work against or mitigate the frictions that such quick changes introduce into our own work experience as those changes are happening. This brings an immediacy and effectiveness to EI skills that many people value and that we often associate with highly effective leaders and team members.

Last, while all human beings are equal in their capacity[i] to understand the ways emotion influences their experiences and to develop their emotional intelligence, individual differences and neurodiversity play an important role in determining how that capacity is expressed. Anything I offer below as a practice or skill may need to be adapted. And much of what I will suggest below falls into what I call the "simple-not-easy" problem: these actions and practices seem very simple but are in fact quite difficult to do and do well, especially in a charged moment.

History

"Emotional intelligence" is a term used to describe a set of competencies connected to understanding and managing our emotional and cognitive experiences, if it's fair to separate the two. Within this broad definition, EI shares some basic approaches with mindfulness traditions that focus on the awareness and regulation of emotions and with philosophical traditions that view the "rational" and "emotional" (or "spiritual") aspects of human experience as deeply connected. But EI is also grounded in neuroscience, behavioral science, and positive psychology. This allows EI practitioners to scientifically measure emotional intelligence behaviors in order to give focus to, for example, skills development, leadership coaching, and team cohesion. The most recent research on emotions and the brain (and consciousness), such as the work of Lisa Feldman-Barrett at Northeastern University, demonstrates just how tangled and interdependent all these categories are.

The term "emotional intelligence" was coined in 1990 in a pivotal study by Peter Salovey and John D. (Jack) Mayer. Salovey, Mayer, and later their colleague David Caruso, continued to

i. It is legitimate to query that all human beings are "equal" in their "capacity" to be self-aware. This is a very complex comment. These articles help to explore further and acknowledge this complexity: https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/self-consciousness/ and https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/pii/S0376635721002278.

build a very robust research program around EI, and this research focus spread to many other research groups. The concept of emotional intelligence was popularized by Daniel Goleman in 1995, who had worked for most of his academic and journalistic career in the field of social and emotional learning.[1] Many people know about emotional intelligence through one of Goleman's books.[ii] In 2008, Mayer, Salovey, and Caruso refined their initial definition of EI, which is the definition I adopt in this chapter:

> Emotional Intelligence includes the ability to engage in sophisticated information processing about one's own and others' emotions and the ability to use this information as a guide to thinking and behavior. That is, individuals high in emotional intelligence pay attention to, use, understand, and manage emotions, and these skills serve adaptive functions that potentially benefit themselves and others.[2]

Emotional intelligence understood in this way intersects with two other major areas of research: social and emotional learning (at all ages) and brain science. It is essentially a form of metacognition. Emotions and memory have extensive connections in our neurochemistry, and we can sometimes actively affect our neural patterns along with mental and emotional states through breath regulation, sensory activation, and visualization. This leaves us in an interesting place, where we are as profoundly affected by emotion as we are by any other electrical impulses in our nervous systems. Certainly, our brains predict, experience, and react to events apart from the conscious mind, but we can also consciously engage our judgment centers to self-regulate, to make choices, and to adopt new habitual behaviors.[3]

Emotional intelligence skills are very significant, I would argue, on the academic side of higher education and research because we are an industry of technical professionals who also interact extensively with people. Our institutional structures organize us into something like affinity groups, with shared (often diminishing) resources and of much longer duration than in almost any other industry. Some of our most toxic behaviors, our legacies of discrimination and harm, and our pervasive conflicts require radical, systemic, and structural remedies. But many, if not all, other issues can either be remedied or mitigated by emotional intelligence skills and strategies. For leaders within these spaces, emotional intelligence is critical because we are at the nexus of organizational and personal/personnel concerns. So, even if we don't want to or aren't empowered to use our leadership to directly address the less functional structures of our institutions, we can be more effective by managing our own responses and behaviors. And if we engage in focused development, we can become more resilient leaders and, frankly, happier people.[4]

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ii. The two books in which Goleman focuses on emotional intelligence are *Emotional Intelligence: Why It Can Matter More Than IQ* and *Working With Emotional Intelligence*.

Measuring and Understanding EI

A number of EI assessment models have been developed out of the research that began in the 1990s. While there are many assessment tools, there are two basic models of assessment: trait models and mixed models. Trait models treat EI as an ability (somewhat like IQ) that can be quantitatively measured using specific tasks in different skill domains. The MSCEIT (Mayer-Salovey-Caruso Emotional Intelligence Test) is one of the most widely and longest used trait assessments. Mixed models tend to be perception-based measurements of demonstrated skills or behaviors. In mixed models, the focus is on how the subject and others perceive demonstrated behaviors that indicate competency in the skill domains. The most widely used assessments are mixed models.

The existing assessments and models of emotional intelligence vary in the competencies or skills domains that they assess, often driven by the purpose of the assessment (e.g., a leadership EI assessment may focus on motivating people, delivering and receiving feedback, and managing conflict). There are, however, four categories, broadly understood, in every assessment:

A. Self-awareness
B. Self-management
C. Awareness of others
D. Relationship management

Highly desired workplace and leadership skills, from time management and attention management to empathy and inspiring performance, may all be understood as practical applications of our skills in these areas.

In my own work, I have come to value mixed models very highly because they tend to provide a solid foundation for formative assessment and leadership development. Moreover, feedback on our perceived behaviors offers valuable insights not only for the subject but also for their specific workplace culture. An effective emotional intelligence assessment always gives a leader the next question to ask and deep insight into the undercurrent of workplace norms that we often must navigate entirely by feel.

Within the scope of emotional intelligence assessments, there are also ways to assess these workplace norms and staff engagement. Organizations and teams have both emotional culture (or normative culture) and cognitive culture. Cognitive culture comprises the things we tell ourselves and the world about what we are and how we engage. Within complex organizations, like libraries and universities, we can find cognitive culture verbalized in mission and values statements and policies. These statements influence the external (institutional) and internal (personal) narratives we build to interpret our experience of work. Emotional culture comprises the ways in which we non-verbally create or reinforce behavioral norms that shape our experience of work. Organizations and teams that can align cognitive and emotional cultures are impressively effective and inclusive. But when the two cultures do not align, or

when there are multiple cultures in conflict with each other, the workplace can suffer. Extreme misalignment might be described as toxic. Becoming skillful in the EI domains can open a path for observing, expressing, and managing these cultures in order to create more inclusive and prosocial teams and workplaces. Our behaviors, decisions, and interactions create or reinforce our emotional or normative cultures. As leaders, with focused development of EI, we can create new momentum and direction in the cycle and promote workplaces that are more inclusive, collaborative, creative, efficient, and productive.

This positive effect comes about because *pleasant* emotions tend to broaden and build our thinking, increasing creativity, productivity, and improving relationships. Over time, these pleasant emotions build prosocial behaviors, flexibility, and efficiency at work. *Unpleasant* emotions tend to narrow and limit our thinking, producing the opposite effects and promoting reactive and antisocial behaviors. It's not possible to always have pleasant emotions, nor is it possible to avoid unpleasant ones. It is possible, however, to use our developing EI skills to transition between these states more quickly, to limit the effects of unpleasant emotional and neurological brain states, and prolong those of pleasant ones. It's not just that emotions affect our thinking; it's that emotions are part of our thinking and the neurological systems that connect throughout the body.[iii]

One of the most significant leadership challenges in academic and research libraries is that few have been trained to manage other academics and librarians. Some receive sustained leadership development opportunities or leadership coaching, but many internal, mid-level leaders are transitional, happy to step back into their old roles when "their turn" is over. The same is true for the kinds of cross-functional teams we see in most academic and research libraries: we have mostly figured out how to interact with each other by doing work together, not by explicitly learning how to work together. Normative cultures are getting passed along, whether they're dysfunctional or healthy.[iv] Through careful and consistent use of directed awareness, EI skills can support incremental change and new, aligned cultures while they promote effectiveness and resilience as much for leaders as for members of teams. EI development supports wellness within the workplace, drives team effectiveness, and creates strong foundations for other kinds of positive change skills. It all starts with awareness.

Awareness

So, what is *awareness* as an emotional intelligence skill in the workplace? Some people and teams might prefer to frame awareness as a kind of mindfulness that directs and supports

iii. Further reading: 1) Fosselin and West Duffy, *No Hard Feelings: The Secret Power of Embracing Emotions at Work* (New York: Portfolio/Penguin, 2019); 2) Feldman Barrett, *How Emotions are Made: The Secret Life of the Brain* (New York: Mariner Books, 2017).

iv. Explore this concept further in Travis Bradberry, Jean Greaves, et al., *Emotional Intelligence 2.0* (San Diego: TalentSmart, 2009).

attention and focus, mitigates stress and anxiety, and boosts productivity and workplace wellness. Others might prefer a strictly EI perspective, focusing on awareness of our emotional states and the things that impact our mindset and experience of work. Through awareness, we develop skills in emotional reasoning, manage unproductive behaviors in ourselves and others, and employ EI-based frameworks to understand how our experiences shape our deliberative processes and behaviors. In an EI paradigm, you cannot build and demonstrate other skills without first becoming aware inward and outward. Awareness, therefore, becomes the first skill we can develop to become more mindful and to respond to our (inevitable) emotions, the (inevitable) emotions of others, and their (inevitable) effect on interactions and decision-making. Without awareness, we are, simply put, reacting without care to the world around us.

Self-awareness and Self-regulation

Self-awareness is the ability to perceive, understand, and regulate our emotions and their effects. We become more skillful in this ability by extending the range of experiences we can perceive and understand, by increasing the range of vocabulary we can apply to our experience, and by decreasing the amount of time between experience and self-understanding and between self-understanding and self-regulating.

We are constantly experiencing things through the many lenses of our prior experience. In EI development, we focus specifically on experiences and events that carry significant "charge"—that is, experiences that have pleasant energy or unpleasant energy for us. Sometimes, we also notice experiences that seem to have no charge or energy for one person but might for others. An event or interaction with a charge activates us and provokes a reaction that is built out of our prior lived experience. That reaction—a behavior, a mindset, a physical state—serves in some ways as a reward for our brain, which is applying its very powerful predictive models to the world around us. The brain craves this predictability and experiences uncertainty in the same way it experiences threat. If you want to throw me for a loop, invite me to a meeting without telling me what it's about. The uncertainties involved in that, especially around other significant factors or events, will send my brain into prediction overload as it presents a multiplicity of potential reasons for a meeting. I can pretty much guarantee none of the most dominant ones will be pleasant. The invitation to a mystery meeting might have a very different effect on another person or no discernible effect at all. When, however, I become aware of how and why I have been activated, I can begin to step into my power to engage. I can, for instance, follow up with an email asking for an agenda or meeting topic. But without awareness, we are pushed from activation to reaction and neurochemical reward: no thought, no reflection, no judgment.

Awareness that we have been activated allows us to interrupt the reactiveness cycle. In EI development, we are *never* seeking to stop emotions or eliminate emotions; the only sure way to do that is to stop electrical impulses in your brain. We are seeking primarily to be aware

of the emotional charge that is present and then to pause the reaction. In that pause between activation and reaction/reward, we can deploy our skills to then help us understand, evaluate, and mitigate. We can deliberately respond instead of reacting. This is just as rewarding.

Developing Awareness

The most successful strategy for developing awareness of emotional experience is reflection. In the moment, we are activated and feel the push to do, say, or decide something. It is very difficult at first to reflect in the moment once we're activated. Human beings and their brains are predictable and highly trainable. We develop habitual reactions and patterns of behavior naturally and very effectively, for good and for ill. We need to be able to create some distance from the reactivity cycle in order to intentionally build new neural pathways for new behaviors until we are skilled enough to engage in the moment. One of the proven ways we can calm our reactivity is to adopt a mindfulness practice, like box-breathing or gentle breathing through the nose. Such a practice uses the brain's natural regulation systems to bring down levels of stress hormones that perpetuate reactive states. It is so much easier to "respond, not react" from a calm state of mind and calm neural state. And it is also much easier to build new and more useful habits—new predictions—from that place of calm.

So, I suggest making time afterward to reflect on the conditions under which we reacted—to get ready for next time. To end a reactivity cycle, it's necessary to notice not only when we react but also what the circumstances are around the reaction. Because we're human, we tend to focus on what we perceive to be negative reactions as the places to develop first; this is fair enough. But we should also notice our positive reactions, from which we can learn just as much and through which we can build capacity to respond well more often. It's a good sign of progress in this skill when you have added curiosity as a habitual reaction to being activated in addition to whatever the habitual emotion was.

Awareness in Practice

The first step in developing self-awareness, then, is simply to reflect after the fact. Schedule some five- to ten-minute slots in between your meetings or, if you can, take five to ten minutes after an interaction that went really well or really poorly. It's also okay to do this at the end of the day—but much better to do it shortly after the interaction. Take a slow count of ten, breathing gently at a comfortable pace. Using a variation on the W5 method,[v] write down *how*

v. The W5 method (or Five Ws) is a method popularly known through journalism in the twentieth century, where journalists were trained to investigate the five Ws of a story (who? what? where? when? why?). But the practice has its roots in the west in ancient Greek rhetorical theory, where we can see evidence that it was used to structure arguments as early as Aristotle.

you felt, *who* was there, *when* it happened, *where* it happened, and *what* happened as a result. You don't need to think about *why*—"why" is too easily the gateway to unhelpful justifications or to litigating the past. What we're after are the contexts around the interaction so you can begin to diagnose your own behavior patterns. Remember to notice good interactions, too! When you feel that you can do this effectively, you can begin to develop self-awareness in the moment or to prepare ahead of time for situations, people, or predictable events that consistently knock you off balance. A steady practice of reflection will extend and deepen your self-understanding and self-awareness and open the door to the next set of skills.

Self-Regulation

To be consistently aware of habitual, and perhaps previously unconscious, reactions to interactions and events is an extremely empowering skill. Using that awareness to understand, evaluate, and affect your experience of the workplace is the hard work of emotional intelligence. In many mindfulness traditions, awareness is supported by intention. For EI development, our intention is always to move toward and stay more consistently in the pleasant and productive states that drive the more positive workplace outcomes. Sometimes that means being able to maintain a productive state in the face of challenges; sometimes it means being able to bounce back from adversity more quickly.

Understanding and responding to our emotional experience is somewhat different from being aware of the circumstances that activate them, pleasant or unpleasant. One of the critical elements of understanding is being able to name and describe the experience. Most people, unless they've received some training or have done some serious, guided introspection and reading, have a fairly limited emotional vocabulary. In addition, whatever range of vocabulary we have to label and describe our emotional experience, most people are conditioned to perceive their emotional states in specific, usually limited ways. I call these our emotion super-highways.

In executive coaching, for example, clients often report that some interaction or event left them feeling "angry." When we apply a process of emotional reasoning, attempting to find more language (labels, descriptions of physical sensations, etc.) to refine our understanding of that emotion and event, we usually end up with a different label. Sometimes, it *is* actually "anger" or even "rage"—a valuable insight and a powerful motivator for certain kinds of change actions. But more often than not, it is "frustrated," "mistrusted," "dismissed," or "ignored." All these emotional experiences, when properly understood, require a *different solution* than anger (see figure 1).

Self-Regulation in Practice

Once we have deepened our understanding of our experience through the process of awareness and labeling, we can shift to self-regulation and solution-seeking. The EI Skills Framework (see figure 2) is an effective tool that I use with teams to start building skills in productive

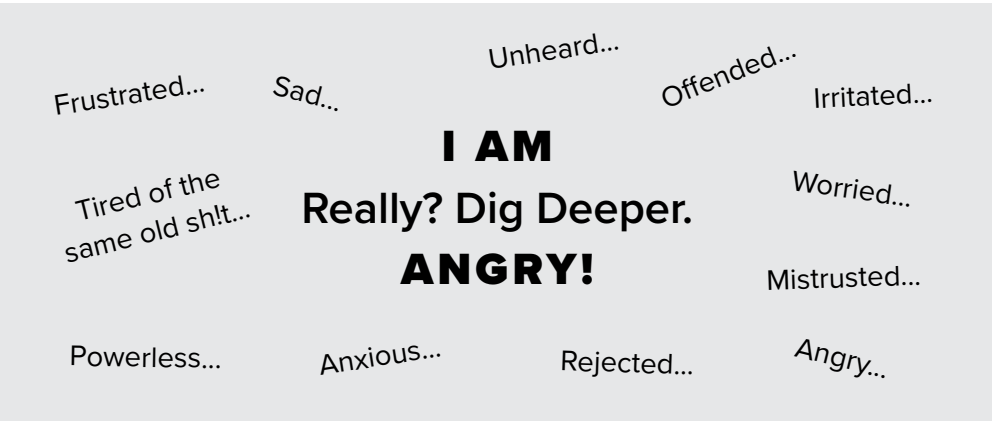


Figure 1. Various emotional experiences can be interpreted or misunderstood as "anger," but require different solutions for coping. SOURCE: innercitadelconsulting.com

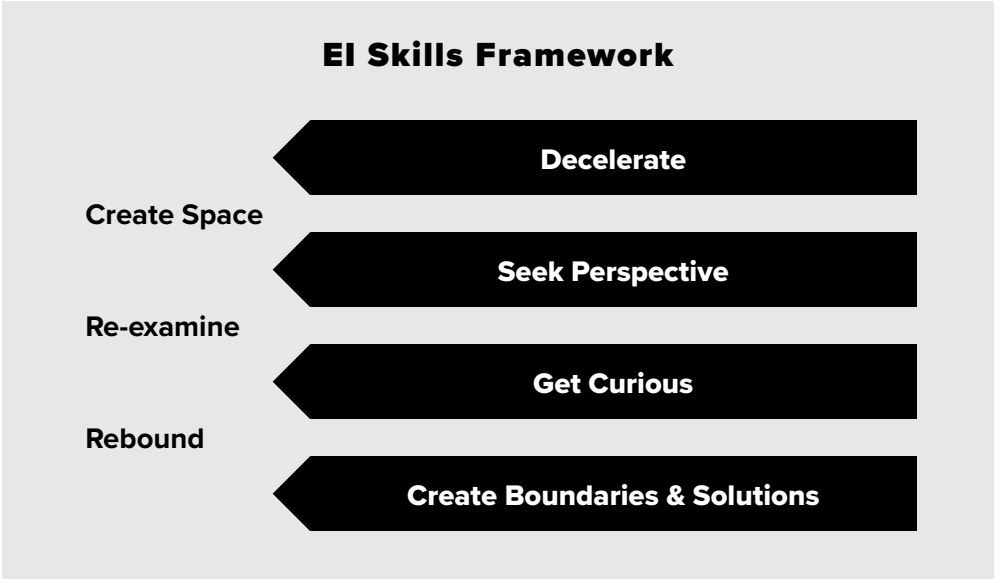


Figure 2. The EI Skills Framework can help build skills for solution-focused self-regulation. SOURCE: innercitadelconsulting.com

(i.e., solution-focused) self-regulation. Once we have developed our out-of-the-moment skills in reflection and understanding our experiences, we can begin to deploy those skills in real time. We become aware that we are being activated and probably understand at least some of the contributing factors. We identify what we think is the thing we are feeling.

When we decelerate a situation to evaluate and understand it, we create space that we can use to seek perspective on our own experience. When we seek perspective, we start to re-examine the circumstances and influences on our experience, activating our curiosity instead of our reactivity and moving us into more productive and creative neural states. Once we become curious, we can begin to rebound—to move from being activated by the

"charge" in the moment—so that we seek new boundaries or solutions to the obstacles in front of us.

It is this first step of deceleration that is often the most difficult, especially for high-energy leaders or individuals with a bias toward action. I usually suggest that people (or teams) come up with several stock phrases that indicate a need to pause or that ask for time to decelerate. These can be obvious ("That comment is hitting hard, and I need a moment to reflect.") or less obvious ("That seems very complex to me. Can we pause for a sec?" or "I'd like to think about that for a minute."). If we can successfully negotiate deceleration, the rest will come together with practice. To be clear, we are not trying to change the emotional experience we are having; we are seeking to understand it clearly so that our response is *chosen*, *relevant*, and *proportionate*. This is the essence of self-regulation through active understanding.

Awareness Outward and Relationship Management

Awareness-of-others and managing emotions in a shared, social context happen in essentially the same way, although across a more dynamic and complex range of circumstances. We can use the same reflection skills we use for ourselves on others. The key difference is that we cannot ever fully understand the experience of another. But to *try* to understand a colleague or a patron requires that we direct active and nonjudgmental curiosity about their present experience while maintaining a clear understanding of our own; this is, by the way, a good working definition of empathy. Gently asking a colleague who is clearly activated and charged about what label they might give to their experience in that moment and then supporting them through an emotional reasoning process is an act of courage. The vulnerability required on the part of the person who is activated is also courage. Unless you are working in a very safe workplace, it may seem nearly impossible to engage in the moment in this way, especially if there is not a normative/emotional culture that supports these behaviors or if the charge is simply too high. Maybe it's enough to sit with a colleague, to breathe with them, and to be silent and curious. Perhaps that safe workplace seems a very distant ideal. But if only two individuals can reach that level of trust in each other's skill to engage in the moment … imagine even that small shift in culture.

Regardless, it is always possible to reflect after an interaction with another person, just as we did for ourselves. The caution, however: resist the temptation to psychologize or to assume anything about another's motivations or intentions. Using the W5 method, as above for self-awareness, can help a great deal (with a slight modificatio*n*).

- "From my perspective, *how* did this person appear to be feeling?"
- "From my perspective, *who* was involved?"
- "From my perspective, (*when*) what was the impact of the timing of this interaction?"
- "From my perspective, (*where*) what was the influence of the physical circumstance?"
- "From my perspective, can I describe *what* happened as objectively as possible?"

The chief benefit of this skill is *not* to accurately understand someone else's experience, but to give you an opportunity to discover patterns in their behaviors and to evaluate how you interpret them. Again, actively avoiding the question *why* is fundamental to adopting a nonjudgmental reflection. *Why* is very often a doorway to misunderstanding and conflict, because in solitary reflection, we can only rely on our bias to answer.

In a psychologically safe scenario, you can directly engage in dialogue with the other person, become curious about their experience, and check with them for understanding. In cases where that is not possible, you can use insights you may have gained through reflection to support the other person's experience of the workplace in productive ways or to change behaviors of your own that may carry a charge for your colleague. This is the value of awareness of others: not to fully understand someone, but to put yourself in a position to develop empathy for their experience, to explore narratives and perspectives other than your own, and perhaps to support someone else in managing their own emotional experience more productively. So, the skill of awareness inward (along with the EI Skills Framework above, figure 2) transfers into the domain of awareness outward, with a slightly different purpose: to develop a habit of adopting non-judgment and curiosity about *other people's* experience. But what to do after that?

Relationship Management in Practice

If I want to influence change in others, I should pay close attention to my own behaviors; if I want to change my own behaviors, I should pay close attention to those around me. From an EI Skills perspective, internal motivation to change behaviors might be enough to create change, but we also need external feedback and stimuli to change in ways that are productive for the circumstance or environment. To be clear, the following exercise is rooted in workplace performance. The intent is not to change or suppress identity or experience, but rather to manage ourselves and our workplace relationships by building awareness of common ground and difference. When that awareness is in place, we can decide to adjust (or not) in order to achieve a better workplace outcome.

For example, I become aware through reflection that I am consistently being activated when I receive real-time feedback on my ideas during decision-making meetings. I have established that my experience could be labeled as feeling mistrusted and that when I am activated in this way, I become extremely defensive. It is not particularly useful or healthy to tell myself to pull it together or to discount my experience. Instead, what I can do is to bring my active awareness to how others are experiencing my reactions or to bring my active awareness to how others receive feedback in this situation. (See figure 3.) Using the EI Skills Framework, I can use my curiosity to evaluate, validate, or change my habitual response. Over time, as I self-regulate inward and notice outward, I can build a more effective habitual response to this kind of feedback as well as gain greater awareness of others. Likewise, if as a leader I need my colleagues to be more responsive to my feedback, I can direct my active awareness inward and consider how my behaviors around giving feedback might need to be adjusted for different colleagues or different contexts.

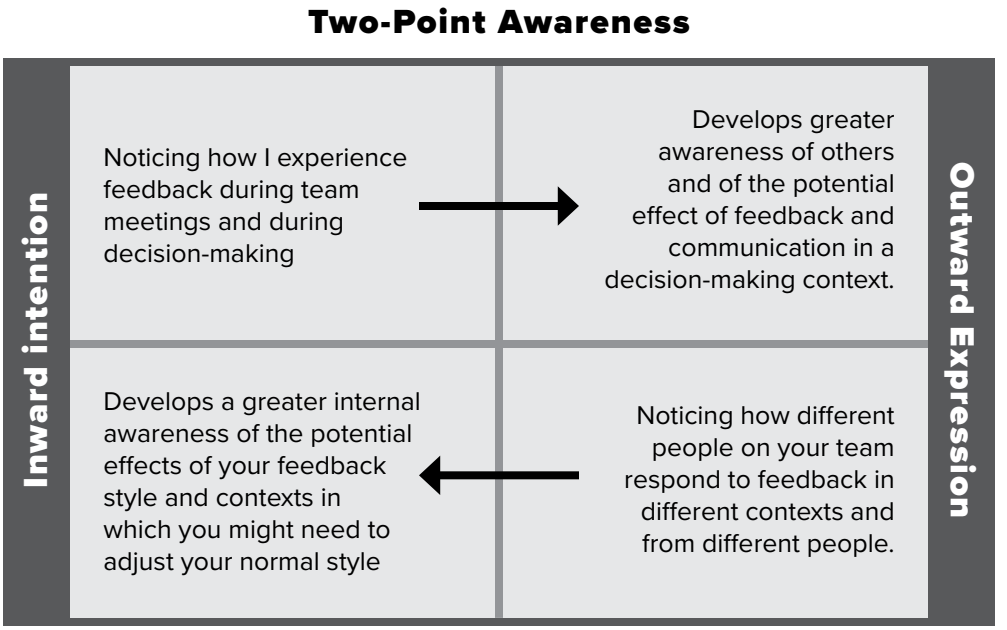


Figure 3. Using two-point awareness to notice inward intention to modify outward expression, then in turn develop greater internal awareness. SOURCE: innercitadelconsulting.com

I realize that this is exactly one of those "simple-not-easy" practices. This is how we learned social behaviors as children, after all, and so it ought to be pretty straightforward. But if more people were easily able to self-regulate in order to manage relationships in the workplace, we would have far less workplace friction and conflict. Using an EI framework, in combination with skills development, offers us a way to gain perspective, choose new behaviors with reflection, seek input from colleagues about how those new behaviors are landing, and modulate as needed.

Belonging, Purpose, and Applied EI Skills

Academic and research libraries require us to work persistently and collaboratively over time and across functional areas to complete important projects with our colleagues. It is in these spaces that we can develop emotional intelligence skills to build better working relationships and processes over time within groups.

Druskat and Wolff argued in 2001 that teams and groups develop a kind of collective EI shaped out of trust, identity, and efficacy, and that the net effect of developing the emotional intelligence of individuals in a group is better participation, cooperation, and collaboration.[5] After almost two more decades of research, they argued that team cohesion, or how well a group of people stick together to reach a shared goal in spite of setbacks or adversity, is similarly developed out of three social needs: belonging, shared understanding, and control (or agency).[6] In addition, teams with higher average emotional intelligence seemed to be much

more effective at helping each other meet those needs and tended to be more cohesive.[7,8,9] When teams are in trouble, we can always trace dysfunction back to at least one of the needs.

Belonging refers to understanding one's specific purpose on a team; without understanding individual purpose, and having it understood by others, a team member cannot feel truly included in the work and normative culture of the team. Shared understanding refers to the cognitive and normative cultures that a team operates under—the predictable mechanisms through which team members engage with each other and their work. When a team has a clear sense of collective and individual purpose, they have a good reason to engage in healthy ways and to preserve well-developed systems of responsibility and accountability. Control or agency refers to the ability to exercise control over one's own work within a team and to be involved in accountability and the consequences for contributions. If a team member has no agency, they cannot feel empowered on a team. Without accountability, it is difficult for a team member to see how their contributions are important to the collective work.

I understand it this way: I will be able to feel like I belong and matter for a shared purpose if I am given agency and then held accountable; when I belong, I will act to uphold or change our norms in order to support the work I belong to. Inclusive and effective norms also support and enhance accountability structures and the ways in which people share power and agency within systems, which in turn reinforces a sense of belonging. We already know from our own experience that emotions in teams and workplaces are contagious, that high-functioning teams tend to be inclusive and to help each other manage adversity and success, and that teams that cannot solve relationship conflict or task conflict tend to fail, to underperform, or to create more conflict.

Conclusion

Our EI skillset is a critically important mechanism for communicating, supporting, advocating for, and promoting our needs within the workplace. In conclusion, I would like to draw our attention back to the two fundamental ideas with which I began. The first is that the vast majority of EI researchers agree that the term "emotional intelligence" represents a set of skills that can be learned and developed; EI is not a fixed trait. With practice and attention, our skills will deepen, like any other skills, and to the extent that our workplaces value and champion these skills, they will become part of the normative culture of the organization. This cannot be overstated within a workplace development context: all of us can become more proficient and effective at EI skills, and everyone benefits when we do. The second idea is that, as is true for conflict transformation and inclusion efforts writ large, developing self-awareness and understanding about what we can and cannot control is the critical first step in a long journey, whether for an individual, a team, or a whole organization.[vi] Simple, not easy.

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vi. Farah Harris' book *The Color of Emotional Intelligence: Elevating Our Self and Social Awareness to Address Inequities* (Flossmoor, IL: WorkingWell Daily, LLC, 2023) provides a focus on emotional intelligence within a lens of inclusive behavior.

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CHAPTER 7

Case Study: **From Library Staff to Faculty Librarian**

Modeling Kindness and Consideration

Boutsaba Janetvilay

Introduction

I've worked at three different institutions in the California State University system for most of my adult life, starting as a student assistant, then staff, and now faculty. My current institution, Fresno State, is also part of the twenty-three public California State University system. Fresno State has recently been classified by the Carnegie Foundation as an R2 (high research activity) institution. It is federally recognized as a Hispanic-serving institution as well as an Asian American and Native American Pacific Islander-serving campus. There were close to 24,000 students in the 2023–24 academic year, with almost 2,000 working toward a master's degree and about 600 on a doctoral track.[1] The breakdown of student ethnic identities is as follows: 16 percent white, 57 percent Hispanic, 12 percent Asian, and a small percentage of African American (3 percent) and other ethnicities. Fresno State offers seventy-two bachelor's, forty-eight master's, and three doctoral programs.[2] Nearly 65 percent of the students are the first generation of their family to attend college.[3]

Given the diverse and dynamic environment, I feel well-connected in serving the campus community. With almost twenty years of experience as staff in an academic library, I demonstrated significant professional growth before transitioning to the role of head of the unit as a faculty librarian. During my time as staff, I gained valuable hard and soft skills across various library departments, which laid a solid foundation for my advancement. As head of the unit, I further honed my leadership abilities and took on greater responsibilities. However, being the lead librarian for metadata and resource description at Fresno State truly broadened my perspective. It highlighted the importance of thinking more globally and innovatively, while also emphasizing the need for inclusive collaboration with students, staff, and colleagues. This experience reinforced my belief in empowering students, supporting staff, and uplifting my peers. As a leader, I prioritize involving our team in the decision-making process, whether we are planning and executing projects or setting annual goals, ensuring that everyone has a voice in shaping our shared vision.

While I do not choose to formally lead unless needed, I always provide informal leadership to encourage others to lead and influence them to involve many voices. I can inspire and empower others to take on leadership roles, which in turn has allowed me to grow and evolve as

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a leader through collaborative efforts with those around me. I am a democratic leader because I include everyone's points of view and perspectives when it comes to teamwork. For example, when I was an undergraduate, I joined the Asian American Student Association at Long Beach State and quickly became part of the leadership team. I appreciated the team-based approach because, alone, I lacked confidence, but together, we empowered one another to build a force that changed and influenced decisions that affected student activities on campus. I choose to pursue positions where I can influence and lead by example.

I learned early on that it's important to show up and be present. A kind of silent power can, sometimes, echo louder than words. I grew up in a multicultural family while being acculturated with American values; my father is Lao and my mother is Chinese. My father, an authoritative figure, would glare over at a group of us loud kids and manage to control the noise volume just with his eyes. From this experience, I've learned to read the social cues of my Asian father. Not that this kind of behavior would work in an important professional meeting room, but it instilled an awareness that there are various kinds of intercultural communication styles. Being from a multiculturally literate family, I must adjust and adapt yet never lose my core values of being Asian: humble and kind, even if at times it seems hard to hang onto.

I noticed that several scholars have embraced silent power, producing some of the most influential works of their careers. Antonio Gramsci, for example, developed key ideas about hegemony and passive revolution while in prison.[4] His work remains significant in critical studies, particularly for his concept of cultural hegemony, which explains how ruling classes maintain power through ideological dominance and cultural practices that shape social norms and values. Similarly, Paolo Freire wrote his most influential work, *Pedagogy of the Oppressed*, while in exile.[5] Stuart Hall, known for his work on race and media representation, expanded the scope of cultural studies to address issues of race and gender and exemplified how intellectual work can thrive under challenging conditions.[6] These examples show how silent power, whether in solitude or under constrained circumstances, can lead to profound intellectual contributions.

As a quiet person, I believe that I am most effective when I can lay the groundwork for the team, and then we can work together toward accomplishing the work. So, at work, I emphasize the importance of sustainable workflow, thorough documentation, clear procedures, and team-oriented guidelines, the elements that ensure long-term success through collective effort. This approach cultivates transparency and demonstrates the result of our unit's work.

From Staff to Librarian

I've worked in every department of the library, except interlibrary loan and administration. I started as a student assistant in the Technical Services repair room, where I also provided mail service, government documents, and periodical sorting. One year, due to my desire to work full-time as an enumerator for the Census Bureau, I was let go from a student assistant position in the Technical Services area. Still, I was able to return to the library in Multimedia

Services as a student assistant, where I helped patrons with media types of equipment, CDs, films, and microfilm/fiche machines. I left the library to work for the University Foundation office and then the Education department. While working as a research assistant for the education professor, I learned about scholarly research processes. By the time I finished with my bachelor's degree, I ended up working for the library again as a part-time staff member at the periodical desk. From that part-time position, I was offered a full-time position in the Circulation department. So, my pursuit of librarianship as a career began. I developed a love for the entire process of investigating using online resources, scholarly research processes, and complete bibliographic citations. Library research strategies are some of the exciting concepts I look forward to sharing with students.

Being a new immigrant, I maintained a low passing GPA as an undergraduate, so I could not meet the LIS GPA requirement for admission. Therefore, LIS was put off while I figured out how to raise my GPA. I then moved to work in the electronic databases area of the Reference and Information department, where I became more intrigued by online databases and automated retrieval systems. I then continued to pursue graduate work by taking classes in the educational multidisciplinary field. After twelve years, I received an MA in the multicultural and social foundation of education, a degree that gave me the leverage to pursue my interest in LIS. While working as staff in the Reference and Information Commons department and taking classes, I became a mother of three children. After several years, I had an opportunity to work in Technical Services at Sonoma State, another CSU campus, where I moved to be closer to family. As my technical services skills improved, I moved from acquisitions and cataloging to electronic resources management. I also earned my degree in LIS from Drexel University within two years.

Fortunately, almost two years after I gained my MLIS, I was able to obtain a part-time job as an adjunct at the Santa Rosa Junior College while continuing to work as a full-time staff at Sonoma State. When there were full-time tenure-track positions available, I was often overlooked by both institutions. I don't know if it was because of my limited English skills, the color of my skin, or due to a perceived lack of soft skills. I had done every prescribed course provided by the ALA Spectrum Scholars leadership training program in 2010. So, with all the obstacles and the struggles I've overcome as a staff and faculty, I remind myself to encourage and inspire students and staff that I mentor to not face the same struggles.

What I can say is that institutional racism is an unavoidable discrimination that many diverse students, staff, and librarians will face. My colleague and co-author, Balladollid Lopez, and I often engaged in candid discussions about our experiences with micro-racism, offering each other vital support as we navigated academia. Together, we critically examined how to leverage our roles to serve and connect our community within academic settings, a theme central to our recent article on practicing critical global citizenship in an academic library.[7]

I served in various staff positions for many years before taking on a full-time librarian position, which happened to be a unit leadership role. As a leader, I wanted to learn from our staff and understand what they want to do in their roles. I was once in their position of feeling voiceless and powerless, when my opinion did not matter. As a staff member, my goal was to oversee the

work of student assistants, making sure that the daily operations were running smoothly. I did not have to think about the overall big picture of a department. Because of the lack of autonomy and variety of responsibilities, it felt like a chore and busy work. It was frustrating at times, and I felt a sense of being stuck with no way to contribute to the organization or department meetings. Our sense of responsibility felt different than being a lead professional librarian. When I became a librarian, I wanted to ensure that our staff wouldn't feel the way I used to feel.

Staff lenses are different from leadership ones. As a leader, we have different priorities, including the interrelated work with other departments, the library, the administrative office, and the campus community. In addition to overseeing staff's work and providing guidance on each project we handled, I was also responsible for my own professional growth and development to meet the retention and tenure review requirements and progress toward securing tenure.[i]

I desperately wanted a librarian job, but even with all the library experience and knowledge, I could not get a librarian position in the town where I resided. While there were several opportunities, I received limited support within my workplace. Rather, they encouraged me to look at the full-time roles at the other local institutions. Ray Pun and a couple of former CSU librarians discussed similar experiences and concerns in a podcast.[8] We need to work more creatively to include others and those in need of our help and support. Most of the time, we don't lose anything when we uplift others.

While I did not expect a handout, some guidance would have helped ease the pain. I was demoralized after numerous years and various job application rejections. Fortunately, I believe one dean and a generous search committee saw the light that needed to ignite in me to become a librarian and gave me a chance by offering me an alternative to the position that I applied for. When I applied for an electronic resources management position, they also needed to fill a metadata librarian position. A pivotal moment in my career came with this more suitable offer since I had experience with cataloging and training in metadata description. Therefore, a combined position of cataloging/resource management (Alma) and metadata description (CSU ScholarWorks) was my start as a full-time librarian and leader.

Empowering Teamwork

So, I began my work experience as a librarian unit lead for resource and metadata description. Leading a small cataloging unit of three staff members and one contract project cataloging librarian, I was faced with having to learn and manage professional librarian-level work and supervisory skills. My first encounter was challenging due to our differing work styles and workflows. Some of the workflows differed from the practices at my previous institutions. As I learned about the staff and my colleagues, I learned my strengths, values, and weaknesses. I also learned to trust new groups of people.

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i. A six-year probationary period for library faculty in the CSU system.

When I started at Fresno State Library, I took a StrengthsFinder test, which was given to all employees to help fine-tune their superpower.[ii] My top five strengths were *learner*, *achiever*, *analytical*, *consistency*, and *relator*. The results aligned with my passion and interests. I first laughed at my strength as a learner and cynically questioned how this could help with work. Despite how I felt, I tapped into my strengths and contributed to the institution and the library. Because I had *learner* as a strength, my dean supported my pursuit of professional development activities by allowing me to take a refresher course on cataloging and metadata. I took the first year of my position to learn not only the tools and applications that I needed for the position but also how to manage efficiently and effectively. I continued to learn about the changing or advancing technology and new standards involving cataloging and metadata. With that knowledge, I encouraged our staff to move in the direction of attending work-related training more frequently.

I emphasized continuing education and professional development for myself as well as for staff. I became chair of the Faculty Professional Development Committee. As chair, I learned to fairly distribute the budget as well as explore whether there is an opportunity to support staff training development. The importance of professional development can be impactful in retaining staff and faculty. Gaining more knowledge gives staff a sense of being an expert in their field of work.

As I continued my growth, I worked to enhance my other strengths.

- *Achiever*—empowered me to strategically complete projects with the team for the department, and to participate in and sometimes take on a lead role in committee work. This trait also helped me achieve grant writing skills and fundraising goals for community services that I've been involved in.
- My *analytical* strength gave me insights to refine data analysis and improve project processes and committee work.
- My last two strengths—*consistency* and *relator*—are both in perfect alignment with the work that I do as a cataloger and metadata and resource manager. The nature of cataloging and metadata description requires that we know and comply with several standards, programming codes, and updates, as the work is continually changing to adapt to new technologies and frameworks. As a *relator*, I continue to work on connecting resources with the local community and campus at large.

Empowering Staff

At our weekly departmental meetings, we strategize and analyze misrepresented metadata or errors in the University Library catalog. I have found that a shared decision-making process,

ii. StrengthsFinder, https://www.gallup.com/cliftonstrengths/en/254033/strengthsfinder.aspx.

transparency in project management, and sustainable documentation work well for the department. We solve most of the cataloging and metadata description issues or problems together as a group. We use our weekly meetings to discuss situations or issues that anyone in our department may have encountered. I never claim to know all the answers, but I always figure it out from the group meetings. When I do not know, I reach out to my peers or mentors.

When our agenda is not filled with issues or problems to be resolved, we use the time to build community by sharing project updates, significant life events, and food or other new experiences. Because I come from a different background than some of my colleagues, I often bring in fruits and food that are in season to share. I've brought in a pastry from the Philippine bakery, Armenian desserts, along with fresh Rambutan and Jujube (fruits). In this way, I support local community businesses and create connections among staff by learning together about our local produce and ethnic food ingredients.

Everyone appreciates having space to engage in critical conversations. We listen to one another's concerns and help each other through our work and life experiences. Our group is small enough that we allow ourselves to grow and learn together, whether to beat life's issues or get work support. We listen with sympathy and share with empathy. We all have gone through life trauma and changes. A healthy state of mind means good mental health at work and home. It's important to have good mental health and moral support from our peers and colleagues. We are not performing neurosurgery, but we also do not want to provide misinformation or misrepresent any crucial data we created while working.

Shared Decision-making

At the beginning of the academic year, before I provide my annual report to the dean, I consult with our team about goals we should work toward each year. Our unit goals are initially proposed by me as the lead librarian. The proposal is then discussed and negotiated to keep within the scope, ability, and capacity of our unit's work. Lastly, we approved it as a team. As much as I want to push forward with many other projects, I need to keep in mind the morale, integrity, and value of each team member. The notion of enriching staff experience and a positive work environment is always at the forefront of my mind. I may have an idea, but if the staff are not in agreement with the goals and project ideas, I cannot move forward alone. I trust their insights and appreciate their input. It's a team effort. When we start a project and complete it together, there's a sense of accomplishment as a group. It makes each individual proud to have contributed to such a significant project. External events also influence our annual goals. For example, throughout the COVID-19 pandemic, we focused on data clean-up projects as having accurate access to resources, which was crucial at the time.

Setting achievable professional activities is an important part of our unit's goals. As I believe that professional development is always critical, I encourage them to build in space to keep up with systems and practice changes from OCLC, Library of Congress, and Alma. This process helps them advance their skills and knowledge.

Project ideas are brought forward to the group, sometimes by members within the unit or sometimes by the ILS administrator. As a group, we discuss the issue during a meeting and then assign someone—usually a staff lead, ILS administrator, or me—to research and figure out how to resolve the problem. At the following meeting, we discuss the solution and how to tackle the project by evenly distributing the bibliographic records work. In parallel, I manage and track all our projects in the university library wiki under our unit's project plans section.

Transparent with Project Management

Our library uses a wiki as an intranet. The wiki is a good way to be transparent and for the rest of the library to see what projects we are working on and what we have completed. It is one way of displaying the accountability and accomplishments of our unit. Managing projects is a skill. We use a project management framework to track our work's progress. It's not intended to be micromanaging but instead is a tool to give us a sense of accomplishment as a team. Most of our projects are done together. By tracking our projects on the wiki, we demonstrate accountability to all stakeholders. If they want to, the rest of the library can find out what project we are working on and its progress. Other stakeholders can also view and be invited to collaborate on certain projects.

Open and Sustainable Documentation

The library wiki contains access points to a Google Shared Drive, which provides a sustainable way to maintain documentation. We have documentation of procedures, instructions, and policies. Updating them requires constantly revising documents; tracking the original copy has been a problem in the past. A new workflow process between the wiki and Google Shared Drive has helped us keep the documents in "live mode." This means all documents reside in Google Shared Drive, and the links on the wiki will connect users to the original documents. Anyone with permission can update and revise files with the latest changes to the procedures. In this way, the document remains up to date. It's a minor tweak in our workflow, but it makes a big difference in the documenting process, particularly when there is a lot of turnover. This process allowed our staff to revise and update the documentation with ease.

All employees can contribute their ideas to change our procedures in the comfort of their own time and space. Shared cloud space makes it a sustainable working environment because the document is not on any individual's workstation. Collaboration also allows for a diverse team to excel. My weakness may be someone else's strength in the same way that my strength may be someone else's weakness. I respect that, and it should be a mutual respect. For example, as a second-language speaker, I am not always confident with my writing. I know that one of my staff members is excellent with the English language. So, with documentation, she would pick up where I left off. It's a good balance of working synergy, as long as I know to be true to myself and learn to accept my flaws and weaknesses. At the same time, I also must continue to

sharpen my strengths as an achiever, of being an inclusive leader, team builder, and information organizer.

In each project, we provide space and time for us to grow, find our paths, and bring out our unique superpower. We have learned to accept each other's differences and focus on the goals and objectives of the project that we are working on—for example, the coloring of spreadsheets versus working straight from a list in Alma. I am opposed to exporting a project list from our ILS system to Excel spreadsheets because I believe that Alma designed the workflow so that we can troubleshoot any issues with the bibliographic record right within the module. In this way, we do not need to look up every single item and then fix the data. It eliminates a few steps. The staff feel that exporting the list is a better approach; they can share the workload equally and work at their own pace while the spreadsheet resides on our Google Shared Drive. Since that works for them, I have no objections as long as the cleanup project is done in a timely manner. We all adjusted and adapted to each other's working styles.

Being an Inclusive Leader Means Knowing Yourself

Know yourself, learn to deconstruct your own biases, and make no assumptions. Constantly ask yourself if what you are asking from one staff member is fair to the others. Ask if you are equitable and fair with your staff. What are their areas for growth, and what can we do to support one another? It's not easy to put ourselves into this vulnerable position, but we must be more receptive to others. Also, we must be aware of the various cultural biases that we encounter daily.

Be kind to yourself as well as others. People in the position of supervisor, mid-manager, or administrator must be considerate and kind to people and not forget how we reached this point. We must lead with a kind-hearted attitude. We don't have to be vocal and loud to lead effectively and influence others. If we employ the right concepts and if we are kind and considerate, people are likely to pay attention to us. Then we can influence and lead.

We can change or influence a decision on policymaking, and it's our responsibility to set the path for our students and future colleagues. Leading by example and getting involved with campus committees represents role modeling for our students and staff. Participating in activities that help build and implement policy will eventually trigger some changes in the long term. We are in a position to influence and improve the situations in which we want to see change. We cannot allow imposter syndrome to get in the way of our determination to change or help others.

Here is a small synopsis of my multifaceted perspective on the job application and interview process through my role as a candidate, a search committee member, and an Equal Employment Opportunity Designee (EEOD).[iii] At Fresno State, the diversity statement mandates the

iii. For more information: Fresno State EEO and Diversity, https://adminfinance.fresnostate.edu/hr/eeo-diversity/index.html.

presence of a non-voting EEOD on every search committee for both faculty and staff positions. I completed the orientation to become an EEOD and participated in a search committee on campus. My commitment to addressing systemic racism motivated me to engage in this process, believing it would contribute to the advancement of equitable practices.

Despite efforts to eliminate bias and ensure fairness, such as incorporating an EEOD in the search committee, instances of discrimination persist. Candidates with an accent or non-European backgrounds are often overlooked, despite the diversity of our student population and community. From my perspective as a search committee member, I recognize the importance of finding and selecting candidates who communicate effectively and whose skills align with the needs of the campus. However, it is crucial to have a fair process of selecting future colleagues who can bring change and a diversity of values, reflecting our campus communities. Systemic racism can be quite invisible and difficult to identify and call out.

As a candidate applying for a librarian position, I still get nervous when I go into an interview and during a presentation. I often debate with myself whether to wholeheartedly express my support for an inclusive workplace and the values of diversity or whether I should only share if asked. Even when asked, I answer diplomatically. Many institutions now display their diversity statement on their websites and ask candidates to submit diversity statements. Other institutions are not sharing or requesting these. Even when they do ask diversity question(s), they may not be willing to embrace daily interactions with diverse colleagues in the future. However, it's not true for many other institutions and their search committee members. They may ask the required diversity question(s), but are they truly willing to tolerate daily encounters with their future colleagues? Compromising and tolerance go both ways for the candidate (if they accept the job) and their new colleagues. I believe many places in academia are not ready to deconstruct their own biases.

Addressing systemic behavior can be quite challenging. It's important to develop and build the work of inclusive values and change within the system. Some responsible actions I've taken within my role include being present and getting involved as part of the campus community's commitment toward the direction of diversity. Becoming an EEOD was one small step, yet there's still a lot of work that needs to be done to ameliorate the lives of future students and colleagues. The work of inclusive leadership in academia is barely the tip of the iceberg. As faculty members, we must engage in various committees, tweak policies, and, most importantly, listen to our students and staff. Students are key drivers of change, so we must work with them and campus communities to improve.

Conclusion

In my leadership role, I must set goals, manage projects, and create an infrastructure for the unit while also participating in the Library Faculty Assembly. Over the past few years, I have served as the chair of the Faculty Professional Development Committee, contributing to the Library Faculty Executive, the leadership team of the Faculty Assembly. The experience I've

gained as a unit lead and member of the Faculty Executive team is invaluable. As a unit lead, I have learned to use project management skills early on to help coordinate workflow using the library wiki, Google Sites for our webpage, and a shared Google Drive. The staff and I set annual goals, which include professional training and resource updates. Through my work on the Library Faculty Executive team, I learned that communication is essential.

One year, the team sat across from the dean and collaboratively worked to improve our cultural differences and generational gap in communication and working styles. That was when I found my voice, speaking openly to connect with both my colleagues and the dean. It was a moment when a shy and quiet girl woke up to be a mature and professional librarian. Our goal was to work more collaboratively in a shared governance environment for the interest of the library leadership team. Working in a large organization, we depend heavily on open and clear communication and collaboration with partners from other departments in the library and campus community.

Reflecting on my last few years of experience, I have grown professionally and reached an esteemed rank by embracing my diverse background and offering perspectives, through advocating for more inclusive voices in the library profession and uplifting the local communities. I am also a faculty advisor for the Lao Student Association, where my leadership style influenced and impacted students to do more for their communities. It is all about giving space to those who are finding their voices. They are not voiceless. They are sometimes limited by resources and space. I am fortunate to have been given the opportunity to learn and grow my strengths that needed only nurturing.

Notes

1. "Quick Facts," Office of Institutional Effectiveness, https://academics.fresnostate.edu/oie/quick-facts/index.html.
2. "Quick Facts," Office of Institutional Effectiveness.
3. Ibid.
4. Antonio Gramsci and Joseph A Buttigieg, eds., *Prison Notebooks*, trans. Antonio Callari (New York: Columbia University Press, 1992).
5. "Freire, Paulo (1921-1997)," Internet Encyclopedia of Philosophy: A Peer-Reviewed Academic Resource, https://iep.utm.edu/freire/.
6. Stuart Hall, *Representation: Cultural Representations and Signifying Practices* (Thousand Oaks, CA: Sage, 1999).
7. Balladolid (Dolly) Lopez and Boutsaba Janetvilay, "Practicing Critical Global Citizenship in an Academic Library: Experiences of Immigrant-Origin Librarians," *Humboldt Journal of Social Relations* 1 no. 46 (2024), https://doi.org/10.55671/0160-4341.1249.
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CHAPTER 8

Cornerstones of Inclusive Leadership

Humility and Inquiry

Robyn Andrews and Jennifer A. DeVito

Introduction

The cornerstone of inclusive leadership is the empathy and compassion necessary to lead a diverse group of people. Inclusive leadership leverages knowledge of and respect for each person's uniqueness and the strengths they bring to the workplace. The intersection of inclusiveness and humility is where leaders can foster environments in which team members are valued and in which leaders demonstrate self-awareness and appreciation of others. Humility is a foundational concept in inclusive leadership because it paves the way for acknowledging that one person does not have all the answers and allows for exploration and curiosity.

In their book, *Results: Getting Beyond Politics to Get Important Work Done*, authors Charlie Baker and Steve Kadish write about the importance of leaving ego aside to get the best results.[1] They note that there needs to be "collaboration, cooperation, and compromise" for productivity. In an article based on their book, they note that "[I]nsight and knowledge come from curiosity and humility."[2] Humility is not often a trait mentioned when discussing leadership qualities. Being humble, or demonstrating humility, may be viewed by some as being weak and not a quality one wants in a strong leader. This implies that, as a leader, one is expected to have all the answers and to rarely, if ever, be wrong. However, a leader who demonstrates humility sets an example that no one person can have all the answers and that no one on the team is infallible. A willingness to be humble shows colleagues that everyone's insights, perspectives, and experiences have value and may contribute to the success of the team. A humble leader acknowledges their own strengths and weaknesses as well as the strengths and weaknesses in others. Further, a leader who acknowledges and utilizes the diversity on their team will find that diversity brings new expertise, wisdom, and vision to the team.

In this chapter, we examine the importance of humility and curiosity in a leader and how both can lead to a work culture that values the insight, experience, and knowledge of all team members. We highlight how humility and curiosity—or inquiry—help leaders build stronger relationships and encourage open communication where diverse perspectives are not only welcomed but also actively sought. We explore ways to incorporate humility and inquiry into one's leadership practice to create more inclusive workplaces.

Positionality Statements

Robyn Andrews

As an African American woman working in a staff position of an academic library of a historically and predominantly white liberal arts institution in the South, I have often been on the other side of well-meaning curiosity regarding race and ethnicity. I have also found myself placed in the sometimes-awkward position of being asked for advice on how to address or proceed on a particular issue regarding diversity, equity, and/or inclusion. While experiential and anecdotal responses are important, equally important are giving people tools and resources to engage in a deeper appreciation of the importance of cultural humility, and humble inquiry is a way to investigate personal biases while learning how to communicate with others who are unlike us, especially as we bridge differences between library faculty and staff.

Jennifer A. DeVito

I am a white, middle-aged, cisgender woman who has dedicated more than twenty-five years of my career to the field of librarianship. I have gained diverse experience, ranging from entry-level positions to management roles across various types of libraries, including public, academic, and corporate libraries. My approach to librarianship is deeply rooted in my family's values, which emphasize the importance of education, curiosity, and lifelong learning. These values have guided me in my work in access services and in encouraging inquiry and life-long learning in my own career. As a white woman, a demographic that constitutes the majority of the library profession, I recognize the significant influence and privilege that come with this position. I have made a conscious effort to foster inclusive environments, advocate for equity in library services, and attempt to remove barriers of systematic oppression.

Humility as a Foundation for Inclusive Leadership

"Ooh, ooh, ooh, ooh!" In the 1970s, there was a television comedy show, *Welcome Back Kotter*, about a high school teacher, Mr. Kotter, and his relationship with a diverse group of quirky inner-city kids. Whenever Mr. Kotter asked a question, one of the characters, Arnold Horshak, would immediately raise his hand, shouting those four immortal "oohs," ready to provide the answer. However, Arnold's answer was rarely the correct answer. Many of us have an Arnold Horshak inside us: wanting to be first and wanting (or hoping) to be right.

That behavior is taught to us early and often, especially during primary school years, through a "pervasive answer-orientation of the education system."[3] It is unfortunate that we learn to measure how smart we are, in comparison to our peers, by how fast we give the right answer to the teacher—then we get the reward in the form of a good grade, a gold star, or even a treat.

Fast forward to the workplace, where those same skills have traditionally been valued as leadership qualities—"knowledge is power" and "winning by knowing."[4] Knowing the right

answer faster than anyone else and telling our boss can get us the reward, whether it is an "atta boy," a raise, or possibly a promotion, where we get the ultimate prize: we get to tell people what to do. "Our culture emphasizes that leaders set direction and articulate values, all of which predisposes them to *tell* rather than *ask*."[5] A common narrative would lead us to believe that leaders are naturally bold and fearless, with visionary clairvoyance and magical powers to see opportunities that others cannot. In the workplace, we have been trained to look to our leaders as people who hold knowledge and rarely make mistakes, which does not set a tone for inclusivity or knowledge-sharing. "The reality is this mythical leader is just that, a myth."[6]

Not surprisingly, traditionally desired leadership traits haven't changed much over the decades, even if the way they are applied has changed. The evolution of leadership theory starts with the "Great Man Theory" and the "trait" theory, which posit that great leaders are born, not made. These theories describe leaders who have several shared characteristics, such as the degree of competence in their area of expertise, being energetic, having integrity, high intelligence, and confidence.[7] Behavioral theory asserts that leaders are made rather than born and that particular behaviors can be learned.[8] Situational theories recognize that the environment can play a significant role in one's approach to leadership, specifically focusing on leadership skills during crisis situations or events of the moment (for example, the right person at the right time), where strength in situational awareness and context are prioritized.[9] Lastly, we've arrived at theories of shared, collective, and collaborative leadership practices, including servant leadership, shared leadership, and inclusive leadership.[10]

A quick search on Amazon for "books on leadership" returns about 60,000 results. Adding the term "inquiry" whittles the results down to around 2,000, while combining leadership and humility gets you around 1,000. Combining all three terms reduces your results to a sum total of twelve (your results may vary). How is it that combining the three terms—leadership, humility, and inquiry—returns such a paltry 0.02 percent of leadership books published up to now? It may be due to those antiquated notions of leadership we hold near and dear to our hearts, because, historically, the traits we ascribe to leadership simply don't include not knowing and being willing to admit you don't know. Author Damon Lembi identifies the "know-it-alls" versus the "learn-it-allalls." We all probably know someone who we consider a know-it-all, and we probably don't think too highly of them. Lembi notes that know-it-all leaders "cling to an image of infallibility and believe they've already peaked," while learn-it-all leaders "possess humility, curiosity and courage."[11]

Humility, by some of its earliest definitions, doesn't sound like a valued trait for a leader. The *Oxford English Dictionary* defines humility as "the quality of being humble or having a lowly opinion of oneself; meekness, lowliness, humbleness."[12] Humility has often been associated with a lack of confidence, definitely not a quality one ascribes to a leader. Some leaders might find exhibiting humility difficult, thinking that it might be interpreted as not being able to do their job. Instead, a humble leader is someone who encourages dialogue and questioning while helping team members develop and exhibit their strengths. This type of leadership often takes a great deal of courage and strength of character because it involves both revealing one's weaknesses and empowering others to demonstrate their strengths.

Humility comprises different positive behaviors and traits. It means a lack of arrogance in that leaders understand that they do not know everything, are able to recognize their own strengths, and are confident enough to recognize and utilize the strengths of others.[13] It is possible to lead with both confidence and humility; they are not mutually exclusive. In fact, it can take confidence and strength to admit that one does not have all the answers or that one has made mistakes as a leader and still has some learning to do. Confident humility is "having faith in our capability while appreciating that we may not have the right solution or even be addressing the right problem. That gives us enough doubt to reexamine our old knowledge and enough confidence to pursue new insights."[14] Incorporating humility and inquiry into one's leadership approach gives the leader the freedom to explore and grow through learning. It also sets a tone for the team to be able to do the same.

Rather than being a sign of weakness or meekness, humility involves honest assessment of oneself, of others, and of one's role in the larger community.[15] These three components are the foundation of humility, which can be defined as "the ability of an individual to have a proper perspective of themselves, their relationship with others, and of their place in the larger environment."[16] Fostering humility in oneself and in the workplace requires self-reflection and self-investigation. Leaders should regularly consider whether they are open to feedback, able to admit when they make a mistake, ready to acknowledge when they do not know something, and are eager to learn. This reflection should also include an analysis of what qualities are ascribed to leadership, and whether or not they align with the attributes of humility and inquiry. Humility and inquiry in leadership are not new concepts; however, rethinking long-held beliefs about leadership traits is a relatively new approach in the leadership toolkit. Evaluating how leadership traits and humility and inquiry can coexist is the first step toward incorporating humble inquiry into our leadership behavior.

Why is It Important to Incorporate Humility and Inquiry in Leadership?

In the 1900s, visions of the future seemed to focus on things—walkie-talkie watches, flying cars, moving sidewalks, robots, and other technological advances. Yet, what we find today is that the twenty-first century has come to define a renewal in learning more about human connection. Contrary to those futuristic visions, twenty-first-century workplaces aren't made up of only computers and robots but also of humans from all walks of life with different backgrounds and experiences. The writer Annie Dillard said, "How we spend our days is, of course, how we spend our lives."[17] For many of us, a large portion of our days is spent at work. Some estimates state the average person will spend 90,000 hours at work over a lifetime, so it seems natural that we want to make our workplace as enjoyable and inclusive as possible.

Humble inquiry is a concept introduced by Edgar Schein, a business theorist and psychologist who was a professor at the MIT Sloan School of Management and a foundational researcher in the discipline of organizational behavior. Schein defines humble inquiry as "the

art of drawing someone out, by asking questions to which you do not already know the answer, building a relationship based on curiosity and interest in the other person."[18] This inquisitive approach demonstrates a willingness to build a relationship where the power dynamic between manager and employee is not at the fore. It sets the stage for developing a collaborative relationship based on sharing and valuing knowledge and experience.

There's a saying: "People leave managers, not companies."[19] The firm Gallup reports that only three in ten US employees feel that their opinions seem to count at work.[20] Inclusive leadership entails making each member feel like a part of the team. It can improve morale and retention. Employees who feel included also report that they are more creative and innovative at their jobs.[21]

When a leader uses humility and inquiry as part of their leadership approach, they actively seek input and feedback from team members and engage with them with genuine curiosity and a willingness to consider the perspectives, ideas, and experiences of those on the team. The benefits of humility in leadership include increased team engagement, higher employee retention, and improved productivity.[22]

Like the demographics, the culture in libraries is still rooted primarily in whiteness. Leaders who model humility and inquiry, and who encourage the same in their team, can begin to normalize discussions that question the status quo. When questioning is an expected part of a process, people are less likely to be defensive when a team member asks "why?" In their article, "A Holistic Approach for Inclusive Librarianship: Decentering Whiteness in Our Profession," authors Espinal, Sutherland, and Roh discuss the impact of defensive responses when norms that are centered in whiteness are questioned.[23] This behavior is often reactionary and meant to convey why the questioner is wrong. Defensive responses tend to stifle conversation and communication. People who feel that they have no voice do not feel included. Instead, they feel ignored and inconsequential and devalued. A non-inclusive or non-questioning environment can also increase stereotype threat among non-white colleagues, which is anxiety or concern about reinforcing or confirming negative stereotypes. For example, the stereotype of the angry Black man or woman may inhibit an African American colleague from speaking passionately about an issue for fear of confirming that very stereotype. As a leader, encouraging humility and inquiry sets a tone (and expectation) of questioning and exploration and may reduce the impulse to react with offense.

Humble leadership supports the dignity of others, emphasizing the identity and self-work of others.[24] Both humility and inquiry can be useful tools when interacting with people of various cultural, ethnic, and other identities. This means recognizing that people bring different experiences, perspectives, and emotions to work. A leader practicing humility and inquiry will be able to take the time to make all team members feel included and explore ways that differences can contribute to the diversity and productivity of the team.

Cultural competence has been identified as a core component of inclusive leadership. It can lead to better communication and teamwork and improved collaboration. But this suggests a sort of checkbox mentality with an end goal, a graduation and diploma, with one having learned all there is to know about a person simply by learning about their culture. This

could lead to a false sense of security that acquired knowledge is all that is needed to create a more inclusive workplace environment. More recently, however, a recommended addition to the leadership toolkit is cultural humility. Similar sounding yet very different.

Cultural humility is "…encouraging curiosity about the context within which others live"[25] and "...knowing and behaving to enact culturally responsive leadership practices,"[26] such as recognizing cultural holidays and providing ongoing training opportunities on workplace inclusion. Cultural humility requires a leader to understand their own perspectives and biases and, perhaps, to challenge them. It also requires acknowledging that groups of people are not a monolith, even if they are from the same or similar cultures. Leaders should regularly assess their own identities and biases and be committed to learning strategies to challenge assumptions, learn about others, and take new and different approaches at work. Cultural humility as a leadership practice fosters a sense of cohesiveness and appreciation for different identities.

Leaders need to be ready to ask questions, then listen, and engage with team members through conversation. "A conversation that leads to a relationship has to be sociologically equitable and balanced."[27] Creating a culture of humility and inquiry while actively seeking to understand different perspectives and backgrounds enables librarians to create a more welcoming atmosphere that values diversity. This inquisitive approach builds trust by helping ensure everyone is heard and given the opportunity to contribute, shifting the power dynamic from manager versus employee to an interactive and collaborative relationship based on the sharing of knowledge and experience. Humble leaders are more likely to explore new ideas and encourage their team to do the same, promoting creativity and a positive work environment.

This is not a "one and done" exercise but a series of successive conversations, which then makes the process interactive and collaborative. This approach demonstrates a willingness to build a relationship where the power dynamic of manager and employee is not at the forefront and where a relationship based on the sharing of knowledge and experience can exist. "Developing interpersonal cultural humility involves critically reviewing perceptions of cultural difference and encouraging openness and respect during intercultural encounters."[28]

Incorporating Humility and Inquiry into Leadership

Brené Brown, a researcher and podcaster, tells us that "studying leadership is way easier than leading."[29] The reality of being a leader can be lonely, exhausting, and challenging. So, how can humility and inquiry be incorporated into leadership practice?

An initial step involves humility—acknowledging that you will make mistakes and missteps and that there will be plenty of opportunities for learning and growth. Humble inquiry as an approach to leadership requires actively deciding to question yourself and allowing people to voice opinions and ideas. Leaders must acknowledge that incorporating humility and inquiry in their leadership style is "a life-long process of developing self-awareness, openness, respect for cultural difference and examining power imbalances."[30]

Humility can complement any type of management style. The benefits include greater acceptance of diverse ideas and an increase in generosity, the ability to forgive, and helpfulness.[31] Humility seems most applicable for leaders who have a coaching style "focused on individual growth, and involves dedicating time to understand your team members' long-term goals, both for their personal and professional development."[32] The coaching management style lends itself easiest to humble inquiry—asking questions with a genuine desire to listen and learn. However, even authoritative (not authoritarian) leaders can apply humility. An authoritative leadership style involves "motivating your team members by connecting their work to a larger organizational strategy, helping them understand how their day-to-day tasks contribute to a greater purpose."[33] Simply asking how employees see their roles in the bigger picture cannot only give people the opportunity to be heard and contribute but also gives leaders the opportunity to build out institutional knowledge. "Leaders who practice humility are more open to different perspectives, have a more accurate outlook of the world's complexity, and recognize personal limitations in leadership settings."[34]

Humble leaders build teams with diverse perspectives and experiences and are ready to use those qualities to strengthen the team and create inclusive, productive environments. Acknowledging that no one person will have all the skills or knowledge necessary in the workplace allows leaders to "surround [themselves] with people whose skills complement your own and empower them to shine in areas where you may fall short."[35] Inherent in this approach is the leader's willingness to allow team members to strengthen their skills and be an integral part of decision-making. This does not mean that leaders will abdicate their responsibility for leading the team but, instead, it means that everyone feels welcome to contribute ideas and feedback, with the knowledge that the leader will ultimately make decisions based on that input.

- **"Be the first to trust."**[36] Lead the way by being first to open up, be vulnerable, and, as Elsa from the movie *Frozen* so memorably reminded us, "Let it go," with the "it" being your ego. Ego has no place in inclusiveness because it centers the self to the detriment of others. Model the behavior you would like to encourage in your team, such as asking questions of your team members, admitting mistakes or misunderstandings, and sharing your workplace experiences. For example, be willing to share that you didn't bring your "A" game on any given day. One leader readily shares when they are feeling overwhelmed, either personally or professionally. Not only does this represent trust and vulnerability, but it also allows the team to know they can share when they're not on their game as well. Diversity and inclusivity should be viewed as strengths in a team. Leaders should "be humble enough to defer to the expertise of others in both personal and professional settings. But I can assure you that in doing this, you'll create an environment where people are empowered to do their best work."[37] For example, don't leave department or divisional retreats for once a year. One library director invites the entire library to a brainstorming session on ways to ensure library goals and objectives align with the institutional strategic plan. Then that leader encourages the same at the

divisional and departmental levels. Being the first to trust means letting go of the notion that you and you alone know all and know best, while instilling a sense of trust in your team to invest in the success of the parts and the whole of the library.

- **Audit *how* you ask questions.** You may be wondering: "What do you mean *how?* A question is a question … isn't it?" Humble inquiry isn't about asking any ol' questions or asking questions without rationale, leaning on the tried-and-true because we are "prisoners of our organizational vocabulary."[38] Dagdeviren notes, "When we question a person or a piece of work, we meet with resistance. Questioning judges, investigates or interrogates. It looks for gaps, expects a valid reason why there are gaps, and tells that there might be consequences."[39] Conversely, asking shows interest and curiosity. It may seem like a contradiction to distinguish between asking and questioning while at the same time encouraging a questioning culture. However, these two concepts can coexist when we reframe questioning through the lens of humble inquiry. No one wants to feel like they're being interrogated by the FBI. So instead of making questioning about scrutiny, make it about fostering a shared curiosity and collaboration in learning the answers. There are many resources on creating a "questioning culture," which is defined by author Michael J. Marquardt as "one in which responsibility is shared. And when responsibility is shared, ideas are shared, problems are shared … and ownership of results is shared. When an organization develops a questioning culture, it also creates a culture of we, rather than a culture of you versus me, or management versus employee."[40] Marquardt's book, *Leading with Questions*, provides excellent insight into the power of questioning and includes reflection questions for the leader to consider.
- **"Choose to listen. Listening is a living example of understanding that no individual has all the knowledge to solve every problem on their own. Listening is the ultimate sign of respect."**[41] Be an active listener, engaged with the speaker and with the information being shared. This does not mean that a leader has to act on all of this information, but there should be a genuine effort to hear it. Listening is a skill that has been called the "foundation upon which many other leadership behaviors are built … [it] is one of the most important ways in which leaders can meet the needs of others and acknowledge that people are valued and respected."[42] You can never hear the phrase, "that's a great question," too many times. It signals that you are really listening and being thoughtful about the subject at hand. According to Edgar Schein, there is a 360-degrees approach of asking—asking down, asking across, and asking up.[43] Are you asking *and* listening to the people who work for you, who are your peers, and who are your supervisors? The listening-to-talk ratio must be in favor of the listening.[44]
- **Be open to different ideas and perspectives.** Exploring ideas and perspectives that are not similar to one's own or that may actually be contrary to one's own helps encourage inquiry and foster discussion. When people feel comfortable in conversation and in asking questions to both their colleagues and their supervisor, it can create a culture of trust. Develop awareness and honesty about one's own strengths and weaknesses. Build trusting relationships with coworkers. Show concern and compassion for others. Put your work in context of the entire organization; focus on the larger picture.[45]

- **Leaders who practice humility may also consider using regular self-reflection.** "True self-examination leads to recognition of one's shortcomings and opportunities for development. In this way, acknowledging weakness makes one stronger, not only because it allows one to strive to ameliorate any weaknesses, but it also demonstrates integrity and self-confidence."[46] Building a practice of self-reflection takes time and intentionality—after all, it's called a practice. Journaling is a good way to start. Use paper and pen or find one of the many apps available. Set a specific time daily or weekly to reflect. It could be in the morning before the day starts or at night before going to bed, or any time that works for you. Try to ensure that this time is free from distraction. Another option is mindfulness meditation. It doesn't mean sitting cross-legged for hours reciting mantras, but simply sitting quietly and reflecting on the day. If you're not one for sitting still, try a walking or movement-based activity, such as yoga or tai chi. Even walking on a treadmill can provide time to think about the day and ask yourself, "How'd I do?" and "How'd we do?" In addition to using reflective practices, having a mentor can be a good source of guidance and advice. Leadership roles can be difficult at times, and it is helpful to have a sounding board.[47] Other chapters in this book address this skill more in depth.

In order to practice humility in leadership, consider acknowledging your limitations and areas for improvement. This approach removes the primary focus from oneself and encourages assessing one's accomplishments and acknowledging one's limitations and gaps in knowledge. For example, openly discussing areas where you seek to grow can foster a culture of continuous learning and improvement among your team. Leading by this example may encourage others to do the same.

Conclusion

The combination of humility and inquiry is not an oxymoron but, instead, they are fundamental qualities of inclusive leadership. Leading means relating to others,[48] and humility is one component of what makes a successful leader who creates an environment of curiosity and idea-sharing. Rather than being a sign of indecision or weakness, humble leadership encourages communication and collaboration and places emphasis on centering others over the leader.[49] "Our culture emphasizes that leaders set direction and articulate values, all of which predisposes them to tell rather than ask. Yet it is such leaders who may need humble inquiry most, because intricate interdependent tasks require building positive, open, and trusting relationships above, below and around them."[50]

Humility and inquiry help set the tone for a collaborative environment where no one person has all the answers and everyone is free to contribute ideas. This approach views leadership as a conversation rather than a command, where questions are asked and there is dialogue among colleagues. It involves regular self-reflection on how we, as leaders, move through the day and interact with others. It requires honesty and transparency with oneself, as this type of

self-evaluation can be difficult and may reveal areas for development, such as implicit biases and preconceived impressions of others. A humble leader is willing to do that type of work and acknowledge when improvement is needed. "Aspects of self-reflection and self-evaluation are interconnected with emotional intelligence and conflict management."[51]

Of course, the reality is that, in our daily lives, there are many situations that test our ability to be humble and to practice humble inquiry. Self-reflection and strong emotional intelligence skills can help navigate those situations, manage reactions, and maintain perspective. The goal is not perfection. "Humility comes from lessons learned over time, knowing that you don't have all the answers and that there's more than one way to do something. It is recognizing that others have knowledge, experience, and wisdom that you do not. It comes from the realization that you will make mistakes and will need the courage to acknowledge and learn from them."[52]

Leading with humility is a process as well as a choice. Each day, leaders are faced with opportunities to practice humble leadership and inquiry. There will be times when this approach is a great success and times when it falls short. Committing to the process of learning from (and admitting) mistakes and limitations encourages trust and lets others know that mistakes are part of learning and growing. "*Leadership is a choice.* Every day, those of us who serve as leaders must choose to recommit to that work."[53] Every day and every situation requires thoughtful, yet deliberate action and a conscious decision toward humility. Choose to be inquisitive. Choose to ask questions. Choose to listen.

Action items: incorporating humble inquiry into your leadership toolkit:

- Ask yourself these questions: Do I have all the information I need? What do I think I know? Is it based on evidence? What might I be missing?
- Step away and look at things like an outsider to get a broader picture.
- Invite more voices to the table and ask for input, not just answers.
- Learn how to admit to making mistakes—model the behavior of admitting mistakes, learning from them, and moving on.
- Use reflective practice techniques to assess actions and make improvements where necessary. This can include writing, meditation, reflective walks, and workshops designed to help people analyze experience, note the impact, and develop a plan using this knowledge.

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CHAPTER 9

Case Study: **Collaborate, Consult, and Communicate**

How a Neophyte Technical Services Librarian Successfully Steered a Migration Project

Michelle Hendley

This case study explores how I, a neophyte head of technical services, collaborated, consulted, and communicated with a team of library and information technology (IT) staff to lead an interlibrary loan server and software migration project. My experience in technical services is limited, having been a reference and instruction librarian for twenty years prior to assuming my new role. I am a late-career academic librarian and have lived experience as a biracial woman of color and an immigrant originally from the Caribbean nation of Jamaica. As a result of these identities, I have faced stereotyping, marginalization, and silencing in the workplace. For instance, in the past, co-workers have attempted to exclude me from discussions and committees that were considering changes directly impacting my work as a reference and instruction librarian. Therefore, I consistently strive to recognize and check my own biases, deliberately pursue a broad range of viewpoints to inform my decision-making, encourage feedback from support staff and librarians, and purposely endeavor to collaborate with my colleagues.

I have worked my entire academic librarian career at Milne Library, State University of New York (SUNY) Oneonta. The university is in the City of Oneonta in Central New York, halfway between Albany and Binghamton. The population of Oneonta is 13,079, according to the 2020 census.[1] Also, the university has a location in Cooperstown, about twenty-four miles north of the main campus. Cooperstown is home to two graduate programs, museum studies, and lake management.

SUNY Oneonta was originally founded as a normal school[i] and is a charter member of the State University of New York. The institution is a mid-size, four-year, public liberal arts university, and its Carnegie Classification is Master's College and University (medium programs). In January 2023, the institution's designation was changed to university from college. The university offers over 100 majors, minors, and pre-professional programs, including forty-three undergraduate majors and ten graduate programs, five of which are online. Currently,

i. Normal schools were created primarily to train elementary school teachers for public schools. The first public normal school founded in the United States was in Lexington, Massachusetts in 1839.

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the university's five most popular undergraduate majors are psychology, business administration, early childhood/childhood education (birth to six), childhood education (one to six), and biology.

The university's total degree-seeking student enrollment in the fall 2023 semester was 5,417. Of that number, 4,820 were undergraduate students and 597 were graduate students. The undergraduate population was 59.4 percent female, 40.5 percent male, and .04 percent other. The university's student body is predominantly white. For example, in the fall 2023 semester, 70 percent of degree-seeking undergraduate students identified as white, 17.1 percent as Hispanic/Latino, 5.8 percent as Black/African American, and 2.1 percent as Asian. Additionally, the student body is overwhelmingly comprised of in-state students. Finally, the university enrolls a sizeable number of first-generation students. Since 2015, the number of first-generation undergraduates has increased, and the student body of the university has become more racially diverse.

Milne Library is located at the center of the university's campus. The staff of twenty-three librarians and library assistants provide information literacy instruction, research, circulation, and interlibrary loan services to the university's students, faculty, and staff. Library users have access to over 900,000 print and electronic books, more than 100,000 electronic and print serials, numerous physical and digital media titles, and an array of electronic databases. The technical services department is responsible for acquiring, managing, and providing access to the library's rich collections. The department is one of four units in the library organization and consists of six full-time staff, including two librarians and four library assistants. The department has undergone significant staff turnover over the past six years, including the departure of three department heads in that time. The department prioritizes diversity and inclusion, as evidenced by its vision statement, which states that staff members believe "that the selection and access to resources that reflect the diversity of experiences of our students, faculty, and staff will provide the foundation for successful academic engagement."[2]

The university also prioritizes diversity and inclusion. One of the university's stated core values in support of its overall mission is inclusivity, specifically, "making sure that everyone feels welcome."[3] In addition, creating a "safe and inclusive climate" on campus is a stated goal of the university's Strategic Diversity and Inclusion Plan.[4] Furthermore, SUNY Oneonta's Diversity Statement states, "As a campus community, we believe that every individual is important in a unique way and contributes to the overall quality of the institution."[5] Accordingly, the university has been acknowledged for its commitment to diversity and inclusion. *INSIGHT Into Diversity* magazine selected SUNY Oneonta for its Higher Education Excellence in Diversity Award in 2023.[6] The university has received this recognition three times. Additionally, the university currently has a four-star rating out of five on the Campus Pride Index, a national list of LGBTQ-friendly institutions of higher education.[7] Based on these accolades, the institution appears to be achieving the goal of fostering an inclusive campus climate.

Fostering a climate of inclusivity on campus is the responsibility of all SUNY Oneonta students and employees. I take this responsibility very seriously and endeavor to apply inclusivity to my day-to-day work and especially in my leadership role. In my role as a department

head, I oversee the interlibrary loan office and its staff. Since I came to the department with minimal knowledge of the interlibrary loan operation, it was imperative that I learn more about this function. Therefore, I approached the individual who knew the operation best, the interlibrary loan clerk, to begin learning about this function. The clerk pinpointed the most pressing problem facing the interlibrary loan operation as the locally hosted software, ILLiad. I asked the clerk for her recommendations to remedy the problem. She advocated for migrating the interlibrary loan software and server to a remote-hosted service. I agreed with this strategy; however, the prospect of a migration project was daunting.

Once I was committed to the migration project, the first action I took was to consult with the interlibrary loan clerk, technologies librarian, and dean of the library to determine the membership of the team responsible for the migration. Left to my own devices, I would have chosen a smaller and less diverse team for two reasons: efficiency and bias. I believed that a smaller team would work more effectively because there would be fewer people to manage. Additionally, I held the preconception that other members of the library staff were new to the organization and did not have the experience or skills to contribute meaningfully to the project. Fortunately, upon remembering my own experience of being excluded from committees and recognizing my own preconceived notions, I deliberately sought the opinions from others regarding team membership. As a result of feedback from the dean of the library, interlibrary loan clerk, and the technologies librarian, we formed a highly skilled team, including recently hired librarians with a strong understanding and knowledge of library technologies, a veteran IT staff person with interlibrary loan software experience, and the long-serving interlibrary loan clerk.

Once the team was selected, I made a conscious decision to convey to members that courtesy, collaboration, consultation, and communication were important values to me. I have firsthand experience of other library staff being discourteous to me and dismissive of my ideas. Furthermore, my Jamaican upbringing emphasized treating others with civility and politeness. Therefore, I was committed to treating all members of the team with respect. I wanted team members to treat each other courteously. Since there was a history of perceived disrespect for the work of the support staff by librarians and some distrust on the part of the library staff and librarians of the IT staff's commitment to assisting the library, I communicated to the team that each member brought a unique perspective and expertise to the migration project. I conveyed that the success of the project demanded that we work together. I communicated my values to colleagues via email and during in-person discussions. Nevertheless, I did have to provide reminders to some team members about being respectful to their colleagues. Some of these conversations were difficult but essential to sustain team cohesion. One team member informed me that she sensed some of her colleagues did not value her contributions to the team nor treat her respectfully, based on her gender. It was apparent to me that she felt unappreciated and demoralized. As a result of my own experiences, her feelings resonated with me. Consequently, I assured my colleague that I would address her concerns. I alerted the dean of the library to this gender bias issue, but I also conveyed to the other team members in private conversations that I valued and needed our colleague's knowledge and experience, and her

participation was critical to the success of the project. Consequently, the member who raised concerns felt heard and did not raise any further complaints. I also noticed a change in the attitude of the other team members with whom I spoke about the significance of our colleague's contributions.

In addition to establishing a respectful environment, ensuring the work was appropriately and fairly distributed among the team was another one of my values. It was also important that the distribution of the workload be transparent. This value was informed by my own experience of having been assigned work responsibilities as a junior librarian that were greater than some of my senior colleagues. It became apparent that some library employees thought that IT staff were responsible for tasks that were clearly in the purview of the library. To achieve transparency and fairness, I created an online workspace for team members. Using an app, I was able to list all the tasks that needed to be completed and assign them to the appropriate person. The app provided the ability for team members to see all the tasks, to whom they were assigned, the task due date, and task prioritization. Team members could provide feedback to me regarding the appropriateness of the assignment to a particular person and suggest additional responsibilities. Since the task list was accessible to all team members, they were able to identify additional essential duties. For instance, once the library migrated to a hosted service, the interlibrary loan URL would change. I omitted including a request to the university web master to update the new interlibrary loan URL in the university's course management system. If this change had not occurred, students would have been led to a dead link when using the interlibrary loan link in the course management system. By being inclusive and transparent, team members caught my oversight and prevented the disruption of the interlibrary loan service to students.

In addition to ensuring a fair distribution of work, I frequently consulted with team members and considered and applied their feedback. For example, I asked the team to consider the best time to initiate the project so as not to interfere with their other work commitments. I have participated in teams where the chairs did not inquire about or care about members' other work obligations. Based on my colleagues' feedback, it was determined that during one of the semester breaks would be optimal. I also asked the interlibrary loan clerk for advice on the customization of the interlibrary loan user-facing pages, as she was most familiar with the user experience. Finally, I consistently invited team members to come to me with any questions, concerns, or suggestions. The interlibrary loan clerk and IT staff member were particularly responsive to this invitation and were not shy about providing information or ideas that helped move the project forward.

Now that the project is complete, I can reflect on the experience and identify four major lessons I learned. Based on these lessons, I will approach future projects differently. The first lesson I learned is that I should have met with the entire team earlier at the beginning of the process to discuss each member's responsibilities and ensure that we all had a shared understanding of those responsibilities. I realized that I had concluded that everyone knew what to do based on optimism bias. Optimism bias is the inclination to magnify the probability of positive outcomes and minimize negative outcomes.[8] I presupposed that all team members were cognizant of their roles in the project. This was not the case. I ended up having the

unpleasant but necessary task of having a discussion with team members who were unresponsive and noncompliant. This behavior could have been preempted if the team had discussed roles, responsibilities, and expectations prior to beginning the work of the migration.

The second lesson I learned was that I should have held more team meetings either in person or virtually. Initially, I resolved to communicate primarily by email because it was convenient, it was a mode of communication used during the pandemic, and some team members were still working remotely. Nevertheless, it became apparent that this project was too complicated to communicate effectively over email when it became evident that there were misunderstandings regarding everyone's roles. In hindsight, my decision to communicate via email was based on my status quo bias. Status quo bias is the proclivity to maintain the current situation and avoid change.[9] Looking back, I believe that more face-to-face or virtual team meetings would have preempted some of the misinterpretations regarding roles and responsibilities. To further compound the situation, not all team members knew each other. Having meetings would have given everyone the chance to introduce themselves and discuss their roles at the university and how they saw themselves involved in this project. Finally, team members would have had the opportunity to interact directly with each other, which may have helped to build trust among the group.

The third lesson I learned was to anticipate changes in the project timeline. For instance, the library requested that the vendor responsible for the migration complete the transition in January on a date prior to the beginning of the new semester. The representatives from the vendor said they would do their best to meet this deadline, but there was a possibility it would not happen. I was convinced that the vendor would meet the January deadline due to another case of optimism bias; however, the vendor had to postpone the migration date to March. I was unprepared for a change to the go-live date of the project and failed to plan for a potential delay. The alteration in the plan caused the team and me to be frustrated and stressed. In hindsight, we should have made a contingency strategy in anticipation of a shift in plan. Having one in place would have reduced our stress and unhappiness.

The fourth lesson I took away from this experience is the need for a post-project meeting. A post-project meeting is a method to give all team members the opportunity to discuss what worked well and what did not, and to make suggestions to improve processes for future projects. As a result of not holding the post-project, we lost an opportunity to determine how to work better collaboratively on future projects.

Based on these four lessons I learned from my involvement in leading a software and server migration, and my lived experience, I have identified eight pieces of advice to share with readers as they explore inclusive leadership in project management:

- acknowledge your limitations,
- seek advice from colleagues,
- address detrimental behavior,
- keep the library administrator in the loop,
- thank your team members,
- tout your team members' accomplishments,

- prepare to pivot, and
- schedule a post-project meeting.

I believe that these suggestions will foster productivity and inclusivity in working groups.

My first suggestion to readers is to admit your limitations to your team. When I acknowledged my shortcomings regarding interlibrary loan software and processes, I conveyed to the team that I was not trying to claim expertise that I did not possess. This demonstrated honesty. I also believe that by admitting my limitations, I revealed that I respected and trusted my colleagues' knowledge. Finally, by acknowledging my shortcomings, I demonstrated humility and a willingness to learn from others. My next recommendation to readers is to take guidance from colleagues who have the expertise you lack. Based on my experience, by seeking their help, team members knew that I valued them as individuals, as well as their knowledge and viewpoints. In addition to accepting guidance, it is important to discuss and clarify team members' roles and responsibilities before delving into the distribution of tasks and commencing work. Clarifying roles and responsibilities in the early stages of the process will ensure a common understanding, reduce ambiguity, and establish expectations. It is essential to address behavior that is detrimental to other team members and unfavorable to a successful outcome. I felt that speaking with team members about unacceptable behavior was the most difficult part of the project; however, I believed that if I did not address the problematic conduct, the project would be negatively impacted. Accordingly, it is important to keep your library administrator in the loop regarding progress and challenges. For example, I communicated with the dean of the library regularly. I informed him of the issues of bias, disrespect, and noncompliance as they arose instead of permitting them to fester. As a result of this consistent communication, he was able to offer timely advice and assistance that changed behavior and kept the project on track.

While it is necessary to take corrective action to change harmful behavior, it is also imperative to thank your team members for their work throughout the process and at the completion of the project. Thanking team members is the polite thing to do, and research shows that expressing gratitude results in positive outcomes for employees[10] and motivates them.[11] In addition to thanking them, tout your team members' progress and success to the library administration. Inform your colleagues that you are going to do this. They will appreciate this gesture. I have been on workgroups in which the leader failed to acknowledge the hard work of the members to the library administration. This lack of acknowledgment made me and other team members feel invisible, unvalued, and unmotivated. Consequently, it was important for me to let my colleagues know that I conveyed the contributions of all team members to our dean, and I did not take sole responsibility for the group's success.

Group success is further fostered when you are prepared to pivot. Well-laid plans may change due to circumstances beyond the team's control. Keeping in mind that adjustments may have to be made and preparing for that possibility may reduce team members' stress and frustration if plans are suddenly altered. My final advice to readers is to hold a post-project meeting. It is important for team members to have space to deliberate and offer frank feedback on the project. A post-project meeting gives team members an opportunity to be heard and demonstrates that their honest opinions are valued. It also exhibits that you are open to

receiving both positive and negative feedback, learning from others, and to improving how to lead future projects.

The migration project was significant to me for a variety of reasons. It was rewarding to see how team members eventually coalesced and collaborated around a common goal and completed the migration mission. This experience was also significant because it demonstrated to me that inclusive practices lead to better outcomes. In contrast, I recall being on a committee to revise the library's collection development policy when I was a junior librarian. The chair of the committee did not practice inclusive leadership. The committee failed to achieve its stated purpose, leaving members feeling disillusioned and demoralized. Conversely, applying inclusive practices, as seen in the project I oversaw, not only led to the successful completion of a project but also helped build trust with team members, especially with colleagues whom I had never collaborated with in the past. Most importantly, I knew that the successful migration to hosted ILLiad would be a positive development for library users and the library. The migration has resulted in a more robust user experience and less staff time spent on software problems. By collaborating, consulting, and communicating with a skilled and knowledgeable team, we completed a formidable task that has benefited our students, faculty, and staff.

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CHAPTER 10

Communicating with Values

Meghan Musolff and Jeff Witt

Who We Are

We carry these perspectives into our work and this chapter:

- Meghan is white, cisgender, and a librarian with a passion for values-focused project management, change management, and strategic planning.
- Jeff is white, gay, cisgender, and living with a mostly unseen disability. Jeff is a DEI practitioner and trainer, working through an organizational development lens.
- As members of the library administration team, both Jeff and Meghan have a strong connection with our library's leadership. We are uniquely positioned in that we can influence communications from leadership and, through years of relationship-building, we have insights into the impact of these communications on the library community. We have a great deal of self-agency in determining our priorities and communicating directly with any library colleagues, regardless of job title, at any time.

After working together for many years, Jeff and Meghan have developed a strong partnership and a vision for our organization, including the creation and adoption of shared values. We see this work as foundational for a thriving, healthy organization and consider ourselves stewards of the library's work connected to the way our organizational values are put into practice.

Our access to library-wide communication efforts allows us to provide guidance and intervention when needed to ensure alignment with our values. Do we always get it right? Certainly not. Creating alignment between our communication strategies and our values is a work-in-progress and the work of many hands. We do not, cannot, and should not do this work alone; we want to express gratitude to our many colleagues who join us in these efforts.

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Introduction

> "Our research revealed that when people feel that they are treated fairly, that their uniqueness is appreciated and they have a sense of belonging, and that they have a voice in decision making, then they will feel included."[1]

This quote, highlighting the qualities of an inclusive workplace, demonstrates the potential of centering our values in our communication habits and strategy. For it is through our communications and related activities that we can model these qualities and truly activate our values. We define values as an organization's ever-present ideals that set intentions, guide behavior, and inform decision-making.

In their article on inclusive leadership, Dillon and Bourke describe six signature traits of an inclusive leader.[2] It is interesting to consider how each trait that the authors describe could be animated as a value through communication. We have challenged ourselves to reflect on this connection (see table 1) and invite leaders who strive to be inclusive in their approach to take a deeper look within the context of internal communication.

While the focus of our chapter is on organizational values, we recognize that those are just one set of values that we, as leaders, carry with us throughout our workday. Individual values, personal and/or professional, also exist and can influence our communication habits and strategies. When our individual values are in tension with our organizational values, we recommend openly communicating about this conflict with your library community and creating spaces for discussion and reflection. We see this as a prime opportunity to model traits of inclusive leadership and to lead your organization with curiosity and humility.

Our chapter is focused on internal communication since that is where our experience and expertise lie. We define internal communications to be any form of implicit or explicit communication that is directed toward and/or received by colleagues within the organization, at any level of the organization. That said, we believe that with careful thought and consideration, the guidance presented below can be applied to your organization's external communications as well.

Critical Concepts

As we consider how professional and organizational values are exemplified through communication, it is important to keep a number of related critical concepts in mind. Understanding of these concepts provides context to the purpose, structure, and timing of communicating to and within the organization. While there are certainly many more concepts related to communication that might apply, we are focusing on four that have resonated with us as being critical to communicating with values: feedback loops, coded language, dominant/counter narratives, and accountability.

Table 1. Six traits of the inclusive leader, from Dillon and Bourke.[i]

Traits of Inclusive Leadership	Reflection question	Connection to communication
Commitment	How do my communication habits reflect commitment?	The frequency and depth of communication around a particular topic can signal to others where my commitment as a leader lies.
Courage	Am I using humility and bravery in my communications, especially as I speak to difficult topics?	Leading with humility means openly acknowledging positional privilege and subject matter limitations. Clearly aligning a stance or position on a topic with organizational values in specific ways is one way to model bravery in turbulent situations.
Cognizance of Bias	How am I building in processes to check for my blind spots as I communicate?	Practicing mindfulness techniques and utilizing implicit bias tools can help bring unconscious bias to our awareness. Surrounding ourselves with colleagues from a wide diversity of backgrounds and perspectives and empowering them to speak truth to power can facilitate bias interruption as it occurs, while also building a stronger community.
Curiosity[ii]	How do my communications model curiosity and open-mindedness?	Sharing where we are searching to gather more information, what we have learned so far, and extending an invitation to the community to bring additional information to you.
Cultural Intelligence	How do I ensure that my communications are culturally sensitive?	Learning to see and communicate about topics through the lenses of a diversity of cultural perspectives is a lifelong learning venture.
Collaboration	In what ways do my communications reflect a team approach, amplify the voices of others, and/or empower others?	Leadership communications are an ideal opportunity to demonstrate effective allyship, show solidarity, and amplify the diversity within an organization.[4]

i. For guidance and advice on effective allyship, see Karen Catlin, "Better Allies," accessed July 27, 2024, https://betterallies.com/.

ii. "Implicit Association Test," Project Implicit, accessed July 27, 2024, https://implicit.harvard.edu/implicit/takeatest.html.

Feedback Loops

The way we listen reflects values.

A feedback loop is an intentional tool that guides the feedback process, and we have found this structure to be helpful, especially when entering conversations (whether one-on-one or with your entire community) where you want to demonstrate values-focused communication. There is much value in knowing, to the degree possible, how a community sees and what is expected of a leader. This awareness can help determine where a leader invests in professional development, areas of leadership that may need more transparency or clarity, and key strengths to leverage.

Feedback loops have three parts:

1. **Open.** This is where we set the stage for the conversation and provide the purpose for the request for feedback. (What am I hoping to learn? Who do I need to hear from on this topic? How will I use the information gathered?)
2. **Body.** This is where we formulate an invitation, exchange information, practice active listening, and demonstrate empathy.
3. **Close.** Closing the loop, as it were, is the most important step in the process, especially in terms of demonstrating accountability. As we close the feedback loop, we will need to provide clarity about what we've learned through the experience and what happens next. Closing the loop can happen in the moment, or you can make a request for time to process. While asking for space to process is important for both participants in the conversation, it is crucial for leaders to present the option to continue the conversation later, especially when providing candid feedback or denying a request.

Coded Language

The language we use to advance our message reflects values.

The words a leader uses to express themself and represent their organization's actions, principles, or ideals matter. Many words in commonplace communication can land with others as code for a deeper or veiled meaning—a way of expressing an oppressive or marginalizing thought without officially going on the record with that thought. Coded language is communication that can trigger stereotypes, schemas, and/or stigma in a way that allows the speaker room for plausible deniability of racism or other forms of bigotry. Author Cara Hutto defines this concept by explaining that "coded language describes seemingly run-of-the-mill words or phrases that have alternative, offensive meanings. Most often, coded language is targeted at people of color, minorities, women and members of the LGBTQ+ community, and is used with the goal of portraying that group of people negatively and upholding systemic oppression."[3]

While coded language is often used intentionally as a form of dog whistle, which is clear to some audience members and easily missed by others, it can also show up in communication

that is completely honorable—although the impact can be the same either way. In our experience, coded language is often used in the workplace. This type of language has shown up in the work of search committees ("Is this person a good fit?"), in performance discussions ("I need you to anticipate my needs more."), and in workplace social interactions ("Having personal items in your workplace could make people uncomfortable.").[iii]

When the words of a leader have an unintended dog whistle effect on some community members and a targeted oppressive effect on others, the result can be catastrophic to a leader's reputation, not to mention the overall loss of the intention behind the communication. Again, words matter. Inclusive leaders choose their words carefully and continually work to grow their self-awareness around the limits and pitfalls of the language we use as a tool to express ourselves. One way to grow self-awareness around one's use of language is to explore inclusive language tools. Such tools, explored further in the chapter, help us to learn words that may land as code and words that reflect values of inclusion and respect.[iv]

Dominant and Counter Narratives

The stories we use to contextualize our messages reflect values.

Communication often creates or relies on narratives to get a point across. According to Literary Devices, narratives are oral or written accounts that connect related events or ideas and/or create meaning for readers or listeners.[4] Narrative is regularly used in entertainment and education to build a storyline that can be used as context and to help the audience relate to the message. Similarly, when leaders communicate, we often do so from the perspective or context of a narrative that is intended to help carry the message.

While the use of narrative can help community members relate to or understand a message, it can also be exclusionary. Unless careful consideration is given to creating an inclusive narrative to carry a message, it can reinforce the advantages that some community members carry and leave others out. The default narrative will often align exclusively with the dominant social group's interests and experiences, signaling that it is the only acceptable way to experience the

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iii. These three examples highlight how bias creeps into our everyday work conversations. They also demonstrate the tendency for leaders to defend the status quo and show affinity to more homogeneity in the workplace over a great deal of diversity.

iv. Tools around coded language that we have found helpful:

1. "Inclusive Language," 18F, accessed July 27, 2024, https://guides.18f.org/content-guide/our-style/inclusive-language/.
2. "The Diversity Style Guide," accessed July 27, 2024, https://www.diversitystyleguide.com/.
3. "Racial Equity Tools Glossary," Racial Equity Tools, accessed July 27, 2024, https://www.racialequitytools.org/glossary#targeted-universalism.
4. Sam Killerman, "How to respond when someone uses non-inclusive (or bigoted) language," It's Pronounced Metrosexual, accessed July 27, 2024, https://www.itspronouncedmetrosexual.com/2012/06/how-to-respond-to-non-inclusive-language-or-bigoted-speec/.
5. "Anti-racist language," Inuit, accessed July 27, 2024, https://contentdesign.intuit.com/accessibility-and-inclusion/anti-racist-language/.

community. For example, if a message promotes the importance of participating in community-building activities with each other but the connected narrative reflects that only happens during a typical Monday to Friday, 9:00 to 5:00 work week, the message is excluding community members who work second or third shift, those who work over the weekend, and anyone who has precious little to no flexibility in their work schedule. In short, the narrative fails to consider, or even acknowledge, the varied experiences of the members of the community and gives even more significance to the advantage held by those with scheduling and positionality privilege. A more inclusive counter-narrative would openly acknowledge the existing diversity of working schedules and styles as well as reflect multiple ways for colleagues to participate in meeting the overall objective of community-building. This approach requires connecting with individuals outside the dominant experience to ask about what they need, as well as creative thinking to provide options for everyone.

John Keene's book, *Counternarratives*, provides many examples of how stories that have been historically told from the dominant perspective and experience can and should be retold.[5] The author demonstrates how we can expand our scope and shift our focus of narrative-building to center the perspective and experience of those who were caused harm, silenced, or left out by building the narrative from the dominant perspective. Inclusive leaders can practice what Keene has modeled in the book by challenging the context of our communication and considering the full range of experiences and perspectives in our community. Mechanisms to help guide your work include recruiting a diverse set of community members to review draft communications, looking for small opportunities for gathering feedback, and collaborating with other organizational leaders to develop alternate options to solutions.

This work takes time, and it's very likely that you will need to be flexible and iterate on your solutions. An example of this is our library's adoption of Focus Days. Occurring monthly, these days are set aside for library employees to engage in work that often gets set aside for other things: professional development, committee or working group-based projects that often get pushed to the back burner, and work that has been postponed or stalled due to high volumes of meetings and emails. Based on feedback, especially from colleagues working at service points and those who work second and third shifts, we have made changes to our Focus Day program communications that allow for greater inclusivity to the wide array of different roles we have in the library.[v] These changes include more flexibility in choosing or even splitting up when the focus day happens each month for an employee and empowering supervisors to make shifts in scheduling practices to allow for more participation.

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v. Here's the current language we use to describe Focus Days on the University of Michigan Library's staff intranet: Departments whose employees staff service areas and would have limited opportunities to participate in Focus Days on the 22nd of the month may establish an alternative practice of scheduling monthly Focus Days for the department provided the practices meet these criteria; participating employees get the opportunity to engage in work that often gets set aside, there is coverage of the applicable service areas, and department leadership establishes the practices in consultation with fellow department heads in the division and with their associate university librarian.

Accountability

The way we accept and invite accountability for the impact of our communication reflects values.

Merriam-Webster defines accountability as an obligation or willingness to accept responsibility or to account for one's actions.[6] In practice, especially in the practice of leadership, we would argue that it is a purposeful process by which an individual or a group takes responsibility for their actions and—more importantly—the impact of those actions. Accountability as an organizational concept can easily be reduced to a buzzword, overused in documents, or performative in nature. As it applies to our experiences with leadership in libraries, for accountability to be effective, it must be directional. That means that accountable leaders understand *who* they are accountable to, *what* they are accountable for, and what accountability looks like in action. As we consider inclusive leadership and communicating with values, we find it helpful to recognize that leaders are accountable to the community they lead and accountable for actions (and communication) that are in alignment with the organizational mission, strategy, and values.

If effective communication is a value or a standard that an organization holds, purposeful consideration of and response to the impact of communication must be a standing element of that communication. An inclusive leader will be deeply concerned about how a piece of communication lands with individuals in the community, and a skilled, inclusive leader will put that concern into action both pre- and post-communication. Activating feedback loops (as described above) both before and after key communication is an act of being accountable to one's community. That act of accountability is amplified when a leader is thoughtfully responsive to what is learned, using affirming or restorative practices.

In Practice

In the following section, we describe five values-focused communication habits and include a discussion about related frameworks or tools that we have found helpful in supporting our communication work.

Commitment to Learning

An important aspect of inclusive leadership is a commitment to learning. This focus on building self-awareness, prioritizing growth, and deepening curiosity extends to our communication habits, styles, and strategies.

Potential areas to explore:

- Deepen your understanding of your own communication style and preferences, and then extend that investigation into your supervisor, your peers, and your direct reports.

- Learn more about various learning and thinking styles within your community.
- Learn more about examples of coded language. (Learn more about "coded language" in the Critical Concepts section above.)
- Understand the pros and cons of using certain communication channels.
- Learn more about past communication efforts to understand what worked and what didn't work, and seek to understand the damage to working relationships previous communication mistakes might have caused.

FRAMEWORK/TOOLS:

- **Coded language inventory.** We have created a living document that captures coded language.[7] This document represents a years-long journey to inventory what we have learned and is a small step in reinforcing our aspirational culture by demonstrating intentionality with our language. This type of tool can be used for individual self-learning. It can also be used in a team environment to ensure a type of controlled vocabulary: here are the words/phrases we have decided, as a team, we won't use in our efforts to center our values.
- **Communication channel map.** A communication channel map can be used as a tool to help leaders, departments, and/or teams grow their collective awareness around existing communication mechanisms, establish communication norms, and build empathy as they communicate with others within the organization.[vi]

Focus on Intent and Assess for Impact

"Intent is the effect we want to have on something. We make language-based decisions whenever we talk about our intent. Our language choices change how we use our time and energy. For every word we use to describe where we want to go, there's another word that we're walking away from."[8]

As leaders, we have set a vision for the values-focused organizational culture we are trying to create. Our communication strategy is an opportunity to remind our community about our vision and to model for others the habits and behaviors needed to get there.

Opportunities include:

- Refer to your organization's values in your communications on a regular basis, at every level.

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vi. An example communication channels template can be found here: https://docs.google.com/document/d/1d9zVmXVHcWC-zYy-Ng7EwohMJrBOY--YQP6Cw7s0Bco/edit?usp=sharing.

- Connect your actions directly to your values (for example, we are making this decision in service of this particular value).
- Focus on your organization's strengths and aspirations and how your values help get you there.
- Aim for transparency around the decision-making process: What information did you use to make the decision? Who did you talk to? How did your values influence the process?
- Highlight the systems you are trying to bring into alignment with your values.
- Give colleagues access to the communication and additional information through recordings and documents and some time to take it in at their own pace and in their own learning style.
- Beyond inviting colleagues to ask questions, invite and encourage them to share how the information or action is impacting them and their work. Provide a variety of forums for colleagues to share impact statements—anonymous reporting, through an employee resource group, in direct communication, and in a community open forum.
- Activate an assessment process that can measure the intended outcomes of a specific communication or action. This could be in the form of a survey, individual check-ins, or as an agenda item in relevant standing meetings.

FRAMEWORK/TOOLS:

- **Internal communication assessment plans.** Developing a list of questions to be asked after major communication efforts will help ensure you are having the intended impact. The mechanism to gather feedback can change depending on what feels right (organization-wide survey, focus groups, or informal hallway conversations). Sample questions to help get you started on your own assessment plans include:

  - Was this type of session an effective way to share information?
  - Based on the information presented and shared, do you feel like you have a sense of how and/or why?
  - What additional information would you find helpful?
  - If you wanted to find more information about this topic, where would you look and/or who would you talk to?

- **Decision-making framework.** Cyndi Suarez's Levels of Involvement in Decision Making framework is a tool developed for leaders to help them decide and communicate different approaches to collaborative decision-making.[9] After considering the level of ownership and involvement desired, Suarez's framework provides leaders with language to communicate the decision-making process as well as fallback strategies for when consensus can't be reached.

Model Inclusivity

As we've noted, our communication habits and behaviors provide an opportunity to model specific values. This is especially true of the widely held organizational value of inclusion. Through our communication efforts, we can model fairness and respect, listening with curiosity to a diverse range of perspectives, and fostering belonging and connectedness within our community.

Questions to consider:

- Who is the intended audience for my communication? Why this audience? Why not a different audience?
- Have I tailored my communication to account for the emotions of my audience? Am I meeting people where they are?
- Did my feedback loop include diverse perspectives? (Learn more about "feedback loops" in the Critical Concepts section above.)
- Did I express gratitude to those who provided feedback? Did I provide closure?
- Am I allowing counter-narratives to be expressed? (Learn more about "dominant and counter-narratives" in the Critical Concepts section above.)
- Is my choice of words reflecting the message and tone desired with sensitivity to a diversity of experiences and perspectives? (Learn more about "coded language" in the Critical Concepts section above.)

FRAMEWORK/TOOLS:

- **Bridges Transition Model.** Developed by William Bridges, this framework provides a vocabulary for the shared experience of transition.[10] The tool is useful for a broad range of change management activities, but for communication, it can help you identify emotions experienced by colleagues in order to tailor/refine messages for different audiences. (In other words, it helps you meet people where they are.) For a team, the framework can be helpful as a shared vocabulary to describe the emotions of living through a change.

Unified Messaging

As leaders in our organizations, we aim for consistent communications up and down and across our community. This can be challenging. Drawing from our own experience, we periodically find ourselves in a situation in which community-wide communication needs to go out in a timely way, representing the management team as a whole. In these instances, we realize that full consensus on the message might not be possible, but we aim for agreement on the overall spirit of the message. In addition, we take the time we need to consider questions that may arise from the communication and work together to make sure that everyone has access to and an understanding of the data and information needed to respond to inquiries.

As a team, things to consider:

- Who will be involved in writing organization-wide communications? Will that change depending on the message?
- How will we ensure a consistent message, especially for communication around a long-term change?
- How will we ensure our values are reflected in our messages?
- When will we aim for consensus for our messages? How will we know when the message is important enough to slow down and get everyone involved?
- Who will deliver the communication on behalf of the management team and in what way?

FRAMEWORK/TOOLS:

- **Communication log.** A simple, but effective tool, we use to help ensure consistent communications is a communication log.[vii] This document is shared with the entire team and records all communications in one place. This fosters a shared understanding of what we have communicated in the past as well as allowing for talking points to be easily repeated throughout the project/change lifecycle.

Be Courageous

Modeling values-focused communication habits calls for bravery in ourselves as well as encouraging it in others. Our communications need to demonstrate authenticity and humility, while also inspiring confidence. Not an easy thing to do!

Communicating with courage forces us to reckon with our relationship to uncertainty and mistakes. We must practice admitting our mistakes and communicating in an effective way about what we learned from that experience. It means that we must admit that we don't always have all the answers and be transparent about our information-gathering process.

Things to think about:

- Are my personal values influencing my workplace communications?
- Am I admitting when I make mistakes and how I've learned from the experience?
- Am I modeling when to call in or call out colleagues?
- Am I assessing the impact of my communication and then holding myself responsible for the impact?

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vii. An example communication log template can be found here: https://docs.google.com/document/d/1RdcXNdax3VRIVy0nXImwj4z9ISsB4wnHjBKX7v_86jY/edit?usp=sharing.

FRAMEWORK/TOOLS:

- **Calling in and calling out guide.** One important consideration in building a sense of community in a workplace is to establish productive norms for times when mistakes are made, disagreements emerge, or conflict arises. Often, human default behavior in these situations includes confrontation and defensiveness. Inclusive leaders strive for better. Most of us are familiar with the practice of calling out a person or behavior that becomes problematic in some way. Calling out skills are quite useful in the workplace to identify, interrupt, and immediately halt behavior that is creating harm. While calling out interventions certainly are needed and justified at times, we find (and we hope) that these situations are few and far between in the workplace. In growing our inclusive leader skills and focusing on values-based communication, we have learned to rely more on skills around calling each other in when communication seems to break down. Calling in practices attempt to bring any harmful behavior to light while maintaining and even strengthening workplace relationships.[11]
- **Brave spaces and safe spaces.** Safe space is intended to be "free of bias, conflict, criticism or potentially threatening actions, ideas or conversations."[12] The concept began within LGBTQ+ culture and has expanded to refer to any space, physical or virtual, that is created and held for people who are in any way marginalized, targeted, or oppressed.[13] The idea has had its fair share of critique and criticism as an affront to First Amendment rights,[14] as a way of furthering societal division,[15] and as an unrealistic promise made. Terminology such as "inclusive space," "safer space," and "positive space" has replaced safe space in many contexts. In addition, the idea of "brave space" continues to grow in popularity—brave space classrooms, for example.[16] The primary difference is that brave space is a shared time and place where the objective is to grow, change, advance, or determine action steps, while a safe space is typically focused on growing awareness and showing up for each other in a supportive way. In a brave space, organizational values are authentically compared to the lived experiences individuals are having, resulting in processes being scrutinized, systems being analyzed, tools being evaluated, and harmful workplace behaviors being interrupted.

  In the context of inclusive leadership in college and research libraries, we have applied specific characteristics and behavioral expectations to safe and brave spaces (see table 2). When we invite our library community to come together in support of one another, to build community, or grow deeper degrees of understanding and empathy, we use Safe Space Guidelines.[viii] When we invite our library community to come together to interrogate a system or process, to make high-impact decisions, or to effect change, we use Brave Space Guidelines.[ix]

viii. "Library Safe Space Guidelines," University of Michigan Library, https://docs.google.com/document/d/1RGIgTFfTXoajDMUyeKjN9oD-KR7KXh6Kf54AE5h17p8/edit.

ix. "Library Brave Space Guidelines," University of Michigan Library, https://docs.google.com/document/d/1Ant2WDP3V6LhfZMGsLbOMUBMpqWdMrJ6t8XYmT2m8JA/edit.

- **The 5 Ds of bystander intervention.** This helpful framework was developed by a social justice nonprofit and provides an easy-to-remember guide for times we find ourselves witnessing someone causing harm to someone else.[17] This framework reminds us that we have choices in these situations and that there are many factors that determine what the most effective course of action might be, especially in the workplace.

Table 2. Characteristics and behavioral expectations for safe spaces and brave spaces.[x;xi]

Safe Space Dialogue Characteristics	Brave Space Dialogue Characteristics
Space for self-exploration, empathy, and growing understanding of each other's perspectives and experiences	Space for collectively challenging barriers and resistance to change and systems that do not work well for all
Focused on being inclusive	Focused on being equitable
Risk avoidance without avoiding conflict; safe does not mean comfortable	Calculated risks, leaning into the discomfort of conflict and change
Guided by rules of etiquette, concerned with how people are being treated	Guided by rules of engagement, concerned with how people can work together toward change
Take an intergroup dialogue approach	Take a multipartial approach
Advocacy frame of reference	Activism frame of reference
Non-closure is the norm	Moving toward change

Conclusion

We hope this chapter has demonstrated the importance of developing values-focused communication habits and practices as part of your journey to become an inclusive leader. We end our chapter with the following list of actions to help hold yourself accountable:

- Create a goal around building values-focused communication habits and share your goal with others in your library.
- Intentionally schedule time to practie and learn more about inclusive communication practices. (See our references for some places to start.)

x. "Intergroup dialogue: Working paper series," University of Michigan, The Program on Intergroup Relations, accessed on July 27, 2024, https://igr.umich.edu/research-publications/working-paper-series.

xi. "Multipartiality," University of Michigan, The Program on Intergroup Relations, accessed on July 27, 2024, https://youtu.be/t1nML7R4wn0?si=bP_b8xynO-QdDE7o.

- Co-develop mechanisms (frameworks, templates, expectations, goals, etc.) to help foster values-focused communication skills in your managers.
- Initiate feedback loops to ensure that your communications are having the desired impact.

Notes

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CHAPTER 11

Case Study: **Fostering Belonging in the Workplace Through Conversations of Care**

Jermal Alleyne Jones

"Everything worthwhile is done with other people."[1] —Mariame Kaba

About one hundred kilometres west of Toronto, Ontario, is the city of Waterloo, a mid-sized city that has all the amenities one needs but without the traffic of the Greater Toronto Area. The University of Waterloo campus offers a relaxed pace, yet the innovation in its buildings is worthy and suitable for a large city. With one of North America's most extensive cooperative programs, it is an attractive option for the best and brightest, especially in the engineering and computer technology fields.

The city and campus reside on the Haldimand Tract, land granted to the Six Nations in the 1784 Haldimand Treaty.[2] This beautiful land spans ten kilometres on either side of the Grand River from Dundalk, Ontario, to Lake Erie. At the time of the treaty, it totalled approximately 950,000 acres. Today, about five percent is stewarded by the Six Nations of the Grand River, just south of Brantford, Ontario. The land I live and work on is the traditional territory of the Neutral, Anishinaabeg, and Haudenosaunee peoples and is home to many other First Nation, Metis, and Inuit. Acknowledging this history, along with meaningful action, is a small step I can take towards reconciliation. By addressing the harms of the past, there is hope for building together an inclusive future on this land.

Introduction

I situate who I am using the reflection question in Jo Chrona's *Wayi Wah! Indigenous Pedagogies*:[3] "How did I come to this work?" Like most folks in equity, diversity, inclusion, and access (EDIA) roles, it was not my childhood dream job. In my youth, I dreamed of becoming a professional soccer player in the English Premier League (EPL), but as you can tell, I have strayed. I would describe myself as an abolitionist,[4,i] even before I had the language to name this

i. Abolition has its origins in the anti-slavery movement, but more recently is concerned with dismantling the Prison Industrial Complex. It is both an ideology and a practice challenging punitive systems. Geoffrey Skoll, and Timothy Kaufman-Osborn, "Abolitionist University Studies: An Invitation," Abolition Journal, May 10, 2020, https://abolitionjournal.org/abolitionist-university-studies-an-invitation/ (site discontinued).

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specific term, because my mother was incarcerated for most of my youth. Her incarceration profoundly shaped my perception of the prison system, as I knew her to be a good and loving person despite her circumstances. This personal experience made me question the purpose and effectiveness of jails and institutions and their connection to freedom. The concept of freedom should not be as complicated as our institutions make it. Nonetheless, along with thinkers like Stefano Harvey and Dylan Rodríguez, I see the goal of abolition as life-affirming rather than destructive or a negative project—a world-making practice. This life experience probably pulled me to the work of seeking justice.

Another related moment that pulled me to this work happened in 2007: I lost my thirteen-year-old (half) brother to suicide.[5] He was bullied after coming out to a friend, and that information spread in his high school. Coming from a Caribbean background and not living with him at the time, I was not aware of the harassment he was facing, much less that it could ever lead to him taking his life. This was the beginning of my critical analysis of gender relations and, more specifically, the analysis of masculinity. Years later, in 2014, I would start Next Gen Men (NGM), a non-profit organization that works with boys and men seeking to change how boys and men see, act, and think about masculinity.[6] I have shared this story many times in hopes that others would understand the power of their words and realize their manhood should not have to be defined or elevated on the souls that society deems "lesser." It was at NGM[7] that I learned how to organize and transform small groups of people.

Professionally, I wear multiple hats: associate director, EDIA at the University of Waterloo, a PhD student, and co-founder of NGM.

While I am currently in a position of power and privilege, this has not always been true of my life. As a Canadian Black cisgender man, I have significant power and privilege. I am heterosexual, neurotypical, and slim. English is my first language, and I have a post-secondary education, including a master's degree. These identities allow me to navigate systemic issues of racism and colonialism with relative ease. However, it has not prevented me from experiencing individual and societal consequences of racism and colonialism. We all participate in our world's beauty and harsh realities. Recognizing this fact allows us to see possibilities to upend these systems, even if the potential solutions are imperfect.

The Problem

EDI(A) Roles in Institutions

Having been an EDI (equity, diversity, and inclusion) professional at different academic institutions, I have supported the disclosures of racism, sexism, and ageism and delivered presentations to students, faculty, and staff. In these roles, I sometimes felt overwhelmed and contemplated how long I could continue doing this work. EDI roles can have unrealistic demands; the work is hyper-visible, and you are under a microscope, yet you can feel invisible in a large institution. I constantly felt like I should be doing more to support those who needed

it; burnout seemed inevitable. I witnessed other EDI colleagues quit, take leaves of absence, and others who constantly worked outside business hours, the burdens of work seeping into our "recovery" time. EDI work presents a dichotomy: while it aims to liberate others, those doing the work often find themselves constrained. Sadly, working towards liberation for others does not necessarily liberate oneself within an institutional environment.

I was at a tipping point when an opportunity at the library presented itself in a newly created position: associate director, library, EDIA[ii] (equity, diversity, inclusion, and access). I believe in the importance of EDIA work and know we can imagine and create spaces where I and others can flourish. I have been part of these fleeting moments and thrived while they were present, but they were in opposition to the mission of the institutions. For example, at most institutions, you will struggle to find the word *care* in its mission statement, which is noteworthy because Saidiya Hartman is quoted as saying, "*Care* is the antidote of violence."[8] Academic institutions are historically and inherently violent, from the land they occupy to the interpersonal violence enacted between colleagues to structures that allow some bodies to flourish while others struggle.[9] Yet, in academic institutions, the fleeting moments of care I have been part of are accessible and kind. The freedom to say anything is balanced with how it will impact my fellow humans. They were spaces intentionally crafted by the folks organizing them.

Coming into this new role, some part of me felt like an outsider. I could not shake a statement from Robin D. G. Kelley, an author and UCLA professor who states, "I want to think about what it means for Black students to seek love from an institution incapable of loving them—of loving anyone."[10] Is it because some perceive the work of EDI(A) offices as stifling freedom of expression, and that there is resistance[11] to EDIA initiatives and those that are leading them? Or is it due to anti-Black racism or the legacy of historical discrimination against marginalized groups? Yet, I still want to belong and feel the same sense of pride my colleagues have working for our institution. Witnessing the struggles of others, as well as my own, drives my commitment to creating a sense of belonging for all, particularly in the spaces where I work. To address the challenge of social disconnection and entering an unfamiliar environment, I needed to create for myself, selfishly, an environment grounded in wellbeing.

The Solution

Collective Care

Collective care is about connection, vulnerability, and community. The idea of collective care can be linked to ideas that come from queer Black feminists and their work forming the Combahee River Collective.[12] It is also articulated by those in disability justice spaces as well as by queer, disabled, and racialized folks such as Mia Mingus and Leah Lakshmi Piepzna-Samarasinha. Collective care, as described by Act Build Change,[13] "is a communal responsibility for

ii. I will use the acronym EDIA to refer to EDI work as it relates to my function at UWaterloo.

people's emotional health and wellbeing within groups or organizations." It upholds concepts such as interdependence, mutual aid and solidarity, and community-building. It resists institutional practices, such as individualism and hierarchies, and advocates for shared, equitable, and inclusive practices. I needed colleagues who wanted to be allies and who I could invite to join me in doing the "good trouble"[14] of dismantling, imagining, and creating inclusive environments with persistence, patience, and care.

The transition to my role in the library took place during the days of COVID-19, when many of us were barely holding on. Many were impacted by the system's lack of work protections, sick days, and support for mental health and well-being. Many marginalized groups and individuals are intimately familiar with this reality. Disability justice activist Mingus writes, "This is nothing new. We have been here before and we are here again"[15] in her blog, *You Are Not Entitled to Our Deaths: COVID, Abled Supremacy & Interdependence.* In a time of collective despair, I saw an opportunity to strive towards something new. I asked myself how I can use the liberatory insights of Black, Indigenous, and queer thinkers to change our realities in the library. The goal was to build empathy and action from common ground to a place where "things" do not need to remain the same for ALL of us. These experiences, histories, and realities helped me develop Conversations of Care.

Conversations of Care

Conversations of Care (CoC) is a series of targeted workshops that I created for library staff on understanding themes of EDIA. The primary goal is to build collaborative and collective care, moving from individual self-care[iii] to a more holistic and collaborative "we"-centered approach. The CoC series provides a "MAP" (microaggressions, allyship, power, and privilege) framework to help library colleagues navigate the complex world of EDIA. These workshops, situated as conversations, aimed to

1. increase awareness around EDIA issues within the library context;
2. develop skills to create a more inclusive library environment;
3. create a sense of responsibility among staff; and
4. encourage ongoing dialogue.

By using the MAP framework with CoC, I hoped that colleagues would see the importance

iii. The self-care framework I refer to includes phrases like going to the spa, vacationing, meditating, etc. These phrases focus on our individual ability to purchase wellness. We hear things like "treat yourself," a directive to buy "nice" things, perpetuating an individualistic notion that it is your responsibility to buy your wellness. This strategy is not inherently bad; taking care of yourself is necessary. However, it does not work on its own. We are experiencing a structural problem, so the solution requires mobilizing and healing together. We are burned down, not burned out. We need collective care, an approach to wellbeing emphasizing the importance of community, interdependence, and shared responsibility. C. Canning, March 14, 2021, Twitter.

of ongoing learning about EDIA and the potential to craft a more equitable and inclusive library.

Witnessing Collective Care: Proof of Concept

Collective care is something I witnessed in action growing up in my community, specifically in my grandmother's home. Her house was a haven for her kin, their kin, and families (friends, partners, extended aunties, and uncles) whenever they needed it. The term collective care in praxis long precedes its use in academia. I wondered if elements of this could be introduced into the academy. Would I be engaging in what author and professor Olúfẹmi Táíwò calls "elite capture"?[iv] To answer this question, I turned to the premise that if "we accept our positions within institutions, working from *within* to change those institutional cultures," yet also "assert our responsibility to be more than mere performers,"[16] we can make a change. We must find ways to create projects within the academy that recreate care to create a collective future—working to de-individualize, destabilize, and resist the concept of person/role being the sole solution. Our thriving is bound together. These small yet essential workshops, framed as conversations, are only part of the solution.

Workshop Design

The workshops were designed as twenty- to thirty-minute facilitated sessions within library departments to create a sense of safety and trust. Initially, I delivered the workshops to library executives to gather feedback and make necessary adjustments. The next step was to offer the workshop collectively to the department heads responsible for departments such as Information Technology, Collections, and Cataloguing. This provided them with an opportunity to ask questions and provide insights on the material as well as to connect with me if any issues arose. Occasionally, department heads informed me about specific situations and suggested that discussing the issues in the workshop could benefit the staff. I would then join a regular department meeting to facilitate the workshop, which, in most cases, turned into conversations. The modules were microaggressions, allyship and bystander intervention, and power and privilege.

The format of the training in each workshop included

1. an explanation of the specific conversation and background context;
2. a territorial acknowledgment that connected the topic to calls to action;

iv. Meaning, would I be taking a community concept made to benefit community outside the institution and use it to benefit those with power? Would I become part of the problem of the well-educated and well-resourced to dominate conversations silencing marginalized voices?

Olúfẹmi O. Táíwò, *Elite Capture: How the Powerful Took over Identity Politics (and Everything Else)* (Chicago, IL: Haymarket Books, 2022).

3. an introduction of concepts;
4. opportunities for discussion, and
5. extended conversations that generally exceeded the twenty- to thirty-minute allotted time.

I was encouraged when staff engaged past the allotted agenda time, as this was a telling and unexpected outcome. In these moments, staff often shared personal details, situations they have experienced, and how they found the information helpful.[v]

Microaggressions Module

A term coined by Dr. Derald Wing Sue,[17] microaggressions are the frequent verbal, nonverbal, and environmental slights, snubs, or insults that target people based only on their membership in a marginalized group. They might be intentional or inadvertent but always convey hostile, disparaging, or negative messages.[18] Some would argue there is nothing micro about them when experiencing them, not to invalidate the term, but to emphasize the severe impact they can have on some individuals.

When I entered department meetings, it was essential to state and build upon community agreements. The agreements included

1. mindfully engage;
2. acknowledge discomfort versus safety;
3. be accountable; and
4. share space (talking time) and respect different learning journeys.

We paid particular attention to mindfully engaging and discerning between intent and impact. The goal of pausing and unpacking what it means to engage mindfully was to draw attention to the relationship between intention and impact. Though well-intentioned, our actions may not always have a positive impact. It is important to recognize that part of our

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v. In the Microaggressions workshop, I used an example of microaggressions that Indigenous students faced in an article from the University of Manitoba. Some students heard these microaggressions: "Don't you go to school for free?" "You don't pay taxes!" "Do you live in a teepee?" These are examples of racial microaggressions are often considered and described as "minor" by those who commit the microaggression.

After the connection, we offer an action/s step.

1. Check out the EDI-R training schedule.
2. Attend competency and capacity opportunities led by the Office of Indigenous Relations.
3. Drop by my office hours or send me a Teams message.
4. Explore podcasts (henceforward by Eve Tuck) and her article with Wayne Kang, "Decolonization is Not a Metaphor."
5. Donate to local Indigenous organizations.

goal to become better communicators (verbal and non-verbal) is to align intent and impact as often as possible. Ideally, the person on the receiving end of our action receives it well.

By unpacking what discomfort is versus feeling unsafe, as a group, we could distinguish between when we might be out of our "element," feeling somewhat incompetent, and when a lack of experience could make us feel disadvantaged. By asking whether this added information is pushing up against my beliefs, we invite self-reflection that encourages deeper introspection and critical thinking about one's perspectives and assumptions. When we encounter new information or ideas that challenge our existing beliefs, it can create cognitive dissonance. That is discomfort—it is valid, it is real, and it is good. It is a moment where, if you can sit with it for a while, it can lead to personal growth. Whereas feeling unsafe is defined as being mentally, physically, spiritually, and emotionally put in harm's way. It indicates that something hurtful will happen to you or has already happened (material, physical, or emotional). I would state, "If this were happening to you, take the time you need and afterwards connect with me or the supports on campus (these were verbal and in the references of the PowerPoint shared after the workshop was delivered)." Our goal in these sessions was to ensure this did not happen. However, if it did, we outlined how to call people in and out.[19]

Before moving into the material, two questions were posed to the participants/colleagues: What happens if I make a mistake? Will people accept me afterwards? I spent some time making sure people understood that, as human beings, we all make mistakes. We reviewed Rania El Mugammar's "Anatomy of an Apology,"[vi] so we all understood how to repair a bridge of misunderstanding, broken trust, and harm. In each session, I shared an example of a mistake I had made to demonstrate that the goal is not perfection but rather action toward improvement.

Allyship and Bystander Intervention Module

The Ally and Bystander Intervention workshop emphasizes that allyship is a continuous process, not a permanent designation. There are three main points to remember on your journey of allyship.

1. **Be willing to make mistakes.** As I stressed in the microaggressions workshops, we are human, and humans err frequently. There will be missteps on our journey.
2. **Practice humility.** We learn to accept critiques about our mistakes with humility.
3. **Focus our actions on improving the lives of marginalized communities.** This is only possible when we listen to non-dominant groups as they share the types of violence and risks they face. Then, we can take action to address systemic inequalities or support mutual aid initiatives.[20]

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vi. Rania El-Mugammar is a Toronto based anti-oppression consultant. The UWaterloo Library invited Rania to co-facilitate several healing sessions after the June 28th gender motivated attack on our campus. Rania El-Mugammar, "Anatomy of an Apology," February 2019, https://youthrex.com/wp-content/uploads/2019/02/Anatomy-of-An-Apology-Rania-El-Mugammar.pdf.

In the Bystander Intervention portion of the workshop, I outlined that bystander intervention involves recognizing a potentially harmful situation or interaction and choosing to respond in a way that can positively influence the outcome. We assessed why we might be hesitant to intervene and learned the six Ds (direct, distract, delay, delegate, document, and defend) and how we felt most comfortable intervening.

Power and Privilege Module

In the Power and Privilege workshop, we underscore the importance of understanding our own identity and recognizing that we all hold biases. This is the first step to creating an inclusive workplace. By reflecting on our identities, the experiences that stem from them, and how they shape us, we can better communicate our experiences and develop a sense of empathy to connect with others. It is crucial for people to feel a sense of belonging in their groups.

We covered the Wheel of Power and Privilege[21] and Dr. Stephanie Nixon's Coin Model.[22] We reflected mainly on informational power and our role as library staff in deciding who has access to resources and how one might receive the information that we gatekeep. We addressed how power is both relational and constantly shifting, which can sometimes limit our ability to act with our full capabilities. However, by understanding personal, interpersonal, cultural, and institutional levels of power and privilege, we can intentionally work to dismantle different forms of oppression (racism, sexism, homophobia/transphobia, ableism, and classism).

Additional Resources

In addition to using slides, I used videos illustrating other voices speaking about their experiences, including the *Seattle Times* Under Our Skin Project[23] and the Burger King *Bullying Jr.* video.[24] The purpose was to have perspectives other than my own, to not appear as the sole authority on EDIA topics, but also to evoke an emotional response. Because of the diversity of voices, experiences, and commonality of feeling defenceless, colleagues could connect and share similar incidents in the workplace if they wanted.

The goal was to provide staff with the tools to intervene when they become aware of microaggressions and harm. I aimed to help them identify valid reasons why they might not intervene and choose a tactic that would still support a colleague. The Comprehending the Power and Privilege module presents numerous frameworks.[25,26] From my experience leading court-mandated sessions for domestic violence offenders, mainly men, presenting multiple and similar messages is influential in sparking action that leads to accepting accountability.

The Impact

First and foremost, I learned that my library colleagues are fantastic—to be welcomed with genuine kindness and receptiveness is something I hold close to my heart. It has opened the

doors to have conversations with staff across the hierarchy, disclosing personal and professional challenges. I treat these disclosures with care and as a measure of success.

I also learned the value of presenting the modules ahead of time to department heads and executive leaders. These people know the staff and the culture of their departments; they shared some potential sticking points. This process proved helpful as each unit is different and experiences similar but different issues. One example was a conversation with a department where the members felt voiceless and mistreated about an incident that occurred and was likely to come up in the conversation. Knowing this ahead of time allowed me to modify my language to meet the audience's needs and build trust. We spent more time on one slide than other departments, but that did not mean it was less valuable.

I valued the opportunity to deliver these *conversations*. The invitation to be included on the agenda by the department heads demonstrated that the conversations were a priority, which enhanced my desire to communicate. Even in these online spaces, we shared a mutual understanding of "this is us." I was grateful to feel we did not need to spend as much time building community through agreements, even though creating community was still necessary.

I learned not to spell it *all* out. Providing the steps is helpful, and leaving room for imagination and creativity allows for negotiating individualized solutions. One goal for CoC was that everyone can and should do EDIA work, and CoC aims to remove barriers and provide tools to reduce harmful behaviours, increase healthy practices,[vii] and enhance cultural sensitivity and knowledge. Cultural shifts happen through little moments, and CoC will be a tool to support that. I believe that as people engage with the content, they find their personal MAP. CoC is just one way; there are many ways to build equitable ecosystems.

CoC and other initiatives under my portfolio have significantly impacted the library culture. One example is the positive feedback received from colleagues about the discussions' impact. I received an email stating, "I just wanted to take a minute to say thanks for facilitating the discussion last week in our department meeting. I really appreciate your approach to these training sessions, and how you've made some charged topics easier to discuss (which can't always be easy, especially in a work environment!)." Another instance involved a discussion about the Allyship and Bystander Intervention video. It evoked painful childhood memories for one staff member, who was able to connect her experiences to her style of welcoming employees. She realized her approach could benefit from some adjustments.

Additionally, I received feedback from my supervisor and other colleagues regarding an internal message I shared about the ongoing Israel-Palestine conflict. The thoughtful engagement from staff demonstrated their increased comfort in addressing sensitive topics, a key goal of our EDIA efforts. Building on this progress, we have expanded our reach by leveraging technology. We have uploaded the Allyship and Bystander Intervention training to the libraries' Online Learning Object Repository, making it accessible to new staff members and the broader UWaterloo community. This approach allows library staff to engage with the content at their

vii. These include using appropriate language, shifting perspective from me to we, and allyship.

own pace, further embracing the principles of inclusivity and accessibility that CoC promotes. The plan is to upload the remaining two modules in 2025 and track the metrics. I look forward to delivering the upcoming modules—Anti-Racist Praxis, Gender is Everyone's Job, and Decolonization and Imperialism—for library staff.

Conclusion and Final Reflections

The opportunity to play an active role in fostering a sense of belonging in the library workplace has meant the world to me. While I do not think we will ever be able to bring 100 percent of ourselves to work, I am in a healthier and vastly different space than when I began. I attribute that to how the university librarian welcomed me, my supervisor, and those who choose to work in libraries. I believe that a curiosity for knowledge, both confirming and challenging our beliefs, lies within us. More importantly, we have a desire to build a welcoming space for diverse ideas and perspectives.

If I had to do anything differently, I would have held "open" sessions to provide opportunities for hosting discussions and facilitating intra-department conversations on these topics. My advice to those doing similar work is that the end goal is to get people on board the EDIA train. The EDIA space is not one with prescriptive roadmaps. It is not Western medicine in the sense that you take two pills twice a day for five days, and you are cured. I do not think about it in that "fix it" way. That perspective means you precisely know everything people need with their diverse backgrounds, and we see them as lacking something. I view my role as one of the many organizers in the movements of disability justice, gender equity, racial justice, reconciliation, and so much more that are working towards a future that includes *all* of us. It is not about having all the facts and naming prominent scholars; it is about getting people to build relations with each other through little moments or big moments to get past fear and isolation. In summary, EDIA work builds relationships.

Be kind. I remember my days of ignorance as a young man and what that socialization meant. I remember not knowing what 2SLGBTQIA meant.[viii] I was fortunate to have people who, when they broke parts of my belief system, were kind enough to help me rebuild it more extensively and more inclusively each time. As we (EDIA professionals) poke holes in people's ideologies, we must make space to help them build (or at least point them to resources) the "new" view that is more inclusive, curious, and with more possibilities.

Each time I do this work, I am reminded of the big picture and recognize that it is not always helpful to "dump" that on everyone. My final takeaway is that we all want to belong; if you are stuck, start there. Ask what you need to belong, and before you know it, you will have a MAP that others can discuss with you.

viii. At Waterloo, we use 2SLGBTQIA+ when referring to the Two-Spirit, lesbian, gay, bisexual, transgender, queer, questioning, intersex, asexual+ community. "Gender Identity and Sexual Orientation: Terminology and Key Concepts: University Relations," University Relations, University of Waterloo, November 7, 2023, https://uwaterloo.ca/university-relations/gender-terms.

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CHAPTER 12

Systems Thinking

A Holistic Approach to Inclusive Library Leadership

Ken Irwin and Elizabeth Kerr

Introduction

Systems thinking is a broad interdisciplinary field, with roots in biological and physical sciences, that has been found to be applicable to many areas, including organizational behavior. The essence of systems thinking is the conceptualization of a situation holistically as a system of interlocking, interdependent parts. By understanding the interrelationships, organizations can gain insight into why challenges persist and where changes can be made to successfully influence outcomes.

The term "systems thinking" refers both to a mindset and to particular tools for understanding the world. Dr. Marie Morganelli calls systems thinking "a holistic way to investigate factors and interactions that could contribute to a possible outcome."[1] Writing in 2006, pioneering organizational theorist Peter Senge wrote, "Systems thinking is a conceptual framework, a body of knowledge and tools that has been developed over the past fifty years, to make the full patterns clearer, and to help us see how to change them effectively."[2] In *The Handbook of Systems Thinking Methods*, Salmon et al. use the term to describe "a philosophy which is applied to help understand and optimise behaviour in work and societal systems.… The overall 'system', therefore, becomes the unit of analysis when attempting to understand behaviour."[3]

This chapter examines concepts and principles in systems thinking that can be used when navigating inclusive library leadership. We have found it to be a useful approach to strategic planning for diversity and inclusion, which is reflected in the examples we provide. Because diversity and inclusion work is so intimately tied with institutionalized systems and policies, systems thinking can be an important tool for inclusive leadership and organizational transformation.

The literature reveals a long history of systems thinking being applied to libraries, but it has not gained widespread traction in practice throughout the profession. The most robust applications are primarily represented by two clusters of writings that center around the implementation of systems thinking, following the leads of two different theorists of learning organizations. One cluster draws substantially on Senge's work, especially but not exclusively at the University of Arizona, led by Shelley E. Phipps,[4] and subsequently by a former U of Arizona librarian, Karen Williams, at the University of Minnesota.[5] The second main application of

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systems thinking was conducted by Mary Somerville at California Polytechnic State University–San Luis Obispo and her colleagues.[6] They followed the lead of organizational theorist Peter Checkland and his "Soft System Methodology," an implementation of system thinking that is similar to but distinct from Senge's. Arizona, Minnesota, and Cal Poly all represent organizations where systems thinking methodologies became deeply embedded in the culture of the organizations as a result of library-wide implementation driven by library leadership. These are perhaps the purest implementations of systems thinking reported in the library literature, having consistently used systems thinking to involve library staff in creating a more effective workplace and leading to sustained library cultural change. Carolyn Gray provides an additional perspective on implementing Senge's systems thinking approach to libraries in an article describing integrating "front room" and "back room" staff at Brandeis University Libraries.[7]

Other articles provide a more theoretical, less implementation-driven view of systems thinking. Corliss et al. provide an overview of Senge's work with an eye toward library organizations.[8] A more recent article by Tim Peters applies the work of human systems theorist Barry Oshry to the realm of library leadership. Peters identifies in Oshry's work three key tensions that need to be balanced for systems to thrive:

1. Individuation versus integration. Members of a system both operate independently and contribute to the operation of the organization as a whole.
2. Differentiation versus homogenization. Specialization can occur within the system, but the system's core values and motivations inform the work and methods.
3. Stabilization versus change. Consistency within the system is important, as is the ability to grow and change.[9]

Beyond the library-specific discussion, we turned to Peter Stroh's book, *Systems Thinking for Social Change*, for insights on applying systems thinking to inclusive leadership. Stroh draws heavily on Peter Senge's seminal work, *The Fifth Discipline*, applying systems thinking to social issues. Senge and Stroh employ several tools for understanding and effecting change in a system. One, which has been a staple of the systems thinking literature, is the identification of feedback loops as self-reinforcing properties of a system. Another is recognizing how our own roles, including efforts to change the patterns we're in, may tend to re-create and reinforce the systems we are already in. Stroh also focuses on identifying leverage points—places in a system where a focused effort can lead to substantial change.[10]

A familiar example of a feedback loop is a persistent challenge in libraries: a lack of racial diversity among librarians compared to the general population.[11] The lack of diversity leads to working environments where people from minoritized groups feel unwelcome. This leads many to choose careers in more inclusive environments, which contributes to the ongoing lack of representation in libraries. Librarianship as a profession has an understanding of the causal loop that creates this situation yet has not successfully disrupted the loop. This feedback loop may be reinforced by well-intentioned actions and programs, despite their intention of ending

the loop. A systems analysis approach could help identify the tradeoffs required to change the system and the leverage points at which changes to the system would be most effective.

Why Does Systems Thinking Matter?

A systems mindset is a valuable tool for planning organizational change. The late Donella Meadows, one of the leaders in the development of systems thinking, wrote that "modern systems theory, bound up with computers and equations, hides the fact that it traffics in truths known at some level by everyone."[12] While we see merit in applying the full set of systems thinking tools to libraries, we have also found that some of the core principles of systems thinking can be useful on their own, and it is at that level where our experience may be useful to others.

Sustainability is both a feature and a potential "bug" in systems—a system tends to continue to yield the outcomes its structure creates. Meadows defined a system as "an interconnected set of elements that is coherently organized in a way that achieves something."[13] Stroh adds that a system tends to be stable and hard to change, and that the outcome ("purpose") of a system "is often not the one we *want* the system to achieve."[14] If our systems are creating outcomes that are not the ones we intend, systems thinking affords us tools for adjusting the organization's processes to generate different outcomes.

Returning to the example of the lack of diversity in library workplaces, library recruitment and hiring practices are areas where systemic change is possible. These practices are vital to how an organization continually re-creates itself by identifying and inviting individuals to join the team. They are also areas in which policy and procedure govern much of the process, and those practices are a leverage point in a library's system. By identifying problems with the current hiring process and replacing them with more inclusive practices, we can have a lasting impact. By addressing inequalities with policy changes, the improvements can outlast individuals and change "the way things are done." Systemic injustices require systemic solutions.

Relationship to Inclusive Library Leadership

We believe that systems thinking is a critical skill for inclusive leadership. If you are thinking about the whole system, you are considering everybody in it. This involves understanding the complex nature of relationships—individual, team, and cross-departmental. The dynamics at play in each library will be different based on the specific people who make up the organization as well as its history and role in the university and community.

Inclusive leaders seek out voices from around the organization and use what they learn to improve the system for everyone. One of the ways that leaders can cultivate systems thinking in their practice is to actively seek the inclusion of different points of view in their organizations. A caution is to not engage in tokenistic virtue signaling but to understand the disparate effects of leadership decisions across the library. Ashikali, Groeneveld, and Kuipers write,

"The inclusion of differences in decision making … involves actively seeking different ideas and perspectives that unique team members have, and considering these in decision-making processes. Because this signals that team members' unique contributions are important, and used to enhance work practices, it could support their feelings of belongingness."[15]

Systems thinking is a mindset available to anybody, at all levels of understanding. Successful organizational leaders take steps to cultivate an understanding of the internal system dynamics of their organizations. Simultaneously, they should understand how their libraries are part of larger academic and social forces in their professions and their communities.

Our Application of Systems Thinking

Timing, research, relationships, and momentum, partnered with understanding institutional context, were key elements in the creation of Miami University Libraries' (Libraries) diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility (DEIA) strategic plan. Developed during the 2022–2023 academic year, the DEIA strategic plan was a collaborative commitment to making long-term, sustainable changes within the Libraries. In the lead-up to the DEIA strategic plan, the Libraries' leadership and staff made cultural shifts, which included reconvening the DEI Committee in 2020, creating a budget for DEI, and prioritizing training for staff on diversity and inclusion topics.

While steps were being taken to make the Libraries a more welcoming and inclusive place, the work was being done in individual silos. The DEI Committee, departments, and librarians were working separately on diversity-focused initiatives, instead of collaboratively. Additionally, the leadership team offered support, but the primary executors of diversity-focused initiatives were the staff. By advocating for the creation of a DEIA strategic plan, we were able to coordinate DEIA efforts, secure commitment from the Libraries' leadership, and assemble a cross-departmental team to develop the plan.

Systems Thinking

We have found a systems thinking mindset to be instrumental in strategic planning and implementation within the Libraries. Where strategic planning is rooted in the vision for our organization, systems thinking can help us place our efforts where they will have the desired effects. At the onset of developing the plan, we conducted an assessment of current projects for advancing diversity goals. While commendable, the projects did not have a unifying purpose. Additionally, larger projects, such as a collections review, were not being conducted because they were daunting, time-consuming, and did not have an individual responsible for their execution. Systemic change was not at the core of these diversity efforts, which limited their efficacy.

One of the motivating factors in developing the DEIA strategic plan was to move the Libraries from individuals working on siloed projects toward collaborating on coordinated projects across the system to have a collective impact for systemic change. The team focused on

how inclusion initiatives could become ingrained in our system rather than being independent efforts. As DeMatthews describes, systems thinking "provides an opportunity to reconsider aspects of leadership for inclusion, given its focus on seeing wholes rather than breaking up aspects of inclusive reform into specific buckets."[16] While developing the DEIA strategic plan, the project team sought out projects that required interdepartmental collaboration and articulated a clear objective to be accomplished. This clarity assisted in uniting staff in a common goal, with a clear path toward how it could be achieved.

Context and Positionality

The two of us practiced inclusive leadership through non-management positions at Miami University Libraries. Elizabeth Kerr (she/her) served as the coordinator of strategy and assessment, and Ken Irwin (he/him) serves as a web services librarian, and we both previously served as co-chairs of the Libraries' DEI Committee. Both of us identify as white, cis, and heterosexual, with our visible identities affording us many unearned privileges. We both seek to combat systemic injustices and contribute to more equitable systems. While neither of us is a supervisor, our positions in the Libraries have provided us with the power to complete the work outlined in this chapter. Although not a manager, Elizabeth served as a member of the leadership team within the Libraries, providing her with access to administration that other staff do not have. Ken's years of experience, along with the unearned privilege of his male identity, positioned him to help lead organizational change.

Miami University is an R2 public university located in Oxford, Ohio, with an emphasis on global and innovative liberal education and with a heavy undergraduate focus. It is a predominantly white institution (PWI) that serves nearly 19,000 students yearly.

Team Composition

As this project took a systems approach, we did not complete the work in isolation. A DEIA strategic planning team was convened to develop the plan, with members approved by senior leadership. The project team included hourly staff, salaried staff, and librarians and ranged in years of service from one to thirty-three, with representation across many library departments. We, the authors, served as co-chairs of the team. None of the team members was a supervisor. The project team consulted with library staff through surveys, departmental meetings, and open comment periods during the development process. The DEIA strategic plan team sought to ensure staff perspectives were represented within the plan and that initiatives would be supported in their implementation.

The remainder of this chapter examines two strategies that can be used when taking a systems approach to inclusive leadership: understanding individual and team dynamics and uniting under a shared vision and values. Each of these concepts is investigated from an individual perspective as well as from a leadership perspective. We also share how we used each tool during the DEIA strategic planning process.

Tool 1: Dynamics

The goal of systems thinking is to consider collective impact over individual projects. This can be challenging when working in libraries, as individuals may feel committed to their unit or department without displaying the same commitment to their library or university. How do you, as a leader, move a team from considering their individual and team goals to considering the larger organization? As an individual, what's the point in embracing a systems approach?

Inclusive leaders must understand their teams and be strategic in how they approach projects and initiatives. Without having a firm grasp on *who* is on your team, a leader can't be strategic in *how* the team works together. Individuals should understand themselves and how they contribute to the larger organization to engage in systems thinking. Inclusive library leadership involves remembering the human aspect of systems thinking—the folks who keep the system functioning.

What is Your Role in the System?

Your job is more significant than the tasks you engage with daily. Your role is simultaneously a part of the system while also influencing how the system operates.[17] Understanding how your role and responsibilities contribute to the larger system can help you adopt a systems-oriented mindset. Adopting a systems mindset requires you to gain an understanding of your organization's structure, who is involved, and the norms of interactions. This can be structural: What are the functions of each department within your library? What are the primary responsibilities of staff and librarians? And who is responsible for various projects? It can also be more nuanced: Who holds power and in which areas? What is the process for launching new initiatives? And what are the accepted norms of collaboration? To adopt a systems mindset as an individual, you must be aware of the context in which you work. As Jones, Forlin, and Gilles share, "Systems approaches to change embrace a holistic view of context and pay attention to different parts of a system that come together in *subtle and explicit* ways to create that unique setting."[18] Every organization is different, complex, and changes over time depending on who is on the team.

When developing and implementing our DEIA strategic plan, we each understood our roles within the organization and how to leverage them. Due to my (Elizabeth's) position residing in the dean's suite, I was able to collaborate with library leadership to discuss initiatives and set expectations. My co-author, Ken, was able to use his established relationships with staff across the system to build commitment and buy-in. Another team member used her role on the collections development committee to draft the initiative on collections. Our hourly team member ensured that hourly staff had a voice in the development of the plan. We each used our position within the Libraries in different ways to advance the creation of the plan.

Creating a Team of Systems Thinkers

While some individuals may take the initiative to learn about their library's organizational structure and goals, not all will. This could be for a variety of reasons, such as limited experience with systems thinking, limited access to information and power due to position, strong commitment to their department, or disengagement. As a leader, it is your responsibility to support your team in gaining the skills needed to be systems thinkers.

Some ideas to help your team learn more about the organization include:

- Set norms and expectations. Be transparent about how your team is a part of a larger system. Be clear that while your primary responsibility is the function of your team, you have a larger obligation to contribute to the Libraries' and the university's success.
- Reinforce the organization's goals and priorities through communication. Share communications from administration and leadership (when appropriate), discuss the library's priorities in team meetings, and frame departmental projects to fit into the larger organizational vision.
- Broaden the scope of your team meetings. Invite staff from other departments to share about interdisciplinary projects. Engage your team to consider how their projects and initiatives have an impact outside the team.
- Look for opportunities for your team members to serve on interdepartmental committees. Have your team members share about projects and priorities in leadership meetings or with other teams in the library or university.
- Nominate your team members for awards and accolades outside of your department. Being recognized within the institutional context helps one find their place of belonging.

When developing the DEIA strategic plan, we had to support our workgroup in embracing a systems mindset. From the beginning, we established norms and expectations. For example, the team agreed only to include initiatives that required interdepartmental collaboration that would fundamentally shift processes across the system. This agreement proved to be beneficial and was referenced throughout the development process. For example, when reviewing a lengthy list of proposed initiatives, our workgroup was able to remove items that were specific to individuals or departments, as they did not align with our goal of system-wide change.

Additionally, it was important for our workgroup to understand the work that was being done throughout the system in order to bring these activities and projects together into one united vision. By understanding the work that staff were already engaging in, the workgroup could look for patterns, interdependence, and connections between parts to see how these individual efforts could be brought together to support the whole.[19] Our job, as systems thinkers, was to pull together individual projects and unite them into a cohesive plan of action that would have a resounding impact across the Libraries. As a result of systems thinking, physical accessibility improvements, building inclusive practices into hiring procedures, and revising collections policies all became initiatives within the strategic plan. Many of these

initiatives were being addressed in multiple ways across the Libraries, with no coordinated efforts. Viewing the individual projects as part of a greater whole aided our workgroup in systemically thinking about how to approach the tasks.

These efforts would not have been possible without knowing the system and what was taking place within the Libraries. Our workgroup members shared our knowledge and experience and examined it collectively. For example, every member had served on a hiring committee or had a new hire within their department over the past year and so had an element of understanding of the hiring process. This knowledge of the system allowed our workgroup to propose an initiative that reflected the work that the current Libraries' staff were engaged with.

Each system is complex and unique, and it is necessary to understand how the parts are structured in order to see how they connect.[20] By understanding our teams and the unique dynamics of our system, we were able to collaborate with a common goal in mind. By knowing who was in our system and how our teams functioned, we were able to tie efforts together to drive change for the Libraries.

Tool 2: Shared Vision

If understanding the structure of an organization is important to systems thinking, one should also understand and embrace their position in the organization. When approaching systems thinking from an inclusive leadership perspective, the result is an approach that embraces how every individual provides unique value to the library. Each team member has the ability to take ownership, consider the goals of the library when making decisions, and find ways to exhibit leadership, regardless of formal title.[21] This balance highlights the tension between individualization and integration that Peters cites in Oshry's work.[22]

When individuals are involved in the goals of the library, beyond their own role and department, they see that they contribute to the success of the system. Staff who take a systems approach become intertwined and connected, forming context-rich relationships[23] and understanding that by working together on a common goal, more can be achieved.

Creating a Vision among Your Team

Systems thinkers see an organization holistically, while also understanding the intricacies of subsystems that interact to create the organization.[24] How then do you keep a team focused on the goals of the organization rather than solely the subsystems they're involved in? Uniting a team under a shared vision helps to clarify the specific goals the team is working toward when there are myriad possibilities. Providing a clear vision also supports individuals who are not systems thinkers by providing clear guidance and direction.

Marchildon and Fletcher share that "vision is essential to establish a common direction. The relationship between a shared vision and systems thinking is cyclical and mutually

reinforcing. While a strong vision can inspire systems thinking, awareness and understanding of the system (systems thinking, in other words) allows actors to contribute to, and potentially reshape, the system vision."[25] A clear vision keeps teams working toward a common goal while also empowering them to become involved, thus increasing the inclusivity of your organization. Barton explains that "living a shared vision encompasses a sense of curiosity about the present and a desire for a new reality. It involves inviting the perspectives of others and co-creating the emerging future intentionally focused on creating spaces for others."[26]

By describing the goals and vision of your library, your team is better aware of the direction the system is headed. This allows your team to understand how they can contribute to the vision, identifying how their responsibilities contribute to the priorities of the library. In addition to supporting systems thinking, providing a clear vision may also reduce staff doubt or anxiety about the library's direction. This vision can serve as a starting point for systems thinking but should not be the end of the conversation. Senge cautions, "Vision without systems thinking ends up painting lovely pictures of the future with no deep understanding of the forces that must be mastered to move from here to there."[27] A clear vision can serve as a strong foundation to enact systems thinking, particularly when backed by a strategy for how to accomplish the vision.

One of the first lines in our DEIA strategic plan, titled "Commitment to Inclusive Excellence," is "the Miami University Libraries are committed to fostering an environment where inclusion, belonging, and equity are intentionally incorporated into services, processes, and decision-making."[28] Stating this vision early in the plan helped to add context to the recommendations within the plan. Framing the work as a strategic plan grounded in the Libraries' values sent a message to the staff and leadership that diversity and inclusion efforts were guided by a principled and systemic approach rather than being one-off projects. The workgroup acknowledged that work was being done across the system connected to diversity and inclusion, but the tasks were done in silos. By taking a systemic approach, we looked to add cohesiveness to the work being done, shifting from additional tasks that staff engaged with to full incorporation of diversity efforts into the Libraries' services, processes, and decision-making.

Balancing Individuality and Systems Thinking

Investing in a system and its vision does not mean you lose your individuality. By working together collectively, rather than assimilating, team members can feel a sense of belonging while contributing to a common vision.[29] An inclusive work culture allows individuals to bring their full selves to work, "feeling safe, engaged, respected, and valued."[30] In an environment where individuals can be their authentic selves, it is important to remember that you must respect individual differences that will arise while working collaboratively. Our identities impact not only who we are as individuals, but also how we work within different systems and contexts. Systems thinking acknowledges the complex nature of individuals, their relationships, and society's influence. Considering context can prove fruitful when working with others in an organization.[31]

When taking a systems approach, it is important to recognize that your approach to collaboration may vary from that of your colleagues. Perspectives may differ, values may not align, and subsystems may have different objectives. For systems work to occur, one must navigate these differences with the goals of the larger system in mind. As an individual, you should find how to adapt your approach within the system while maintaining your own integrity. This will require flexibility, communication, and negotiation.

Ultimately, when it comes to a systems approach, words matter. Systems thinking provides a shared language for communication.[32] However, individuals may approach that communication differently. Being a systems thinker requires you to know the individuals who are part of the organization and understand how to adapt your communication style to reach the system's goals. We all bring a multitude of strengths to the table. Knowing when to lean into specific facets of your identity at strategic times can help when working in teams and moving forward with the goals of the system.

When working with others within your library, consider the following strategies:

- Know the subsystems within your library. Marchildon and Fletcher share, "Constructing appropriate vision, communication, and engagement requires a strong understanding of each system level."[33] To communicate effectively, you should strive to understand others and their relationships to the system in order to communicate effectively with them.
- Be open to new perspectives. Systems are complex and have conflicting and complementary forces. When collaborating on a team, others may have perspectives that you don't.[34] Be open to hearing what other people have to say, keeping the goals of the organization in mind.
- Tailor your language. While systems thinking takes a unified approach to change, it does not mean everyone does the same thing. Adapt your communication to be appropriate to the audience you're communicating with.[35] Tailoring your message does not mean that your communication is inauthentic but rather demonstrates your ability to adapt information to help others understand the vision you are collectively working toward.

Developing the Libraries' DEIA strategic plan took strategy and finesse when it came to communication. The workgroup was meticulous in drafting a plan that incorporated perspectives from staff throughout the Libraries while staying true to the ultimate goal of making the Libraries a more inclusive place. We were also aware that selecting the wrong language could derail the plan. Examples of carefully selected language within the plan include:

- The formal title of "Commitment to Inclusive Excellence" rather than DEIA Strategic Plan. Staff and leadership were wary of another strategic plan. The political landscape while drafting the plan was hostile toward DEIA efforts. As a result, we selected a name that reflected the impact of the document.
- Initiatives are phrased as "recommendations." Both leadership and staff were concerned with how failing to accomplish specific items in the plan would be perceived. We opted to take a softer approach by framing initiatives as recommendations.

- "Collection definition and evaluation." The initial intention was to recommend a collections diversity audit. After discussing with the collections committee, selectors, and leadership, we found that the term "audit" carried negative connotations and that the task was broader than initially realized. This language shift added a level of comfort and staff investment.

Our workgroup also tailored our language when presenting the plan. When communicating the plan to departments, we discussed the role their team would play while communicating the broader vision of the plan. When communicating with library leadership, we leaned into language regarding progress, incremental steps, and staff involvement to demonstrate the systemic nature of the plan.

Conclusion

A core insight of diversity and inclusion work is that the problems we face (and which we often collectively uphold) are systemic.[36] Racism, sexism, ableism, and other forms of oppression are tenacious and deeply embedded, and systemic changes are needed to address them.

Many of the diversity-minded activities libraries have long embraced, such as displays featuring books by authors representing various cultural backgrounds or signage promoting inclusivity, affect people's surface-level experience in the library but do not change the underlying structures that can disadvantage or alienate library users and library staff. These kinds of activities are valuable in visual acknowledgment of the commitment. Yet, libraries must do more to achieve their DEI goals.

The policies and practices that make up the operations of the library form the foundation of people's experiences of the library. Collectively, those policies and practices encode and reinforce many beliefs and values held by the "system" of the Libraries, even when they are at odds with the values we explicitly espouse. Unpacking the systemic and structural effects of these policies is an important aspect of inclusive leadership.

A systems thinking approach to making libraries more inclusive focuses our attention on how to effect meaningful change. What leverage points exist in your library's power structure, and what are the mechanisms for change? In our library, strategic planning is one of the chief drivers and channels for making change, so we identified it as an avenue through which we could have an impact. Perhaps, in your organization, there are library policies that are known to be languishing and in need of updating. A policy waiting to be updated is a prime opportunity to cause systemic change. You may find that leadership will support a team updating a policy known to need work, and the team can bring inclusive intentionality to the process. Susan Vega García and Katie Wampole at the Iowa State University Libraries developed a rubric for evaluating the inclusiveness of library policies.[37] Their work can be an excellent guide for libraries pursuing policy change for inclusive leadership.

Find an ally in library leadership willing to push for the creation of a workgroup to tackle structural challenges. Many libraries espouse a commitment to DEI but may be focused on less

structural approaches to the work. Those committed to DEI work are likely to recognize the importance of structural change.

Your team should include people from around your organization, as well as those who have some understanding of how the system works as a whole. Some of those people may be in library leadership, while others may lead in other ways within your organization. Build a team. Identify opportunities in your system. Investigate ways the system can be improved. We hope that this chapter may provide a path forward for pursuing structural change and inclusive leadership in your organization.

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CHAPTER 13

Case Study: **Kindness and Support in Librarian Searches at George Washington University**

Jen Froetschel and Peter Cohn

Introduction

Librarian search processes in academia can be daunting. Candidates apply, and if selected as finalists, often endure what can be a grueling interview process of presenting and being interrogated by stakeholders. How could we create a kind and supportive search process that centers applicants and embeds diversity, equity, inclusion, and access in the experience?

In 2021, George Washington University's Libraries and Academic Innovation's (LAI) Council of Librarians formed a group, the Ad-hoc Committee on Search Procedures (Ad-hoc Committee), to rethink and mindfully reconstruct our librarian search procedures. The goal was to embed our values of diversity, equity, inclusion, and access in our searches. In doing so, we hoped to broaden the pool of applicants who could see themselves in positions and, by extension, bring more diversity to the group of librarians in our organization. The Ad-hoc Committee examined our search processes to increase the diversity of our candidate pools and improve the overall applicant experience. We purposefully reviewed and updated every step of the search process to build kindness and equity into the process.

The revisions of hiring procedures have led to a more inclusive, equitable, and respectful person-focused search process. We have received consistently positive feedback from candidates on their experiences since these procedures were implemented. This has helped create better diversity within the organization.

The work of the Ad-hoc Committee built on work that began with a "cluster hire" to fill ten positions in 2019 and 2020. During that time, a number of colleagues left LAI to capitalize on other professional or personal life activities. Because of the number of vacancies, our leadership decided to search for a number of candidates as a group rather than making ten individual searches with a separate committee for each, which would be a huge drain on resources.

Having one pool for multiple librarian positions allowed efficiency for us and the applicants. Applicants indicated which positions they were interested in and would only have to apply once for multiple positions, instead of applying for every opening individually. We could also look at the one pool and approach applicants for positions they may not have considered applying for.

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The Search Committee revised the process to center diversity, equity, and inclusion and make the workload more sustainable.[i] We looked at each part of the hiring lifecycle to make sure that we were adhering to the spirit of the "cluster hire" of being flexible enough to enable candidates to bring their best selves to the process. The majority of the changes we made were implemented or formalized during the search procedure revision process,[1] which we cover in the next section.

Context: GW LAI

The George Washington University (GW) is a private research university located in Washington, DC. GW has three campuses, two in Washington, DC, and one campus plus two education centers in Northern Virginia. We are classed as an R1: Doctoral Universities - Very High Research Activity and recently became a member of the Association of American Universities. The GW student body is approximately 26,000 students: 14,887 graduate students and 10,929 undergrads.[2] This student body represents all fifty states, Washington, DC, and over 130 countries. There are thirteen academic schools within GW offering over seventy degrees, with five libraries located on the three campuses. We are recognized for our strong programs in international affairs, political science, and public administration.

Library and Academic Innovation (LAI) includes three of the five campus libraries, and we work closely with both the Burns Law Library and Himmelfarb Health Sciences. We are a member of the Washington Research Library Consortium (WRLC), which comprises research libraries in DC and Virginia. LAI's goal is to serve as a central hub for the GW community's research and educational needs. Part of our mission is to provide resources and services that benefit the GW community by eliminating some of the financial barriers that exist for our faculty, staff, students, and researchers. In addition to offering services that are traditionally thought of as library services, LAI offers many other services that support research, teaching, and learning. Some of these include assistance with course design and pedagogy, including accessibility, fellowship and internship application assistance for undergraduates, tutoring services, and access to advanced (and often expensive) multimedia software and equipment. Most recently, we've established the Open Source Program Office (OSPO) to lead and foster the development of open-source software and data.

We are able to offer this wide range of support because we have a staff with a broad range of skills, experience, and interests. We're also continuously cultivating collaborative relationships across units in order to better meet the needs of the community. For example, librarians support instructional designers who are helping faculty design online courses. Those instructional designers then support librarians with creating accessible learning or instructional materials.

In addition to librarians, LAI has full- and part-time staff with a range of domain expertise and educational experience, as well as student workers and temporary employees.

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i. When discussing the Cluster Hire Search Committee, "Search Committee" will be capitalized. When we discuss search committees in general, "search committee" will be lower case.

As an institution, GW has focused on creating a diverse, inclusive, and accessible culture within the GW community. In 2010, the university established the Office for Diversity, Equity, and Community Engagement (ODECE). ODECE provides training upon request and heads the Honey W. Nashman Center for Civic Engagement and Public Services, Disability Support Services, and the Multicultural Student Services Center.

Diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) has been a focus in LAI for many years. With the launch of the cluster hire in 2019, we saw an opportunity to work to increase diversity among librarians. This was only one of the efforts that LAI as an organization put into place to increase awareness of and address systemic oppression that exists within society, academia, and the library profession. LAI established a committee to lead DEI-related initiatives and programming in 2019. Each summer, the DEI Committee helps create learning groups that select different movies, podcasts, books, or topics to discuss. The DEI Committee facilitates monthly "Learning Table" sessions focusing on a variety of topics. Sessions have included topics such as reparative cataloging work, integrating diversity into collection development, student support services on campus, creating accessible course materials, and many other topics.

About the Council of Librarians

Most librarians are members of the Council of Librarians (Council), which was formed in 1967.[3] It provides a means for librarians to have a voice and stake in the strategic planning and a framework for engagement within the university and profession. The Librarian Code and Council of Librarian Bylaws (code and bylaws) provide the structure for Council operations and outline the responsibilities between Council and the University.[4,5] Our code and bylaws also cover the process for hiring, reappointment, and promotion review, and outline the criteria for each librarian rank.[6] Most positions that have "librarian" titles are members of Council, which has thirty-five members. The few positions that are not members of Council are externally grant-funded. The hiring process for librarians is outlined in our code and bylaws, which non-Council positions are not required to follow. While the staff in LAI is fairly diverse, the diversity of Council of Librarians members, as with the librarians in the profession as a whole, is less so.

Most Council meetings are open, so any staff member may attend. Within Council, there are four permanent committees: Executive Committee, Code and Bylaws, Librarian Review and Development (LRDC), and Grievance. Additionally, search committees and other temporary committees are formed as necessary.

Council members have a unique status that lies between faculty and staff, which we sometimes call "faculty lite."[ii] We do not have tenure, but we do have renewable appointment periods of three to five years, which are determined by rank. We are also eligible for research leave—six months every six years—though not as much as the sabbaticals or leave that faculty is entitled

ii. Librarians are a special class. We have rights and responsibilities that mimic those of faculty; however, we aren't eligible for tenure, aren't covered by Faculty Senate, but have limited term appointment periods, unlike staff who are at-will.

to. The renewable appointment periods require Council members to go through a reappointment process facilitated by LRDC. There are four ranks of librarians: I, II, III, and IV. Rank isn't tied to the position; it's tied to the individual in the position and is based on experience. Though it doesn't necessarily coincide with management or supervisory duties, expectations of the level of work and professional engagement increase as you move up in rank.

Positionality

The authors each have experience in both the cluster hire and the Ad-hoc Committee. During the cluster hire, Jen served on the Cluster Hire Search Committee, and Peter participated as a hiring manager.

Jen is the metadata services librarian, which has limited supervisory responsibilities, is not a hiring manager for any position, and has not served on subsequent search committees. She identifies as a straight white woman, is a first-generation college graduate, and has worked in multiple professional fields. She has been at GW since 2018.

Peter is one of three directors of Research Services, has extensive management and supervisory duties, and has chaired and served on search committees both before and after these procedures were implemented. Peter identifies as a gay white man and has spent his whole career in academic libraries. He has been at GW since 2016.

Improving Processes

Forming the Ad-hoc Committee on Search Procedures

The Ad-hoc Committee on Search Procedures (Ad-hoc Committee) was formed in early 2021 with a group of five volunteer Council members. It was tasked with updating and documenting our librarian search process and procedures. The members also consisted of hiring managers, Cluster Hire Search Committee members, and applicants from the cluster hire. They represented various departments and identities.

Research on DEI and Hiring Best Practices

As previously mentioned, at the start of the cluster hire, the Search Committee implemented a number of changes focusing on DEI. Some notable changes included conducting virtual information sessions to discuss the positions and LAI as a place to work, minimizing the number of required qualifications, and writing job postings in a way that would enable candidates to see themselves in the positions. The Ad-hoc Committee conducted additional research to be better informed and aware of best practices so we could be deliberate about codifying those changes. Making the hiring process more equitable and kinder isn't something that is exclusive

As a...	I want to...	So that...	Stage	Theme
Search committee member	know how to best recruit applicants	we have as diverse and inclusive a candidate pool as possible.	Recruiting, Position Requirements, F	DEI
Search committee member	use good practices for reviewing applications	we interview applicants with the most potential to contribute to LAI.	Application Review	DEI
Candidate	know what salary I can earn in the position	I know I will be compensated equitably and be positioned well in my career progression if I take a job at LAI.	Position Requirements, Posting	Salary
Candidate	know what salary I can earn in the position	I can make the best decision for myself and my family and not take up the time of the committee if it's inadequate.	Posting	Salary
Candidate	know when the appropriate time is to negotiate my salary	I can advocate for myself while not potentially starting off with someone on the wrong foot.	Posting	Salary, Communicaiton
Candidate	know what salary increases there may be each year	I know I will be compensated properly longer term if I take a job at LAI	?	Salary
Candidate	know what what the physical environment is like	I know LAI is a safe workplace and I would be comfortable working there.	Finalist interview	
Candidate	a clear presentation topic that relates directly to the position	I can address the position's needs and can present myself as an effective candidate.	Finalist interview	
Candidate	clear expectations communicated about the	I know how and on what I will be evaluated	Finalist interview, Screening interview, Evaluating candidate	

Figure 1. Example from the user stories feedback spreadsheet.

to library and library-adjacent institutions, so we were able to look at literature both inside and outside of the library profession. We did a comprehensive literature review, attended multiple workshops (both in person and virtual), and watched on-demand webinars to research best practices across all industries and fields.

Engaging with Stakeholders

One member of the group used their experience in software development to bring "user stories" as a way for us to engage with stakeholders. User stories, part of agile software development, consist of statements that follow this format: As a [role] I want [something] in order to be able to [business need]. These short statements enable us to better understand stakeholder needs to guide the work of a given project.

To create user stories, we interviewed colleagues who were hired after 2019, which included folks hired just before as well as from the cluster hire. We also included other stakeholders from the organization, such as hiring managers and non-librarian staff. The goal was to make sure that we collected data and viewpoints from the various roles involved in the librarian hiring process.

Changes to the Search Process[iii]

Forming a Search Committee and Checking Bias

The work of the group resulted in many changes (and we would say improvements) to our librarian search process. Each change in the process was framed with the idea of supporting

iii. The approved procedure document, which includes templates for various communications, examples of postings, and additional resources, is linked in the endnotes of our case study.

candidates and making the whole process as welcoming and inclusive as possible. We wanted to attract a more diverse pool than we had gotten in previous searches. The process was thereby designed to center the experience of the candidate, bring a sense of kindness and inclusion, support the candidate throughout the process, and ultimately allow them the space to perform at their best.

One of the first changes to the search procedures was to ensure that every search committee acknowledges its own implicit biases. If a search committee doesn't recognize its own biases and work to limit the impact, then it's not addressing the most basic and foundational part of the process, and that can negatively impact the goal of being more equitable. Each search committee designates a diversity advocate—a practice that predates the revision of the search procedures. This person is a full member of the search committee who takes ownership of keeping diversity, equity, and inclusion at the forefront hiring process. While every committee has a diversity advocate, it is the responsibility of all committee members to hold their fellow members accountable for centering DEIA in our conversations and deliberations. The committee also coordinates with the ODECE for a training session for committee members. This training helps educate or remind us about unconscious biases, reframe our way of thinking when going through the process, and ground our work in bringing kindness and humanity to what is an exhausting process. As part of informal bias training, they encourage members to self-examine through Harvard University's Project Implicit Bias or other online resources.

Creating the Job Posting

The next place the Ad-hoc Committee focused on is the job posting or position description. When drafting position descriptions, the goal is to focus on what duties or outcomes the job will involve rather than a laundry list of skills or knowledge required. Our goal is to enable candidates to see themselves in the position with their own unique experiences and skills. We worked to minimize the required and preferred qualifications to apply. Research shows that potential applicants, especially from underrepresented groups, often choose not to apply if they don't have all the preferred or required qualifications.[7,8] Many skills or experiences under the "preferred" or "required" section could be learned on the job with the proper institutional support. For example, in some cases, a position for a director may list management experience as preferred rather than required. We want to consider candidates who demonstrate the potential and interest in managing. In addition to crafting position descriptions with less detailed requirements, the positions were posted at an open rank, which allowed for candidates with a breadth of skills and experience to apply. Experience, like skills, can be gained on the job, especially with institutional support. Finally, we encourage applicants to apply for the position if they feel their unique experiences will enable them to thrive in the role.

This also included a recommendation that any required degrees be obtained prior to the official date of hire instead of at the time of application. With our code and bylaws, librarians are required to have a master's in library and information science (or other advanced degree),

unless otherwise waived by Council. The hiring process within academia can take months, so someone might be in their last semester at the time of application, but the official date of hire could be months after their degree is conferred.

We also began to offer virtual information sessions about open positions. These sessions enable candidates to hear from search committee members about the positions, LAI, and GW as a place to work. Attendees have the opportunity to anonymously ask questions about the positions. These sessions are completely optional, and they are recorded and posted on the library website so that they are available on demand. Attendees remain anonymous to each other and on the recordings. We made it clear that attending these sessions had no impact on applicants' candidacy, and we did not track attendance. Our goal was to enable candidates to see themselves in the position and to get a more personal view of GW and LAI before they even apply. By making the recordings available, we make the content accessible to anyone who cannot make the live event.

The Interviews

In general, we try to focus on the candidate's experience as they engage with us and our spaces, either virtually or in person, so that we can make the interview experience as positive as possible. There are also a handful of small changes we made to both the screening interview and the finalist interview to enable candidates to bring their best selves to the experience. For example, we send most of the interview questions in advance. Some folks are better on the spot and others perform better with time to reflect and prepare.

Since the pandemic, all of our librarian interviews have been conducted virtually using teleconferencing software. To provide as much flexibility to the candidate as possible, we give the option of doing the interview over one or two days. We also ensure that every meeting has a clear purpose in both assessing the candidate and giving them a clear understanding of the position and the organization. We share the schedule in advance and make sure that candidates have ample time to ask questions at each meeting of the interview. For presentations using computer technology, we proactively offer candidates practice time to make sure that the hardware and software work and that they are familiar with the software.

We are conscious and deliberate about scheduling designated break times for candidates and are diligent about protecting that downtime. We know how exhausting interviews can be, and everyone needs to recharge their batteries.

Because most of these positions are eligible for hybrid work, we ensure that candidates have the opportunity to learn more about the GW campus environment. This includes what it is like to live and work in the DC metropolitan area. Finally, candidates who are offered the position are invited to visit campus as part of their decision process.

While we have not yet conducted interviews in person since the pandemic, our procedures certainly allow for this, and we've made a number of changes that will improve the experience. We will proactively send information about facilities, such as all-gender restrooms, lactation facilities, and places to take breaks. We will also ask in advance to see if

there are things that we can do to make the experience more accessible. Not everyone feels comfortable self-advocating when it comes to an institution full of strangers, so we want to present them with an opportunity to tell us if there's something they need or would like for the day of the interview.

Future Work

We framed this work with the mindset to "strive for progress, not perfection." We work within larger systems, and it's hard to completely change and/or ameliorate the harms caused by systemic injustice and inequity. We know that there is a lot of work left to be done.

We see these procedures as a first step in creating a more diverse librarian workforce. Going forward, we might consider other ways to continue to make progress in this area. Some possible ideas include making space for internships, as other institutions have done, and doing more formal or direct outreach (beyond posting positions) with library organizations for underrepresented groups.

While there are a number of systemic barriers we cannot address, one barrier for retention that we can address is to develop a better structure for employee onboarding. Research indicated that this is one of the successful ways to retain historically underrepresented individuals in an organization. Recognizing that this is the next step in a robust and diverse organization, in late 2023, LAI established a committee to improve the onboarding process. Our hope is that this will contribute to a greater sense of belonging within the organization.

Our future work could also include working with LAI to incorporate some of these best practices from librarian searches in hiring processes for non-librarian staff and student workers.

Takeaways

Small incremental changes can have impactful results. For example, providing candidates with some of the questions prior to the interview didn't take much effort. The small additional effort was worthwhile, considering we received richer and more engaging answers from candidates.

Asking candidates if they wanted to do virtual interviews over one day or over the course of two days allowed for flexibility in the process. While this was something we wanted to do specifically during the pandemic, when childcare was particularly onerous on parents, it's something we have continued to offer because it gives candidates the opportunity to customize the experience to fit their needs as best as possible. It can also make some of the logistics of scheduling with stakeholders easier. Not everyone chooses to do it over the course of two days, but everyone gets the choice to decide what's best for them rather than us mandating the same exact process for everyone.

Having ODECE conduct training at the start of the process is a sea change for the hiring committee mindset. Not only does it educate and/or remind us about some of the inequity that exists and highlight some of our own internal biases, but it also fundamentally changes the way

some of us look at the hiring process and how we evaluate applicants. There's often a feedback loop in hiring, where the hiring body looks at potential candidates and thinks, "Is this person the right fit?" This can lead to hiring people like ourselves. It's not the best way to frame a more equitable hiring process if you're trying to bring diversity to an organization.[9] Dr. Jordan West, associate vice provost in ODECE, showed us the importance of looking at a job and an applicant with the mindset of "What are we missing? How does this person, job, etc. fill that gap?" We were able to look at applicants in the cluster hire process who expressed interest in one position but had skills to fill a gap aligned with a different position. We could ask if they would want to be considered for the other position. It has made a difference in how we look at candidates and has strengthened the organization as a whole. At the end of the process, Council is a more diverse group of individuals. Not only do we have different racial, gender, and other demographic identities, but we also have a broader depth of experience and expertise.

We now have a kinder applicant-centered process that is more supportive for candidates. The majority of the feedback we've received about our hiring process, from both candidates who became colleagues and candidates who were not offered positions, was overwhelmingly positive. The process also enhances our reputation as a supportive workplace, which, in turn, may help us in continuing to recruit high-level talent to our institution.

Acknowledgments

The authors would like to acknowledge the other members of the Ad-hoc Committee on Search Procedures who helped to improve our search processes: Bill Gillis, Monecia Samuel, and Laura Wrubel.

Notes

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CHAPTER 14

Collaboration, Engagement, and Decision-making

A Path to Compassionate Relationships and Empowerment

Vanessa Seals and Annie Bélanger

"If you want to go fast, go alone. If you want to go far, go together." —African Proverb

Introduction

Inclusive leadership, as defined in the Deloitte article on the six traits of an inclusive leader,[1] identifies collaboration as one of the critical traits, as these leaders seek to empower individuals as well as create and leverage ideas from diverse groups. Additionally, inclusive leaders should be curious to understand others' vantage points, be aware of their blind spots and biases, and commit to a culture of belonging. Layering the ACRL definition of inclusive leadership, inclusive leaders "seek out and consider different perspectives to inform their decision-making [as well as] collaborate more effectively [by centering] empathy and compassion in their approach."[2] Both Deloitte and the ACRL definitions center collaboration, engagement, and compassion in articulating what inclusive leadership is.

In libraries, collaboration and engagement are often seen as cornerstones of our work, our organizational culture, and, at times, our professional identities. Some might say that collaboration and engagement are a given in our field. Yet, literature and anecdotal conversation demonstrate that collaboration and engagement continue to be areas of necessary focus and growth in libraries' organizational culture and leadership development, followed closely by communications, healthy conflict resolution, and boundary-setting.

The terms "collaboration" and "engagement" are often used interchangeably. Yet, they have different meanings. Let's explore both dictionary and working definitions of these terms:

- **Collaboration** is defined in the dictionary as "the situation of two or more people working together to create or achieve the same thing."[3] A *Forbes* article defines collaboration in real life as "how people work together to accomplish goals or tasks. It's about creating an environment in which workers are willing (and enabled) to work well with teammates to positively impact the outcome of their projects and the organization overall."[4]

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- **Engagement** is defined as "the process of encouraging people to be interested in the work of an organization, etc."[5] The same *Forbes* article defines real-life engagement as "how people feel about their work and lives in general. It's about creating an environment in which each worker feels like an integral, included and valuable part of the team."[6]

Research has shown that collaboration and engagement are needed for healthy workplace cultures.[7] It has also been shown that they lead to more creative and stronger outcomes as people have ownership of the work, persist at challenging tasks longer, and can share their expertise early and often.[8] In other words, if collaboration is to be successful, we must have engagement in the workplace, and if people are to be engaged, we must foster collaboration. These distinct concepts are deeply interrelated and are part of a virtuous or vicious cycle. Therefore, both collaboration and engagement must be part of the inclusive leader's toolkit as they foster participatory or facilitative approaches[i] to leading and decision-making.

Over the last few decades, the demands on leaders have continued to grow as our organizations and societal expectations have evolved.[9] Leaders, who are often also managers, must now be able to master their functional expertise as well as additional skills, such as facilitation, coaching, mentoring, team-building, conflict resolution, advocating, and advancing equity.[ii] Since libraries are powered by humans who bring their passion and knowledge every day, it makes sense that leaders need to ensure they can leverage these with an equity-minded approach that centers compassion and accountability. At the same time, library leaders must fight against vocational awe[iii] of librarianship and of leadership.

Yet, like all things, too much of a good thing can lead to worse outcomes. Good and balanced collaboration and engagement enable creativity, shared purpose, enhanced communications, understanding, and more. Overzealous or unbalanced collaboration and engagement can lead to analysis paralysis, consensus trap, inefficiency, lack of role clarity, lack of decision-making clarity, and more. In an era of increasing demands and shrinking budgets in parallel to low morale and high burnout, how might we ensure collaborative, engaged workplaces that advance our missions as libraries? The question then becomes: How might we redefine collaboration and engagement within the context of inclusive leadership and healthy workplaces to ensure that productivity (outcomes), efficiency (process), and purpose (mission-alignment) are balanced?

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i. In participatory leadership, the leader still holds the final decision-making power while actively seeking input from the team before making a choice. A facilitative leader primarily guides the discussion and ensures everyone is heard, allowing the team to reach a consensus without imposing their own opinion.

ii. For more information on the competencies of leading self, leading others, and leading the organization, consult *18 Key Leadership Competencies for 2024 Success* by the Academy to Innovate HR at https://www.aihr.com/blog/leadership-competencies/.

iii. Vocational awe was defined by Fobazi Ettarh in 2018. Ettarh stated, "Vocational awe describes the set of ideas, values, and assumptions librarians have about themselves and the profession that result in notions that libraries as institutions are inherently good, sacred notions, and therefore beyond critique." https://www.inthelibrarywiththeleadpipe.org/2018/vocational-awe/.

Positionality Statements

I, Annie, am a white, cisgendered, disabled woman. I live in the US as a permanent resident, remaining an immigrant. I am a first-generation college graduate who has lived firsthand the social mobility that education can provide. I bring a strong identity as a library leader, with all but one year of my career as a formal leader. I also hold identities as a cultural minority in Canada as well as a mother and wife.

I, Vanessa, am a Black, biracial, cisgender woman. I have lived all of my life in the western US and have spent my entire adult life in higher education—as a student, a teacher, and an employee. I am the product of the TRIO program[iv] through the US Department of Education, and I credit the support I had in the McNair Scholars Program[v] with making it possible for me to attend graduate school and earn a doctorate degree. While I have been a leader in many spaces, I am relatively new to the library space and have been in my current library leadership position for over three years.

Concepts and Principles

Defining Collaboration, Cooperation, Engagement, and Empowerment

As stated above, collaboration is "the situation of two or more people working together to create the same thing."[10] Engagement is "the process of encouraging people to be interested in the work of an organization."[11] Another way to state this is that collaboration is an action, and engagement is a feeling or sense. Inclusive leadership takes into account not only the ways in which we work together but also how we bring others along and attend to the various cognitive and emotional factors that influence others' sense of belonging.

Libraries are, by nature, interlinked organizations. For example, collection management and retention involve multiple teams, such as collections, access services, and special collections. Yet, active collaboration is more than actualizing interdependence but also moving to proactive collaboration. Fostering engagement within libraries also creates an environment where all participants feel invested in the work as they are included and valued. And a key part of engagement is "empowerment," which is defined as "the process of giving a group of people more freedom or rights."[12] This is key to inclusive leadership because leadership includes more than simply managing. It's about developing the skills and talents of the people one leads that can help them grow.

iv. TRIO is a group of federal programs that help students access and succeed in higher education. The programs offer academic support, financial aid, and other services to help students from low-income and first-generation backgrounds.

v. McNair Scholars is a TRIO program designed to prepare undergraduate students for doctoral studies through involvement in research and other scholarly activities.

Also, collaboration requires more than simply cooperation, which is defined as "the act of working together with someone or doing what they ask you."[13] The second part of that definition—"or doing what they ask you"—is where collaboration fails. There is little sense of engagement or empowerment in that way of working together. Another way to define cooperation is a "socially contrived mechanisms for collective action."[14] This is not to say that cooperation can't also lead to engagement; however, when cooperation is not authentic, or when there are asymmetrical power structures and low levels of agency, efforts become about compliance, which can be harmful to progress.

Tension of Collaboration and Clarity/Structure

As inclusive leaders guiding collaboration, we are constantly balancing the need for agency and collaboration with clarity and structure. How do we provide what people need to be successful *and* keep our projects on target at the same time? How do we offer some guiding principles within which people can ideate and innovate while not hemming them in too much? It's a delicate balance. Part of being an inclusive leader is knowing roughly where you want to end up and creating mechanisms by which the team can get there by diverse pathways.

The collaboration roadmap needs to include clarity around decision-making. We will discuss multiple tools for decision-making in groups below to help inclusive leaders encourage others to provide deep input while not diluting the reality of decision-making authority. Acknowledging from the beginning of the process who ultimately has authority for the decision leads to more productive and satisfying collaborations. Think of a time when you were part of a decision-making process and you felt your contributions were undervalued or set aside. We want to avoid that feeling by telling people to what end they are participating in any given process. In that way, participants are able to decide, from the beginning, how much and what types of effort they would like to put into the collaborative process and to what end.

Qualities of Strong Collaboration

Before naming some tools and resources for building strong collaboration and engagement, we first want to name some qualities of strong collaboration. The first and most important quality is that the team has a sense of community. Because engagement is crucial to the success of collaborations, building a sense of community in which each person matters and is valued creates a strong foundation for collaboration. Creating community also requires developing a shared purpose. Once we have a shared understanding of our purpose, the next layer to a successful collaboration lies in communicating clearly from the beginning, setting guidelines of how we will work together, and managing expectations. This requires having a problem statement, purpose, vision, or mission so we all know where we're going and why. In that way, we can build a flexible roadmap together that will allow us to pivot and make decisions that are in line with our goals and values.

Once you've established a community and have agreed on a destination, you can build capacity[vi] by defining the roles, responsibilities, and authority of each team member. One framework that can inform this conversation is considering levels of empowerment within teams. Rabhi et al. refer to four types of empowerment: structural, leadership-related, cultural, and psychological.[15] Structural empowerment is related to the tasks associated with each person's role in the organization. Leadership-related empowerment lies with those making decisions. Cultural empowerment is built into the functioning of an organization or team. Cultural empowerment is achieved by rewarding the achievements of teams that incentivize groups to work toward a common organizational goal. This type of empowerment lies outside of the bounds of traditional positional authority and provides an opportunity for more inclusive leadership practices. Finally, psychological empowerment distributes the concept of power even further by focusing on the individual. Psychological empowerment is a process by which people are encouraged to evaluate their behavioral and interpersonal components of the way they work in order to more effectively collaborate and reach their destination.

This framework for team empowerment allows for creative and flexible thinking about the different ways individuals and groups are enabled to contribute to organizational goals. Importantly, this conceptualization acknowledges the realities of structural and leadership power while also creating space for empowerment at all levels of the organization. This is just one framework, and there are many others that can inform team dynamics in ways that take into account organizational positionality outside of formal leaders. Formal leaders can use these concepts to find a balance and clarify responsibility within processes at the beginning of a journey to ensure the group reaches its destination.

Tools and Practices

Collaboration and engagement, like all theoretical concepts, must be anchored in tools and practices if they are to become part of the culture and ongoing approach within libraries. We have selected several tools and practices that we, as formal leaders and leadership development practitioners, have found most applicable to the widest range of situations for both formal and informal leaders. Some of the tools focus on relational aspects while others focus on organizational processes.

Team Building

If you recall the quote at the start of the chapter, to go far, we must go together. When a team forms, and reforms as members change, it is important to take time to establish the team's

vi. Capacity-building refers to the process, individually or organizationally, of strengthening the ability to perform, produce, or implement. In other words, it refers to the development of skills, abilities, and knowledge that support future growth and ongoing learning.

purpose, values in action, and how we will be approaching our work together. Critical tools include creating a group charter (or team purpose statement) and collective engagement agreements (or rules of engagement).

Group Charter

A group charter is a statement of the team's purpose in its most basic form. It should also articulate the roles and responsibilities of the team overall as well as of specific team roles and goals. While taking the time to define team purpose stands in the face of efficiency, the Center for Creative Leadership points out that we often skip past the basics of healthy team dynamics when we don't take the time to define "why [teams] exist, where they fit, and how they'll accomplish their objectives."[16] "[The team charter] acts as a compass, guiding team members toward shared goals and fostering a cohesive work environment."[17]

Group charters, or team charters, are helpful because they increase accountability and buy-in, improve clarity and alignment inside and outside of the team, and unite members around a shared outcome and approach.[18] They also establish boundaries for the team's scope and authority as well as the path to gain support.

The article from the Center for Creative Leadership defines a process to create a team charter, to which we have added our experience and knowledge as team leads:

1. Meet to co-create the team charter, including time for team-building. In this meeting, it is important to find a space and time where everyone can be fully present. The group can explore key questions such as:
   a. Purpose
      - What kind of team is this? Is it ongoing or time-bound? Is it for a specific outcome or a process?
      - Why does it exist? What is it responsible for accomplishing?
      - What is the accountability and responsibility of the team?
      - What topics are in scope and out of scope?
   b. Values, process, and communications
      - What are our shared values as a group?
      - How will we communicate?
      - What do we expect of each other?
      - How will we resolve conflicts?
      - How will we plan for and track action items?
      - How and when will we meet?
   c. Decision-making
      - How will we make decisions?
      - What decisions are ours to make? What should be a recommendation?
      - Who is the team accountable to?

d. Consultation
   - Who is the team responsible for consulting with?
   - What will others need to know about our team and have input into?

e. Goals and roles
   - Who is on the team? What is each person's role?
   - Are there specific roles on the team?
   - Are there any sub-groups? And if so, what will they require?

2. Draft your team charter with, at a minimum, the following components:
   c. Team purpose. Articulate why the team exists and what it is meant to accomplish at a high level.
   d. Team context. Articulate accountability, decision-making, and reporting lines.
   e. Team roles and responsibilities. Articulate any specific roles, shared responsibilities, and goals.
3. Use the team charter to check on how the team is doing, resolve disagreements, and onboard new members.

Collective Engagement Agreements

Collective engagement agreements,[vii] which can be a component of a team charter, can be used on their own as a way to create a shared understanding of how a group will be together, what is expected of individuals as they interact, and at times share how conflict will be resolved. Whenever possible, it is best if members co-create these so that they have ownership in their enactment. The higher the stakes, the more critical these shared relationship agreements become.

Before setting up collective engagement agreements, it can be helpful to have a group self-reflect and then explore in small groups the following:

- Name a time when you were able to feel heard and valued. What made that possible? What was present or absent?
- Name a time when you felt dismissed or erased. What occurred for that outcome?
- Consider how you work and collaborate best. What are some of your critical needs, and what skills/strengths do you bring to a collaboration?

These leverage storytelling to highlight the components that are important to individuals and enable a common connection.

Questions to explore to set up collective engagement agreements include:

- How do we wish to be together in this space?
  - For example, we will listen to understand; we will use E.L.M.O. (Enough, let's move on.)

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vii. Collective engagement agreements are also called rules of engagement, group agreements, participation agreements, discussion ground rules, and more.

- What needs to be present for each of us to do our best work?
  - For example, I need us to be focused and engaged; I need to start and end on time; we will build material reading time into our meeting.
  - What needs to be absent for us to participate fully? For example, no interruptions (or acknowledge and stop), no curse words (varying workplaces have varying comfort levels), no phones on the table.

Note that it can be helpful to bring some starting statements for those new to the process. Here are two sample collective engagement agreements, from short to detailed:

- Metropolitan Area Planning Council
  - "Be fully present
  - Use 'I' statements
  - Take space, make space
  - Share the lesson, not the story
  - One mic"[19]
- University of Minnesota Office for Digital Accessibility
  - "As facilitators, we propose the following agreements as starting points for our learning community.
    - We respect the difference between discomfort and harm. We know that oftentimes the deepest learning comes when we are pushed outside our comfort zone.
    - We assume that everyone is doing the best they can, and we know that there is a difference between intent and impact.
    - We acknowledge that we enter into this work with varying levels of familiarity and vulnerability. We respect and offer one another the 'right to pass' (for instance, not respond or engage with the conversation) without question.
    - We understand that regardless of our educational and intellectual achievement, we have all been taught misinformation about experiences that differ from our own.
    - We may be familiar with different manifestations, but we agree that our society (and university) is shaped by intersecting systems of inequality—racism, sexism, cissexism, transphobia, heterosexism, ableism, classism, xenophobia, caste, colonialism, and more (glossary of terms).
    - We recognize that everyone makes mistakes during the learning and unlearning process (including facilitators). We commit to responding with patience, graciousness, and compassion.
    - We trust one another to reflect on how our identities/subject positions influence the ways we do (and do not) take up space, the voices we privilege, and the kinds of knowledge we value.
    - We welcome all kinds of engagement and encourage 'stepping up by stepping back.'

- We will hold the possibilities of silence with curiosity, openness and non-judgment. Silence does not imply any of the following: consent; dissent; agreement; disagreement; comfort; discomfort; awkwardness; understanding; misunderstanding."[20]

Communication Mechanisms

In collaboration and engagement, communication is a critical element that must be planned with intentionality and acted on in a deliberate manner. For larger efforts, a communication plan, sourced from project management methodology, can be a great tool to plan your communications approach, cadence, and content.[viii] The following tools are more organic and meant to help you consider how people will be expected to engage (participation), how feedback loops can be created to offer a communication flow, and how to foster community connections.

Spectrum of Participation

We have adapted the spectrum of participation from the IAP2's Spectrum of Public Participation, which "was designed to assist with the level of participation that defines the public's role in any public participation process."[21] In the context of collaboration and engagement, it is important to define the level of engagement that others in the library or the greater community can expect. As you read the participation levels, you may note that misaligned participation expectations will quickly lead to feelings of disenfranchisement.

Adapted for library collaboration and engagement, the spectrum of participation is:

- **Informed.** Information will be shared to ensure that decisions and outcomes are communicated. Information required for implementation will be provided.
- **Consult.** Feedback will be solicited at specific stages of development. Feedback will be considered and may impact the final outcome or the process.
- **Input/involve.** Input will be actively solicited early in the process and will have a significant impact on the outcome or process. Members in this section may be actively involved in the development of the outcome or process.
- **Collaborate.** Members will be asked to collaborate in the active development of the outcome or process. They will be engaged in understanding the context, problem identification, and in solution development. Their recommendations will be considered.
- **Empower.** Final decision-making, often within a set scope and range, will be handed to the group participants.

viii. We recommend consulting ACRL's "Fostering Change: A Team-Based Guide for Project Planning and Management Tools, Including Communication Planning," https://www.ala.org/sites/default/files/acrl/content/publications/booksanddigitalresources/digital/FosteringChange.pdf.

Feedback Loops

Often in libraries, and other service organizations, we seek feedback from our colleagues and users. Yet, too often, we fail to close the loop when we neglect to let colleagues know how their feedback impacted the outcome. The feedback loop tool is meant to help articulate the three phases of the feedback cycle. The following three-step feedback loop was shared by Meghan Musolff from her work as the director of Strategic Planning for the University of Michigan:

4. "Open the feedback loop: Set the stage. What feedback, why, and what for?
5. Body: Have a conversation using active listening and a solutions-focus. Take notes so feedback themes can be shared.
6. Close: What next? What did you learn? How did the feedback impact your work? What follow-up will you provide?"

She describes the feedback loop as an opportunity to practice care for our work, to anchor accountability in our approach, and to live our organizational values.

Decision-making within the Context of Collaboration and Engagement

In the collaboration and engagement processes, it is important to articulate who will have decision-making power early and clearly as well as what level and type of empowerment can be expected. It is also important to articulate what type of decision-making approaches will be used. Reflect on a time when you thought you had decision-making authority, only to feel overruled. Sometimes, this occurs because of a lack of inclusive leadership or because the process was not made clear.

When considering decision-making, we need to articulate a few things:

- **What** are we deciding? Is it one decision, or multiple smaller ones? (What type of decision are we making?)
  - There are three key types of decisions:[22]
    - *strategic*—long-term decisions; often the purview of senior leaders;
    - *tactical*—medium- to short-term decisions, may create a precedent; often the purview of middle managers; and
    - *operational*—day-to-day decisions; often the purview of supervisors, but also offer an opportunity for empowerment of staff within the scope of their role and responsibilities.
- **Who** should be involved and what role should they play?
- **How** will we make the decision? What process will we use, what criteria will help us decide among options, and how will we communicate and follow through?
- **When** does the decision need to be made?

Over the last two decades, management and leadership literature has encouraged leaders to move decision-making as close to those impacted as possible. The benefit of this is to reduce blind spots in decision-making, identify and surface inaccurate or incorrect thinking quickly, and to ensure that those impacted or implementing decisions have an opportunity to have voice. As decision-making has been decentralized, there are often times when decision-making authority is unclear, leading to confusion and often frustration. Therefore, it is important to define the way decisions will be made and by whom. In other words, we need to define decision rights, which "refer to the commonly accepted rules and practices that outline who has the authority to make various types of decisions."[23]

Additionally, we believe that inclusive leaders need to center equity in their decision-making process in order to honor collaboration, a range of voices, and differing experiences. Several tools can be used to support this exploration and application:

- **Equitable Decision-Making Tool** by Clark College's Office of Diversity, Equity and Inclusion: https://www.clark.edu/about/governance/shared-governance/EquitableDecisionMakingTool.pdf
- **VIBE Framework to explore views, inclusion, benefits and burdens, and equity:** https://www.facultyfocus.com/articles/equality-inclusion-and-diversity/decision-making-for-equity-applying-the-vibe-framework-for-more-equitable-outcomes/
- **3P process for multi-dimension equity lens:** People, Place, and Process by Harvard's School of Public Health Office of Diversity and Inclusion, https://www.hsph.harvard.edu/diversity-dev/wp-content/uploads/sites/2597/2021/08/ODI-Equity-Lens-for-Decision-Making-WCAG.pdf

RACI and RAPID

The RACI model was popularized by project managers as it articulates clarity of roles and scope of responsibility by stating the following:

- **responsible**—individual(s) who executes the work, ensures its completion, and seeks to prevent overlapping efforts;
- **accountable**—individual who won the task's success, makes key decisions, and ensures progress is happening;
- **consulted**—person or people who provide valuable insights before decisions are made or decisions are taken; and
- **informed**—person or group of people who will need updates on task progress and outcomes.

RACI can be a useful tool to know who you will collaborate with and how.

The Bridgespan Group, a nonprofit leadership group, elaborated on the RACI framework to create a decision-making framework, which they named RAPID. They created this tool

"to spell out roles in order to help nonprofits improve the organizational decision-making process."[24] They advocate to first define your decision-making purpose, roles, communication, and timing. In our opinion, this tool helps provide clarity of power in decision-making and engagement towards decisions.

The RAPID model is meant to address those who should be involved and how they should be involved by defining "who provides input to a decision, who shapes the decision and ultimately decides on it, and who carries out the decision once it is made."[25] Bridgespan defines these roles, which don't need to occur in the listed order, as:

- **Recommender:** this individual, or small team, leads the decision-making process, gathers relevant information, seeks input and feedback, and develops a formal recommendation for the Decide[r].
- **Agree:** and while this only applies to some decisions, these individuals must agree with the final recommendation. Consider legal providing agreement to a possible decision.
- **Perform:** this encompasses the individual or team that will implement the decision once it is made. *We believe it is important to identify them early and see where input can be solicited.*
- **Input:** these are those who provide data, information, and advice to the Recommender. This is typically the largest group as it includes subject experts as well as those significantly impacted by the decision.
- **Decide:** This is the person who makes the decision, committing the organization to implement the decision and the associated actions.[26]

Decision Modes

Collaboration and engagement intersect with decision-making as the modes of decision-making—how the decision will be made and by whom—are considered. The Management Center has outlined a decision mode framework that sets a range from "joint" to "consult" to "test" to "persuade" to "tell."[27] It has strong ties to the spectrum of participation, RACI, and RAPID as it outlines a spectrum of decision-making approaches. The framework can help an inclusive leader articulate which mode of decision-making they are using as well as the criteria for the selected model for each given decision type. As a decision-maker, consider which decision-making mode to use. These working definitions can help in the deliberation.

- **Joint:** The team is the decision-maker and will collaborate to come to agreement; often looks like voting or using a consent/consensus process.
- **Consult:** The decision-maker(s) are seeking input on a specific decision or option and will consider new ideas or feedback to shape the final outcome; this could look like brainstorming or weighing a few concrete options.
- **Test:** Decision-maker(s) have a concept or draft and want to see how it works, lands, or holds up for different audiences.

- **Persuade:** Decision-maker(s) want to build buy-in and have already done work to get here; concerns raised will inform improvements (and, in some rare cases, might change the decision).
- **Tell:** The decision is made. Decision-maker(s) are sharing information, including context or rationale, to promote understanding; questions and input will aid implementation.[28]

When leading inclusively, the modes should be considered, decided on, and communicated ahead of decision-making. This will help to support transparency and shared understanding.

Gradients of Agreement

Gradients of Agreement, developed by Kaner, Berger, and staff of Community At Work in 1987, enables team members to express their level of support for a decision or course of action under discussion.[29] It moves a group beyond a binary of yes or no. The traditional gradients range from "agree" to "agree with reservation" to "mixed feelings" to "disagree but won't block" to "disagree." The spectrum can be customized to the group's local language.[ix]

Here's how to use the gradient of agreements:

1. Determine the level of agreement necessary. Some decisions need a high level of agreement, while others do not.
2. Engage in a six-step cyclical process, which can be repeated several times in one meeting or over time. In the *Facilitator's Guide to Participatory Decision Making*, Kaner, Lind, Toldi, Fisk, and Berger articulate a cycle to use the gradients of agreement.[30]

    1. After a time of discussion, have someone suggest a proposal for action or next steps.
    2. Write down the proposal.
    3. Check for understanding of the proposal.
    4. Ask each person in the group to determine their level of agreement. Have them indicate it on the gradient. Hold explanations until the next step.
    5. Discuss responses round-robin style, allowing each person to explain their level of agreement or disagreement. Have the group consider modifications that would enable higher levels of agreement.
    6. Poll the group again. Repeat steps two to five until the necessary level of agreement is reached.[31]

ix. Examples of localized adaptations include simple to more complex: 1) yes/maybe/no; 2) enthusiastic support, lukewarm support, meager support or stand aside, strong objection; and 3) love it, like it, can live with it, doesn't affect me, hate it.

Conclusion

We opened the chapter with the proverb, "If you want to go fast, go alone. If you want to go far, go together." Another version of this concept is represented by the US Navy SEALS saying, "Slow is smooth and smooth is fast." This saying encapsulates the dichotomies that exist when working with a team. Taking the time at the beginning of a project to establish a sense of community, a path to a destination, a clear sense of power structures and responsibilities, and a plan for how to address disagreement will make the rest of the process much smoother and faster. It also embodies the nature of inclusive leadership by making space for all participants and being transparent about the influence of their level of participation. And, critically, having a plan for when things go wrong is much easier to discuss before things have gone wrong.

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CHAPTER 15

Case Study: **Never Too Old**

Inclusive Leadership Traits of a Late-Career Librarian

Regina M. Beard

Florida Gulf Coast University (FGCU) is a regional public institution located in southwest Florida. Its early emphasis on sustainability means that some of its 800 acres remain under conservancy. Students have access to sixty-four undergraduate, twenty-six master's, and seven doctoral programs. As of fall 2023, degree-seeking students numbered more than 13,000 undergraduates and nearly 1,900 graduates. The university does not grant tenure but confers faculty status on teaching faculty and librarians. Promotion criteria documents mirror traditional tenure requirements in their rigor.

After nearly twenty years in the banking industry, I was at a professional crossroads—I had reached the limits of my current position and was ready for a new challenge and a different industry. The previous fall, in preparation for such a change, I enrolled in library school. On the heels of this development, I was notified, along with 1,300 of my colleagues, of an impending layoff. There I was, a married African American woman, facing both middle age and a job loss. Although I approached the layoff with as much optimism as one can—I had already taken steps to retool my skillset by applying to a graduate school program—I faced many months of unemployment until graduation. Unlike most of my classmates, however, I had never worked in a library, unless the semester as a library proctor when I was in the ninth grade counts. And since I was no longer employed full time, I took advantage of every internship opportunity I could squeeze into my schedule and even landed a paid part-time reference desk job at an urban university library.

As a young working professional, I thought that success was defined by a steady and discernible ascent up the organizational ladder, and "up" meant moving into a management position and ensuring that team members completed assignments. In that context, little to no consideration was given to individual aspirations or professional development. During my time in banking, I worked to advance my career, imagining that I would earn my way into a management position, but after several years and a couple of non-managerial promotions later, I realized that management as I experienced it—micro-managed my time, nitpicked my work processes, and ignored my professional aspirations—was a far cry from the manager I thought wanted to be.

To be fair, my co-workers' less-than-professional behavior, considering less-than-professional treatment, also contributed to my discouragement. I concluded that I had neither the

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patience nor the desire to develop the requisite skills to successfully manage (or babysit, as I came to see it) a unit. Once I reached that conclusion, I pretty much abandoned the desire to pursue those opportunities. That kind of management looked too hard to sustain and its rewards too small. I told myself I didn't need that headache.

Some years later, as a business librarian, I circled back to the idea of leadership and how I would approach it. I found that my attitude toward leadership had grown more contemplative as my notions about success matured. I applied and was accepted as a Fellow in the ARL Leadership and Career Development Program (LCDP), an incredibly enlightening experience and one that informs my approach to the work I do now. Participation clarified my thinking about my capabilities and boosted my confidence in my belief that I could be effective in a leadership role. Specifically, the program clarified, for me, that managers and leaders focus on different aspects of organizational development. I came to understand that managers' roles focus on making sure that the work gets done, while leadership is concerned with developing people. The roles are equally important, and one individual can and, ideally, should wear both hats.

Our LCDP discussions and self-assessments centered relationships between the leader and the staff, among colleagues in a unit, and between mid-level and senior leadership. The discussions also focused on the significance of trust in the workplace. I learned that trusting relationships empowers individuals to perform at higher levels and take greater risks to develop and implement new services and programs because their confidence in leadership emboldens them, and they are less fearful of the repercussions of failed attempts.

During that period, I also came across a book, *Trust and Betrayal in the Workplace: Building Effective Relationships in Your Organization*,[1] which was a real lightbulb moment for me. The book discusses the connection between trust and communication in the workplace, something that resonated with me. I know how I felt when I thought information from administration was being censored or withheld. While the book notes that clarity in communication is paramount, it also reminds the reader that although there may be valid reasons for withholding information, it is just as important to acknowledge that information is being withheld. This distinction makes it clear to the recipient that there is no intention of misleading. Folks may not like it when they don't get the full picture, but when they know that much, they are less likely to speculate the worst.

A year or so later, I had the opportunity to put into practice what I had learned through the fellowship and from the literature when I assumed an interim department head position. I anticipated that this temporary foray into the administrative ranks would clarify my career's direction and settle—for me—whether I had the fortitude to be in leadership.

I joined Florida Gulf Coast University in 2015 at the associate rank (having achieved tenure at my previous institution) and was responsible for the College of Business, the School of Hospitality, and, ultimately, the School of Entrepreneurship. The library operated traditionally; its subject librarians' responsibilities included reference desk shifts, library instruction, research consultations, and collection development. Oh, and two weeks after I started, my department head resigned. The associate dean hinted that I might want to apply for the position, though I neither felt prepared for nor did I particularly want the job. However, five years

later, in 2020, when the new department head resigned and the newly arrived dean asked me to step in, I accepted. Why the change of heart? Well, by then, I was ready for a new challenge. Despite my outreach efforts, business faculty showed little interest in the library or its services. I interacted with faculty and students outside the classroom regularly, but not to the degree that felt impactful. Since I planned to remain in the library for the foreseeable future, I began to plan a role that emphasized service and scholarship. I identified research projects I wanted to pursue and service commitments I was willing to make.

Of course, the telling of this journey would not be complete without mentioning the pandemic and its immediate and long-term impact on the library. At its worst, the institution went into lockdown mode when classes shifted to virtual mode, as did library services—in-person research assistance went virtual, classroom instruction all but ceased, and email questions increased. Once we returned to campus, however, the residual impacts remained. One of the most impactful changes in the library was the organization's attitude toward remote work. While the pandemic forced everyone to work remotely, both from home and then from our respective offices, once we were allowed to return to campus, librarians continued the practice of working from home when their schedules allowed. I admit that I struggle with the concept since my personal preference is to commute to work every day. While I would prefer that everyone follow my lead and come to the library five days a week, I acknowledge that the tools we have available to us allow us to work regardless of location. I must trust that our respective approaches to achieving our professional objectives occur whether I can see them or not.

I had a new job with a new administration and had to determine the kind of leader I would be and how to go about becoming that leader. Throughout my childhood, my mother asserted that I was a "natural" leader. I believe that I am a reluctant follower, for which I credit (or blame) my mother's unequivocal insistence that rather than "follow the crowd," I would decide for myself how I would navigate my world. In a leadership context, these qualities suggest some level of proactivity and willingness to act independently where circumstances allow, a personal initiative that I nurture in myself and encourage in others.

The environment I strive to nurture and build is one in which individuals comfortably express ideas, where difficult conversations do no harm, and opposing viewpoints are not perceived as personal attacks. One way I promote such an environment, when I meet with the librarians individually, is to coach them through what they presume might be a difficult conversation with another librarian or a teaching faculty member. When a librarian wanted to resign from a university committee she chaired because she felt overwhelmed by expectations, I agreed that she could resign from the position or that she could ask for a volunteer from the committee to co-chair. In that way, she could remain on the committee and gain valuable leadership experience. Although she is still challenged by a lack of committee participation, a member agreed to be co-chair. I was gratified by her willingness to step out of her comfort zone, and I believe she is glad that she was able to navigate through to a solution.

Such an environment is predicated on trust, and trust derives from several behaviors, including keeping confidence, being true to one's word, and maintaining clear and regular

communication. If trust is the connecting tissue in the workplace, how does leadership exemplify it in the workplace? It is incumbent on leaders to maintain trust at all costs because once trust is broken, it's nearly impossible to mend. Communication is always a challenge—it's not only about how information is shared or received or perceived. Communication is only effective when it flows two ways and is multi-channeled. Not all communication can be shared, or there may be timing issues in sharing information. I share as much information with my department as possible and encourage the librarians to proactively seek it out. When individuals complain about not being informed, they have abdicated the responsibility for equipping themselves to fully engage in the work of an organization. I communicate this expectation to the department regularly.

Leadership should strive for transparent, clear communication to establish, at least, a baseline level of trust. Individually, we must agree that sometimes people make mistakes, say too much, or say too little. Realistically, no one's behavior will ever totally eliminate questions. My own approach, besides optimizing transparency, is to make sure that I do what I say. If I say I will advocate for a specific project, I do so and report back. If I have doubts about a proposal's reception, I voice as much and then attempt to encourage the librarians to reframe the issue so that library administration will reconsider it.

Gossip, the seedy underbelly of communication, can undermine the most noble attempts to create and maintain clear communication channels. Individual and organizational growth is stunted when gossip prevails. And gossip prevails when individuals share information when they should not. As a department head, direct reports may need to share certain information with me. It is so important that they know that I won't repeat anything they tell me that I typically ask them to share only as much as they believe I need to know. I try to keep my questions to a minimum, asking only as much as I need to resolve or understand their situation. As I matured, both personally and professionally, I came to realize that possessing information is a burden that I am too old to bear. Knowing too much is as bad as knowing too little. Gossip, the urge to share another's story, is presumptuous and, in leadership, diminishing.

Since I started my current position, I have continued to develop my leadership skills. If we're honest, those of us in leadership would admit that we will never master it. How we lead is governed, in part, by those we lead. We're constantly adjusting to those around us to provide the professional environment that optimizes growth in our colleagues. I do not consider myself a complete leader—I still make what I consider to be rookie mistakes. There are days when I seem to have the right answer to every question, and then there are days when I must apologize for or amend some decision. I continue to look to relevant literature for guidance. I take advantage of leadership development opportunities offered by ALA. Finally, I regularly meet with my own mentor, a colleague who works at another institution.

Communication is key to inclusive leadership. So, while it's not always convenient to allow people to stream through my office unannounced, I understand that creating an environment where team members feel heard is essential, and I enjoy working through a challenge or request with a librarian. As a result, I often struggle to maintain a balance between making time for these impromptu discussions with the staff and the ability to manage my own workload. I

have learned to set boundaries—I may impose time limits on drop-ins or encourage scheduled appointments for deeper conversations. If I am really pressed, I close my door. This balancing act is a part of my ongoing growth as a leader. I may be older than the typical leader, but I continue to learn from my departmental colleagues, and I hope that they learn something of value from me and from each other.

Notes

1. Dennis Reina and Michelle Reina, *Trust and Betrayal in the Workplace: Building Effective Relationships in Your Organization* (Oakland, CA: Berrett-Koehler Publishers, 1999).

CHAPTER 16

Compassionate Care in the Library Workplace

Shannon D. Jones

Positionality

I am a Black woman who leads an academic health sciences library situated in downtown Charleston, South Carolina, which was once the largest slave port in the United States, so I also pay homage to the lives and labor of the enslaved African men, women, and children whose first steps on United States soil were in the city I call home. This chapter is written from my lived experience as a Black librarian and library leader with over twenty years of experience working in academic health sciences libraries. As a leader, I have spent the last fifteen years exploring how diversity, equity, inclusion, and belonging are operationalized in the academic health sciences library environment. In my professional practice, I aspire daily to use my voice and leadership privileges to cultivate a welcoming, safe, affirming, and inclusive workplace environment—an environment in which people want to work, one where they feel like they belong, and one that I would be proud to lead. I am acutely aware of my biases and how I show up and step up on behalf of others, disrupt uncivil behavior, and model compassion in the workplace. In librarianship, I am committed to creating brave spaces for historically excluded library workers, those experiencing trauma or hurt, those navigating life challenges, and celebrating their successes.

As a Black woman leader in higher education, I am acutely aware of the well-documented challenges that Black women have faced in that space, including the devaluing of their research, barriers to promotion and tenure, heightened levels of scrutiny and mistreatment, racism, sexism, and persistent underrepresentation.[1] These challenges weighed heavily on my mind as I wrote this chapter, especially considering the untimely deaths of the late Drs. Antoinette "Bonnie" Candia-Bailey, Joanne A. Epps, Orinthia T. Montague, Attorney Browne C. Lewis, and other Black women who passed away while in service to higher education. Their passing serves as a somber reminder of the heavy burdens Black women often bear in higher education and underscores the need for systemic change to support the well-being and success of Black women in higher education. I do not want to work in a stressful, unsafe, toxic, demeaning, or devaluing workplace, nor do I want that for the people I lead. The deaths of the aforementioned Black women inspired my exploration of what protection looks like in the workplace environment. This exploration led me to the concept of compassionate care. Ultimately, I do not want to lead an environment rooted in toxicity, but one upheld by compassion.

Introduction

You may be wondering why there is a need to prioritize integrating compassion and care at work. Since 2020, we have navigated the challenges of the COVID-19 pandemic, a tense presidential election, the racial reckoning following George Floyd's murder, an increase in book banning and censorship in libraries, and the dismantling of diversity, equity, and inclusion programs in some states. The years following 2020 have been deeply traumatic for many, personally and professionally. Many have experienced the loss of loved ones, health challenges, and ongoing attacks on libraries. These difficulties make incorporating compassion in the workplace more crucial than ever.

Compassionate care forms the foundation of a supportive and inclusive work environment. It involves creating spaces where individuals feel valued, respected, and empowered to thrive. Hougaard asserts that showing compassion in the workplace can improve collaboration, boost levels of trust, and strengthen loyalty.[2] Let us start by breaking down the meaning of compassion. The etymology of the word "compassion" is derived from the Latin words *cum* (with) and *patior* (to suffer).[3] Another definition explains compassion as "a deep feeling of sympathy and sorrow for someone who is going through a difficult time, accompanied by a strong desire to alleviate their suffering."[4] Compassion extends beyond empathy, which is the ability to share others' emotions, to include actionable steps that alleviate suffering. According to Trzeciak, Mazzarelli, and Seppala, compassion is an emotional response to someone else's struggles that involves a genuine desire to help.[5]

Compassionate leadership builds on a solid foundation by encouraging leaders to integrate empathy and action into their practices. Compassionate leaders recognize their teams' challenges and actively work to address them, creating environments that prioritize well-being and trust. Donnellan emphasizes that compassionate leaders can express sympathy, empathy, and compassion as needed in the workplace, but it is essential to understand that these terms have distinct meanings.[6] According to Singer and Klimecki, empathy is the ability to share the emotions of others. It allows a leader to connect with their positive and negative feelings; we can feel joy when we share in someone's happiness and experience their pain when we empathize with them.[7] Compassion goes beyond feeling empathy; it also involves taking responsive action.

Before blending the concepts of compassion and care, it is crucial to understand what it truly means to show care in the workplace. Merriam-Webster defines care as "to do the things that are needed to help and protect (a person or animal) or look after (someone or something)."[8] In this sense, providing care in the workplace means creating an environment where employees feel supported, valued, and respected. It involves understanding what each employee needs to thrive in their role, practicing empathy, and fostering a culture of trust and inclusivity. Compassionate leadership, which blends care, empathy, and love, can alleviate the suffering of others. According to Hougaard, Carter, and Beck, a leader's compassion is evident in their commitment to promoting the happiness and well-being of those they lead.[9]

Inclusive leadership ties these elements together, emphasizing that compassion and care must extend to all library workers, regardless of their background or identity. Inclusive leaders

go beyond fostering individual well-being; they actively work to dismantle systemic inequities, promote equity, and ensure all team members feel a sense of belonging. Compassionate care and leadership are integral to inclusive leadership because they create a workplace culture rooted in empathy, action, and equity. By blending these approaches, leaders can cultivate environments that empower individuals, celebrate diversity, and drive meaningful, systemic change. Ultimately, the intersection of compassionate care, compassionate leadership, and inclusive leadership equips organizations to navigate challenges while fostering resilience, loyalty, and engagement. These principles serve as a guide for leaders striving to create workplaces that prioritize humanity and mutual respect.

The Compassionate Leader

The leader sets the tone for everything in the library by leading by example, being self-aware, and demonstrating compassion for others. The relationship between the leader and the people on their team is crucial in any library. This involves more than performing administrative tasks and making decisions, especially in today's rapidly changing information landscape. It also involves creating a supportive workplace environment, building relationships, and fostering a sense of belonging among library workers.

The leader's understanding of compassion and ability to show it in their daily interactions is tantamount to creating a positive and inclusive work environment, ultimately contributing to the team's well-being. Compassionate leadership involves recognizing and addressing staff members' needs and challenges, promoting support, and fostering a collaborative atmosphere. According to Donnellan, compassionate leadership is using your head and heart to inspire and positively influence people.[10]

- Developing a compassionate leadership practice requires exhibiting specific behavioral attributes. A nursing study outlined these to include listening, developing a relationship, alleviating suffering, touching, and going beyond the nurse's role.[11] These are equally vital for inclusive library leaders, too.
- Listen actively to understand and amplify diverse perspectives, ensuring that all voices are heard and valued.
- Build relationships and foster trust, creating meaningful connections that transcend barriers of race, gender, ability, and background.
- Alleviate suffering by addressing systemic inequities, reducing barriers to access, and creating an environment where individuals feel supported and empowered.
- Demonstrate empathy and emotional connection, which helps cultivate a sense of belonging and psychological safety. This is the equivalent of "touching" in nursing, where physical care is important.
- Go beyond their defined roles to advocate for diversity, equity, and inclusion, championing policies, practices, and resources that ensure all library workers are supported and represented.

Hougaard, Carter, and Hobson suggest that combining compassion and wisdom is necessary for approaching difficult situations in a humane way.[12] Compassionate leaders approach challenging situations by being present, courageous, direct, and transparent to lead most effectively with compassion.[13] Hougaard adds that the most important action a leader can take to enact compassion is to be present, but it must be paired with asking questions, demonstrating understanding, and listening. Campbell describes the seven traits of compassionate leadership as one who understands that leadership requires learning, removing barriers, making a positive impact, holding oneself and one's ethics to high standards, seeking influence, not authority, inspiring passion, and understanding the importance of a team.

Meanwhile, Donnellan identifies seven core attributes of a compassionate leader: being contemplative, curious, confident, compassionate, collaborative, civil, and courageous.[14] These attributes align with inclusive leadership, as both approaches prioritize creating environments where individuals feel valued, respected, and empowered. A contemplative leader reflects on their biases and actions to ensure that their efforts to be inclusive are intentional. Leaders seek to understand diverse perspectives by being curious, fostering learning and empathy. Confidence enables leaders to challenge inequities and advocate for marginalized voices, while compassion ensures they lead with empathy and care for the well-being of others. Collaboration emphasizes the importance of working together across differences and valuing each team member's contributions. A civil leader promotes respect and open dialogue, cultivating psychological safety. Finally, courage is essential for confronting systemic barriers, implementing change, and championing diversity, equity, and inclusion. These attributes form the foundation of inclusive leadership. Where compassion and inclusivity thrive, meaningful and transformative progress.

Promoting compassion in the workplace offers numerous benefits. According to Chowdhury, these benefits include increased employee retention, stress reduction, improved physical well-being, and strengthened interpersonal bonds.[15] Rodriquez-Zaba further emphasizes that a compassionate workplace boosts employee morale, maintains strong teamwork, enhances job performance, and leads to outstanding customer service.[16] Achieving these benefits in the library workplace requires leaders to increase their understanding of the challenges and stressors and what it takes to make their team members feel safe, valued, understood, heard, and supported. Compassionate leaders "create safe environments where their teams are encouraged to practice self-compassion, vulnerability, and compassion for others."[17] One of the seven traits Campbell ascribes to compassionate leaders is removing barriers:

> Compassionate leaders immerse themselves in the daily grind with their team, helping them face and solve problems harming productivity or hindering reciprocal communication when closing deals. Removing barriers is twofold. Leaders must understand each team member's internal emotional patterns, which hold them back and promote them to success.[18]

Leaders must understand their social identities and biases and how those biases shape their worldview. Understanding one's identity is essential for providing compassionate care and promoting inclusive leadership in a library setting. Inclusive leadership thrives on empathy, equity, and understanding, which require leaders to be attuned to their diverse social identities and those they serve. Identity is shaped by various intersecting factors such as race, ethnicity, gender, age, sex, socioeconomic status, sexual orientation, religious beliefs, national origin, and other factors, which profoundly influence your worldview, interactions with others, the way you make decisions, and how you respond in challenging situations. Coined by Kimberlé Crenshaw, intersectionality "describes the way your social identities can overlap."[19] Intersectionality is

> a lens, a prism, for seeing the way in which various forms of inequality often operate together and exacerbate each other. We tend to talk about race inequality as separate from inequality based on gender, class, sexuality or immigrant status. What's often missing is how some people are subject to all of these, and the experience is not just the sum of its parts.[20]

Awareness of social identities fosters empathy and equips leaders to create environments where everyone feels valued and supported. Inclusive leadership relies on this ability to connect authentically with others, address systemic inequities, and adjust decision-making processes to ensure fairness and equity.

Everyone has biases. Acknowledging and mitigating these biases, particularly implicit ones, is essential for inclusive leadership. Raising your awareness of implicit biases is especially important, as they "operate almost entirely on an unconscious level. While explicit biases and prejudices are intentional and controllable, implicit biases are less so."[21] Implicit biases influence perception, conflict resolution, and decision-making. Recognizing this, leaders must address their biases, such as taking the Harvard Implicit Association Test, attending workshops, reading about implicit bias, practicing self-reflection, and fostering intentional connections with others. These actions not only enhance self-awareness but also contribute to cultivating an inclusive and equitable work environment. Although biases may never fully disappear, increased awareness can improve your decision-making, leadership approach, and ability to foster a culture of belonging and equity for all library workers.

The leader must also consider their relationship with and understand what it means to be a compassionate leader. How they define compassionate care, receive it, give it, and enable it at work. The leader must also be aware of the goal of providing compassionate care. One of the goals is to reduce burnout among the library staff. This exploration is critical because the leader's understanding of compassion will impact workplace decisions. In addition, this will assist the leader in providing better care for each person they lead. Increased awareness of the identities held will allow you to gain clarity when identifying the influences of power, privilege, and oppression in your environment. Exploring your identities will help you notice when individuals in your environment are marginalized, oppressed, sidelined, or silenced.

Operationalizing Compassionate Care

Inclusive library leadership is essential for making compassion a core value and prioritizing its practice in daily operations. Inclusive leaders actively work to create a supportive and equitable environment where library workers feel valued and empowered. Demonstrating compassion through leadership fosters a positive workplace culture that promotes collaboration, trust, and belonging. Operationalizing compassion requires leaders to stay informed about institutional policies and resources to ensure library workers have the support they need to thrive. Key strategies include encouraging healthy work-life integration by offering flexible work arrangements and providing time off for personal obligations. Additionally, offering professional development opportunities and recognizing staff accomplishments, like nominations for awards and other recognition programs, can enhance team morale and strengthen mutual support. The suggestions and examples discussed in this section are from my experiences implementing compassionate care and inclusive practices at the MUSC Libraries.

Setting Ground Rules

Creating a workplace culture based on compassion requires establishing clear ground rules. This begins with library leadership setting explicit expectations for all employees, regardless of their positions within the organization. The ground rules you establish should align with your institution's standards of professional behavior or code of conduct. Using these standards is effective because they apply to all personnel, regardless of rank, seniority, or position in the library. They can also serve as a basis for holding individuals accountable during performance evaluations. The ground rules can be reiterated during one-on-one meetings and all-staff meetings to ensure a consistent message is shared with all team members. The ground rules for a compassionate and inclusive workplace are:

- **Ask for help whenever needed.** Fostering an environment where individuals feel comfortable seeking assistance promotes collaboration and acknowledges the importance of mutual support within the team.
- **Stay home when you are unwell.** This rule prioritizes individual health and contributes to the overall well-being of the entire workforce. An essential aspect of this rule is refraining from penalizing individuals for taking necessary time off or disconnecting.
- **Give and receive grace.** Acknowledge that mistakes and mishaps are inevitable. This rule fosters a non-judgmental atmosphere that supports learning and growth.
- **Ask questions and seek clarification.** Before forming a judgment about a colleague, first seek to understand, as you may not know what challenges the person is experiencing or what they may be dealing with at that moment.

- **Leaders must exemplify the established expectations.** By leading by example, managers reinforce the importance of these ground rules and create a culture where adherence is expected and celebrated.

Establishing clear ground rules lays the foundation for a compassionate and inclusive workplace. However, leaders must also utilize institutional programs and resources to ensure their team members have access to the support they need during personal or professional challenges.

Awareness of University Programs and Resources

A strong indicator of compassionate and inclusive leadership is an awareness of the resources available to employees during crises, personal challenges, lifestyle changes, or while implementing wellness initiatives. Leaders should take a proactive approach to learn about the support mechanisms within their organization, such as paid time off, extended sick leave, flexible work arrangements, and family and parental leave. Furthermore, compassionate leaders play a crucial role in fostering a supportive and empathetic workplace environment by understanding the Employee Assistance Program (EAP) and the Family and Medical Leave Act (FMLA). Familiarity with the EAP and FMLA is vital for ensuring the well-being and support of employees.

You do not need to have the same level of understanding as someone from your HR department, but you should be aware of the basics to recognize when to refer EAP and FMLA to an employee. An EAP is a supportive and proactive intervention program that employers provide to offer confidential help to employees dealing with personal issues that may be affecting their performance at work.[22] The Substance Abuse and Mental Health Services Administration states that EAPs can identify and address a wide range of health, financial, and social issues, including mental and/or substance use disorders.[23] A leader who understands the scope and benefits of the EAP can actively promote and encourage its use to help employees access the support they need.

It is important for library leaders to attend training sessions that their institutions offer to enhance their knowledge of laws such as the Americans with Disabilities Act (ADA), the Pregnant Workers Fairness Act (PWFA), and the PUMP Act. Becoming familiar with these relevant laws and the programs your institution offers will help you provide better support for your staff. Moreover, taking a proactive approach to understanding relevant resources not only demonstrates empathy but also contributes to building a culture where employee well-being is a top priority. Understanding the programs and resources available at your institution is important for supporting staff, but addressing broader systemic issues such as salary equity and monetary incentives is critical for fostering an equitable and inclusive workplace.

Salary Equity and Monetary Incentives

Addressing salary gaps and inequities among library staff is a tangible way to demonstrate compassion and recognize the challenges that library workers face in the current economic landscape. Library leadership must acknowledge that library salaries do not keep pace with increasing living costs and should take proactive steps to mitigate financial hardships for their staff. This includes providing competitive base salaries, offering bonus payments, and conducting equity studies with the human resources department.

As workflows and processes in your library change, it is important for leaders to actively work to reclassify positions to align with current work and move away from traditional library classifications. In my library, we opt for information technology classifications for personnel working at the library's information desk, as their work involves much more than circulating books, especially since our library no longer maintains a physical collection. Another rationale for transitioning to IT-based job classifications is that they often pay higher salaries. The benefit of reclassifications is to go beyond addressing immediate financial concerns; it sends a clear message to the staff that their contributions are recognized, valued, and fairly compensated. In doing so, the library fosters a more equitable work environment and aims to actively alleviate financial stressors that employees may face, promoting their overall well-being and job satisfaction.

Rewards and Recognition Programs

Recognizing and celebrating employee achievements through shout-outs, awards, or informal recognition is an excellent way for leaders to show compassion and inclusivity. It also fosters a positive, appreciative culture. Celebrating the successes of library workers boosts morale and demonstrates their value to the team. Compassionate leaders actively listen, observe their employees' efforts, and express genuine gratitude. This recognition creates a supportive work environment, motivating individuals to excel and contribute more effectively to the team's success. By demonstrating an understanding of the hard work and dedication their employees display, compassionate leaders build trust, loyalty, and camaraderie, ultimately fostering a workplace culture that values and uplifts every team member. A few methods include:

- **Begin meetings by inviting** team members to share "wins, complements, or kudos," which can include personal and professional achievements such as birthdays, completing an academic degree, a child's upcoming graduation, a new publication, a conference paper/poster acceptance, or recognizing support from a colleague, among other things.
- **Offering a kudos/compliments form** on the library's website would allow patrons to recognize and express their appreciation for library staff members. To enhance communication, submissions can be emailed to the employee, their direct supervisor, and the library director.

- **Nominating colleagues for library profession awards**, such as those offered by the American Library Association, the Medical Library Association, or a regional or state association.
- **Ask staff how they prefer to be recognized for their work-related achievements and successes.** Gathering staff feedback is essential because everyone has distinct needs and preferences regarding recognition. For example, some library employees may prefer public acknowledgment of their accomplishments, while others might value private recognition. Understanding individual preferences allows the library to customize its recognition efforts to effectively motivate and engage all employees.
- **Establishing an Employee Recognition Committee** to formalize and spearhead the library's recognition efforts to bolster staff engagement and morale. Having an established committee will prioritize recognition and make it an important part of our organizational culture. An excellent example is the University of Florida's George A. Smathers Libraries' Employee Recognition Committee whose charge is to do the following:

> Establish an ongoing and responsive staff recognition program that is effective and meaningful to Smathers employees; Create a direct correlation between the Libraries' values and goals and what it recognizes and rewards; Collect and solicit from individuals and departments throughout the Libraries individual and departmental achievements and milestones; Coordinate staff recognition opportunities through the Convocation Planning Committee; Encourage opportunities for staff recognition through other library programs, including Public Information and Staff Development; Build and ensure a committee membership that reflects library-wide participation; Seek means of funding recognition programs and awards.[24]

High-touch Engagement

Incorporating high-touch engagement strategies into your leadership approach is a powerful way to demonstrate compassion within a library setting. High-touch engagement, as used in this chapter, is based on the concept of high-touch service, which involves a high level of personal contact with customers, as opposed to low-touch customer service provided by vending or self-service machines.[25] By fostering open communication channels, building trust, and creating an environment where staff feel comfortable sharing their experiences, you strengthen the team and address individual concerns more effectively. As a leader, it is essential that you go beyond direct reports and actively engage with members throughout the library. The first step is scheduling regular check-ins to connect with library workers who do not directly report to the leader. These meetings are not aimed at fishing for information but rather to find out how the person is doing, what they are excited about, and if there are any workplace barriers or challenges the leader can help them navigate. Another benefit

of regular check-ins is the opportunity to address any challenges that staff may be facing regarding their workload. Finnegan describes these check-ins as "stay interviews," which are crucial for gathering the information leaders need to create personalized engagement and actionable retention plans.[26] Suggested questions leaders should ask during a stay interview include:

1. What do you look forward to each day when you commute to work?
2. What are you learning here, and what do you want to learn?
3. Why do you stay here?
4. When was the last time you thought about leaving us, and what prompted it?
5. What can I do to make your job better for you?[27]

Besides these touchpoints, maintain an open-door policy and stop to chat with staff at the front desk, in the breakroom, or in common areas. The aim is to foster a space for authentic conversations about their experiences. Trusting your managers is important, but gathering insights directly from staff members can give leaders a deeper understanding of the library's dynamics, ensuring a well-rounded view of the work environment.

By consistently prioritizing these interactions, you create a culture that values every team member's input to foster a sense of inclusivity and appreciation. Adopting a high-touch engagement approach not only enhances the overall well-being of the staff but also promotes a collaborative and supportive atmosphere within the library. Using high-touch engagement is an excellent retention strategy as it allows library leadership to be intentional about keeping its high-caliber personnel. Demonstrating compassion through high-touch engagement strategies ultimately contributes to a more resilient and connected team, positively impacting the work environment and the library's ability to serve its community effectively.

Time Away from Work

A key indicator of a leader's commitment to promoting time away from work is leading by example. Library leaders should prioritize their well-being by regularly taking time off to reset. Encouraging library staff to prioritize their well-being by taking time off is an essential leadership action. Acknowledging the demands and stressors of library roles and fostering an environment that values rest and rejuvenation sends a clear message that employees' mental and physical health are top priorities. Promoting a culture that supports breaks, such as getting up and moving around the library or campus and taking lunch breaks, contributes to job satisfaction. A 2018 study by Tork found that "North American employees who take a lunch break every day scored higher on a range of engagement metrics, including job satisfaction, likelihood to continue working at the same company and likelihood to recommend their employer to others."[28] This commitment to work-life integration fosters a healthier, more supportive workplace for dedicated individuals who ensure optimal library services operations.

Wellness and Well-being Professional Development

Libraries may also provide professional development opportunities focused on library worker wellness and well-being to promote a compassionate and supportive work environment. While traditional professional development opportunities allow staff to pursue opportunities aligned with their roles, wellness initiatives focus on fostering a healthier, more engaged workforce. For example, many organizations provide training for their workforce, such as Mental Health First Aid (MHFA), which teaches participants

> how to identify, understand, and respond to signs of mental illnesses and substance use disorders. The training equips individuals with the skills necessary to reach out and offer initial help and support to someone who may be developing a mental health or substance use issue or is experiencing a crisis.[29]

Inclusive leadership also involves recognizing and respecting individual differences. For instance, if your library provides training, like MHFA, you should give employees the choice to determine whether it meets their needs. This approach acknowledges that discussions about mental health can be triggering for some individuals. It demonstrates empathy and consideration for diverse needs and circumstances, reinforcing a culture of care and respect. By encouraging staff to participate in professional development opportunities focused on workplace wellness, inclusive leaders ensure their teams possess the resources and knowledge necessary to sustain their health, support colleagues, and assist patrons during difficult times.

Compassion Fatigue and Self-care

Being compassionate toward your team members is essential as a leader, but this can often feel like a heavy burden. People are constantly dealing with good and bad things in their personal lives while trying to show up as professionals and as our authentic selves. Therefore, it is crucial to be aware of compassion fatigue and take daily action to mitigate it. Compassion fatigue is the "emotional and physical exhaustion that can affect people exposed to other people's traumas or stressors. It is characterized by a decreased ability to empathize, feelings of helplessness, and burnout due to the demands of supporting those suffering."[30] As a leader, you will encounter situations that require you to show compassion for your team members. However, constantly shouldering their burdens can adversely impact your mental health and well-being. This is why self-care is crucial, enabling you to face the challenges that arise without allowing them to overwhelm you.

Self-care is a highly individual activity influenced by several factors, including personal values and available resources. I strongly encourage you to identify the strategies and activities that work best for you and are financially feasible. The most important thing is that you engage in activities that help you reset yourself, such as seeing a therapist, retail therapy, art therapy, pet therapy, getting a massage, taking a staycation or vacation, practicing mindfulness, spending time with friends or family, pursuing a hobby, or disconnecting from social media or electronic devices.

Self-Reflection Tools

Becoming a compassionate leader is a journey that demands intentional effort and consistent action. One way to support your personal growth is by completing the twenty-eight-question Compassion Assessment developed by Hougaard, Carter, and Beck.[31] This self-reflection tool offers insights into your level of compassion. By answering each question honestly, you can evaluate your current level of compassion and gain a deeper understanding of what it means to be a compassionate leader. The Compassion Assessment provides a comprehensive report highlighting areas for improvement along with practical tips and strategies to help you become a more empathetic leader. By recognizing your strengths and weaknesses, you can better understand your compassionate nature and pinpoint areas for growth. This self-reflection process yields valuable insights into the depth and wisdom of your compassion, enabling you to cultivate a more nuanced and sophisticated understanding of this essential leadership trait.

This assessment pairs well with a practice of self-reflection. Adopting a self-reflection practice will challenge you to consider what it truly means to be a compassionate leader, what compassion means to you, how you have received compassion from others, and how you give compassion. By taking the time to reflect on your level of compassion, you will see moments when you have missed the mark and other times when you have knocked it out of the park when it comes to being compassionate. Examples of self-reflective practices encouraged by the University of Minnesota's Earl E. Bakken Center for Spirituality & Healing include noting, mindfulness and deep listening, journaling, music and art therapy, walking, and moving meditation.[32] Ultimately, self-reflection will help you be better equipped to lead with compassion, kindness, and understanding.

Donnellan recommends leaders begin by identifying a strength from the list and committing to a specific action that leverages that strength.[33] Additionally, they should pinpoint their most challenging attribute and consider one actionable step to enhance their capacity for compassion toward themselves or others.

Team-based Tools

Investing in tools that foster team growth is as essential as individual development. One impactful avenue is providing managers with comprehensive training and development opportunities. Another tool leaders may use is Academic Impressions, which offers leadership, personal development, and skills-based training tailored explicitly for faculty and staff in higher education.[34] It aims to equip leaders with the knowledge and expertise to overcome challenges, enabling them to reach new proficiency levels. The DeEtta Jones and Associates Inclusive Managers Toolkit also stands out as a valuable resource. This ten-week online course is designed for individuals in formal or informal leadership roles, offering inclusive and practical tools to maximize workforce performance.[35] The diverse training options, from Academic Impressions to the Inclusive Managers Toolkit, contribute to a well-rounded approach to managerial development.

Another tool worth exploring is executive coaching, a resource that has proved beneficial for several managers in our organization. As Elliott highlighted, working with an executive coach provides various benefits, including combating executive isolation, enhancing thought leadership, elevating executive presence, operating in one's zone of genius, and increasing self-confidence.[36] These team-based tools contribute to individual growth and are pivotal in cultivating a collaborative and high-performing team culture.

Conclusion

Compassionate care in library leadership is not just an aspirational goal but an essential practice for fostering a supportive, inclusive, and thriving workplace. Inclusive leadership enhances this approach by ensuring all levels of personnel feel safe, valued, seen, empowered, and able to perform at their best, regardless of background or identity. Leaders who embrace inclusivity and compassion cultivate environments that celebrate diversity, prioritize well-being, and provide equitable professional development opportunities. Inclusive leadership, rooted in compassion, ensures library workplaces are spaces where leaders and their teams can thrive.

Leaders must intentionally cultivate a sense of belonging, dismantle systemic inequities, and create opportunities for individual success. This chapter underscores the significance of establishing a positive and supportive library environment through actionable strategies. These strategies encompass promoting team well-being, encouraging work-life balance, acknowledging achievements, and providing opportunities for professional development. Such initiatives foster a workplace culture that values equity, resilience, and mutual respect. However, compassionate and inclusive leadership demands more than strategies. It requires intentionality, self-awareness, and a commitment to continuous growth. Providing compassionate care requires leaders to operationalize key actions, including the following:

- **Evaluate leadership practices.** Reflect on how you lead and how your actions impact your team's well-being and sense of belonging. Commit to making compassion and inclusivity central to your leadership style.
- **Promote inclusivity.** Acknowledge and address your team's diverse needs so they feel like they belong in your environment.
- **Encourage self-care.** Lead by example by prioritizing your well-being and empowering your team to do the same.
- **Foster a culture of recognition.** Celebrate the contributions of your team members authentically and equitably.
- **Commit to lifelong learning.** Seek opportunities to grow as a compassionate and inclusive leader through training, reflection, and feedback.

The challenges that libraries and library workers face are significant, but the potential for meaningful change is equally powerful. Library leaders can transform their workplaces into

havens of support, innovation, and excellence by integrating compassion and inclusivity into their daily operations. This serves as a reminder that every act of compassion and inclusion you demonstrate strengthens the resilience, strength, and humanity of your library team.

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CHAPTER 17

Case Study: **Difficult Conversations**

Transparency Reveals Fairness and Empathy

Lisa Kallman Hopkins, Dawn M. Harris, and Bridgit McCafferty

What makes a good job? A good job can be considered one in which individuals trust and feel trusted; experience appreciation for their unique, diverse contributions while feeling included and valued; and feel engaged and motivated. An organization that esteems inclusive leadership creates fertile conditions to propagate good jobs and a diverse, collaborative workplace. In their international study examining inclusive leadership across cultures, researchers Prime and Salib describe four inclusive leadership behaviors: empowering employees toward career development and performance, displaying humility, having the courage to maintain integrity and act on convictions and principles, and allowing employees to be accountable for their own performance and accomplishments.[1] Leading outwardly entails clearly articulated expectations; regular, consistent, and constructive feedback; encouraging a sense of ownership and autonomy with requested guidance; and a conspicuous, bias-free allyship.[2] Leading inwardly requires one to examine one's own emotions, identity markers, and principles.[3] Engaging in difficult conversations is an important means of ensuring inclusive leadership, as it requires listening, promotes collaboration, and builds trust.[4]

At the Texas A&M University-Central Texas (A&M-Central Texas) University Library & Archives, we often have intentional and thoughtful conversations with our staff about difficult topics, such as employees' strengths, weaknesses, and special needs; compensation and job functions; employee performance; and professionalism. These conversations promote inclusive leadership, honesty, and camaraderie among our employees and colleagues.

A&M-Central Texas is a unique institution, as it only offers upper-division and graduate-level courses. According to data from the 2022 IPEDS (Integrated Postsecondary Education Data System), A&M-Central Texas, a Carnegie medium Master's College, had an enrollment of approximately 2,300 students in 2022, with 80 percent enrolled in a bachelor's program and 20 percent in a master's program.[5] Since the school is adjacent to Fort Hood, the world's third-largest military base,[6] active-duty soldiers, their dependents, and prior military members comprise a large block of the student population, and this has been the case throughout the school's fifty-year history. Currently, approximately 44 percent of its students are military-affiliated.[7] The heavy military influence is reflected in the school demographics, with students reporting their racial identity as 38 percent white, 27 percent African American, 26 percent Hispanic, 4 percent Asian, and 1 percent Pacific Islander.[8] Nontraditional students are the

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norm, with an average student age of thirty-four,[9] and 62 percent of undergraduate students attending part time.[10]

Our medium-sized university library is located centrally on campus and employs thirteen full-time and ten part-time faculty and staff. The governance of the library is primarily managed through the leadership committee, made up of the library dean and assistant dean, department heads, and the collection development and business coordinators. The assistant dean position is like that of an academic department chair: an individual is not hired into that role; rather, one of the three main department heads serves as assistant dean in addition to their other leadership duties. With the exception of personnel and budget matters, most decisions are made within the leadership committee, and each member of the committee is empowered to develop and add to the biweekly agenda. Every individual on staff is invited to contribute to the leadership committee agenda, but, admittedly, few do. This style of decision-making promotes more transparency and inclusivity, in that most supervisors are on the leadership committee or are one layer away. The three authors of this chapter serve on the leadership committee and leverage our complementary strengths when engaging in difficult conversations.

Difficult, uncomfortable, even awkward conversations are grounded in a demonstration and expression of empathy, compassion, and care. On the surface, difficult conversations often feel like conflict, something to be avoided, but frank, truthful conversations can reveal trust, commitment, and courage. This practice can create an environment where employees from diverse cultures, backgrounds, and experiences feel safe to address concerns and issues, even those that are sensitive. We have developed a process of intentionally and thoughtfully recognizing our biases, and we work together to negate their impact on interactions with other library employees. We also recognize that interactions with employees require individual approaches that are tailored to meet employees where they are.

While all three of the authors are white women, our backgrounds, life histories, education, career paths, generational perspectives, and cultural exposure differ substantially. These differences inform the ways in which we inhabit leadership roles and impact the ways in which we approach difficult conversations. Working closely together for the last ten years, the three of us have learned to augment and buttress our individual strengths, characteristics that could become liabilities for inclusivity when isolated. The dean of the library, Ms. McCafferty, became a librarian relatively early career after first achieving a master's degree in English with a certificate in digital humanities. She is now pursuing an EdD in higher education administration. She sees the big picture; her approach is strategic and far-reaching, qualities that can lead her to appear remote and too far removed from the staff. The assistant dean, Ms. Hopkins, came to the academic library much later in life, having graduated from a liberal arts college with an emphasis in philosophy and then prioritizing parenting until her children were older. She is a mentor for library employees, and her role is motivational and encouraging. On the other hand, she tends to let too much emotion into her conversations. Ms. Harris, with thirty years of experience supervising in a public library, initially pursued a nursing career. She is very hands-on and practical. She approaches problems in a non-emotional, nonjudgmental

manner. Unchecked, those same qualities make her too rigid and tied to rules. Together, we harness our combined understandings, diverse experiences, and educational backgrounds to welcome inclusivity on staff, bringing a nuanced perspective and enhanced contextualization.

The four categories of difficult conversations that we explore in this chapter are: employee abilities, encompassing discussions about employees' strengths, weaknesses, and special needs; employee compensation and job makeup, including discussions about salary and position descriptions; employee performance, including annual and semiannual evaluations and addressing subpar work; and employee professionalism, which looks at non-performance issues, such as sleeping on the job, body odor, unprofessional behavior, or interpersonal interactions.

Effective inclusive leaders recognize and own their biases and support colleagues through transparent but thoughtful conversations rooted in reflection and a willingness to consider cultural differences.

Difficult Conversations about Employee Abilities

Prior to engaging in discussions about an employee's strengths, weaknesses, or special needs—such as guidance for expanding or scaling back on their duties or targeted pursuit of career aspirations—it is important to check one's emotions and biases about the situation and to listen carefully and deeply to the individual. If possible, these conversations are perfectly suited to take place in person and face-to-face rather than through video call or by phone, with a follow-up email summarizing the discussion and a plan composed immediately after the conversation.

When others initiate a conversation with the assistant dean, they often do so while experiencing distress, anxiety, or uncertainty. Before the conversation even begins, she grounds herself and breathes deeply so that she can avoid introducing emotions during the discussion that complicates the situation. While her preference is to look her colleague in the eye, she has encountered situations where that practice was off-putting for the individual for cultural or personal reasons. As a result, she follows the person's lead and does not consider the lack of eye contact a sign of disrespect. She then listens, checking her own tendency to interrupt with questions, engaged in active listening in such a way that her eyes and body language express genuine concern, a lack of judgment, and, hopefully, a celebration of difference. It is important to recognize triggers and resist getting pulled into a conflict with the person or "take sides" in a disagreement with others. The intention is to hear what is said and allow silence. Context can be established, and underlying beliefs and emotions examined afterward, whereupon a solution can be arrived at together.

There are times when a meeting is initiated with an employee who seems unhappy or frustrated—and the outcome of the meeting can be very enlightening. One example is a library specialist who seemed to undergo a change in the way she thought about her job: whereas once she was a happy participant in team meetings, always bringing in new ideas, over time, she became withdrawn and quiet. During a very uncomfortable conversation, it became clear how

angry this person was about her supervisor's management style. Her supervisor held biweekly team meetings wherein everybody's projects and workload were discussed. Since everybody in the department is cross-trained and anybody can jump in and help one another, extra support is offered to those who request it during these meetings. While this is a collaborative approach, this employee revealed that some people do not feel that their individual, specialized work is valued and unique when there is such an emphasis on collaboration and teamwork. For this employee to take pride in and feel ownership of her work, she needed to have distinct boundaries around her assignments. The lesson here is that collaboration does not equal inclusion.

It is important to listen for clues that an issue should be referred to or discussed with another administrator, such as serious issues that should be escalated or concerns that would benefit from the practical expertise of a seasoned supervisor. These opportunities ensure that all employees are treated fairly, in that they allow for more objectivity, engage different strengths tailored to the individual and the situation, and encourage collaboration and teamwork.

It has taken the assistant dean many years to become an inclusive leader. When she was a new supervisor, she lacked confidence and feared confrontation. To avoid conflict, she communicated selectively and timidly, wavering in her resolve and often making inconsistent decisions. She was not a dependable supervisor. She realized that leading with inclusivity requires open communication, trust, and transparency—and an underlying confidence in oneself. It is necessary to feel secure in one's abilities to successfully supervise and lead others.

Difficult Conversations about Employee Compensation and Job Makeup

Conversations about compensation and the makeup of an individual's job can be extremely difficult. The dean of the library is often called upon to have these conversations with employees when they are already frustrated or displeased with their current lot at the library. Employees engage with these topics in situations where they are upset about a missed opportunity, such as a promotion they applied for but did not receive, or about their work situation compared to someone else's, either at our library or at another institution's library. Most employees will not engage with senior management about pay or job structure unless they are dissatisfied with some aspect of their current work situation.

HR departments typically keep job classifications and compensation, in particular, close to the chest. Managers are taught that if employees know what other people are earning and why, it will open the university up to low morale, constant comparisons, and potentially even litigation. The library dean has begun rejecting this approach to communication about salary, a luxury afforded her, in part, due to well-articulated position descriptions, classifications, and pay scales found within many large, public university systems. As a result, salary is not—and should not be—a secret at the institution: pay is a matter of policy and easily explicable. This is underscored by the fact that every salary at the institution is publicly available online due to freedom of information requests. However, even if this were not the case, she would have

come to reject this secretive approach as a matter of principle. If employees are being paid a fair salary as set forth by the guidelines, there is no reason not to discuss why an employee is making a certain amount. Mystifying compensation is a way to paper over and hide inequities that are better brought into the light, if they exist. For this reason, when an employee expresses displeasure about their pay or with their current position classification or role, the dean requests a meeting. Armed with a copy of the employee's job description, classification, and pay scales, the conversation is refocused away from questions that center on why someone else got a promotion or makes more to instead discuss why the employee is compensated at the current level and how he or she might advance.

For instance, if a new employee at the same level is making more than an employee who has been at the library for several years, this might be the right time to discuss the role of salary negotiation with the lower-earning employee; the number of employees, even professional librarians with years of experience, who do not negotiate for a higher salary is shocking. This is especially true for women who frequently accept the first salary they are offered as a matter of course. Salary compression and what the library is doing to combat that are also discussed. Reviewing the position description for the employee, as well as the position description for the next level of classification, may reveal that the employee is doing the work for a higher classified position without getting the pay. Often, employees who are underpaid are in the wrong classification for their level of work, which needs to be readjusted. If, however, they are correctly classified, they may be encouraged to take on new duties or advance their current duties to get closer to the next classification. Giving employees new experiences and tasks as they master lower-level skills does require close monitoring but can help every employee see a path toward promotion.

Transparency and willingness to engage about salaries make it clear to all employees that the library is earnest in its pursuit of equitable compensation. This is especially important for librarians who come from diverse cultural backgrounds or who grapple with disabilities. Often, with no objective criteria for promotion and no opportunity to openly discuss it, managers pass over librarians for promotion who work differently, failing to understand their unique approaches to the work. Openness is a way of ensuring everyone has a fair shot to advance, based on their abilities and objective criteria, as well as the opportunity to advocate for themselves. Moreover, this encourages frank discussions about the employee's interests and strengths, which leads to better management when tasks are assigned where the employee can excel.

Very occasionally, these conversations bring to light other issues beyond advancement. An employee may come to complain to the dean about someone else's compensation or promotion, but their motivation in doing so turns out to be their own biases about their colleague's cultural background, disability, or some other factor. For instance, they might complain that a single mother makes the same as they do, since in their mind, that mother does not have the same flexibility to work overtime. It does not matter that they both do the same type of work, amount of work, or the same quality of output. Another example might be an employee complaining about a higher-classified colleague who cannot do as much physical labor as

someone in a lower classification because of a disability. In these cases, frank conversations about compensation and classification open the door to recognizing potential biases that are creating these perceptions, hopefully helping the complainant to grow and identify their own limitations. By refocusing the conversation away from what someone else is doing and back to the objective pay or classification scale, it quickly becomes clear when the issue is a dislike or bias toward someone else. In each case, these conversations with the dean reveal strategic thinking, enabling employees to view their position as it fits into the larger goals of the library and the institution, and helping employees to see how they may advance.

Difficult Conversations about Employee Performance

Addressing employee performance is one of the most critical supervisory tasks. While praising an excellent employee is a pleasure, approaching subpar performance can be a trying, dreaded experience. However unpalatable these interactions are, it is imperative that any low work performance or undesirable behavior is addressed in a timely, thoughtful, and honest manner. These behavior issues will not simply solve themselves or go away. Instead, they will continue and possibly develop into even larger issues. In addition, there is a significant risk that allowing low work performance or undesirable behavior to continue will damage workplace morale, as other staff will undoubtedly be aware of the issue. Not addressing issues in the workplace will lead to other employees losing faith in the managerial abilities of their supervisor.

Forming personal, though professional, relationships with employees goes a long way toward understanding them as individuals. Getting to know about their lives, past work experiences, and current perspectives facilitates a supervisory approach tailored to them. This approach can include matching the pace of training to a particular employee's learning needs, judging an employee's preferred method of communication, and applying the right amount and type of positive reinforcement for an employee's comfort level. A hands-on approach to day-to-day library work is invaluable for building trust and camaraderie between supervisors and employees. Whether this involves shelving, shifting projects, manning a public service desk in a pinch, or simply being on the front lines, these actions demonstrate that their contributions are valuable to the organization and give everyone the opportunity to learn about each other in a less formal setting.

When conversations about performance and behavior issues are approached positively and deliberately, these interactions can lead to increased trust and openness between employee and supervisor. Prepare for difficult conversations by gathering specific examples of the concerning behavior and looking for underlying causes, such as unclear expectations, insufficient training, prior experiences in another work climate, or factors outside of work.

Face-to-face or virtual meetings offer the best opportunity for meaningful two-way dialogue in real time, especially when discussing serious adverse performance matters. In addition, the tone—that of a true conversation, not a pre-set agenda—is central to a successful outcome. Accusatory and adversarial approaches, which are always disrespectful to the employee, will

create a defensive position and lead the employee to disengage from meaningful dialogue. The conversation's tone must be established from the start, beginning with an unemotional and factual summary of the problem, followed by an invitation to the employee to share their perspective or explanation. Depending on the conversation's emotions, the supervisor may need to use various methods to lower the discussion's temperature. Taking deep breaths, pausing and thinking before speaking, and empathizing with the employee's feelings and emotions will go a long way toward keeping the conversation respectful and fruitful. For specific performance issues, providing context is an important first step. Explaining why a function or procedure should be performed in a certain way or how the employee's actions adversely impacted colleagues, patrons, and the organization provides a firm foundation to begin discussing the issue and exploring a workable solution that addresses the needs of all involved. Employees who participate in solution-seeking are more likely to buy into the outcome. At the end of this conversation, both parties should walk away with a precise, targeted action plan that has been agreed upon. However, conversations about performance or behavior issues should not be a one-and-done episode; follow-up plans and discussions need to be outlined and agreed upon and then pursued in accordance with the acknowledged timeline.

Finally, these frank conversations should not be "held" until the formal evaluation process but instead addressed in a timely manner soon after an incident or issue. Negative feedback at a formal evaluation should not come as a surprise to an employee. If a supervisor is doing her job right, problem-solving discussions should occur long before the review process.

Every employee conversation concerning performance issues is unique and needs to be approached as such. In addition, each supervisor comes to the table with her own set of tools acquired from training or past experiences. It is the supervisor's responsibility to recognize when the best path toward a solution is beyond her abilities and experiences. If that is the case, she should draw on the expertise of her fellow leaders. This allows for a joint investigation of the issue that will define the problem, identify any deficiencies in training or organizational expectations, and consider possible solutions.

Difficult Conversations about Employee Professionalism

Conversations about what we have termed employee professionalism are perhaps the most difficult and fraught of these four types. Often, the dean will take the lead on these conversations because other employees are hesitant or unable to engage on these topics. These include issues related to body odor, personal hygiene, sleeping on the job, negative interpersonal interactions with other employees, or other kinds of unprofessional behavior that might not clearly fall into another category. Part of the reason these conversations are so fraught is that they often relate to physical or psychological health concerns that make it imperative that employees do not feel attacked or unduly judged for something they cannot help.

When approaching a conversation about these topics, the first thing the dean does is contact the HR department for advice. This is not a bad suggestion for most of these

conversations but is especially important when addressing something that may be health-related. Sometimes HR can refocus a manager's thinking about an issue, even revealing the manager's own unconscious biases in the process. When having these conversations, the dean avoids accusatory language. She approaches the conversation collaboratively, recognizing the need to work together to remedy the issue. She uses a kind tone to convey that this is not adversarial. The dean often conveys that the conversation might be uncomfortable and that she will try not to pry into personal matters. She also inquires about whether the issue could be a medical one for which an accommodation is necessary, as is often the case for employees who, for instance, have a strong body odor or doze off at work. She does not probe the employee about the medical issue. Instead, she suggests they discuss potential accommodations with HR, while at the same time opening the door for the employee to inform her of their condition and potential accommodations if they so choose. It is important not to expect employees to share medical information if they do not wish to. If the employee chooses to speak to HR about an accommodation, the conversation ends there until HR contacts the library about what is required. If the issue is not medical, the dean discusses why the behavior has occurred and how the library can help the employee avoid it in the future. The dean always follows up these meetings with an email summarizing the conversation and action points, asking the employee to verify the accuracy of the summary. This ensures that all parties understand the conversation in the same way.

This comes into play with other complaints related to professionalism, which is a term that is vague and easy to wield as a weapon if someone dislikes or has a bias toward another employee. Perhaps a staff member discusses a hobby in the break room that their colleague finds boring or banal. Maybe an employee has something hanging in their office that for religious reasons another employee finds inappropriate but that does not otherwise violate campus policy. Possibly an office mate has a tick or way of gesturing that grates on the person with whom they share an office. The first step is always to discuss it with HR and find out how campus policies might apply in each case. Beyond that, though, there are many situations where the answer to the employee's complaint is "This isn't any of your business" or "I can't do anything about that." Usually, the dean will provide a way for the employee to avoid or move away from the irritant, if possible, both for the complainant and the subject of the complaints—but part of providing a safe workplace for everyone is allowing people to be unique in their own way, as long as they are not violating campus policy or intentionally harassing other members of our staff. Having conversations with employees who want to change or micromanage their colleagues, who may be very different than themselves, is part of managing a healthy, accepting workplace, as much as having conversations about problematic behaviors. This is particularly important because employees from non-dominant cultures may be particularly targeted by this type of complaint.

Final Takeaways: Primary Pieces of Advice for Readers

- Use self-reflection to discover which personal strengths and weaknesses you bring into your leadership role. Look for ways to harness your strengths while preventing your weaknesses from harming your relationships and ability to be effective.
- One of the most important and valuable qualities of communication is the ability to listen deeply.
- Conversations about salary and advancement can be demystified, and this can lead to higher morale.
- Most difficult conversations are best in-person or via video call, but sometimes clarity can be achieved through written communications such as email.
- Contextualizing, understanding, and trust-building are all crucial components in establishing effective communication.
- When engaging in difficult conversations about performance issues, mental or physical health issues, or other sensitive matters, it might be advisable to check in with HR before or after the conversation—not only so they are aware of a potential situation, but also so they can "have your back."
- Difficult conversations require and establish trust, openness, and honesty, and these are all important components of inclusive leadership.

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CHAPTER 18

Case Study: **Holding Space**

A Holistic Approach to Leadership in the Academic Library

Gricel Dominguez

Introduction

I never expected to find myself in a leadership position. Like many librarians, I came to the profession as a second career after a brief stint as an adjunct. It was 2008, and I was an English major with a master's degree and no prospects. Having worked in education for a few years, I pivoted my interest in research and decided to go to library school. I entered the profession intending to become a cataloger; somewhere along the way, I fell in love with public services and, even more so, with the desire to serve in a role that allows me to have a real impact on the work that I, and my colleagues, perform. Through my experience with great and not-so-great library leaders, I developed a personal style of leadership based on a slow, methodical, self-reflective approach. This allows those in my unit to carve out time to engage in high-quality deep work, to accomplish their goals, and to find purpose, while recognizing that sometimes good enough is enough.

This case study will examine ways to engage in empathetic and compassionate leadership. This approach addresses ways to hold space for yourself and your team through self-reflective practices. My goal is to provide a practical approach for new and experienced middle managers to engage in supportive, empathetic practices that may run counter to the hustle of the dominant culture, while creating room for personal and professional growth.

Positionality Statement and Professional Background

I am a white, first-generation Cuban American woman, born and raised in Miami, Florida, in a largely homogenous Hispanic community. I am also the daughter of immigrants, raised under the poverty line in a single-parent household, and the product of a public-school education. Pell grants and scholarships made it possible for me to earn my bachelor's and master's in English, a privilege that allowed me to work my way through library school with limited student debt. My personal struggles with chronic health issues, as well as my experience growing up with a chronically ill and underinsured parent, are a major influence on my philosophy of leadership, particularly in relation to self-care and staff wellness. I acknowledge and use my privilege and

position where I can as a rebellion against organizational practices that prioritize the demands of the institution over the physical and emotional needs of staff.

At the time of writing, I have served a combined thirteen years as a middle manager in academic libraries. My first role as a supervisor was serving as an assistant director at a small, private Catholic university in South Florida. At the time, I was fresh out of library school, still finding my footing in the profession and unsure that I would be able to handle the challenges of being a supervisor. It was a small library, but a vibrant and busy one. I was in charge of public services and all the complications that came with it, while I also had an incredibly supportive director and one of the best mentors that I have met in the field. Under his leadership, I experienced the kind of leadership that I hoped to practice myself, one rooted in compassion and a genuine regard for the very human needs of our staff.

On the other hand, I learned what not to do after serving under supervisors who were either self-acknowledged micro-managers or so disengaged with the role that our work felt meaningless. These managers instilled a lack of trust in their staff, along with a general sense of dissatisfaction and pessimism. A disengaged leader can be just as negative as an over-engaged one. Neither allows their staff the space to thrive, whether by setting excessive demands, checking in to an unreasonable extent, or showing a complete lack of interest.

Since 2016, I have served as department chair of a reference department at the sister campus to a large, urban, publicly funded, R1 state university. Our student body includes a little over 66,000 students across all programs, with 30 percent made up of first-time college students, 18 percent graduate, and 63 percent identifying as Hispanic/Latino. Courses are offered in person, online, and in a hybrid format, with the library positioned across all three modalities to best serve students. I joined the department as user engagement librarian in 2014. Since then, I have transitioned to my current position as chair of the reference department at my institution's sister campus, where I continue to engage in reference, instruction, and collection development alongside my administrative duties, which include leading a small team of faculty librarians and sometimes staff.

In my current role, I have applied what I learned from the leaders I have known and others I have studied to develop a style that aligns with my vision for effective library leadership. It relies on compassion and reflection, leaves room for failure, and allows time for personal and professional growth, balancing the needs of library faculty and staff with the needs of our patrons, while remembering that everyone brings a set of lived experiences that influence what they need to thrive. I call this "holistic leadership," a personal philosophy that includes aspects of servant leadership, slow librarianship, and self-care practices to address and guard against burnout.

Challenging the Status Quo

Holistic leadership often goes against the status quo, asking us to consider the person as a whole and acknowledging the lived experiences that influence who we are in the workplace

and in relation to others. Jim Funk, a leadership consultant who often blogs about holistic leadership practices, describes holistic leaders as leaders who "know how to integrate their character and values into their leadership."[1] He identifies nine traits that set holistic leaders apart: virtue, ethics, trust, transparency, balance, awareness, service, inspiration, and the capacity to get the job done.[2] Holistic leaders know what it takes to get the work done. They lead with a vision, display emotional intelligence, and establish strong relationships based on trust, ethical behavior, and a solid awareness of their needs and those of others.

Of course, adopting a holistic leadership style is not without its challenges. It takes time to embrace these characteristics, especially in a workforce that values unquestioning commitment and speed over care and self-reflection. Too often, we find ourselves sucked into hustle culture, looking for the next innovation, wanting to try the next project/event/gadget that will make our library stand out or bring attention to our unit. Innovation is great, but I've witnessed many (particularly librarians new to the field) crash and burn as they try to do it all. They overcommit, over plan, and stretch themselves too thin before starting all over again to try the next shiny new scheme. I'm guilty of this myself. It happens to the best of us, setting a precedent that leaves little room for iterative learning and reflection. After falling prey to the cycle myself, I came to value the opportunity that my role as chair grants me to create an environment that serves as a safe harbor for those who have been stuck in the cycle of hustle, burnout, hustle in the name of productivity.

Too often, we give too much of ourselves in a desire to serve our community, forgetting that we, too, are deserving of empathy and compassion in our day-to-day lives. Starting from a place of reflection, I encourage you to take a moment to consider the myriad ways in which you overwork and how this may set you back in the long run. Are you demanding more of yourself than you are physically or mentally able to give? Are you setting expectations that will lead to a standard that you cannot sustain? Are the projects that you are committing to bringing you joy? Do they feed your curiosity or professional interests? Or are you saying yes to everything because you haven't mastered the art of saying no?

One of the greatest challenges that I face as an empathetic leader is navigating the fine line between the demands of the institution and the needs of the individual. We all want to excel, myself included, but there is a balance between prioritizing the tasks that require a fast turnaround and knowing when a slower, more methodical approach will lead to better results. Several years ago, I became aware of the slow movement when I was seeking ways to adopt sustainable living practices, particularly in the areas of food and fashion. For those who may be unfamiliar with the concept, the slow movement was sparked by a protest against the opening of a McDonald's in Italy in 1986.[3] Starting with the eponymous Slow Food movement, the slow movement has expanded to other areas of life, often challenging consumerist and capitalist ideologies. More recently, this concept was applied to the field of librarianship, most notably by Meredith Farkas in her piece, "What is Slow Librarianship?" As Farkas defines it, slow librarianship

> is an antiracist, responsive, and values-driven practice that stands in opposition to neoliberal values. Workers in slow libraries are focused on relationship-building, deeply understanding

> and meeting patron needs, and providing equitable services to their communities. Internally, slow library culture is focused on learning and reflection, collaboration and solidarity, valuing all kinds of contributions, and supporting staff as whole people. Slow librarianship is a process, not a destination; it is an orientation towards our work, ourselves, and others that creates positive change. It is an organizational philosophy that supports workers and builds stronger relationships with our communities.[4]

This perfectly aligns with the values that I seek to espouse in developing a holistic leadership practice. Slow librarianship encourages a regard for staff that reminds us that we cannot draw from an empty well, or, as my mom says, "No saques jugo de una naranja exprimida" (roughly, "You won't get juice from an orange that's spent"). It reminds us that there is value in taking time and letting things come together without rushing to reach an end goal that leaves us burned out and feeling like we didn't give our best.

This might sound highly optimistic. The truth is that we are often faced with increasing demands from organizations that don't appreciate the value of reflection and time for ideas to evolve. As I said, this is where the challenge starts. If there is any power to be found in my role, it is the power to create a space where these values can thrive. This often means acting as an advocate for my staff, highlighting their achievements, and positioning myself as a champion of the ways in which they bring value to our patrons, serve our institution, and bring new ideas and innovations into our practice. It also means acting as a guide when it comes time to plan our yearly goals—that time when the drive is high and our expectations often exceed our ability to sustain achievable deadlines. In these moments, I like to remind folks to be realistic about their time and energy, to consider deadlines that allow for interruptions and moments when their attention may be drawn by time-sensitive matters that throw their goals for a loop. I also encourage them to build time for professional development. Not only is it a chance to develop new skills, but it is also a very real part of our organization's requirements for promotion and therefore essential to their advancement. As a leader, I take it as my duty to ensure that folks have the ability to carve out time for this kind of work, even if it means setting goals along a timeline of months rather than days or weeks.

Serving the Needs of the Group

Another philosophy that underscores my idea of holistic leadership is servant leadership, a concept coined by Robert K. Greenleaf, who describes servant leadership as a practice that emphasizes the good of the community, shared values, and decentralized leadership. Servant leaders recognize the unique talents of their staff and are committed to helping them reach their potential, particularly in the areas of "task effectiveness, community stewardship, self-motivation, and future leadership capabilities."[5] The servant leader listens and engages in one-on-one communication to get to know their staff, to understand their needs, and to learn how to best serve their interests, build trust, and help them become leaders themselves.

I was introduced to Greenleaf's philosophy by the person who helped me grow into my own role as a leader. Their example led me to consider the ways in which I might use my position to pay it forward and help others grow—whether that is as unit heads, supervisors, or committee leaders. It's a full circle moment to be able to share what I have learned.

A major part of servant leadership is gaining trust through connection and a deep understanding of the lived experiences of your team members. These are authentic connections—you can't pretend your way through this kind of relationship. It requires a certain level of vulnerability and mutual respect. It also takes time. If you've ever joined an established group, whether as a leader or member, you know that trust takes time and respect needs to be earned. My recommendation to new leaders is to take the time to build these connections. Be open and flexible with your availability, and meet your staff where they are most comfortable, whether this is in a group setting, casual meetings, or informal catch-up sessions. In my experience, it takes anywhere from three months to a year of relationship-building to establish a sense of trust within a group, though some relationships may take longer.

By building authentic connections, you'll learn more about your team members than you will learn from an annual assignment or review; you'll learn what motivates and inspires them, and you'll gain insight into the ways that you might be able to support their aspirations. This might translate into new and creative ways to arrange staff schedules or embrace alternative work models. It might also translate to scheduled check-ins for individuals who like to talk ideas or prefer to have an accountability buddy; or it might translate to a more hands-off approach for those who prefer to check in via email or messenger.

In my current role, I see myself as a mentor and guide—a leader who wants to see her team of faculty librarians thrive in their personal lives as much as their professional lives, always returning to the understanding that while we might strive for work-life balance, there can be no balance if we do not recognize the way in which our professional and personal lives impact each other.

However, I will not pretend that this is always easy. There are limits and challenges to the work I can do, even in my role as chair. In the next two sections, I will go into some of these challenges, particularly those that arise when we forget to have compassion for ourselves.

Lessons Learned from Difficult Situations

Let's go back to slowing down. Life is never without its challenges, and neither is being in a leadership position. From challenges in my personal life to challenges in the lives of my team, I've experienced a roller coaster of emotions over the years that I've served in these positions. Being an empathetic and compassionate leader often means that we share in the pain and difficulties that our team experiences. One thing that I've learned is that the important, life-changing news will never come by email. It won't come in a messenger app. It's a reminder to myself as much as to you. Don't worry so much about checking email after work. The big news will arrive through a phone call.

You will never be prepared either. In my first few months as manager of my current department, I was faced with the harsh reality of the opioid epidemic. I can safely say that this wasn't a situation that I learned about in library school. Suddenly, I had to learn what resources were available to support someone in active addiction and how to safeguard that person's job while they were away in recovery. I knew that I couldn't do much to change their situation, but if there was one thing I could do, it was to learn what our options were with regard to leave times for recovery.

Sadly, one of the greatest challenges that I would face that year was the loss of our colleague to a sudden overdose. However, this would not be the only unexpected loss that my department would face. Collectively, we would grieve the loss of another member of our staff in 2023. These are the moments that challenge us most, both as leaders and members of a tightly knit group. Holding space for grief comes with its own set of challenges. We all grieve in our own way; some prefer to come together in remembrance, while others prefer distance and privacy. During these times, I've had to hold my own feelings in check in order to be there for others, but I haven't held back when it's been time to share in community.

The same is true when illness or familial challenges have touched the lives of our department members. I may not have the power to change their situation, but as a compassionate and empathetic leader, I have the power to do whatever I can within the limits of our institution's regulations. Over the years, this has meant working with our HR department to ensure that staff can take full advantage of leave options and gain insight into relevant benefits. It also meant evaluating staffing needs and finding ways to accommodate flex scheduling options when life throws someone a challenge, or hybrid options when the demands of a project or task require more focus than can be gained in the office.

Leading From a Place of Self-Care and Compassion

This is the part where I admit that I am not always the best at taking my own advice. Call this the "Do as I say, not as I do" segment of this piece. You, like me, may have a hard time taking your own advice, particularly if you are working toward compassionate leadership. Too often, we give more than we are able when it comes to our time, our energy, and our strength, sacrificing our own health, time, and attention to serve those in our department and community. I'm a huge proponent for the establishment of boundaries when it comes to my team members, particularly if those boundaries serve to carve out the space and time that they need to achieve goals that bring them satisfaction. That said, I often find myself too willing to give up my own time and energy, agreeing to meetings and commitments that I might be better off declining. I'm sure that I'm not alone in suggesting that the pandemic sent me into a spiral of bad habits that eventually led to burnout. In trying to alleviate the strain on my department, I took on more than I should've, joining committees and engaging in more service commitments and projects than I had the bandwidth to really engage in—all in an effort to be the kind of leader who leads by example and takes on the tasks that others don't have time for. The only problem

was that it led me straight down the path to burnout. I'm still crawling my way back out, but here are a few lessons to be gleaned from my mistake.

Leading from a place of compassion does not mean that we need to take on every task. It does not mean that we need to sacrifice every aspect of ourselves to ensure that others thrive. If we aren't thriving ourselves, we can't lead effectively. Pessimism, cynicism, and a generalized lack of interest are hallmarks of burnout, and I was feeling all of these. You know what these are not great for? Creating a positive and supportive work culture within your department.

In my experience, the trust and collegiality inspired by this approach often lead to a reciprocal response from colleagues. A culture where effort is recognized and valued encourages shared accountability—support encourages support. In practicing self-care, it might mean stepping back and delegating tasks or revisiting shared goals.

We need to be as kind to ourselves as we are to our staff, reminding ourselves that we, too, are deserving of care and compassion. Consider your values when agreeing to new commitments. Do these align with your vision? Do they serve your mission (your own or that of your department)? Are you the best person for the role or task? Or would this be a better opportunity for another member of your organization whose skills are better suited to the task? Are you agreeing because you think you must? Or because you really want to?

Sometimes we can't say no. Some tasks fall to us because of our position, and there is no backing out, but when given the option, pause to consider your *why* and remember to create space for yourself where possible. Over the last few years, I've found it harder to remember this lesson myself. After the pandemic, I often found myself struggling to make time for myself, giving too much of my time and energy to tasks that I would have delegated in the past, but which suddenly felt like a burden that I didn't want to place on others. Despite experiencing challenges of my own, I took the self-sacrifice a little too far and fell deep into what I finally recognized as burnout. In helping others, I forgot to be compassionate toward myself, a lesson that I won't forget anytime soon.

Recovery and Takeaways

In seeking to recover from burnout, I have turned back to basics, granting myself the same respect and compassion that I grant others. I've slowed down, re-evaluated my *why*, and considered what I truly care about in a professional capacity. For me, that's finding ways to support my staff and providing memorable experiences to our students in addition to quality reference services. It's taken me years to sit down and capture my thoughts on leadership, but one of my goals at the start of 2023 was to find ways to give voice to the ideas that I've been grappling with for nearly a decade. Being an empathetic leader is a skill that requires a lot of self-reflection, which can be a particularly challenging task during times of high stress and increasing demands to get more done. Stopping to reflect might feel like a chore when all you want to do is scratch another item from your to-do list, but experience has taught me that not making time to reflect and prioritize is a sure-fire way to get ensnared by the sneaky do-more

mentality that is so pervasive in American culture. As an empathetic leader, I seek to serve as a champion against the idea that doing more is always better, particularly when more comes at the cost of quality and satisfaction with one's work. Realistic, sustainable goals allow my team to engage more meaningfully with their work and allow me to more meaningfully engage with them throughout the process, creating space for check-ins, changes, and challenges to be addressed along the way.

At the heart of holistic leadership is a solid sense that we are all human, dealing with the many challenges that come with living. Every individual in your department is facing their own range of concerns, whether these are related to work, family, health, loss, finances, etc. Holistic leaders acknowledge all parts of the human experience and understand that these are bound up in the ways that our staff engage with the daily tasks of their job. As holistic leaders, we are not here to judge, but to support our staff and provide them with the tools that are at our disposal, whether that is an ear to listen, extra time on a project, a flex schedule, or time away from the office. In the end, we are all better when our humanity is taken into account.

My leadership style is always evolving (as it should), but I hope these musings encourage you to bring compassion into your practice and remind you to take care of yourself in the process.

Notes

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PART 3

Living into Inclusive Leadership

CHAPTER 19

Talking Among Ourselves

Using a Book Club as an Inclusive Leadership Tool

Elizabeth L. Wallis

Introduction: Inclusive Leadership and Cultural Humility

Libraries are often seen as progressive strongholds in the current culture wars, but our institutions are not truly free from racism and bias, either historically or at present. In fact, librarianship is still very much a white-majority profession.[1] Libraries, like most workplaces, "were not built *by* or *for* all kinds of identities, but rather for those who originally built the modern workplace and still dominate its leadership ranks."[2]

But as service-centered organizations, libraries bring in a wide range of people in various states of need. We must be prepared to accommodate everyone. Are we providing equitable assistance to every member of our communities? Are we also considering the unique background of each patron? And lastly, asking how that background might impact their experience of our services.

In order for libraries to be more inclusive, equitable, and anti-racist spaces, it is incumbent upon us as leaders to light the way. This effort requires a dedication to inclusivity that lets us see power imbalance and recognize the ways in which we can use our own power to leverage change. In addition, we library leaders must reflect upon our own positions while recognizing the ways in which power influences every interaction.

In her book on inclusive leadership, Jennifer Brown describes the Inclusive Leader Continuum, which helps leaders identify their place on their diversity learning journey in four steps: unaware, aware, active, and advocate.[3] Many leaders begin in the unaware stage, where they are growing aware of challenges that other people face, but they feel that diversity compliance is someone else's problem. In the second stage, aware, people learn about their own privilege and realize that they do have a part to play in leveling the playing field for others. In the active stage, leaders are willing to show vulnerability and begin to use their voices to lead and participate in difficult conversations with their teams in the interest of learning and improving. Finally, in the advocate stage, leaders utilize their power to lead change, consistently confronting inequality to dismantle systemic discrimination. When we finally uncover our biases and prejudices, we can dig deeper and recognize the ways in which our actions perpetuate inequality. Applying this continuum to our work pushes us to understand that no strategy to address systemic racism can be successful if it is not connected to the leaders who have power and influence.

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As inclusive leaders seek to change inequitable systems, it's also important to apply humility to our practices and to be open to failing forward. As Brown describes, the practice of humility includes "a willingness to accept new ideas, information, and perspectives–even if they contradict our own views or expose our imperfections." Specifically, cultural humility is a valuable practice that leads us to realize that our perspectives are not the only way to see and experience the world; it is an ongoing practice in which we commit to learn from others and redress power imbalances. As noted by Hurley, Kostelecky, and Townsend in their research on cultural humility, "Being able to see other perspectives helps prevent incorrect assumptions from interfering in your interactions."[4]

An important way that librarians and library staff themselves can begin dismantling power inequity is through the practice of such cultural humility, led by their leaders in the workplace. Cultural humility creates a more inclusive and helpful environment for patrons and library staff alike. Practicing cultural humility is difficult for most of us because it requires that we decenter our personal perspectives and "set aside defensiveness, to engage in critical self-reflection, and to recognize and use whatever power we have as individuals to overcome structural inequities and redress power imbalances."

A key step in leading change is to "develop empathy for the lived realities of people from different identity groups and feel motivated to get involved in the change effort."[5] To absorb new perspectives and combat the echo chambers in which many of us live, it is helpful to consume a variety of media outside of our usual choices. This includes podcasts, TV shows, books, and more. To this end, I maintain that one way to begin to explore different perspectives and establish these vital yet difficult culturally humble practices is through a diversity book club for staff that includes library leaders, in which we can inspect and reflect upon different perspectives together.

Background on Book Clubs

There has been a lot of research conducted on book clubs and reading groups. Most often, book clubs are conducted in social settings, but for our purposes, we'll be considering reading groups held in professional settings with the aim of expanding participants' cultural competence and humility. Book clubs are especially well-suited for this use because they provide an informal and safe space for conversational learning and critical inquiry that can be focused on social change. In addition, book clubs can foster community for participants in a setting that often dismantles institutional hierarchy, and they have the added benefit of being a low-cost professional development opportunity.

Workplace Learning

Lifelong learning tends to be part and parcel of being a librarian, not only because many of us are naturally curious people, but also because we are regularly exposed to new information as we are

helping patrons, conducting research, teaching classes, or selecting books. Just as important as learning on our own is the idea of building knowledge alongside colleagues, be they librarians or staff members working in libraries. Studies have shown that workplace learning provides significant benefits to organizations, including better service to clients, increased productivity, higher morale, and improved work climate.[6] But conventional staff training sessions and workshops are not always the most effective vehicle for team learning. Research into workplace learning demonstrates that informal learning approaches, in fact, can provide more valuable learning experiences for participants.[7] Informal learning, or non-formal learning, is an opportunity provided outside of a traditional teaching environment and, per Grenier et al., "is characterized as voluntary participation for personal enrichment with social processes such as group discussion and exploration."[8] Non-formal education provides advantages in that it is flexible and adaptable, and it can meet the learning styles of a wide range of people in a generally enjoyable format, but it may require more enthusiastic leadership than traditional training since it often requires creative efforts to get it rolling. In addition, because it's voluntary, leadership needs to keep it relevant and compelling in order to get participants to keep coming back for more.[9]

Benefits of Book Clubs

Book clubs can be powerful vehicles for the introduction and discussion of sensitive or controversial topics; in fact, numerous articles and studies reveal that book clubs provide a uniquely supportive arena for participants to engage with, explore, discuss, and appreciate other cultures and other perspectives.[10] In particular, a number of authors discuss the ways in which group reading can contribute to empathy and reduce bias, thereby expanding the capacity of readers to understand and be open to people different from themselves.[11] As Davis notes, "Empathetic reading is an overlooked ingredient in the development of anti-racist political sensibilities."[12] She goes on to state that "sympathetic reading experiences can play an important role in a larger chain of events that provoke critical thinking about racism and enable a shift in political perspective."[13] As has been argued in a number of articles,[14] this increased awareness of positionality and cultural inequalities may prompt the growth of a political consciousness in readers and can inspire "students and others to engage in those struggles that further possibilities for living in a more just society."[15]

Critical inquiry calls on individuals to evaluate information from multiple perspectives in order to create new understanding. Research has shown that participation in book clubs can build the critical thinking skills necessary to undertake critical inquiry. Book clubs also lead to critical reflection,[16] which helps professionals "be better prepared to deal with the diverse range of students, clients, or patients that they will encounter throughout their careers."[17] Related to critical inquiry is the concept of conversational learning, wherein "understanding is achieved through the interplay of opposites and contradictions."[18] In dialogue, participants create new pathways of understanding as they interact with each other and challenge their own perspectives. I argue that this process of conversational learning is distinct from critical inquiry in that conversational learning cannot be done solo, whereas critical inquiry can be.

"Talk is one of the ways through which human beings make meaning."[19] As one might expect, the research on book clubs is full of examples of conversational learning in action—be that in the professional development of librarians and library staff,[20] graduate students,[21] classroom teachers,[22] corporate professionals,[23] or in purely social book clubs.[24]

Among the most valuable characteristics of a book club is the opportunity for participants to explore difficult or controversial topics in a supportive, safe space.[25] This is a key element of inclusive leadership. Building safe spaces in the workplace where colleagues can ask questions, make mistakes, and learn from each other as they explore their biases and grow their knowledge.[26]

Another benefit of book clubs is their relatively low cost,[27] which can be particularly valuable if they are used as staff development opportunities in organizations with little funding for professional development. While some groups may be able to provide a copy of the selected book for each participant, just as many reading groups rely on members to provide their own books. In addition, one does not need access to any special facilities to hold a book club meeting.[28]

It's perhaps not surprising that the literature is rich with examples of how book clubs and reading groups foster a sense of community and even friendship among participants,[29] sometimes simply by showing readers through group discussion that they have more in common with other people in the group than they thought.[30] In professional settings, book clubs have been found to help foster community,[31] improve working relationships,[32] provide opportunities to connect with colleagues one does not usually work with,[33] and to "provide an important route for many of the participants to develop friendships and camaraderie within the workplace."[34] In addition, the dynamic of reading group discussions can help to minimize workplace hierarchies and put participants on equal footing.[35] As noted in one article, giving people a safe space where they can discuss shared problems can help workers "to feel seen even outside of the book club."[36]

IDEA Book Club at Kresge Library

Oakland University (OU) is an R2 public doctoral research institute located about twenty miles northwest of Detroit, Michigan, with an enrollment of approximately 16,000 undergraduate and graduate students. The university serves a diverse student body, of which 68 percent are white, 8 percent are Black, 6.5 percent are Asian, and 36 percent are first-generation college students.[37] Our libraries comprise Kresge Library, which serves undergrad and graduate students at OU, and the School of Medicine Library. Our library faculty and staff of approximately forty-five people are predominantly white and able-bodied, though we do have colleagues with various hidden disabilities. And while I suspect there is a mix of sexualities, the group is overwhelmingly cisgender. As one might expect in an academic library, colleagues are privileged with education and there are a great many advanced degrees among the group.

As a middle-class, cis-het, white woman with an advanced degree, I make a point to acknowledge my privilege and seek to use it to empower those around me. I have intentionally studied diversity topics to better understand and interact with others. As the mother of twins who are members of the LGBTQIA+ community, I seek both personally and professionally to

create warm, welcoming, and judgment-free environments. As an administrator, I lead groups in the library that provide opportunities for committee members to contribute their ideas and energy to make a difference for all members of the library staff. As a leader, I seek to be inclusive in my work and aim to create opportunities for our team members to learn from and with each other in safe settings.

In the winter semester of 2021, the University Libraries' Inclusion, Diversity, Equity, and Accessibility (IDEA) Task Force was formed, and this task force became a standing committee the following year. The group was charged with promoting a welcoming, respectful, and inclusive environment in the University Libraries. Among the first plans that came from the task force was an IDEA book club for library faculty, staff, and student employees. The book club would be accompanied by a related learning opportunity each semester, thus creating a semesterly IDEA theme. Each book club meeting would start with summary information about the book so that colleagues could attend the discussion even if they had not read the book.

The first semester that we ran the book club was fall 2021, when we explored the theme of race by reading *White Fragility* by Robin Diangelo. Because the library budget was flush, we were able to purchase a copy of the book for every employee in the library, including student workers. The hope was that by providing the book to everyone, people might still read it even if they didn't choose to participate in one of the group discussions. After consultations with the libraries' management team, it was agreed that staff members could use work time to read the book, thereby encouraging participation and underlining our team's commitment to the learning process. To encourage colleagues with opposite work schedules to attend book discussions, we hosted gatherings on two separate dates and at different times of day; the discussions were all held via Zoom to make attendance as convenient as possible. (In the end, nearly fifteen people participated in the two meetings, or approximately 33 percent of library employees.) In this first round of book club discussions, we brought in a faculty expert from another university department to moderate the book club; however, while this method was certainly informative and interesting, we found through post-meeting surveys that participants didn't have as much time to discuss the book as they were hoping for.[i] Eleven out of twelve respondents (91.6 percent) to our post-discussion survey either somewhat or strongly agreed that the book discussion was helpful in improving their understanding of the theme. We paired this book with a workshop on racial bias later in the semester by the university's Center for Multicultural Initiatives.

For the second semester, in winter 2022, we took up the book *Gender: Your Guide* by Lee Airton. Once again, the budgetary situation allowed us to purchase a copy of the book for every library staff member and student employee. The content of the book guided discussions about gender and sexuality during our two separate book club meetings, which, again, were set up at different times of day in order to encourage attendance by those with opposite schedules; these meetings were also held in a remote format to encourage participation. For this round, the attendance was about the same as the first semester, roughly fifteen people between

i. Because of this, we moved away from having expert moderators in future semesters. Instead, we now share moderating duties among members of the IDEA committee.

the two meetings. Moderating duties were split up among members of the IDEA Committee for each meeting, providing the team members with planning and leadership opportunities. Our post-discussion survey revealed that all participants found the moderator questions to be helpful starting points for discussion and that we provided sufficient time for participant discussion of the book. Thirteen out of fourteen respondents (92.8 percent) either somewhat or strongly agreed that the book discussion was helpful in improving their understanding of the theme. The intention for this theme was to bring in the Gender and Sexuality Center to provide ally training, but scheduling difficulties and staff availability ultimately prevented that session from being held.

The third round of the book club, in fall 2022, featured *We're Not Broken* by Eric Garcia. In this book, Garcia takes a deep look at autism from the point of view of a person who is autistic. At this point, we could no longer afford to purchase books for the staff, so we interlibrary loaned copies of the book for all interested individuals based on their responses to an opt-in survey that we sent out at the beginning of the semester. For this title, the IDEA Committee altered our approach and broke the discussions into several meetings across the semester so that we could cover a few chapters at a time rather than the entire book at once. The benefit of this approach is that staff have less content to cover before each meeting, but the drawback is that we could not schedule multiple meetings for each book section to reach every employee. The members of the IDEA Committee once again traded off moderating duties at the meetings. The overall participation by colleagues was lower this semester for the discussions (closer to ten people), likely due to scheduling conflicts. The results of the post-discussion survey revealed that all participants found the discussion to be helpful in improving their understanding of the theme, and eleven out of twelve respondents (91.6 percent) either somewhat or strongly agreed that dividing the book into smaller chunks for discussion made the book club overall more accessible. As a companion to this theme, we welcomed the director of OUCARES, the university's autism outreach service, to present to the staff. She provided a valuable perspective on working with autistic individuals and meeting their diverse needs.

In the next round of the IDEA book club, in winter 2023, we read *Demystifying Disability* by Emily Ladau. An opt-in survey was again sent to all staff members and books were requested through interlibrary loan for interested individuals. We once again divided the book into small sections for each online discussion. Our accompanying training material was a series of online videos that featured the author, the URLs for which were shared with the entire library staff. Overall, participation was lower for this semester, with only seven participants total; this was perhaps due to waning energy in reading a diversity book every semester. Fortunately, all respondents to the post-discussion survey indicated that the discussion was helpful in improving their understanding of the theme.

Finally, in fall 2023, we varied our approach by utilizing articles and videos as our learning materials rather than a book. Our theme was cross-cultural understanding, and the learning material focused on the lived experiences of Jewish, Muslim, and Asian American individuals living in the States. Feedback following this semester indicated that participants quite enjoyed the mixed formats of materials but suggested that the theme was perhaps too broad. While this

semester saw participation of fewer than ten participants across both meetings, the folks who did participate indicated in the survey that they found the readings to have been useful in their understanding of the topic.

Following the cross-cultural understanding theme, the IDEA book club took a hiatus as the committee focused on some other DEI-related projects within the library. We will be bringing back the book club in the winter semester of 2025.

As noted above, a post-book club survey was sent out to the entire library staff following each series of discussions during the semesters. Questions were intended to engage even those individuals who did not participate in the book club that semester in hopes of gauging whether our colleagues opted not to participate due to lack of interest or simply a lack of time. The survey was branched in order to gather additional input from the people who did participate in the discussions about whether they found the discussion sessions to be valuable.

Lessons Learned

In the first two and a half years that we conducted our IDEA book club, we learned a number of important lessons to improve our experiences. These insights came both through the participant surveys as well as from the observations of IDEA Committee members. Below you will find our best practices, backed by research.

For most of us, schedules are busy, brains are full, and commitments are many. Because of this, book club participation should be voluntary, allowing readers to come and go from the group as needed.[38] While participation among library staff varies by semester, we have found that there is a core of people who attend nearly every meeting. And while the group discussing the book is often just a small percentage of the whole library staff—perhaps seven people, or 15 percent of the staff and faculty—the literature suggests that this may be a positive, as "book clubs composed of a small number of participants may present environments conducive to conversation and learning, especially for those who are hesitant or shy about participating in larger social groups."[39]

There is research that indicates that lack of time is the main reason that people do not participate in book clubs,[40] so, as mentioned above, we established with department supervisors that it is acceptable for our staffers to read the book club selections during work hours, both to illustrate the administration's commitment to encourage learning on the job and also to reduce barriers to participation by employees. It is not clear whether this policy increased the number of people participating in the book club.

A practice that we learned quickly is that it is helpful to chunk books into sections and hold multiple meetings throughout the semester rather than have just one discussion about the entire book near the end of the term.[41] We have found that this approach not only makes completing books less daunting for participants but also allows our IDEA Committee members to easily take turns as facilitators. As facilitator, one prepares a summary of the section under discussion and has questions ready to spur conversation should it not start organically. Ideally,

the session facilitator should be inviting and should keep an eye on participants who may not have contributed to the conversation in order to invite their thoughts.[42] I have been pleased to see how our committee members have enjoyed taking on this leadership role, putting skills to use that they may not have had the opportunity to display in their everyday professional roles.

Finally, we have learned that it is vital to reflect upon how the readings will impact our individual practices. As noted by Greenawald and Adams in an article on nurse book clubs, "Reflecting on issues as presented in the context of a book can prepare nurses to better respond to real-life scenarios,"[43] which is certainly true of service and education professions as well.[44] The ultimate goal of the IDEA book club is to raise staff awareness about inequalities and enhance our cultural humility, moving us all from the unaware stage of the continuum to the advocate stage by "getting actively involved in the change effort, disrupting the status quo, and applying an equity lens to the systems, policies, and practices that surround you."[45] Through this effort, we can improve the equity of our services and resources for our community, and the critical inquiry that is spurred by book club discussions can begin that process.[46] Participants have been responsible individually for enacting changes to their work practices as a result of our readings rather than having library administration mandate any changes.

Conclusion

Jennings and Kinzer state, "We are all affected by systemic whiteness; therefore, action is not about who we are, but rather what we do daily to consciously end inequality."[47] As inclusive leaders, it is our role to guide our teams through the conscious task of interrogating our privilege, and we must "lead with purpose" from the "front lines of challenging inequities and changing systems."[48]

As described in this chapter, our efforts to decenter whiteness and end inequality in our services at Kresge Library have thus far focused primarily on the book club, which has provided valuable learning experiences for all involved and has offered a form of "creative abrasion," which inclusive leadership author Jennifer Brown describes as a process by which "ideas are productively challenged, avoiding the dangers of groupthink."[49] As book club participants, we have certainly benefitted from developing anti-racist mindsets together as we work to develop more inclusive sensibilities and seek solutions to complex problems.

Author Taffy Raphael describes the cultural humility "eureka moment" like this: "In our best moments, our interactions through talk or writing or other modes may cause us to step back, eyes wide open in surprise, as we stumble onto some new recognition of ourselves, whether that be a positive realization or a realization that challenges our current conception of our self-identity."[50] My aim is that our IDEA book club produces moments like these, where colleagues can share in moments of recognition and learning, be vulnerable together, and find support from their leaders and each other through the continuing work of increasing their cultural humility in order to provide a more welcoming, accessible, and inclusive service environment for everyone who uses our library.

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CHAPTER 20

Case Study: **Empathy and Effectiveness**

Onboarding Temporary Student Workers with Care and Leadership

Russell Michalak[i]

Introduction

This case study provides an in-depth look at the experiences and contributions of temporary student workers, also known as contract workers, who participated in the library's book and stack reduction project. Under my guidance as the library director, the case study examines the innovative strategies implemented and the pivotal role of these workers in this significant library initiative. Temporary student workers are defined here as individuals contracted for a specific project—namely, the library's book and stack reduction project—hired for a fixed term and financed through special project funds from the president's office. Building on prior discussions in earlier works,[1] this study highlights the critical importance of a structured and inclusive onboarding process, effective use of a project management tool, and the necessity for regular communication and feedback through user guides, which establish a formal agreement between the supervisor and the employee.

In this paper, I explore the transformative power of empathy, compassion, and care in the context of onboarding temporary student library workers. I will delve into how these principles, coupled with the guiding mantra of "support, advocate, and celebrate," can significantly enhance the onboarding experiences of not only student workers but also employees from diverse backgrounds. As Zaki aptly puts it, "Empathetic experience undergirds kind action,"[2] and within the library workplace, this holds true when employees grapple with new library concepts and procedures, new co-workers, and unfamiliar software and hardware. By the end of this paper, I hope to offer a clear understanding of how these principles can be practically applied to support the success and well-being of all employees in line with organizational goals. The onboarding strategies discussed will extend beyond temporary student workers, proving useful in enhancing the onboarding process for various roles within the organization.

i. Author's note: Many student workers contributed research and labor to this chapter: Devon Ellixson, Zehra Canbaz, Mikala Williams, Jared Sloane, Collin Mangan, Najla Smith, and Sheldon Johnson. While I share this project from my perspective as the library director, yet this case study is truly a collaborative narrative. The temporary student workers not only contributed to the project's success through their dedicated work but also helped craft key paragraphs within this manuscript. Their reflections, insights, and edits enriched the content, ensuring that this case study reflects our shared experiences and collaborative achievements.

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Additionally, I present insights into the challenges and successes encountered in managing temporary student workers, offering practical lessons learned. Key among these are the necessity of clear instructions, the flexibility of training methods, and the crucial role of feedback mechanisms in project management. The case study aims to illustrate how these essential elements can be seamlessly integrated into a supportive and empathetic onboarding framework, contributing significantly to the broader goal of cultivating a positive and productive environment for temporary student workers.

Understanding the Goldey-Beacom College Library

The recent upgrade of Goldey-Beacom College from a Master's Colleges & Universities: Specialized Programs to a Master's Colleges & Universities: Larger Programs category reflects a significant evolution in our academic identity and how we engage with students. The college has traditionally had a diverse student body, with 46 percent minority students. It is recognized as an emerging Hispanic-Serving Institution, highlighting the need for an inclusive onboarding process as we recruit student workers from the student body. Our commitment to our Hispanic students through scholarships and partnerships is part of a broader dedication to creating an inclusive educational environment. Additionally, the college's strengths in economics, psychology, criminal justice, and computer information systems help shape the roles and expectations of the students I hire.

Since the onset of the COVID-19 pandemic, Goldey-Beacom College library has maintained its mission and the overall size of its collection, though the nature of its resources has shifted. Our mission emphasizes empowering our community with essential research skills and the responsible use of information and digital technologies, supporting academic success and lifelong learning. The library supports scholarship and intellectual curiosity by providing rich collections and expertise in information literacy, along with spaces and programs promoting exploration and learning. Although the print collection has diminished, our investment in electronic resources, which began before the pandemic, has allowed the collection to remain robust. The library has continued prioritizing programming for residential students and commuters, including initiatives like the Library Speakers Consortium, which features live virtual talks by renowned authors.

Staffing, however, has seen dramatic changes. Just a year before this project, we had nineteen student workers, several part-time librarians, and library assistants serving 2,000 students. Now, I work almost alone,[3] supported only by one library intern; we serve 1,200 students. However, the library provides the same quality and scale,[ii] perhaps more, of services, resources, and tools than before staffing cuts.[4]

ii. Goldey-Beacom College's library, like many academic institutions, has adapted to a leaner staffing model driven by budget constraints and enrollment challenges, necessitating a strong focus on self-management and strategic use of technology to maintain service levels

For this project, I (Rusty) proposed to the senior college leadership that we hire temporary student workers. Additionally, by collaborating with the director of the Academic Excellence Center, situated in the library but not run by the library, the peer tutors who are located in the library could assist with the book reduction project when not tutoring, playing a crucial role in its completion.

Author's Identity and Positionality in Leadership

As a white male library director at Goldey-Beacom College, a growing Hispanic-Serving Institution, I'm acutely aware of the influence my identity and position hold in the onboarding process for employees, including student workers, temporary student workers, and library staff. In a leadership role surrounded by diverse students, my approach to fostering an inclusive library environment is shaped by the complex interplay of power and diversity.

Acknowledging the privileges associated with my racial and professional identity is crucial. It's my responsibility to use this awareness constructively to address systemic inequalities and create a workplace where diversity is not just respected but actively celebrated. This commitment is rooted in continuous self-reflection and dedication to employing my position for inclusive change by practicing mindfulness sessions on my own and with my staff.

My leadership philosophy, encapsulated in the mantra "advocate, support, celebrate," guides my approach. Advocacy involves championing diverse students, student workers, and employee needs and voices, especially those from marginalized groups. Supporting means providing resources, mentorship, guidance, and emotional support tailored to our student body and library employees' varied experiences. Celebrating every employee's contributions, whether a library staff member or student worker, fosters a culture of appreciation and value for various small and significant achievements.

Empathy is central to my leadership style, especially in understanding and responding to library staff's diverse backgrounds and experiences, including the temporary student workers who contributed and were instrumental in completing the library's book-stack reduction project.

Strategies for Effective Onboarding with a Communication Agreement

Central to my onboarding strategy is implementing personalized communication agreements, known as user guides (see appendix A).[5] These evolving documents are crafted to reflect each student worker's unique background, experiences, and needs, and they are continually updated to adapt to changing communication preferences. For example, adjustments might include the need for headphones for solitary work or a quieter environment for those with auditory processing disorders.

The purpose of these user guides extends beyond facilitating clear communication; my aim is to foster an environment where each team member feels recognized, valued, and genuinely appreciated, enhancing team cohesion and alignment.[6] Initially, some student workers viewed completing their user guides as busy work. I clarified their crucial role in tailoring communication and roles, enhancing workplace personalization, and effectively addressing individual preferences and requirements. For instance, setting communication preferences might involve choosing between updates in person during routine interactions or through electronic communications at their convenience, which helps define clear communication methods and accommodate personal preferences.

Feedback from this process has been invaluable, showing that user guides create a respectful and accommodating work environment. Documented preferences improve interactions, enhancing team dynamics and productivity. In our collaborative setting, I serve as both facilitator and team member, addressing shelving and discarding issues democratically. Our team-building exercises promote respectful and collaborative dialogue, allowing everyone to share and consider different perspectives effectively.

User guides also promote self-advocacy among student workers by encouraging them to articulate their needs and preferences clearly, building a culture of mutual respect and understanding. These guides provide a structured yet flexible framework that respects diverse needs and fosters collaboration and unity, turning varied perspectives into collective strengths.

Celebrating individual and team achievements is an essential component of our approach, acting as a significant motivator and morale booster by reinforcing the value of every contribution and instilling a sense of pride and accomplishment in all team members.

The cornerstone of our transformation in onboarding is the communication agreement, which shifts focus from individual achievement to collective effort, fostering collaboration and setting the stage for open dialogue and inclusive problem-solving. This profoundly impacts the workplace, as Zaki's insights on empathy in communication suggest, encouraging student workers to engage in empathetic interactions and ensuring that diverse perspectives and reflective practices are valued.

These principles are dynamically reinforced through continuous engagement with team-building activities, brainstorming sessions, and regular consultations of the agreement, keeping these values central in every interaction and knitting together a cohesive, high-performing team.

By integrating these nuances within the communication agreement, we redefine the onboarding experience, creating a workspace where collaboration and empathy are not just promoted but deeply embedded, transforming our community into a more inclusive, empathetic, and productive environment.

Building on this empathy foundation, we delve into specific strategies and tools, such as the communication agreement, that operationalize these principles in daily interactions, aiming to foster an environment that supports our student workers' emotional and cultural needs. This holistic approach promotes a supportive, understanding, and empowering work culture, allowing every student worker to thrive and contribute maximally. By prioritizing empathy, we enhance the experiences of our student workers and foster a more equitable, high-performing, and cohesive organizational climate.

Before beginning their tasks on the library's stack and book reduction project, student workers engage with various aspects of the onboarding process—communication, reporting, one-on-one meetings, feedback, and discussions on micromanagement—with me serving as a resource throughout their journey.

Student Workers' Perspectives on Onboarding Strategies

Communication

The student workers have expressed a keen understanding of the importance of effective communication in synchronizing team efforts and efficiently addressing challenges. They value the structured communication approach facilitated through ClickUp, appreciating the platform for its role in ensuring prompt sharing of schedule changes and project updates in one centralized place (see figure 1). I didn't use email for this project unless it was something that needed to be shared that was private. Throughout the project, the student workers emphasized promptly acknowledging messages and provided thoughtful responses in the "Last Comment" column. Clear and direct communication is essential, whether through face-to-face conversations, emails, or project management tools like ClickUp. This practice maintains project momentum and cultivates a collaborative work environment.

Reporting

In terms of updating me on their daily activities, the student workers clearly understood the hierarchical reporting system within the library. They demonstrated an understanding of the need for patience during delays and changes in plans, acknowledging that such delays often result from the time required for responses from supervisors or HR. This awareness reflected

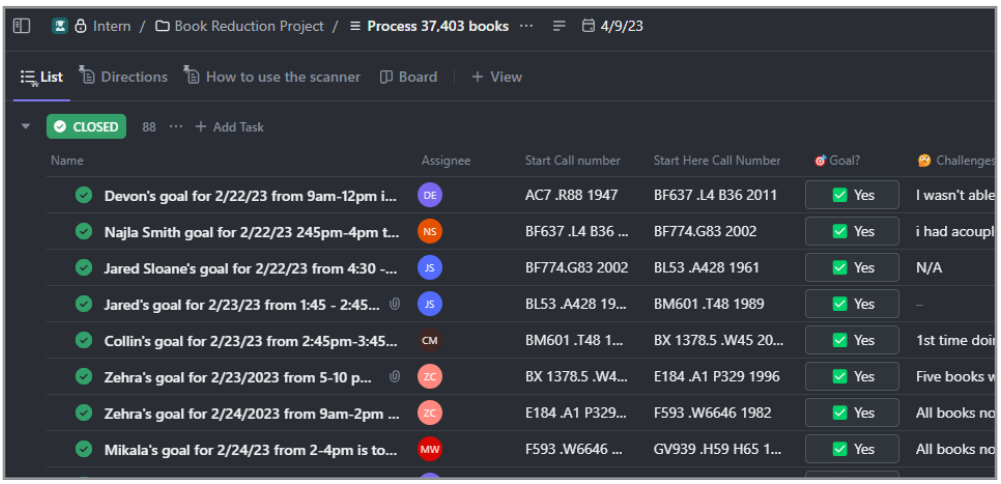


Figure 1. Task list for the Book and Stack Reduction Project in ClickUp.

their preparedness to navigate the ebb and flow of the project's dynamics with clarity and patience.

1:1 Meetings

The feedback from student workers highlights the significant value of one-on-one (1:1) meetings as an essential tool for reviewing progress, setting goals, and exchanging feedback. They recognized the importance of entering these meetings with a prepared agenda and specific ideas, viewing these interactions as key opportunities for both personal growth and project advancement. One student worker emphasized that having students lead the meetings enhanced their sense of freedom to discuss chosen topics, which not only fostered leadership skills but also contributed to their personal development.

Feedback from Me to You

The workers demonstrated a positive reception of my approach to feedback. They valued the opportunity to contribute to the library's growth and appreciated the recognition of their efforts. Their understanding of addressing conflicts directly and swiftly showcased their commitment to fostering a respectful, safe, and supportive team environment.

Feedback from You to Me

From the beginning, the student workers agreed to give me direct and constructive feedback. They received examples of previous user guides to help guide them, and they were free to revise their guides as needed during their tenure. Since preferences often evolved throughout a project, they were encouraged to update me via email on any changes. For instance, many of the student workers asked for more infrequent one-on-one meetings (in the beginning, we met once a week or as needed) once they became comfortable with their work environment, their work schedule, their teammates, their supervisor (me), and their duties. This process underscores the importance of managing expectations and maintaining open communication about project progress and any challenges. It also shows their awareness of the need to understand each other's communication styles and triggers, crucial for ensuring a collegial and productive working relationship.

On Micromanagement

There is a clear appreciation among the student workers for my stance against micromanagement. This statement helps them recognize the importance of being proactive, self-motivated, and maintaining consistent communication, especially within a lean-staffed environment. Their commitment to staying ahead of tasks and effectively communicating with me and the team underscores their proactive approach to the project. One way I avoid micromanaging is

by allowing student workers to set their own schedules. I trust them to complete their tasks without strict oversight and check in occasionally to offer support. I like to set broad project timeframes instead of strict deadlines, giving student workers the space to manage their time in a way that works best for them. If I notice from their feedback or how things are going that we need a firmer deadline, I'll work with them to set one that makes sense for everyone.

Me as a Resource to You

The student workers acknowledged my role as a valuable resource, expressing their intention to communicate their needs clearly to achieve success. They appreciated the support offered, whether it involved accessing college resources, problem-solving, or seeking guidance, and are committed to making the most of my experience and knowledge.

Logistics

Regarding logistics, the student workers display adaptability to the preferred meeting times and recognize the importance of proactively seeking answers and clarifications. They value my availability through scheduled meetings, emails, or impromptu discussions, acknowledging the importance of staying informed and aligned with the project's goals.

Enhancing Empathy and Clarity: The Role of User Guides in Online Onboarding

In modern onboarding practices, communication agreements, which we refer to as user guides, are recognized as a pivotal innovation, significantly contributing to addressing the generational, cultural, and gender differences in communication styles (see appendix A). These guides serve as foundational tools for cultivating effective communication and enhancing emotional intelligence within the workplace. Stanwick highlights the substantial role of communication agreements with libraries, stating, "The communication agreement provides library managers with a tool to bridge differences in communication styles between employees, enable employees to engage in more effective communication, assist employees in developing better understandings and respect for colleagues of different backgrounds, and raise employees' emotional intelligence."[7] This perspective is mirrored in the feedback from temporary student workers, who have acknowledged the user guides. The user guides effectively establish a foundational understanding of individual communication styles and work preferences, enhancing the onboarding process and team dynamics. Feedback from temporary student workers, collected during the offboarding process, further confirms the guides' effectiveness.

One student worker appreciated the guide's role in helping understand "each other's styles and preferences with communication and work." However, they also suggested enhancing the guide by incorporating a personal question or fun fact, indicating a desire for a more

personalized and engaging onboarding experience.

Another student worker highlighted the user guide's practical utility in offering "clear instructions on how to be reached and how we prefer to receive and give feedback." Yet, they pointed out a technical challenge with integrating the guide into ClickUp, suggesting a need for improved compatibility with project management tools.

One student worker stated, "I think it [the user guide] was beneficial for all of us and [sic] whenever I needed help, my teammates were supportive enough and we managed the process more easily." At the same time, the feedback points to areas for enhancement, such as making the guide more personalized and interactive, addressing technical challenges, and ensuring smooth integration with project management tools.

Further feedback from additional student workers underscored the guide's effectiveness in establishing a baseline for team interactions, specifically mentioning its role in facilitating an understanding of "how our teammates worked on this project and what was the best way of communication." This underscores the guide's role in fostering a cohesive team dynamic. Nevertheless, a wish for the user guide to be "more fun and interactive" was expressed, pointing toward an opportunity to enhance the engagement aspect of the guide.

Fostering Inclusivity, Empathy, and Celebrating Diversity in Onboarding

From the outset of the onboarding experience, there is a deliberate emphasis on cultivating cultural awareness and sensitivity through the communication agreements, recognizing the invaluable contributions that the unique backgrounds, experiences, and perspectives of our student workers bring to each project.

In crafting our onboarding materials, inclusivity, care, and empathy remain paramount. Initiated in 2017, a comprehensive online orientation process now forms the core of our strategy.[iii] This process mandates that all library employees working on any new project undertake a pretest, engage with an online training video, and complete a post-test. This method, inspired by Bauer's guidelines in "Onboarding new employees: maximizing success,"[8] ensures that all participants are well-versed in the department's goals, history, and power structure, addressing the challenge of ensuring competency across varied job roles in an academic library.

The design of our onboarding materials carefully considers the diverse identities of our student workforce. By incorporating multilingual resources and culturally nuanced content, we create a welcoming and supportive environment that mirrors the comprehensive support and engagement promoted by the library director. An integral part of this process is the

iii. Read the following chapter to learn more about our process: Russell Michalak and Monica Rysavy, "Online Onboarding: Library Workplace Training in a Trilingual Interactive Online Asynchronous Environment" in *Digital Workplace Learning*, Dirk Ifenthaler (New York: Springer, 2018), 291–306, https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-319-46215-8_16.

celebration of cultural heritage, where student workers are encouraged to share their traditions and personal narratives. This initiative not only fosters a sense of belonging and community but also strengthens intercultural bonds within the library and the broader institution. Moreover, international students find additional support through AI tools like Grammarly, which assist them in overcoming language barriers, ensuring their contributions are clear and effective. This celebration of diversity does more than acknowledge differences—it acts as a catalyst for building a cohesive and inclusive college community.

Integral to our onboarding process is celebrating and acknowledging cultural heritage, an initiative that encourages student workers to share their rich traditions and personal narratives. By sharing how they communicate with you, as the supervisor, you quickly learn about their personal cultural preferences and traditions. For example, a female Muslim student from India and a female student from Turkey indicated they preferred we not shake hands. The user guide fosters a sense of belonging and community within the library and strengthens the intercultural bonds among student workers and between the students and the institution. Celebrating diversity extends beyond mere acknowledgment; it catalyzes building a cohesive and inclusive team. Similarly, Pedro, an international student worker from Brazil, found personal and cultural discoveries while recataloging books like *Dom Casmurro*, which turned the mundane task of copy cataloging into a profound cultural reconnection, emphasizing how libraries serve as dynamic spaces where culture, education, and personal narratives converge.[9] His experience highlights the significant role of academic libraries in preserving cultural heritage and fostering personal growth and a sense of belonging among students from diverse backgrounds. This underscores the library's mission as a cultural repository and an intellectual incubator, crucial for nurturing students' cultural identities and intellectual pursuits. One student worker learned from a Colombian student who excitedly found the book, *Pedro Paramo*. He said it is part of high school curricula, and everyone has to read it.

I actively seek and highly value student workers' diverse perspectives and voices. By providing accessible platforms for dialogue and feedback, I listen and actively incorporate the rich array of student worker ideas and suggestions into the onboarding process and the broader organizational practices. All communication after the user guide is completed occurs in ClickUp. The dashboard has a "Last Comment" column where users can share and acknowledge each other's contributions and perspectives. My inclusive approach enriches the institution's processes and empowers student workers, validating their contributions and reinforcing their sense of belonging.

Recognizing that certain student workers may encounter unique challenges, tailored support for underrepresented groups is a cornerstone of our commitment to equity and inclusion. This commitment is informed by years of experience working with diverse populations, which has honed our approach to ensuring every student worker has access to the necessary resources and support mechanisms to thrive. This reflects a holistic approach to student success and well-being, built on a deep understanding of these groups' specific needs and obstacles. We continuously refine our support strategies through this seasoned perspective to better serve all students and foster an inclusive environment.

Inclusivity is a core value that permeates every facet of the library's operations, extending beyond the confines of the onboarding process. Student workers are actively involved in decision-making processes, ensuring that organizational strategies are not only inclusive but also genuinely reflective of the real needs and aspirations of the diverse student workers.

Lessons Learned and Future Directions

Reflecting on the journey of onboarding temporary student workers at Goldey-Beacom College Library, I find valuable lessons that have shaped the library's approach and guided us toward future directions. This section looks at the insights gained from our experiences and outlines our vision for continuous improvement.

1. **The power of empathy.** One of the most profound lessons we've learned is the immense power of empathy in the onboarding process. Understanding and addressing the unique needs and challenges of our student workers has resulted in a more inclusive and supportive environment. We are committed to fostering even deeper empathy among all stakeholders. For example, our library intern reported feeling isolated when working alone after previously being part of a team. Recognizing this, I reassigned tasks to incorporate team-oriented projects with clear goals, such as organizing community outreach events, which re-engaged and invigorated their sense of connection and purpose within the workplace. This approach underscores the importance of empathy in enhancing team dynamics and individual well-being.
2. **Continuous feedback loop.** We have come to recognize the importance of a continuous feedback loop in refining our onboarding strategies. Regular feedback from student workers, supervisors, and mentors has been instrumental in identifying areas for improvement. We intend to strengthen this feedback mechanism to ensure that our onboarding process remains responsive and relevant, including offboarding after every project and gathering feedback on procedures and processes.
3. **Flexibility and adaptability.** The dynamic nature of our student body and the evolving landscape of higher education demand flexibility and adaptability in our onboarding approach. I have learned to embrace change and respond proactively to emerging needs; our onboarding program is iterative. The library's future direction includes a focus on staying agile and responsive to the evolving requirements of our student workers.
4. **Mentorship and support.** The role of mentorship and support cannot be overstated. Our experiences have shown that providing mentorship opportunities significantly enhances the onboarding experience. We aim to expand our mentorship programs and provide even more robust support systems for student workers.
5. **Leveraging technology.** Technology has played a crucial role in our onboarding process through pre- and post-tests and online videos, especially in facilitating

communication and training. Looking ahead, we plan to explore innovative technological solutions that can further enhance the efficiency and effectiveness of our onboarding strategies. One example includes incorporating Hypothes.is, a social annotation tool, into our online trilingual onboarding training and user guides so they can comment within the document instead of in ClickUp. Anytime anyone leaves a tool, the risk of the task not getting done increases exponentially.

6. **Commitment to diversity.** Our commitment to diversity and inclusivity will continue to be at the forefront of our efforts. We aspire to deepen our understanding of the unique needs of our diverse student workforce and further embed diversity into our policies and practices. Because of this project and my work with student workers, the college has institutionalized the library's goal-setting document for all college departments. Furthermore, the success of this project has allowed the library to retain one student worker, Zehra, (the other student workers graduated), and two more student worker positions.
7. **Celebrating achievements.** Recognizing and celebrating the achievements of our student workers is a practice we will sustain and amplify. By acknowledging their contributions and successes, we aim to motivate and inspire future generations of student workers. The pizza lunches, especially at the mid-point of the project, were especially impactful to them. But most important were the open communication channels at the start, through the user guide, and at the middle and end of the project with the "Last Comment" feature in ClickUp. The expectation was for me to provide regular feedback on their comments. But most impressive was that the students started giving feedback and acknowledging each other when they exceeded their daily goals in ClickUp.
8. **Research and evaluation.** To ensure the ongoing effectiveness of our onboarding process, we are committed to research and evaluation. This includes conducting regular assessments, benchmarking against industry best practices, and staying informed about the latest trends in onboarding.
9. **Collaboration and partnerships.** Collaboration with other departments and institutions will be an essential aspect of our future directions. We recognize the value of cross-institutional partnerships in enriching the onboarding experience and providing additional resources for our student workers. This project could not have been accomplished without the insights and labor provided by Academic Excellence Center peer tutors, who reported to the director of Academic Support. The peer tutors were allowed to assist the temporary student workers with the project as long as they didn't have a peer tutoring session scheduled.
10. **A community of learners.** Finally, I envision our library as a vibrant community of learners where the onboarding process is an initiation and a continuous journey of growth and development. We look forward to fostering a culture of curiosity, exploration, and learning among our student workers, who we have been able to retain to the success of this project.

Conclusion and Call to Action

It is essential to emphasize the importance of the onboarding process, not only for the individual growth and development of student workers but also for the overall vitality of the academic library.

The journey doesn't end here. I believe that my experiences and insights can serve as a catalyst for positive change across academic libraries. Therefore, I issue a call to action to my fellow librarians, educators, and leaders in higher education:

- **Embrace diversity.** Recognize the diverse backgrounds, experiences, and needs of your student workers. Commit to fostering an inclusive environment where every voice is valued.
- **Prioritize empathy.** Place empathy at the core of your onboarding strategies. Listen actively, understand deeply, and respond with care to the challenges and aspirations of your student workers.
- **Establish mentorship programs.** Mentorship plays a pivotal role in the onboarding journey. Develop mentorship programs that provide guidance, support, and a sense of belonging to your student workers.
- **Seek continuous improvement.** Create feedback mechanisms that allow for continuous improvement of your onboarding process. Regularly assess the effectiveness of your strategies and adapt to evolving needs.
- **Leverage technology.** Explore innovative, novel technological solutions to streamline communication, training, and support. Embrace digital tools that enhance efficiency and accessibility.
- **Celebrate achievements.** Recognize and celebrate the achievements of your student workers. Show appreciation for their contributions and create a culture of positivity and recognition.
- **Commit to assessment.** Engage in research and evaluation to ensure the ongoing effectiveness of your onboarding process. Stay informed about industry best practices and trends.
- **Cultivate a learning community.** View your library as a vibrant community of learners where onboarding is not an endpoint but a continuous journey of growth and development.

By answering this call to action, we can collectively elevate the onboarding experiences of student workers in academic libraries and contribute to their success in both academic and professional realms. Together, we can create a brighter and more inclusive future for all student workers, where their potential is nurtured, their voices are heard, and their contributions are celebrated.

APPENDIX A

Employee User Guide Template

Important tip (MUST READ): This is a master template. Please follow these steps to personalize and share your user guide:

1. Click **File** in the toolbar.
2. Click **Save As**.
3. Choose **Download a Copy**.
4. Open the file on your desktop.
5. Again, click **File** in the toolbar.
6. Select **Save As** and rename the user guide to "User Guide_Your First Name."
7. Open the User Guides folder. If you can't drag the file into the folder, email your user guide to [Supervisor's Email].

Start Here

Me As A Resource to You
I am here to assist whenever possible. Feel free to reach out, and I will respond as soon as I can. If I'm available, I'm more than willing to help.

You as A Resource to Me
Insert your details here: Describe your preferred methods of communication. Be honest and specific about how you would like your supervisor to engage with you, including any alternative methods if the primary preference isn't feasible.

1:1 Meetings
Insert your details here: Share your expectations and what you would like to achieve during our 1:1 meetings. Consider mentioning the structure, frequency, and content of these meetings that would be most beneficial for you.

Team Meetings
Insert your details here: Explain what would be helpful for you in team meetings. Also, outline the value and contributions you aim to bring to each meeting.

Feedback from Supervisor to You (DO NOT DELETE)

1. I appreciate being informed on areas for improvement, and I strive to better myself continually. Recognition of good work motivates me, but seeing you succeed is my greatest reward.
2. I prefer verbal and private feedback, but I am also responsive via email and in our project management tool comments.

Feedback from Me to Supervisor

Insert your details here: Describe how you would like to receive constructive feedback from your supervisor. Consider your comfort with receiving feedback in different settings (e.g., private, email, during meetings).

Supervisor's Comments (DO NOT DELETE)

Please understand that while I will do my best to accommodate your preferences, there may be situations where I need to adapt communication methods based on circumstances. If tasks are not completed as verbally agreed, I will document this via email to ensure clarity on expectations and responsibilities. This is meant to support your development and should be seen as an opportunity for dialogue and improvement.

Feedback from You to Supervisor

Insert your details here: Share how you prefer to provide feedback to your supervisor. This can include the format, setting, and any specific aspects of their management style you feel could be enhanced.

Supervisor's Comments (Do NOT Delete)

I value your feedback immensely as it helps improve our workplace and our effectiveness. While change can take time due to the various approvals required, your input is crucial and always welcome.

Supervisor's User Guide:
Rusty's revised user guide

Welcome to Our Team!

Welcome aboard! We are excited to have you join us at this pivotal time. Our library is more than just books—it's a vibrant center of knowledge and community. As a new member of our student worker team, you play a key role in preserving and making knowledge accessible.

Open Communication

We're committed to an open-door policy—your insights, questions, and feedback are invaluable in driving innovation. Here's how we can best communicate:

1. **Flexible Schedules:** Our team has extended operating hours, which means overlapping work times can be limited. It's important to proactively communicate your availability and any schedule changes. Use the comment section of our project tasks in ClickUp to keep everyone updated.
2. **Prompt Responses:** I value quick acknowledgments. A simple reply stating when you can address a request or provide an update is greatly appreciated—for example, "Hi Rusty, received your message, and I'll have an update by end of day tomorrow."
3. **Need Time to Think?:** If you need time to process a request, just let me know when I can expect a response, rather than leaving it unanswered.

4. **Self-Management:** As we may not always work simultaneously, self-management and initiative are crucial. Keep me informed of any significant delays, especially those affecting our project timelines.
5. **Transparency and Updates:** Please tag me in ClickUp (@Michalak, Russell) to update me on your progress or if there are delays. Communication is key, and unexplained delays are challenging.
6. **Meeting Requests:** I'm here to support you. If you need to discuss something, suggest a time, and I can extend our meeting as necessary.
7. **Thoughtful Questions:** When asking questions, try to come up with a preliminary solution or recommendation. This approach fosters problem-solving skills and initiative.
8. **Brief and Direct Communication:** My emails are typically short and to the point, reflecting my busy schedule rather than any displeasure.

Effective 1:1 Meetings

1:1 meetings are your opportunity to discuss projects, strategize, and showcase your progress. Here's how to make the most of them:

1. **Come Prepared:** Maintain a running list of ideas or questions and prepare an agenda for our meetings. This ensures productive and focused discussions.
2. **Documenting Discussions:** Clearly document action items, responsibilities, timelines, and needed resources during our meetings.

Building Trust and Continuous Learning

Our goal is to build a trusting and collaborative relationship. Here's what you can do:

1. **Proactive Learning:** Take charge of your learning journey. Ask questions early on, and later, guide your learning based on the needs and feedback.
2. **Share Your Progress:** Keep me informed about your learning achievements and challenges. Remember, it's impossible to over-communicate in our environment.

Feedback Dynamics

Feedback is a two-way street:

1. **From Me:** Expect regular feedback aimed at fostering your growth and integration into our team. I'm learning too, and I appreciate your insights that help improve our library.
2. **From You:** I welcome direct feedback on my management and communication style. This helps me adjust and support you better.

Remember, I'm Here for You

Always feel free to reach out if you need clarification, support, or resources. I'm committed to your success and development as part of our team. Let's make great things happen together at the library!

Notes

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CHAPTER 21

Black Women Library Leaders

Challenges and Considerations for Inclusive Advocacy

Aisha M. Johnson, Shaundra Walker, Tamika Barnes, and Tina D. Rollins

Introduction

Black women leaders face unlimited challenges navigating the complex landscape of leadership, balancing race and gender dynamics that often intersect to create unique obstacles. The intersectionality of our identities compounds the hurdles we encounter, making our leadership journey particularly challenging. Research indicates that Black women leaders frequently grapple with systemic racism and gender bias in both professional and societal spheres.[1] Additionally, we encounter stereotypes and preconceived notions that affect perceptions of our competence and authority.[2] We strive to break through the glass ceiling while confronting structural barriers and limited representation at executive levels, exacerbating an uphill climb.[3] The impact of Black women leaders extends far beyond individual achievements, influencing organizational dynamics, societal perceptions, and the broader landscape of leadership. Research highlights the significance of diverse leadership, with studies suggesting that companies benefit from a variety of perspectives and experiences.[4] Black women leaders, in particular, bring a unique set of skills and insights that contribute to innovation and organizational success.[5] Furthermore, their presence challenges stereotypes and inspires future generations, fostering a more inclusive and equitable environment.[6] Black women in leadership have a positive ripple effect related to inclusive library leadership as well as organizational culture, diversity initiatives, and the empowerment of underrepresented groups.

Personal Growth Tools

The Black women library leaders of this chapter are advocates, educators, and recognized scholars in the field of library and information science (LIS). We have focused our careers on academic libraries with over eighty years of collective experience. As professionals, we have experienced less than desirable work environments that fueled our need to encourage and support others as means to demonstrate inclusive leadership. Our leadership is a testament to those who came before us but also those who were not supportive.

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Dr. Johnson's Narrative

I became a leader to advocate for people and resources. However, it has not been the less complicated, well-supported journey I witnessed those who do not look like me receive. A natural leader, or bossy last child, I sought to do good work. Yes, I wanted to become a leader, but no one warns you about the unexpected racism and ageism that also come along with the goal of contributing to the betterment of library organizations.

I am unaware of a Black woman leader who hasn't experienced racism in their role. Furthermore, for those of us who entered the field as a first career, and/or younger than average, to be met with ageism was also disheartening. The story goes: I am hired for all that my vision, forward thinking, and knowledge… yet that seemed to become a threat I never posed. It becomes a situation that I find myself needing relief from, so after accomplishing specific things and making contributions to organizational change, I move along. The End. Right?! Yes and no, since we carry experiences with us. These experiences offered me profound lessons that contributed to personal and professional growth; I gained the ability to enter any organization with strategy. But more so, I gained an understanding that my experiences with poor leadership and/or lack of support were my transformative catalyst for developing into an effective and empathetic leader. I am not only compassionate and inclusive but also have intentions rooted in people development. That's how you develop an organization.

Though bad leadership experiences are undoubtedly challenging, they indeed serve as powerful learning opportunities that shaped my leadership. I am a more effective, resilient, and ethical leader. As an advocate for people, I reflect on these experiences and apply the lessons learned. I prioritize transparency, empathy, and inclusivity, ultimately fostering more positive and productive work environments.

Leadership Toolbelt

An arsenal of approaches and tools is instrumental in shaping our leadership by emphasizing the importance of caring for and considering people. Implementing feedback mechanisms, such as regular check-ins and anonymous surveys, allows leaders to understand and address the needs and concerns of their team members effectively. Additionally, leadership training programs focused on emotional intelligence and empathy equip leaders with the skills to create supportive and inclusive environments, which foster stronger and more collaborative teams.

We must not disregard support mechanisms for personal growth, including mentoring programs that provide guidance and feedback, enabling individuals to develop their skills and navigate career challenges. Regular access to professional development opportunities, such as workshops and training, helps individuals stay current with industry trends and enhance their competencies. Additionally, a supportive network of colleagues and peers provides encouragement and constructive criticism, creating an environment that fosters continuous learning and self-improvement. At its core, goal-setting is based on the theory that consciously defining objectives influences action.[7] Being reflective requires intentionally going beyond a checklist.

A reflective leader takes accountability for how their growth and the development benefit their team. For example, the organization can use the 3×3×3 approach, where the leader decides on three weekly, three monthly, and three annual goals. Progress may occur daily but also considers desired personal and professional growth. Monthly and annual goals may include engaging in professional development, personal growth resources, and/or networking opportunities as simple as virtual calls with other colleagues in the field. Goal-setting provides a clear direction and measurable objectives, which help ensure that advocacy efforts are focused and effective. By defining goals that prioritize inclusivity, we ensure that the needs and voices of all community members are considered and addressed in the advocacy process.

Mrs. Barnes' Narrative

I came to libraries originally as a stopgap between finishing undergrad and determining what I wanted to do next, since medical school was no longer the dream. I had worked the night shift as a student and even worked overnight shifts during finals at the undergraduate library and decided that I liked helping students achieve their goals, whether it was giving them a reserve item or helping them find a reference resource to use for their paper. Once I began working full time, I quickly knew that I wanted to get my LIS degree because I wanted to be in a leadership role to have a voice in the decisions that were being made.

My first leadership role in libraries came after reflecting on what I wanted to do in the future and deciding I wanted to be in a leadership position. However, after looking at job descriptions, I quickly noticed that most supervisory/management positions required prior experience. My position as a reference librarian had no supervisory or project management duties. I asked the assistant department head if I could collaborate on the hiring of library school graduate students. After shadowing them for a semester, I then took the lead on hiring, scheduling, and training. This became the springboard that I needed to continue on the management track.

Reflection

After the creation of these goals, I strongly suggest consistent reflection on what has been accomplished, for accountability. The frequency of reflection should be determined not only based on the goal itself but also on the team members, setting the stage for collaboration and partnership. It is also helpful to note the support systems that assisted you in achieving these goals as well as any people or systemic barriers that prevented an achievement. This will allow time for self-evaluation of your accomplishments and see which goals are attainable and which, if any, may need to be re-imagined. How you support yourself will also reflect your leadership style because it influences how you manage challenges, make decisions, and interact with others. For example, a leader who prioritizes self-discipline and resilience fosters a culture of accountability and perseverance within their team. Alternatively, someone who focuses on self-care and emotional intelligence cultivates an environment where empathy and

collaboration thrive. Ultimately, the way you approach your own growth and well-being sets the tone for how you lead and inspire those around you. Setting an example of self-care and resilience encourages others to adopt similar practices and fosters a culture of well-being and balance. Personal growth and investing in yourself enable the growth and development of the organization.

Dr. Rollins' Narrative

The journey to leadership, especially within the LIS field, is often fraught with challenges, obstacles, and barriers, especially for leaders like me who bear the intersectionality of being Black and female. Regardless of the many initiatives to address the lack of diversity, the profession remains alarmingly white and female, with minimal gains in increasing the number of people of color. The microaggressions faced and constant credential and credibility challenges, compounded with systemic barriers, have created a situation that has made many people of color leave the field for the sake of maintaining their professional careers and overall sanity.

Leffler writes, "As young people move through life, they acquire experiences that become a form of leadership practice. They observe responsible adults as teachers, librarians, scoutmasters, ministers, doctors, lawyers, and they imperceptibly shape their aspirations and sense of responsibility."[8] This sentiment has been part of my path to leadership. Whether at church, school, or home, my mother ensured that I would be taught self-reliance and leadership skills, which she knew I would greatly need.

My path to leadership within the field came after several staff and librarian positions at both predominantly white institutions (PWIs) and historically Black colleges and universities (HBCUs). Within these positions, I built skills and made connections that helped create my professional identity and prepared me to face the unique challenges that I would encounter in crafting myself as a leader. Each position uniquely positioned me to face many obstacles that I would later learn to navigate.

I entered library leadership in my early thirties. Having a position of authority during early middle age is interesting because it puts you in the position of leading those both older and younger than you. Being in the middle of both age groups allows for a rather unique perspective of being able to relate. Consequently, it also leads to oppositional views that question your experiences and competency due to your age. Although starting my leadership career at an HBCU has allowed me the opportunity to not be consistently faced with racial indignities within my immediate environment, it has not cocooned me from experiencing bias and microaggressions when working with others in the field. I am still often the only director of color in many groups or the only one who will speak up about the need for inclusion and diversity outreach in all facets of the field, but I no longer feel the need to be the only person who takes action or accountability. I have also been repeatedly questioned about my

experiences, and others have often felt the need to review my collaborative work or follow up on my projects and contributions.

At this point in leadership, I have learned to always lean on my intuition and be my authentic self. All my experiences have allowed me to develop a sense of self of who I am as a leader and what my boundaries are as a leader. I am not a superhero. I cannot do everything. I am not responsible for soothing professional egos, and I don't walk on eggshells so as not to bruise white fragility. I have learned to call others in to call them out. This allows me to help interrupt bias and let someone know that their words or actions will not be tolerated.[9] I have also developed tools to have a professional level of sympathy and empathy. I will continue to reject the notion of imposter syndrome and stand firm in knowing that I have worked for everything that I have accomplished and am a leader in my field.

Despite my healthy level of confidence, I know that no leader is perfect. I sometimes make decisions in good faith that do not turn out the way that I envisioned. I still need to learn to balance my work and personal life and not consider it a failure when I can't. I also have to continue to work on my health journey and continue to take care of myself physically. But above all things, I am continuing to learn grace, not only for others but for myself.

Abandon Magical Myths

Historically, Black women have been conditioned to take on the stress and burden of being the providers and "fixers" for our families, employers, and communities. This idea that Black women can do it all was later turned into the concept of "Black Girl Magic." The term, coined by CaShawn Thompson in 2013, defined the celebration of Black women's power and resilience.[10] Although this term is meant to celebrate Black women and our accomplishments, it can also lead to the unwarranted perception that, both personally and professionally, we as Black women are responsible for everything and everyone's well-being while neglecting our own.

This perception is especially dangerous within the LIS field, as we consider this myth coupled with the other systemic diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) issues that we face as leaders. This can lead to the feeling that you are the only one who can reverse past barriers, and your experiences - whether positive or negative - will directly affect other BIPOC. In these instances, the myth must be a constant reminder that you cannot save everyone and everything. Equally important, shared responsibility is essential in any organization. Trying to do everything will result in burnout, which has detrimental personal and professional implications. The combination of race and position does not make for total accountability or responsibility to improve the plight of DEI within libraries and library organizations. True change is everyone's responsibility, and no one person has "magic" to tackle and change systems that are historically embedded with conscious and unconscious racism and bias.

"No" is a Full Sentence

As leaders, we are always faced with never-ending tasks, meetings, paperwork, and other responsibilities. Additionally, we are positioned as teachers, trainers, mentors, and even ad hoc support systems for those we lead. We respond to personnel issues and often respond to personal issues within our employees' lives, which may impact their work. We are counselors, and our days are often long, as commitments do not neatly wrap up at the traditional close of business hours.

We often find ourselves tasked with additional work outside of our regular duties within our organizations: invisible labor. The concept of invisible labor is the often unacknowledged and undervalued work, such as administrative tasks and emotional support, that disproportionately affects marginalized groups and is essential to the smooth functioning of organizations.[11] This could include stepping in when a department has a staff shortage, additional hours to get some uninterrupted time to tackle various issues, or helping other departments within the larger organization. To address inequities related to invisible labor, consider implementing the following policy or practice changes: develop recognition and reward systems to acknowledge these contributions, make invisible labor more visible through documentation and reporting, ensure equitable distribution of tasks, provide training on its value, and involve diverse team members in policy development.[12]

- **Recognition and reward systems.** Develop formal mechanisms to recognize and reward invisible labor, such as administrative tasks and emotional support, ensuring that these contributions are acknowledged in performance reviews and compensation structures. This can include creating awards or bonuses specifically for those who go above and beyond their formal job descriptions.
- **Visibility and transparency.** Make invisible labor more visible by documenting and reporting the scope of these tasks. This can involve including a section on invisible labor in regular team meetings or reports and ensuring that these tasks are acknowledged and valued during evaluations and planning sessions.
- **Equitable distribution.** Implement policies to ensure that invisible labor is equitably shared among team members. This might involve regularly assessing workloads and redistributing tasks to prevent certain individuals from shouldering a disproportionate amount of invisible labor.
- **Training and awareness.** Provide training to leaders and employees on the value and impact of invisible labor. Raise awareness about how this work contributes to overall team success and establish guidelines for how to support and distribute these responsibilities fairly.
- **Inclusive policy development.** Involve diverse team members in the development and revision of policies to ensure that they address the needs and challenges related to invisible labor. This can help create more inclusive and representative policies that better reflect the experiences of all employees.

The LIS field also contains endless opportunities to participate in conference presentations, grants, publishing, and speaking engagements. Leaders need to be more aware, as scholarship and service to the profession are expected. The many opportunities can be enticing, but boundaries and balancing are important. Saying "no" is acceptable and a declaration of your desire to set boundaries for a healthy work/life balance. In declining an opportunity, beyond pre-determined goals, you must be affirmative in your "no" and disregard the guilt-trip from colleagues and/or within. Saying "no" is a form of self-care and an indication of growth as an efficient leader.

Team-based Tools

Even with a designated leader, shared responsibilities foster a sense of ownership among team members. Library employees should be allowed and encouraged to step outside of their day-to-day to have the opportunity to consider other perspectives and experiences. Oftentimes, it takes a team to succeed in uplifting an organization and growing beyond any past leadership traumas. Such trauma tends to result from underdeveloped leadership who lack key skills, experience, or maturity, often resulting in ineffective guidance, poor decision-making, and limited ability to inspire or manage a team effectively.[13] It may also involve a lack of strategic vision, insufficient communication skills, or inadequate support for team members, which can hinder overall organizational success. When this occurs, growth must be intentional and rooted in support. A few support mechanisms for team growth include the following:

- **Situational leadership** has been widely applied in diverse organizational contexts, proving particularly useful in guiding leaders to perform custom leadership strategies catering to the unique needs of individual team members. Numerous studies and applications have explored the effectiveness of situational leadership across industries, making it a valuable framework for leadership development and organizational success; a primary form of leadership with effectiveness for team growth unmatched.[14] It allows team goal-setting while guiding individuals on contributing. Team members do not want blanket or one-size-fits-all leadership. They want the intimacy and individualism of situational leadership, as it allows people to feel seen, heard, and valued.
- **Policy audit** enables new leaders and library employees to review policies from fresh perspectives, fostering a more inclusive approach to policy development and implementation. This practice can be particularly useful in homogeneous teams that are serving increasingly diverse constituencies, as it helps identify and address gaps or biases that may not have been apparent to the original policy creators.
- **Team assessment** is a way to increase the cohesiveness of your team by using assessment tools such as Clifton Strengths to discover not only individual talents but also those of your team. To maximize the tool's impact, you and your team members each take the test while also engaging in a facilitated workshop. This program also

shows how a team benefits from diverse talents, providing each team member a better understanding of how a person processes information and decision-making on personal and professional levels.

- **Information gathering** as a leadership method is a significant task, but perhaps it is underrated. It ensures that decisions are informed by comprehensive and accurate data, leading to more effective and strategic outcomes. Gathering diverse inputs from various team members enhances the collective knowledge base, allows for a broader understanding of issues, and facilitates more nuanced problem-solving and innovation.[15] Questions a leader may ask include information on successes, challenges encountered, and support needed. Information gathering encourages intentionality among the team.

Team-based solutions are crucial for leadership because they leverage diverse perspectives and expertise, fostering collaboration and innovation that can lead to more effective problem-solving and decision-making together. By engaging team members in the solution process, leaders can enhance buy-in, increase commitment, and harness the collective intelligence of the group to address complex challenges. Seeking to understand a team that has felt unheard or unsupported is a process, and the leader must be aware of their leadership style and communicate their support and vision.

Black Women Leaders Forge Inclusive Futures for Everyone

The challenges faced by Black women leaders are complex and multifaceted, stemming from the intersectionality of race and gender. The literature and research in this area highlight the systemic biases, stereotypes, and structural barriers that hinder the progress of Black women in leadership roles.[16] As Black women navigate these obstacles, their resilience and determination emerge as powerful forces for change. We must recognize the transformative potential of addressing foundational issues. Moreover, organizations and society at large must embrace inclusive policies and practices that acknowledge the unique experiences of Black women leaders.[17]

Dr. Walker's Narrative

When I completed my undergraduate degree in history from Spelman College, I was destined for law school. However, as the time drew near for classes to begin, I was unsure of my decision and decided to defer my admission for a year. As I was looking for work, I discovered a position in a library that required an MLS. The work sounded rewarding, so I set about to discover where I could earn such a degree. I was surprised to learn that Clark Atlanta University, a stone's throw from the gates of Spelman, offered such a degree. I applied, was accepted, and the rest is history. I believed that I could be a librarian, and later a library leader, because I saw Black women from my community and with whom I shared experiences serving as librarians.

I grew up in a community that was not integrated but was very instructive and resourceful in developing my young mind and in providing role models for me. With few exceptions, my teachers, principals, and even my librarians were Black, and quite a few of these leaders were Black women.

While I saw librarianship as a viable vocation for me, I did not set my intentions on becoming a library leader. In all of my roles as a librarian, I can honestly say that I was attracted to the work. As I gained more experience and had ideas that I wanted to initiate, leadership positions seemed to be the best opportunity to make the kind of change that I was seeking. Upon reflection, I realized that although I never set out to become a library leader, I had quite a few examples of Black women who served in that capacity, such as Eliza Atkins Gleason, Clara Stanton Jones, Dorothy Porter Wesley, Jessie Carney Smith, and countless others.

It was another Black woman who gave me my first opportunity to serve as a leader in a library. Due to the kind of informal networking that still takes place among Black professionals, I was able to reconnect with an institution where I once interned. Opportunity and preparation met, and I became a department head. I learned a lot from that director, both on-the-job learning as well as how to structure my career. She introduced me into leadership and gave me invaluable wisdom that I still benefit from to this day. I eventually took on another leadership position, this time at a large institution where academic librarians have faculty status and are eligible for tenure and promotion. That position, along with my doctoral studies, has allowed me to operate at the intersection of theory and practice. My doctoral degree is in educational leadership, concentrating in higher education administration. I was very deliberate about selecting my discipline because I knew that I was passionate about academic libraries and wanted to have a broad base in their history and societal function. I felt and still feel that such a foundation assists me in understanding the opportunities and challenges of the academic library and prepares me for collaborating with other leaders on campus.

My key identities are my race (Black) and my gender (cisgender woman). The women of the Combahee River Collective declared the following: "If Black women were free, it would mean that everyone else would have to be free since our freedom would necessitate the destruction of all the systems of oppression."[18] This declarative statement describes my positionality within the academy. My experiences as a Black cisgender woman have sensitized me to the experiences of marginalized groups and individuals, those with whom I identify directly and those whose key identities may be different from my own, but whose challenges are similar. A litmus test for me as a library leader is how accessible the library's services and resources are to the least of us, because if the most marginalized are empowered by the library, we know that empowerment will follow for everyone else.

> What other creature in the world besides the Black woman has had to build the knowledge of so much hatred into her survival and keep going?[19]

Librarianship is a feminized profession. The introduction of race as a variable further complicates my experience and that of my sister colleagues. As a Black woman leader in the

academy, I cannot say that my journey has been easy. I have worked in various types of institutions, ranging from a private liberal arts college to an HBCU land-grant institution to a public liberal arts college. At every level, I have faced challenges that have been informed by the intersections of my race, gender, and sexual identity. As an information professional operating in a time when notions of truth, evidence, and credibility, even for a role as sacred as a librarian, are challenged, my work at times can be difficult. I often think of Hall's seminal article, "Yassuh! I's the reference librarian!"[20] I remember reading it early in my professional career and finding it to be a bit unbelievable. But to borrow an adage from the Black community, I "kept on living," and have found that those experiences resonate with my own. I recognize that my race, gender, and, to a certain degree, my sexual identity negatively impact some people's perceptions of my efficacy as both a professional and a leader. Yet, I keep going.

With few exceptions, I have had to take responsibility for my professional development and career planning. Admittedly, I have not had very many mentors. I have made "Black history" at two of three institutions where I have worked, being the first Black librarian at two, the first Black person and Black woman to earn tenure and promotion at one, and the first Black department chair and director at another. Rather than mentors, I have benefited greatly from my professional network, which is primarily composed of similarly situated individuals. Quite often, they are able to understand the dynamics of being a Black woman leader in the academy and can share strategies for addressing the kinds of challenges that I face.

This year marks my twenty-fifth year of work in libraries and higher education, and as I think about the time that I have left in the field, now more than ever, I am committed to being a mentor and helping to improve the path for those who will come behind me. Quite often, when we think about leadership, we think about formal leadership, such as that which is embodied in titles and positions. I have found that, as a Black woman leader, at times I must lead in other ways, such as with my scholarship and my service to the profession and to my larger community. In some instances, those arenas provide opportunities for me to both build and demonstrate my leadership that are not present in the academy. As I plan to close out my career and consider my legacy, those achievements that I thought would be the pinnacle of my career, such as traditional scholarship and professional recognition, are still important, but I believe that those accomplishments that will mean the most to me and that will be more lasting will be those that relate to recruiting the next generation of librarians. As I have progressed through my career, I have been surprised to learn that my presence as a Black woman leader in the library has served as an inspiration to other Black women. I have had at least four of my informal mentees pursue a career in librarianship. I believe that those women will ultimately be my legacy.

Conclusion

As society becomes increasingly aware of the importance of diversity and inclusion, it is incumbent upon institutions and individuals to actively dismantle the structural impediments

that hinder the progression of Black women leaders, promoting a more equitable and inclusive future for all. We can pave the way for Black women leaders to thrive, contributing invaluable perspectives to leadership roles and shaping a more just and equitable future if we simply provide authentic and inclusive support. Doubling down here: the inclusion of Black women leaders brings diverse perspectives and innovative solutions to the forefront, enriching organizational decision-making and driving cultural competence, which collectively enhance overall performance and foster a more equitable and dynamic work environment.[21]

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CHAPTER 22

Case Study: **Building the Next Generation of Inclusive Leaders**

Collaborative High Impact Practices for Student Workers with Campus Experts

Elise Ferer, Sharon Bunch-Nuñez, and Richie Sebuharara

Introduction

In this chapter, we address inclusive leadership as it pertains to student employment in academic libraries. We do this by describing the workshops that have been facilitated for our student employees and delivered by a staff member from our campus's Multicultural Resource Center (MRC). We pair this with information on how our libraries' student supervisors incorporate inclusive leadership in their day-to-day supervision of student employees. Student supervisors have been successful in using these principles in their work and modeling inclusive leadership for our student employees.

Positionality Statements

The authors would like to begin by describing their positionality as it relates to their work:

- Sharon identifies as a non-disabled, white, cisgender woman raised by US-born parents in the Northeast region of the United States. She has a master's in student affairs administration and has been working in the Binghamton University Libraries for ten years.
- Richie identifies as a non-disabled, black, cisgender man raised by Congolese immigrant parents in the Northeast region of the United States. He has a master's in student affairs administration and has been working in higher education for seven years and for five years in the Multicultural Resource Center; he is currently director of Upward Bound at Binghamton University.
- Elise identifies as a currently non-disabled, white, cisgender woman raised by US-born parents with advanced degrees in the mid-Atlantic region of the United States. She has a master's in library science and a graduate certificate in instructional design. Elise has been at Binghamton for only two years, but she has been working in academic libraries for thirteen years.

Institutional Context

Binghamton University is a large public R1 university and one of the doctorate-granting University Centers in the State University of New York (SUNY) system. From its humble beginnings in 1946 as Triple Cities College,[1] Binghamton University has grown to encompass six schools with a combined graduate and undergraduate average enrollment of at least 18,000 students since 2019.[2] The university is a major employer in the region, with an economic impact of over a billion dollars in the Triple Cities area.

Binghamton University is a PWI (predominantly white institution) with 53 percent of the student body identifying as white, 15 percent Asian, 12 percent Hispanic, 10 percent international, 5 percent African American or Black, 3 percent identifying two or more races, and 2 percent unknown. Sixty-three countries are represented within our international student body.[3] Approximately 20 to 30 percent of the student population can be classified as first-generation students whose parents or guardians do not hold an undergraduate degree.[4]

Binghamton University's effort around diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) is embedded in the strategic priorities of the university, with a clearly articulated commitment to "an environment that advances diversity, equity and inclusion; international perspectives; and community engagement" in the university mission.[5] For three years running, Binghamton University has received recognition for its DEI efforts from Insight Magazine, a leader in showcasing best practices for DEI in higher education.[6] The Higher Education Excellence in Diversity (HEED) Awards are the only national recognition for institutions of higher education, and along with the larger campus recognition, Binghamton University Libraries received the inaugural 2024 Libraries Excellence in Access and Diversity (LEAD) Award for the work they do to support DEI efforts and initiatives across campus.[7]

The Division of Diversity, Equity and Inclusion (DEI) was created from the Binghamton University Road Map strategic planning process. The Roadmap to Premier, unveiled in 2013, brought together stakeholders from across the campus and community to identify the projects and initiatives that would advance the desired outcome and profile of the university. The Strategic Priority: Inclusive Campus (SP#3) calls us to "unite to foster a diverse and inclusive campus culture" and supports the development and implementation of diversity and inclusion initiatives through funds earmarked for that priority.[8] The Division of DEI understands diversity as encompassing all individuals and groups, as well as social, cultural, political, religious, and other affiliations. The office supports human diversity in our learning and working environs and promotes an atmosphere where prejudice, harassment, and discrimination are unacceptable.[9] The impact of the collaborative efforts out of the Division of DEI's Multicultural Resource Center (MRC) cannot be understated and includes the annual Men of Color Summit, which brings together students, staff, faculty, and community members to build connections and focus on issues that impact men of color. In 2022, the Association of College Unions International (ACUI) awarded the Men of Color Summit with the Teresa D. Drummond Memorial Award for "executing an outstanding multicultural program, event or activity with an emphasis on cross-cultural communication and acceptance."[10]

The mission of the MRC is to support and educate the campus community through initiatives designed to increase awareness and understanding of cultural diversity. The MRC facilitates programs and activities supporting the recruitment, retention, and personal and professional development of all students, with a special emphasis on students from culturally diverse and historically underrepresented populations.[11]

Libraries' Commitment to Inclusion

In the spring of 2021, the Binghamton University Libraries' commitment to anti-racism and inclusion was formalized with the creation of the Office of IDEA (inclusion, diversity, equity, and accessibility). This office is dedicated to intentionally and actively nurturing an organizational culture that is anti-racist, inclusive, and ensures that every employee in the Libraries receives the support they need. IDEA operationalizes that mission through regular and recurring programming focused on establishing and instilling a shared understanding of inclusion and how to embed inclusive practices in the work we do in the Libraries[12] Under the guidance of the Office of IDEA, the following language has been added to job descriptions within the Libraries "…participates in a work culture that promotes diversity and anti-racism and actively works to eliminate or mitigate the effects of systemic racism and bias."

Binghamton University Libraries employs an average of 100 student employees each academic year. Our student employees are vital to our operations, keeping library spaces open late into the evening and through the weekends, providing circulation desk coverage, serving stacks maintenance, supporting resource-sharing operations, and providing research help. These students regularly provide patron support in the absence of professional staff and faculty, with an average of 503 hours of circulation desk coverage across our three library locations in any given week during our regular semester hours. One could argue that our student staff are the face of the Libraries.

As some of our most public-facing employees, the Libraries puts significant effort into supporting the professional development of our student employees. Along with general libraries onboarding, orientation, and job training provided by student supervisors, our Libraries' High Impact Practices (HIP) Student Employment program provides supplemental paid professional development workshops focused on career readiness as defined by the National Association of Colleges and Employers (NACE), which is defined as "the attainment and demonstration of requisite competencies that broadly prepare college graduates for a successful transition into the workplace."[13] On-campus employment in academic libraries offers a unique opportunity for student supervisors to support the development of their students' workplace competencies by embedding high-impact practices in their supervisory practices.

Binghamton Libraries' HIP Student Employee learning objectives include skills in critical thinking, effective communication, teamwork, digital technology adaptability, leadership attributes, and intercultural competence. The Libraries' associate head of High Impact Practices and Service Locations, a professional staff member in patron services, actively partners

with experts on campus to more effectively educate students on the concepts related to these competencies. Each semester, library student employees are offered workshops such as "Stump the Librarian: Research and Reference Support," presented by our Binghamton librarians, "Maintaining Safe Library Spaces," presented by our University Police Department partners, "Updating your Resume," with the Fleishman Career Center, and both "Inclusive Leadership" and "Cultural Humility in the Libraries," with our partners in the MRC.

Two Workshops: Cultural Humility in Libraries and Inclusive Leadership

As part of the Libraries' High Impact Practices workshops for students, the Libraries has worked with staff from the campus's MRC to offer a workshop on Cultural Humility in Leadership. This workshop addresses intercultural competence, cultural humility, and skills related to inclusive leadership. Utilizing student employment funds, these workshops are paid opportunities for student employees to add to their skillsets and introduce them to new parts of the Libraries and the larger campus. All workshops are offered several times over the semester to allow for students' schedules. The Cultural Humility in Leadership workshops last one hour and set out to accomplish the following goals: define culture, communication, and leadership; discuss the similarities and differences of cultural competence and cultural humility; articulate the importance of creating an inclusive culture in the Libraries; and identify strategies for applying cultural humility in Libraries work by familiarizing participants with the traits of inclusive leaders to improve situational leadership; and lastly, reflect on the importance of and dynamics of intercultural communication.

Over the spring and fall semester in 2023, workshops were offered at three different times each semester, alternating between different library locations as well as over Zoom in order to allow the maximum number of students to attend. Over the spring 2023 semester, twenty-seven students attended these workshops, and over the fall 2023 semester, twenty students attended the workshops.

Sessions began by working through the basics of definitions for "culture," "communication," "intercultural communication," "leadership," "inclusive leadership," and "cultural humility." This was done in small groups where participants discussed how they defined each (one word at a time), then was followed by a brief group discussion. Once these words had been defined, the groups shared personal anecdotes of how they have seen these words show up in their lives and/or work. The group then watched a short video clip on cultural humility and how effective it can be for future roles in workplaces that are increasingly more multicultural. We closed with tips on how to improve the effectiveness of intercultural communication and develop inclusive leadership en route to cultural humility.

Assessment

After the workshops, student employees are given a Google survey to gather feedback on the workshops. This is done for each of the different workshops in the High Impact Practices workshops series. Students had many positive things to say about their experience, including:

- "I really enjoyed the interactiveness. Richie was very personable and made the presentation enjoyable."
- "[I enjoyed] meeting other library workers."
- "[I liked] working in smaller groups and the sharing out."
- "I like working with my peers and discussing various questions."[14]

Student employees also offered feedback on how the workshops could be improved. Some of the comments that students made included:

- "[have a] Bigger group of people."
- "[Incorporate] more application to careers."
- "I think I would maybe add a component where the students who learn about the various talks can share what they learned at the end."[15]

The student feedback survey elicits a series of Likert scale self-assessment measures asking students to rate their understanding of cultural humility and inclusive leadership as well as their confidence in their ability to incorporate these practices into their libraries' duties. The survey also poses several open-ended questions related to the overall facilitation and presentation format. Students consistently reported an increased understanding of the core concepts presented and an overall positive experience with the workshop format and materials. Students also shared challenges and potential areas for improvement for the workshops, which we discuss in more detail below and include scheduling, delivery method, securing space, and working with their supervisors. More intentional assessment to measure pre- and post-workshops could be developed in the future to better assess the impact of the sessions.

Challenges

In administering the workshops, the method of delivery posed a challenge. Of the six workshops, four were delivered in person and two were delivered through Zoom. For the in-person sessions, depending on the group, engagement was a challenge at times. Over the hour-long workshop, the facilitator started by defining culture, communication, intercultural communication, and cultural humility. Participants were separated into smaller groups and asked to define each word individually for about five to ten minutes. After discussing, the facilitator would bring the full group back to share ideas with each other. This process

was repeated for each word and was utilized to increase engagement of participants. Participants were more comfortable sharing with a smaller group before addressing the whole group. After definitions, the facilitator transitioned to address leadership and traits of an inclusive leader. This portion pulled from the prior definitions and discussions and was a full group discussion for roughly ten to fifteen minutes. Lastly, the facilitator provided tips to assist with navigating intercultural communication for inclusive leadership. Over the hour-long workshops, there were several breakout sessions where participants were able to discuss with one or two people, which helped participants be more comfortable sharing their perspectives in smaller groups and then with the full group. Once participants were comfortable, the challenge of the in-person workshops was the time limit. A single hour, at times, was not enough time to both help participants get comfortable and to fully discuss ideas. For the Zoom workshops, engagement posed a greater challenge. Due to the nature of the conversations, Zoom workshops removed opportunities to build off ideas from other participants in real time because of the separate breakout rooms in Zoom. Discussions over Zoom were fragmented because of the frequent breakout sessions.

Inclusive Leadership in Supervision of Student Employees

Most librarians are not given any training on supervising other employees (including student employees). Many begin by using their own experiences (both good and bad) to inform how they supervise others. Most student supervisors are working through their own understandings of cultural humility, inclusion, and equitable practices that could be defined as inclusive leadership, even though they may not attend a specific workshop on these topics.

The Libraries' Office of IDEA offers programming on topics related to these, including presentations and regular emails on content related to diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility. As Elise has learned more about leadership and supervision, along with diversity, equity, and inclusion, she has tried to incorporate what she has learned into her day-to-day work as a student supervisor. This includes caring for the whole student with empathy and compassion as well as monitoring her own biases, incorporating differing perspectives into decision-making and operating within an awareness of cultural differences. What follows is from her own experiences as well as those of other student supervisors at our institution. Information from other student supervisors in the Libraries was collected via a brief survey and one interview.

Biases

As student supervisors, we recognize that we come into the workplace with our biases. Many of us are mindful about how these can come out in the hiring and supervision process, and we work to counteract them. This included removing or hiding names and other identifying information when reviewing application materials and instead using neutral questions to filter out applicants. These can range from using shift availability and questions about types of work

experiences or skills. For example, one student supervisor uses a question on experience with libraries and/or research as a way to filter out applicants to staff a research help desk.

Other student supervisors noted the need to check their assumptions and instead focus on the responses to questions they ask an applicant during the process as well as the applicant's comfort with the position's duties. Another student supervisor notes that they strive to give applicants the benefit of the doubt during an interview and notes making accommodations for student applicants. Some student supervisors in the Libraries note that there is a tension present when considering applicants that they suspect are non-native English speakers in their application or interview. Student supervisors need to hire students who can communicate effectively in English while seeking not to immediately disqualify applicants who are English language learners. Some student supervisors have been successful in hiring and working with English language learners in ways that reduce the impact of their abilities with English on their work and still provide a fulfilling experience. This could include providing a student employee with written as well as spoken instructions in plain language during training for job duties.

Biases are also present after the hiring process. During training, student supervisors note the importance of giving all students the same foundational knowledge about our library environment so that prior library experience is not a factor in a student employee's success. One student supervisor notes that they find it easier to connect with students like them, so they spend time working to build relationships with students who may be different. When it comes to day-to-day work, it can be easy to make assumptions about our student employees based on their past performance. While this can be helpful when handing out work, it is important to give student employees the chance to do the types of work that they seek experience with (within their position) as well as provide an acceptable level of challenge when appropriate.

Differing Perspectives

Considering differing perspectives is an important part of supervising student employees, especially valuing the perspectives and opinions of students who are doing any work affected by decision-making in the library. Students can also represent a patron perspective when working in a university library; in some cases, they are helpful when we are making decisions that affect their peers.

Student supervisors take the perspectives of their employees into account in differing ways. Student supervisors ask student employees their opinions on workflows as well as the ways that tasks and projects are accomplished. In addition to encouraging student employees to ask questions about the work they are doing, student supervisors also take note of the questions that their student employees ask to gather information on projects, how to explain them to others, or how to carry out the work with students. Student supervisors want their student employees to take ownership of the work they do in addition to bringing their own perspectives to it. While there are students who just want to do the work and leave, student supervisors will encourage student employees to be curious about the work they are doing.

Many student supervisors list student employees as one of the multiple perspectives that they rely on in addition to colleagues and their own supervisors when making decisions. Student supervisors gather feedback from students in multiple ways: considering perspectives that come up during daily work, surveying their workers, scheduling meetings with them, and even taking them to lunch to gather their opinions and feedback.

Our library also provides support in the form of meetings each semester for student supervisors and has created an informal group in which to seek support and guidance. Some even note taking the actions and viewpoints of other student supervisors into consideration when thinking about how to supervise their own student employees. We also have a staff position that assists with all recruitment, hiring, and employee retention for all in the Libraries, including current students.

Cultural Humility

One of the benefits of hiring a group of diverse student employees is learning from those employees about their own cultures. This is especially helpful when your student employees reflect the diversity of your own campus's student population. But student supervisors can only do this when they practice cultural humility with the students they supervise. It is equally important not to ask a student to be representative of a marginalized group they may be a part of; student employees may offer their opinions, but this should not be taken as a representation of all students in that particular group or community.

Student supervisors report the benefits of practicing cultural humility in their own supervision of students. They have learned how religious holidays that are foreign to them may affect attendance as well as how student employees with different backgrounds may perceive and react to national and local events. One student supervisor noted that they were able to recognize their own cultural mistakes or assumptions and learn from them alongside their student employees. Other student supervisors have noted that students from different cultures will give different meanings to common body language and the importance of taking this into account. This is an important part of practicing cultural humility—knowing that mistakes will happen but recognizing that one can learn from them and sometimes even laugh about them.

Practicing cultural humility can affect and improve communication with student employees. Challenging assumptions present in language and slowing down to make sure verbal and written communication is clear has helped at least one student supervisor improve their communication skills with people who are non-native English speakers. Modeling cultural humility through curiosity about different cultures and languages with student employees can improve communication with our students overall, and, when done well, can serve as a sign of respect for our own student employees. Additionally, working in an educational environment gives us the extra push to continue learning about the world around us.

As student supervisors, we can adopt cultural humility, but it can be frustrating when our student employees are still developing their own sense of cultural humility. Student supervisors can use empathy and compassion to respond to their student employees, developing cultural

humility, as well as continue to encourage their students to learn. Supervisors can decide to make the times in which student employees lack cultural humility into teachable moments or to incorporate these situations into existing training. Supervisors can also encourage their student employees to attend workshops on cultural humility, such as the one described earlier in this case study.

Empathy and Compassion

Not surprisingly, student supervisors in libraries have experience approaching their student employees with empathy and compassion. This includes considering the whole student and encouraging them to put their studies first. Some student supervisors can be flexible with scheduling and offer the ability to change projects or to do work from home when needed, such as with a long illness. Even when schedules are more rigid, student supervisors will check in with student employees to make sure that the set schedule is not overwhelming and that students are prioritizing schoolwork outside of their working hours. Some student supervisors have student employees who have disclosed a disability or chronic illness and have worked to give their student employees the needed accommodations.

In some areas of the Libraries, student employees may work with sensitive materials or with materials that may cause trauma. This can especially occur in archives and special collections as student employees process collections. Student supervisors in this area have taken extra care to check in with students and offer to change the project a student employee is working on when needed. Additionally, student employees who work with cataloging or metadata may encounter language that is now considered harmful or racist; as student supervisors, we can take extra care with the student employees who work in these areas.

Student supervisors can also support students by checking in with them on their progress, both in their library work and in their classwork. Student supervisors reported providing a "listening ear" as well as being a resource to student employees. This can be especially helpful to students as they navigate higher education, whether they are first-generation students or not. And as students make progress toward their prospective degrees, student supervisors have enjoyed cheering them on and celebrating students' accomplishments.

It is important to note the role that student supervisors can play in connecting their students with the right resources. This can include everything from academic resources, like tutoring, writing centers, and librarians, to ones that support a student's well-being, such as student clubs and activities and the counseling center. Because our own student employees are not just on campus to work in the library, it is easy to justify supporting the whole student in our supervision. This gives us the important opportunity to reinforce a student's sense of belonging on campus. Student supervisors will be encouraged to continue incorporating aspects of inclusive leadership into their supervision of students through opportunities like the workshops on Cultural Humility in Leadership that are offered to student employees and other similar offerings on bias, differing perspectives, cultural humility, empathy, and compassion.

Future Directions

Workshops

The experience of offering workshops on Cultural Humility in Leadership was enriching in many ways. Opening up dialogue that allows students to be vulnerable and ask questions about sensitive topics has long-lasting positive effects. It can be challenging within the daily operations of the library to find opportunities to do so, and these workshops created a space that encourages the discussions. As we move forward, we are inviting and encouraging supervisors to attend these workshops along with their student staff. This will allow supervisors to walk away with a shared understanding of the concepts vital to cultural humility and the signature traits of inclusive leaders, as well as a shared language to facilitate an ongoing dialogue with their teams. Most importantly, these workshops reinforce the concept that cultural competence is a continual process that requires each of us to regularly self-reflect and actively engage in opportunities to develop a deeper understanding of the many cultures that our colleagues, peers, and patrons bring to each interaction.

Supervision

Building on our inclusive leadership methods, which predate the ACRL definition, we will continue to incorporate inclusive leadership methods into our supervision of student employees. Above all, our student supervisors offer empathy and compassion to student employees because we realize that they are students first, and being a student is challenging in many different ways. As student supervisors deepen their engagement with our IDEA office, they will adopt additional supervisory practices, including an increased awareness of bias, cultural humility, and a greater appreciation for diverse perspectives. These practices will become embedded in their daily supervisory habits, ensuring that the Libraries remains a welcoming and supportive environment for all student employees.

It is our expectation that student supervisors, both at our institution and at others, will persist in engaging with these inclusive leadership practices to foster student success and inclusivity in the workplace. By modeling these approaches and teaching our student employees about them, we hope to equip students with the skills to carry these values into their future careers, making a lasting impact on their professional lives.

Recommendations

There are many ways in which other library workers can bring these ideas to their student employees and student supervisors. We think that it is important to foster space for dialogue that allows students to be vulnerable and ask questions about sensitive topics. Giving student employees a forum or specific ways in which to do this can help them find their voices. As far as creating or offering workshops, it can be challenging to make these workshops happen, but

they can create a space that encourages these discussions around DEI, inclusivity, and inclusive leadership. Additionally, creating a series of workshops or a way in which students can continue the conversation allows for more time to focus on specific details. Integrating components of these workshops into the regular onboarding of student staff is also encouraged, as it would provide students and staff the opportunity to work together to implement inclusive practices in library operations while avoiding the perception of an extra task to be completed.

Within the realm of supervision, student supervisors can reflect on their own leadership style and how they work with their own students. While every workplace is different, there is a lot we can learn from one another, both in other institutions and other areas of the library. You can also look to other offices on campus that employ students for examples of inclusive leadership. Our campus career center has been a leader in assisting student supervisors develop best practices for supervision, mentoring, and working with student employees with the purpose of helping students develop career skills and giving them tools to articulate them to future employers. We also want to highlight the importance of learning from student employees as a way to understand the students who visit and use our libraries.

Conclusion

In this chapter, we have described how inclusive leadership can apply to student employees in academic libraries. In our experiences with helping students learn about inclusivity, cultural humility, and related concepts through paid professional development workshops, we have seen how students can learn and think about how to apply these concepts both in school and beyond. In addition to the workshops we offer student employees, we have described how student supervisors in our organization operate within the definition of inclusive leadership. As a major employer of students on our campus, we take responsibility in modeling supervisory behavior for our students and preparing them to enter the workforce full time in the future. We hope that our experiences will help other student supervisors, especially folks who are new to student supervision and wish to give their student employees a positive experience working in libraries.

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CHAPTER 23

Bias, Balance, and Brilliance

Leading from the Inside Out

Lorin Jackson[i]

Introduction

"We give lip service to acceptance, as though acceptance were enough."
—Octavia Butler, *Parable of the Sower*[1]

As leaders, we tend to accept unfavorable situations at work and settle for what we consider "good enough." Our current expectations for work fall short of what we truly need and deserve. Put another way, we are less focused on feeling celebrated or celebrating others and more on accepting what we can tolerate. At the Medical Library Association (MLA) Annual Conference in May 2024, library leader Chris Shaffer supported an immersion session I co-led with fellow library leader Jill Deaver, entitled "Lessons in Slow Librarianship: Making Room for Thought, Intention, and Kindness." One of the comments from his discussion group regarding how to embrace the rapidly growing concept of "slow librarianship" was that, in library work, "enthusiasm is a champagne problem." That quote has stayed with me. For many individuals, often due to valid reasons like recovering from past workplace trauma, a job may simply feel like a means to an end. *We have work to do, and we do it.* Taking into consideration that there are many systemic barriers that dissuade and disempower library workers, I want to challenge all of us (including myself) to imagine what *is* possible. I argue that when we allow ourselves to embrace our whole selves—personally and professionally—we open the door to reimagining our potential beyond the limitations we once accepted as absolute truths, particularly in the workplace, where we spend most of our time. This mindset shift empowers us to move beyond the entrenched norms (or status quo) within libraries, particularly inherited cultural values that prioritize productivity over self-care. Operating from a productivity-first perspective can lead to increased burnout, high staff turnover rates, and worsened health issues among personnel. By implementing more of the care we need in libraries, we can create a more balanced and sustainable approach to our work.

i. In September 2024, Lorin transitioned from executive director of the Network of the National Library of Medicine Region 2 Regional Medical Library to assistant director of the Holman Biotech Commons at the University of Pennsylvania.

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While circumstances at work may not be ideal, library leaders often consider them acceptable if they meet some essential needs, such as providing steady employment, a stable income, or social status. However, if we are to identify and work as inclusive leaders, we must ask ourselves if it is truly sufficient to tolerate negative behavior, demoralizing circumstances, and a lack of engagement from others or ourselves. Moreover, what advantages will we gain if we strive for the celebration and visibility of more of our whole selves?

In a past Oprah Book Club pick, *A New Earth: Awakening to your Life's Purpose* by Eckhart Tolle, he wrote: "The modalities of awakened doing are acceptance, enjoyment, and enthusiasm. Each one represents a certain vibrational frequency of consciousness. You need to be vigilant to make sure that one of them operates whenever you are engaged in doing anything at all—from the simplest task to the most complex."[2] Tolle emphasizes here that, for awakened doing, while acceptance is essential, acceptance is solely the first step. The energy of resisting or denying the reality of a situation results in suffering and perpetuates a seemingly inevitable cycle of disappointment in our lives, including in our professional journeys. Work experiences like reluctant acceptance lead to depletion of morale and burnout, which we certainly want to avoid.

To achieve the most success in our professional endeavors, we must aspire beyond mere acceptance, as articulated by Octavia Butler in the opening epigraph. Acceptance alone isn't enough. Ideally, we would seek opportunities to fully thrive in our work and cultivate a sense of enthusiasm. Rather than framing inclusive leadership at a lower vibrational frequency in our lives, as Tolle articulated, we could aspire to embrace inclusive leadership with genuine enthusiasm and welcome the gifts this framing brings to our lives. Work can then authentically center on genuine growth from the inside out, rather than the energy of obligation, drudgery, artificial performance, or a focus on tolerating (or surviving) difficult relationships.

I recognize that the approach I am advocating may seem fundamentally and structurally impossible, but the seeds of change are already present. With focused attention and a shift in perspective, we can zoom out to view the bigger picture. Dwelling on moments that do not contribute to a stronger vision of library work, where inclusive leadership can flourish, serves only as a distraction—it is disheartening and detrimental.

Although it may feel safe to confine ourselves to library-specific literature and research, our field has much to gain from engaging with experts in other areas, such as community workers. Limiting our research confines our growth and narrows our perspective. As Mia Birdsong highlights in her book *How We Show Up: Reclaiming Family, Friendship, and Community*, there are valuable lessons to be learned beyond constructed boundaries. She writes about how trusted colleagues exposed her to new, innovative ways of thinking that lit a flame within her to address her needs in community with others:

> The future I was invited to imagine back in 1998 felt both exhilarating and terrifying. Not terrifying because of the absence of police and prisons, but because dreaming that big was uncomfortable.... Ruthie's words that day in 1998 introduced me to something I didn't know I was looking for—another version of life that says my safety is grounded in positive things like

> care and love, and that I have a responsibility to not abandon others to struggle on their own. It said that all of us are deserving of the things we need to live.... This is in such stark contrast to American Dreamism—the toxic individualism, the winners and the losers, the demand that we prove our worth by being "productive members of society." I want, as Ruthie wrote with journalist and former prisoner James Kilgore, "a society that centers freedom and justice instead of profit and punishment." And part of what I've come to realize is that it's not unrealistic or utopian, because it's happening.[3]

Birdsong illustrates beautifully how the possibility of inclusive community-building and "another version of life" is already close. She reflects how others supporting her in centering her values of care, love, responsibility, and accountability realigned her moral compass and reinvigorated her passion. I know that venturing outside of our comfort zones in libraries can be terrifying, but Birdsong reminds us that the discovery can also be exhilarating. We can demonstrate our values holistically through intentional retooling by starting with our "why."

Positionality Statement and Connection to Libraries

I identify as a Black, queer, disabled library worker and leader. At the time of writing, I reside in the Southeastern part of the United States, although I grew up in the Northeast. I was raised in a small, racially homogenous, predominantly white town. I have an educated background and am a native English speaker. Even though I identify as a member of the LGBTQIA+ community, I can pass for heterosexual and cisgender, so that affords me some privilege.

My identity impacts my approach to working in libraries because belonging and inclusion are at the forefront of my desired experience. I constantly advocate for others to have access and to experience inclusion. Due to frequent experiences of micro- and macro-aggressions, my research focuses on critical librarianship, trauma-informed librarianship, and compassionate leadership practices. I use research and analysis to make sense out of my experiences. I make it a point to embody core values such as respect, integrity, and kindness to challenge the status quo in libraries.

Leadership positions are meaningful to me as part of a broader effort and motivation to counteract implicit bias resulting from a lack of representation. Representational bias is when people believe that someone who looks like me or a member of another marginalized group cannot serve in certain roles or achieve leadership positions because they simply have not been seen there before. Or, if we apply insight from Mia Birdsong, while there have been leaders with diverse backgrounds, the type or style of leadership was not likely defined as "leadership" within the library's existing culture. When there have been members of marginalized groups in leadership positions, their presence has been routinely ignored and unacknowledged "because dreaming that big was uncomfortable." The library operates comfortably in the maintenance of the status quo. We can draw parallels to the current political moment in American history. Inclusive practices open more potential but also require more intentionality

and deeper reflection, which is often seen as dangerous, unproductive, and expensive to the library's business as usual.

The propagation of the invisibility of Black women in leadership positions stems from a powerful myth centering on misogynoir.[4] As a counter story, I ground my inclusive leadership praxis, teaching philosophy, positionality, and orientation in the following work from the Black feminist lesbian organization active from 1974–1980, the Combahee River Collective:

> The psychological toll of being a Black woman and the difficulties this presents in reaching political consciousness and doing political work can never be underestimated. There is a very low value placed upon Black women's psyches in this society, which is both racist and sexist. As an early group member once said, "We are all damaged people merely by virtue of being Black women." We are dispossessed psychologically and on every other level, and yet we feel the necessity to struggle to change the condition of all Black women.[5]

I'm aware that I live in a liminal space. I know that my current reality as a leader in a medical library was highly unlikely and, in the past, seemed downright impossible. My ancestors were barred from reading and accessing libraries, and yet, here I am, a library executive director before turning forty. I'm not saying this to flex (well, maybe a bit), but to enforce the inherent conflict of my existence in these spaces. As the Combahee River Collective statement explains, the psychological toll and the oppression dispossess Black women in society. Black women are often restricted from access to leadership in all industries, since misogynoir is a universal problem. Obviously, Black women do exist as leaders in libraries. Inclusive leadership in libraries is possible because being critically aware of what information is and how it is used dissolves arbitrary, artificial boundaries, thereby increasing accessibility for a more diverse group of people to lead. Having more critical awareness and literacy affords library leadership opportunities to more adequately reflect the diverse communities they serve.

In many ways, libraries are political. In the 2016 book *Critical Information Literacy: Foundations, Inspiration and Ideas*, Annie Downey offers a concise definition of critical information literacy that situates the concept within the broader field of librarianship. Downey describes how fundamental it is to utilize power as a lens through which to view information access and knowledge production through the concept of critical information literacy:

> *Critical information literacy* … looks beyond the strictly functional, competency-based role of information discovery and use and the traditional conceptions of information literacy that focus almost wholly on mainstream sources and views and takes into account the complex power relationships that undergird all of the information, including its creation, presentation, storage, retrieval, and accessibility. Critical information literacy is in a sense an expanded version of information literacy that places the learner at the center in a more empowered role and focuses on the sociopolitical, economic, and cultural aspects of all types and stages of information and the research process. It is very concerned with the power relationships that

> impact information production and dissemination and tries to move information literacy beyond purely mechanical and technical.[6]

Using critical information literacy, we understand that power undergirds everything present at the surface level of how libraries operate. This awareness enables us to better comprehend why there is a lack of representation of more diverse leadership in libraries. We find evidence that many issues in libraries stem from the same root of a political history of assimilation in libraries. Therefore, it stands to reason that the exclusionary history of libraries will continue to negatively impact those most marginalized in the field unless we adopt more inclusive practices.

Considering Inclusive Leadership

Implicit bias suggests that we harbor biases, whether consciously or unconsciously, toward others based on various factors. Bias can arise from various sources, but Project Implicit succinctly defines implicit bias as "an automatic reaction we exhibit toward other people."[7] These ingrained attitudes and stereotypes can negatively influence our understanding and behaviors toward others, such as by discriminating against them. Unfortunately, we often strive to validate our biases (enacting confirmation bias),[8] adhering to preconceived notions that may hinder our ability to perceive individuals holistically. This tendency results in external discrimination through various systematic and systemic avenues.

In addition to influencing how we perceive others and potentially causing challenges in our interactions, implicit bias can also become internalized. This internalization may lead to issues affecting us personally, as we absorb and internalize the impact of trauma to the extent that we start believing in the validity of negative messaging. For instance, if we consistently see a lack of representation or success among people like us, we start questioning our potential. Similarly, we may then label ourselves as disagreeable or angry; we may start adopting these stereotypes as our truth, leading to self-doubt and questioning our suitability for advanced roles. In other words, *we begin to see ourselves out*.

We're now living in a time when we know that imposter syndrome is much more complicated and not solely self-imposed. The concept of being an imposter is part of the same systems that denied equitable access to all in this country from the beginning of its history—and the inception of libraries. We are in a critical moment that calls us to challenge these negative perceptions and not perpetuate the lies that these perpetuate about who we are. The larger mission of the status quo in libraries is to deny marginalized people entry into the field and leadership positions within it. We don't have to actively (or passively, for that matter) oppress ourselves. This applies not only to people who live on the margins. I invite people from more privileged backgrounds to disrupt micro- and macroaggressions, contributing to lasting change.

Self-Reflection Tools

Landscape Analysis

Landscape analysis is one tool I've learned from executive coaching with Candice Rose Valenzuela,[9] a holistic coach and social justice educator. Landscape analysis repurposes the landscape analysis concept, typically used in competitive market research, community needs assessments, and geographical mapping research, into a creative and artistic modality that charts how various factors and dynamics interact in a particular situation. When completing a landscape analysis exercise, you draw the different factors that broadly impact a given situation as you understand them from your perspective as a leader. You can set a timer and create a visual representation of all the elements of your experience, either digitally or on paper. This landscape analysis drawing can involve the major and minor figures (people) involved in the situation, colors representing your emotions or thoughts, symbols, words—anything that comes to mind. This creative tool can be used to engage in self-care as a leader by naming, classifying, and arranging your thoughts, allowing you to process them effectively. This equips you with the ability to act when confronted with self-doubt or feelings of overwhelm. Landscape analysis provides a way to externalize and ground your experience, allowing you to think more clearly about what to do next.

Anchoring

Anchoring is another strategy that supports grounding and clarity. Anchoring is a mindfulness technique often used in K-12 settings to support students with self-regulation in the classroom environment. In a 2023 article, "A Daily Practice That Students Can Use for Self-Regulation," Lori Desautels writes about the importance of grounding for supporting students:

> Our brains and bodies are always reacting to our environments, relationships, and experiences. It's normal for our nervous system states to change throughout the hours, days, or weeks, but when we get stuck in nervous system states of anger, anxiety, or heavy sadness, our behaviors are often misunderstood. Underneath those behaviors, our students are moving into survival and protective states because they often do not feel emotionally safe and connected.
>
> Unless our students can find ways to ground themselves with feelings of safety and belonging, they cannot learn, focus, problem-solve, reason, or regulate their emotions. One way to help students tap into these positive feelings is to teach them about anchors, or practices that they can access during challenging times to feel more grounded.[10]

As inclusive leaders, we must recognize the social-emotional needs of others, as well as of ourselves. This mindfulness approach can support our reactions to stressors or uncertainty in both the workplace and our personal lives. These anchoring and grounding techniques are helpful for adults and leaders who are confronting their experiences of battling biases while activating their self-care toolkit.

Anchoring Techniques for Enhanced Self-Reflection

Here are some anchoring techniques, including micro-practices, that you can use to enact self-care as you move through leadership experiences:

- Breathing exercises can support regulating your parasympathetic nervous system (PNS), which supports active rest and recovery after stressful situations.
- Having a stone to hold or any other tactile item can support anchoring. I recommend using Pinterest to explore the various values of stones, allowing you to be intentional about the values you want to prioritize. I tend to use citrine for clarity and hematite for grounding.
- Taking the time out of our day to color in an adult coloring book. Coloring offers a low-stakes invitation to be imperfect and creative within a structured framework and can help reconnect us with our inner child.

When we are grounded, we are better equipped to show up fully and authentically as inclusive leaders. Also, when we are grounded, we are less likely to be judgmental, project, or perpetuate further harm against others or ourselves.

Here are some self-reflection prompts for anchoring while journaling:

Have I defined my 3 core values? How are my current actions in alignment or out of alignment with my values?
Reflecting on your values can help ensure that your actions are aligned with your authentic self, which, in turn, will help you feel more grounded and ready.

What am I feeling right now? What are my triggers?
Identifying and understanding your emotional state can help ground you in the present moment and increase your self-awareness, as well as how you may be impacting others. This practice helps you develop your empathic muscles.

What is the real challenge here? Can I think of how I have navigated similar situations in the past? What did I learn from those experiences that might be useful right now?
Reflecting on past successes can provide reassurance and clarity in handling current obstacles.

What do I need right now? How can I feel more balanced and supported? Who/what can aid me right now?
This question helps you focus on self-care and identify what is missing from your current routine or environment.

Team-based Tools

Acknowledging Positionality

Acknowledging positionality is a tool that can support authenticity and communication within teams. Earlier in this chapter, I provided my positionality statement. I acknowledged some of the ways I self-identify as well as the privileges that I experience. Even though I have several marginalized aspects of my identity, it is also important to acknowledge that privilege is relational; there are ways to acknowledge both/and regarding our identities. I've found that positionality statements are a valuable tool for community building on a team. Sharing these statements offers a glimpse into the complexity of each of our human experiences, while also being part of a larger team. We identify both visible and invisible influences on our lives to aid us in better understanding ourselves and one another.

Focusing on your plot reminds us of the importance of focusing on our locus of control as a team. The team and its leader may be unable to improve the biases at play or the culture of the larger library organization. Still, how can we intentionally direct our focus to what we can control, which is the energy and culture of our immediate team? Why would we waste time and effort on something that we cannot change?

Embodiment

Embodiment practices are important tools for self-reflection and team-based work. It is important to orient ourselves and reconnect with our bodies. Disembodiment and disconnection are common experiences within libraries. We tend to deny our bodies and focus on what we interpret or classify as purely cerebral pursuits. We cannot ignore our bodies, though, because we live in our bodies. I know this may sound obvious, but please follow me here, because we often deny what our bodies are communicating to us by sitting at our desks for inordinate amounts of time or by ignoring how we feel when we are overwhelmed with schedules, for example. Focusing solely on our mind or intellect does not serve us well, especially when it comes to addressing biases and practicing self-care. We need to be allowed to feel our feelings to be more inclusive leaders. We can't focus on the needs of others without first attending to our own individual needs.

Here are some suggestions for learning more about embodiment practices.[11]

Take mindfulness and meditation classes

Mindfulness practices help you become more aware of your body's sensations, emotions, and thoughts in the present moment. Many online platforms and local wellness centers offer classes focused on connecting the mind and body. Apps like Headspace or Insight Timer offer guided meditations that often focus on bodily awareness.

Explore somatic experiencing

Somatic experiencing is a therapeutic approach developed by Peter Levine that focuses on how the body responds to trauma and stress. By learning to tune into bodily sensations, you can

release stored tension and regulate emotions. Look for workshops, books, or certified practitioners who offer somatic therapy.

Practice yoga or qigong

Yoga and qigong emphasize mind-body awareness through movement and breathing. Both are rooted in ancient practices designed to increase bodily awareness, reduce stress, and foster a deeper connection with oneself. Consider joining classes or using online platforms like Yoga with Adriene and Yoga with Jessamyn Stanley.

Use body scanning techniques

Body scan meditations help you develop a deeper awareness of different parts of your body. This practice involves mentally scanning each part of your body from head to toe, noticing sensations without judgment. Many mindfulness programs include body scans as part of their routine, such as MBSR (mindfulness-based stress reduction) courses.

Read books on embodiment

Books that explore embodiment practices provide a solid theoretical foundation and practical exercises. Some recommendations include:

- *Radical Acceptance: Embracing Your Life with the Heart of a Buddha* by Tara Brach
- *Embodiment—Moving Beyond Mindfulness* by Mark Walsh

Join embodiment workshops or retreats

Many organizations offer retreats or workshops dedicated to embodiment practices. These can range from short courses to immersive retreats where participants focus on body awareness through movement, meditation, and other practices.

Study dance, movement, or somatic dance

Somatic dance and movement therapies are forms of expressive dance that encourage the exploration of body awareness and emotional expression through movement.

Explore breathwork practices

Breathwork is an embodied practice that involves conscious control of your breathing to promote physical, emotional, and spiritual healing.

Work with a body-oriented therapist

A body-oriented psychotherapist or somatic coach specializes in helping individuals connect with their bodies as part of the therapeutic process.

Exploring these practices, you can cultivate a stronger mind-body connection, enhance self-awareness, and integrate embodiment into your daily life.

Conclusion

Striving to be an inclusive leader is worthwhile *and* challenging. Reluctantly accepting challenges instead of embracing them, or better yet, attempting to enthusiastically engage with them, leaves us at a disadvantage. We're learning how to shift our mindset of the circumstances we experience. The truth is that we are unable to experience joy at work or reach our full leadership potential when we tacitly accept suboptimal circumstances. When we strive for more, we permit ourselves to receive more positive energy and interactions. We avail ourselves of the possibility of being fully embodied, contribute our best selves to our work, and motivate others to contribute meaningfully.

Regardless of your background, identity, or positionality, as leaders, we must recognize implicit and explicit biases that influence us. To lead inclusively, we must practice self-regulation and prioritize self-care. These practices allow us to bring our best selves and reach our full leadership potential. Confronting biases, especially internalized ones, requires tremendous self-awareness; we must become more comfortable with the discomfort of engaging with our learning edges to help others navigate *their* discomfort. Tools such as landscape analysis allow us to creatively distance ourselves from situations, engaging our right brain to process and respond thoughtfully to the situations at hand. This approach not only strengthens our capacity to lead, but also models intentional self-regulation for our teams, contributing to a healthier organizational culture—one that we enthusiastically want to be a part of along with others.

As inclusive leaders, we can apply techniques often used in classrooms that help students self-regulate and anchor ourselves in critical moments. By acknowledging positionality and focusing on what we can control, we reintroduce humanity into our workspaces. Compassion for our teams starts with showing compassion to ourselves. Importantly, throughout this journey, we must not overlook the significance of embodiment. Our bodies signal when we feel safe or threatened, and our biases can reinforce those triggers. By becoming attuned to these physical cues, we enhance our capacity to lead inclusively, maintain balance, and position ourselves for success. We can become more aware of our biases, cultivate the necessary conditions for achieving balance, and be our best, brilliant selves. We can unlock our maximum leadership potential beginning with leading ourselves from the inside out.

Notes

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CHAPTER 24

Case Study: **Reciprocal Mentoring**

Helping Peers to Become Better Leaders

Tatiana Usova

Introduction and Context

When inclusive leadership constitutes a core organizational value, the vital role of creating a culture where everyone feels welcomed and empowered falls on leaders. Even with many years of experience, leaders are still human beings with biases shaped by their background, upbringing, cultural environment, and experiences. These beliefs are deeply ingrained, and it is hard to recognize them as biases. Self-reflection, analysis of work incidents, and assessment tools, like the Implicit Association Test (IAT), can be used to identify these flawed assumptions and help to address them. Yet, it is not easy to recognize the errors of judgment in daily situations, as we are not aware of our subconscious biases. It helps when someone can point out the faults in our thinking and actions. Staff members may rarely bring their dissatisfaction to the attention of the leader for fear of retribution, even though they widely discuss it behind closed doors among themselves. Some leadership flaws could surface in a conversation with a supervisor; however, it is usually less painful and more effective to receive candid feedback from a close colleague than a top manager.

In this chapter, I present a case study of reciprocal mentorship developed between myself and my colleague, who is also the library director at a U.S. university's overseas branch. We both live in Doha, Qatar. Our respective universities are part of the Education City (EC), a unique ecosystem in the Middle East, which is a true mini representation of a global village. Twelve square kilometers of Doha land house eight universities, six of which are satellite campuses of leading US institutions: Virginia Commonwealth, Weill Cornell, Texas A&M, Carnegie Mellon, Georgetown, and Northwestern universities. Each of these establishments offers a four-year undergraduate residential education with a choice of four to six majors. The student body in each US university varies from 330 to 460 undergraduates representing more than forty nationalities. All universities house libraries whose staff mirror the diversity of the student population. Even a small team of five staff members often has people from four different nations on it. With such diversity in the student and staff body, inclusivity and equity are paramount to sustaining a positive work environment.

Continuous learning is a basic expectation for library leaders to stay competent and change-adept. There are very few opportunities in Qatar for professional development within

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the library field, especially for people in top management positions. Leadership programs are mainly business-oriented, and there is no established regional library association. Participation in online training programs run by US professional associations (ALA, ACRL, SLA, et al.) is hindered by a significant time difference. Apart from that, there are hardly any peers to discuss matters and sharpen ideas in the university structure, so the library leader's development quest remains a solitary journey. Thus, top managers are accustomed to working alone and relying on their judgment in decision-making.

Engaging in a reciprocal mentoring relationship was a natural way for me and my peer to shift this paradigm. As female expatriates (American and Belarusian-Canadian) coming from similar but different cultural backgrounds and each living abroad for more than ten years, we lead libraries of two US satellite universities specializing in fine arts and sciences. Both of us are faculty members and accomplished professionals, comfortable with change and disruptions, and genuinely interested in staff development and empowerment. Our reciprocal mentorship emerged organically. The relationship started based on a shared goal to conduct research and meet the scholarship expectation for faculty librarians. Knowing each other from previous EC business meetings, we decided to work together on a collaborative research project. In no time, our communication went beyond discussing the research topic and extended to the sharing of leadership concerns and stories. The side conversations were driven by the need to get a colleague's perspective on work situations, release emotional tension, and learn what was happening in another library. It is rewarding to discuss things with a person who is on the same page and knows how hard it is to be a leader. Dialoguing about our experiences as humans and professionals forged a better understanding of our respective social contexts and constituted an important part of reciprocal mentorship.

Definition of Reciprocal Mentoring

The concept of mentoring has been extensively studied and is well-covered in the literature. Research largely focuses on a traditional mentoring model where a senior and more experienced colleague "acts as a guide, role model, or sponsor" to a less experienced junior employee, and "the mentor is charged with transferring existing organizational knowledge to the protege."[1] Another model, reverse mentoring, is also implemented in organizations. In these cases, roles are reversed: "Established leaders are paired with early career mentors to challenge existing processes and learn technology ... adopting new skills and ways of thinking,"[2] and transferred knowledge often comes from outside the organization.

Traditional and reverse mentorship programs as instruments of advancing professional growth and development are commonplace, with top companies actively adopting them. These models are hierarchical: "The person being mentored is always in a position of not knowing, a position of lesser status,"[3] and one-sided when "the relationship is primarily of benefit to the mentee."[4] Mentors and mentees are often assigned to each other, which does not always result in a good match.

By contrast, a third type of mentoring, reciprocal, represents a mutually beneficial exchange where both members of the mentoring dyad contribute to the experience and each other's learning. It is often referred to as co-mentoring and collaborative mentoring in the literature.[5] Reciprocal mentoring relies on a consensual connection between people of similar occupational standing, not like others that match a new professional and an industry veteran. Paris offers a clear-cut definition: "Reciprocal Mentoring (RM) pairs two equal, though differently skilled, experts who act in the role of mentor and mentee to each other for their mutual benefit."[6] In such a dyad, "mentor and mentee roles become blurred and joint learning becomes the goal."[7] In comparison with other models, this mentoring is "experiential and mutual, relationship-based, more egalitarian and less hierarchical, inclusive, and, finally, ecological and life span-oriented."[8] The imperatives of rich reciprocal mentoring are "a willingness to be open and an ability to trust … coupled with the consistent discussions,"[9] a desire to learn from each other, and to try new ways of thinking and working.

RM is not a new concept; it is widespread in higher education but often in informal and unrecognized ways.[10] Despite the abundance of articles on mentoring within the library profession, there is not much information on non-hierarchical models. However, the body of literature related to new kinds of mentoring, such as peer mentoring, mentoring circles, and mentoring networks, is growing.[11] Collective intelligence is more powerful than individual thinking, and reciprocal mentoring provides a platform for meaningful learning for leaders. Both parties act in the capacity of a mentor as well as a mentee, and both participants genuinely want to learn from the other.

Overview of the Mentoring Journey

In our case, an informal mentorship naturally occurred between my peer and me, two library professionals of equivalent status. The choice of a partner for a mentoring relationship was intuitive; I turned to a trusted colleague for advice and found it valuable. Furthermore, our approaches to work aligned. We are two library directors who feel a personal responsibility to be the best leaders we can, the ones who accomplish goals and make sure that the people we supervise feel they are treated fairly, heard, appreciated, and included. The fact that we knew each other's line of work was important. Connecting with a peer beyond organizational boundaries was beneficial as it provided fresh perspectives and bypassed the challenges of internal politics. Lack of time, a problem experienced by many mentoring partners, was not an issue since we already had a set schedule of regular meetings to conduct a research project. Our scientific collaboration had a social element, as the desire to communicate outside of the context of our research was mutual. Sometimes it was a quick question and sometimes it was a request for help or a need to let off emotional steam. The collaboration lasted for a year and a half and had a blended nature: in addition to meeting bi-weekly to discuss our research, in parallel, we engaged in reciprocal mentoring. While the priority was to work on the research, we carved out enough time in our conversations to discuss

workplace challenges, especially when we had face-to-face meetings and, to a lesser extent, when we connected via Zoom.

Work issues sometimes are too complex for only one person to tackle. Unconscious bias can easily distort the judgment of an individual in isolation. Even with decades of experience, we both still had a lot to learn from each other. Having a trusted colleague to talk to, ask for an opinion, discuss concerns, and brainstorm ideas helped to build a greater understanding of ourselves as leaders and the things that we need to change. We organically identified our shared interests and goals. Topics that we discussed during meetings were related to staff management and empowerment, cultural knowledge and awareness, cultivating relationships with teaching faculty and university leaders, library facilities improvements, conferences, and individual scholarship. We talked about situations where we felt pressure and were not sure how to proceed, checked on the biases, shared field experiences, and conferred on how to better manage relationships and navigate the power dynamics of the institution, given the complexity of our environment. In our interactions, we interchangeably took the role of a friend, counselor, coach, advisor, resource provider, sounding board, cheerleader, and role model,[12] embodying inclusive leadership behavior.

There was no obligation to have mentoring conversations every time we met. The advantage of having regularly set meetings for the research project was that at the end we could always bring up work-life challenges and receive support, guidance, and advice exactly when we needed them. Our relationship was in sync with what Luna and Cullen wrote, "Mentoring is best used for specific purposes and goals and with faculty who volunteer to participate."[13]

In fact, we did not establish collaborative norms as is done in a traditional mentoring model, but we explicitly agreed to maintain confidentiality and mutual respect critical to sustaining trust. Desai et al. stated that mentoring is relationship-oriented, and its success depends on the "mutual interest and engagement of the participants, mutual trust and respect, willingness to engage in a discussion," and commitment to rise above cultural differences.[14] All these elements were present in our interactions. We conversed as equals, and both were intent on being honest with each other. Within our mentoring dyad, we created a safe space where we put aside fears, candidly spoke about challenging work situations, and offered critical insights in a collegial manner. To be open to other perspectives requires humility and empathic listening. Our conversations were powerful because we were transparent with each other and did not feel vulnerable sharing our thoughts, as often happens in a formal context.

Lessons Learned

There was no formal evaluation conducted on the impact and effectiveness of our mentoring relationship since it was informal. However, from my personal reflection, it is evident that our collaborative learning relationship benefited both of us. Through interactions, we nurtured perspectives not visible to the self alone, cultivated a more flexible mindset, and elevated decision-making. The major benefits of mentoring were competence enhancement critical to the

job, confidence boost in personal abilities, and a trusting relationship that would carry into the future. The experience helped us strengthen six signature traits of an inclusive leader: curiosity, cultural intelligence, collaboration, commitment, courage, and cognizance of bias,[15]which are of utmost importance when working with a diverse workforce.

Our dialogue was a powerful tool for mutual growth and for shifting thinking forward. In a mentorship dyad, we shared complementary knowledge, validated and reexamined our experiences, engaged in reflective analysis, and reassessed professional practice. Finding out what's happening in another library and hearing how colleagues tackle difficulties offered exposure to new ideas that would not resurface otherwise. Discussions of strategies to advocate for increased library resources and to deal with employees' performance issues revealed our differing viewpoints. Peer feedback and differences in perspectives helped us to illuminate some blind spots and biased thinking patterns as well as reframe our approaches. The experience also forced us to be more organized and efficient. Reciprocal mentoring does have a price: patience and time. Therefore, it was necessary to prepare for meetings, reflect, improve clarity of thinking, and prioritize what to bring up for discussion, since the time to interact was limited. At meetings, it was also important to stay engaged in the conversation, build upon the thinking of the mentoring partner, co-generate solutions, and consider their impact on the supervised teams.

While mentioning professional growth, we cannot discard moral support. Reciprocal mentoring promotes confidence and emotional resilience. The mentor provides "support at the personal, relational, and/or professional levels and that support may be cognitive or informational ... and/or social, emotional, political support."[16] Our trusting and genuine relationship built a psychological bond and a better understanding of each other's personal values, struggles, and aspirations. Friendly communication and encouragement alleviated stress associated with work, rejuvenated energy, significantly boosted confidence, and dispelled the sense of isolation. We are better people and professionals thanks to this relationship.

Reflecting on what could be done differently next time, the mentoring relationship could be further improved by establishing specific conversational goals and discussion topics. Even though the relationship formed naturally and was informal, acknowledging co-mentoring roles and discussing participants' needs and growth objectives can be considered to make the interactions more intentional. The commitment was there, but it would help to have a better structure and clarity of goals each hoped to achieve as well as expectations in a conversation. Taking the time to establish a mutually set purpose and agreed-upon topics for discussion, with room for change in the process, could improve the outcome of interactions.

Final Takeaways

In the ever-changing world, leaders have a responsibility for continuous learning. Decisions need to be made fast, and leaders often become self-reliant and dependent on their prior knowledge and expertise when looking for answers. It is tricky since relying on past knowledge

in a dynamic landscape elevates the risk of erroneous judgment. Also, many managers have not had a chance to gain the experience needed for effective decision-making in a multicultural and diverse organizational context.

When professionals reach the peak of their careers, there are fewer opportunities to learn and to find formal mentors. Considering the solitary nature of the journey, the reciprocal mentoring model can be an excellent way for established leaders to address professional growth and refine decision-making with a focus on creating an inclusive workplace. Along with mutually beneficial knowledge exchange, RM offers peer support, reframes thinking, and reinforces inclusive practice; it allows leaders to leave a solo track of self-reflection and tap into collective intelligence.

Apart from professional growth, this model also nurtures leaders' well-being. Caring for each other, validating one's feelings and thoughts, and "making each other feel worthwhile are important vehicles"[17] of emotional health and psychological resilience, so it is preferable to opt for informal mentoring rather than make the process "too formal." Besides, at the top position, there are not many choices for formal mentoring.

When choosing a mentor, interest is not sufficient for the relationship to be successful. It is important to choose a partner who can bring something to the table—a manager who has enough experience to provide developmental assistance. Factors to consider for matching could be relevant background, comparable experience and similar career level, geographic proximity or ease of communication, and a willingness to engage in the co-mentoring relationship.

RM helps to avoid the pitfall of mentor-mentee mismatches occurring in traditional mentorship models. It facilitates the pairing with people who are compatible and open to taking risks together so that the interaction becomes "more relational, rather than transactional."[18]

Mentoring connections can be made between friends and institutional colleagues. However, as proved by our experience, there are certain benefits of reaching out to peers outside of organizational boundaries, so that the relationship is not marked by power and knowledge imbalance. The co-mentoring could be even more beneficial if it is cross-generational, cross-gender, and/or between individuals of different racial or cultural backgrounds, as there is a better chance to get diverse perspectives, even if it adds an extra layer of complexity. The interactions may occur either face-to-face or online, which opens up possibilities for engaging in RM with international colleagues.

Challenges may arise in identifying a suitable mentor. The onus is usually on the interested person to take an intentional approach in identifying a peer for RM and reaching out to that individual. Attending networking lunches and receptions, serving on professional association committees, taking leadership training, or, as in our case, finding a common project to collaborate on could be a good way to create connections with colleagues and find a potential mentor. Mentoring thrives on trust, respect, and candor. Sharing experiences is a good way to start building that special bond that turns the relationship into a source of learning and social support.

High-performing managers are an asset to the organization. It is inevitable for top leaders to experience loneliness, fatigue, cultural misunderstanding, and administrative tensions.

Reciprocal mentoring could be a great way to address these challenges. RM promotes professional growth and offers many other advantages, including "reduction in feelings of isolation, greater connectivity, increased confidence and commitment, career progression, knowledge acquisition, and better understanding of the culture."[19]

RM empowers mentoring peers with knowledge essential to navigate the complex landscape of diversity and inclusivity as well as with important skills, whether it is the development of political agility, assistance with "damage control," or support for key professional positions. Such a relationship fosters an open dialogue where candid discussions contribute to the acknowledgment and respect of diverse perspectives. The learning in RM is mutual: it is rewarding to contribute to the eventual growth of another professional, but it is also a great opportunity to hear different viewpoints, reflect on professional activities, and build an understanding of what needs to change. Having lived through the experience, I can affirm that reciprocal mentorship provides the capacity to improve professional practice, lower personal biases, deepen cultural understanding, enhance inclusive leadership practice, and, consequently, benefit the institution and contribute to the betterment of the world.

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CHAPTER 25

Case Study: **Lessons from Liberal Arts Libraries**

Courtney L. Young and Martin L. Garnar

Introduction

In this case study, we reflect on our experiences as the chief administrators of libraries at two highly selective liberal arts colleges and how we are using inclusive leadership practices to begin the process of changing the cultures at our respective institutions. Using our different lenses of positionality (straight cis Black woman and gay cis White man), we will explore where our approaches to communication, governance, and inclusion both align and differ; how the similarities and differences of our institutions inform our work; what challenges we faced at the start of our leadership journeys; the successes we've had in using inclusive leadership practices; and what opportunities we still have for improvement. Examples that will be discussed and examined include setting expectations around communication and values, creating a culture of shared governance, and modeling authentic leadership through transparency and reflection.

Martin Garnar:

Courtney, I'm so excited for us to share notes on inclusive leadership. I know we've both been thinking about culture change at our libraries, and I'm looking forward to hearing about and learning from your experiences. Before we dive in, I think it would be helpful if we share some information about our institutions so that our readers have some context for our conversation. I'll start.

Amherst College was founded in 1821. It is located in Amherst, Massachusetts, a small college town in the western half of the state. We are considered highly selective and are classified as a baccalaureate college (arts and science focus).[1] In fall 2023, we enrolled 1,898 students from all fifty states, plus students from Washington, DC, Puerto Rico, and seventy countries.[2] Our student body is almost evenly split between women and men (52 percent to 48 percent), and 97 percent of our students live on campus. International students make up 11 percent of our student body, and 48 percent of our domestic students self-identify as students of color. We do not offer any graduate programs, preferring to stay focused on the undergraduate experience. Amherst is part of the Five College Consortium (the other colleges are Hampshire, Mount Holyoke, Smith, and the University of Massachusetts Amherst), which allows students from all schools to take classes at the other campuses, and we have a single shared library services platform (FOLIO), so there's a lot of cooperation between library staff.

Tell me about your institution!

CC BY NC ND

Courtney Young:

Martin, it's a pleasure to have this conversation with you. It's hard to believe we've known each other for fifteen years! During that time, we've changed institutions, roles, and professional focus. I'm honored to be in the position to explore this topic with you.

Changes in administrative leadership, the development of new university strategic plans, and—I'll be the first one to mention it—the COVID-19 pandemic all made significant impacts on our library's culture.

Colgate University was founded in 1819. It is located in the village of Hamilton, New York, in the central part of the state. It is a vibrant liberal arts university of 3,200 students. The university is known for its intellectual rigor, world-class professors, campus of stunning beauty, and alumni famously loyal to their alma mater.[3] In 2023, we enrolled 807 students from all fifty states, including 221 international students. Our total student body is a bit more female than male (56 percent female, 44 percent male), with 13 percent first-generation students. International students make up 13 percent of our student body, and 25 percent of our domestic students self-identify as students of color.[4] We offer one small graduate program, a master of arts in teaching, through the Department of Educational Studies. Overall, Colgate's priority is focused on the undergraduate experience in a residential campus setting as well.

Now that we've introduced our institutions, let's focus on our libraries, as that's where our stories get interesting.

Garnar:

Interesting is one way to describe starting a job across the country in the middle of a pandemic! My husband and I moved to Massachusetts in July 2020. When I started my job the following month, I was working from home most of the time, with an occasional Saturday in the library to support the student workers. As a result, I didn't meet most of my staff in person until the following summer, when people began to return to the office. This made it complicated to build a sense of community, which was one of my initial charges. My predecessor's leadership style did not mesh well with the staff, and I was brought in to help rebuild the library culture. Though the library's leadership team had done some excellent work with a consultant prior to the pandemic, there was still a lot of healing to do, and the trauma of the pandemic itself has complicated our recovery process.

Meanwhile, though the college has the most racially diverse student body of all the places I've ever worked, the library staff is the most homogenous by the same measure. This isn't unusual for western Massachusetts, but it is still something we are striving to change, as we think it's important to more closely reflect the community we serve. On the other hand, compared to my previous libraries, the Amherst library has a higher percentage of LGBTQ+ staff than any place at which I've worked, including on the leadership team. While that might not be surprising since my former workplaces consist of a Catholic institution and a public university in a very conservative town, our part of Massachusetts is known for being welcoming to the

LGBTQ+ community, so it's been an adjustment to feel like I'm not as isolated at work as I used to be.

Courtney, tell me more about your library.

Young:

I began at Colgate in the summer of 2018, which coincided with the year-long celebration of the university's bicentennial (1819–2019). The opportunity for the university to look back and consider its next 200 years was also an opportunity for the University Libraries to do the same. The University Archives contributed a significant amount of work and resources toward supporting the celebration. This indicated to me not only the importance of this department in this process but also the University Libraries as a whole's potential to remain central to Colgate's future.

The Colgate University Libraries include Case Library and Cooley Library. Cooley is known as the science library but is used as a study and meeting space by many students whose dorms are closer to its location on campus. Case is the large library building that helps to connect what is known as the upper part of the campus to the middle and lower campus. Case Library is 151,000 square feet over five levels. The Geyer Center for Information Technology is also housed in the building; it also houses operations for Information Technology Services, including the help desk.

The University Libraries, which are part of the provost and dean of the faculty division, went through an external review resulting in a report in 2015. This report provided a number of recommendations for the organization to consider and undertake. As I came in as a new library director, this provided me with a significant data point to start from in getting to know the organization. In addition to familiarizing myself with the three-year-old report, I did a listening tour with all library faculty and staff. These thirty-minute meetings were designed to find out what library staff felt were the best things about working there and if they were in my position what they would do first. These informal conversations provided me with an opportunity to gain some institutional knowledge and hopefully signal that my office, which is often associated with the role itself, is a welcome space for all.

One thing I quickly discovered was that there was a culture of decisions needing the blessing of the provost. In some cases, this was not accurate, but many faculty and staff were steadfast in their belief that any changes to library policies or service models would need the stamp of approval by the very busy provost. This signaled to me that inclusive leadership was historically limited and the opportunity to empower the staff might represent an unexpected cultural shift.

Most of my staff identify as white. When I arrived, only one other librarian and two staff members were people of color. Today, there is one staff member and two librarians, including myself, who identify as people of color. This is an interesting position for me to be in, but likely not an unusual one for any librarian of color not at an HBCU or HSI. This means that our library staffing does not match the limited racial diversity of our student body.

Garnar:

Not surprisingly, there are a lot of issues to navigate in our institutions' governance cultures. I knew that I had been asked to come to Amherst because of my commitment to collaborative leadership, so one of my early goals was to see how my style worked with the leadership team's approach to governance. I want to acknowledge that the interim director and leadership team did a lot of work in this area in the year before I arrived, as they were responsible for shifting the department heads from an advisory council to a true leadership team, so they laid a good foundation. We spent the first year just surviving the pandemic and didn't spend a lot of time thinking about how we made decisions—we just did what we needed to do to keep the lights on. However, when it was time to begin filling vacancies that developed during the pandemic (one quarter of the staff either retired or left), we knew it was time to develop procedures for making decisions.

Like my previous library, Amherst didn't have a lot of written documentation regarding library policies and procedures but instead had depended on insider knowledge of what the rules were. Since we were changing the library's governance model to be more inclusive, this was a great opportunity to start from the beginning and build our process using a set of shared principles. At the top of the document, we listed the four levels of agreement, with the top level being the aspirational goal and working down through the other options as needed:

- Ideal: universal agreement
- Better: unanimous consent
- OK: majority consensus with some dissent
- No consensus: the director decides

We also had a series of conversations about how to involve the rest of the library in decision-making. Recognizing that the library is not a democracy, we still wanted to make it clear that all library staff would have input on decisions, so it was a matter of detailing when and how staff would be consulted as part of the process. The decision-making document included all the steps so that staff would know when they would be involved.

Though the initial process always included a consultation with the library's diversity, equity, and inclusion (DEI) committee, we soon realized that there were other constituencies that needed opportunities for input. That's when I proposed that we create a leadership council that included all members of the leadership team, plus the business manager, all chairs of committees and groups, and a representative from the non-exempt staff. This body would be the main facilitator of policy development and review, and the structure allowed for an easy way to consult with all possible interested parties in one fell swoop.

The first few months of the council were a bit rocky as we found our collective footing. Folks who weren't on the leadership team had to figure out what felt comfortable when it came to speaking up in front of their supervisors and the director, and we also had to overcome the

ingrained reluctance to speak up and contribute to discussions that was a product of my predecessor's leadership style. We've had to adjust some timings of the document review process to reflect the cadence of meetings so that there's adequate time for reflection and input between the monthly council meetings and the monthly all-staff meetings, but we recognize that this is a work in progress and that it's OK to make changes. Now that the council has been around for almost two years, I'm really happy to say that it's working just as I imagined: we get timely feedback from committees and groups, we have robust conversations about the topics of the day, and more people are involved in the actual work of governing the library. In fact, once you add up all the representatives (normally around twenty), about half of the library is on the leadership council. It sounds like it could be unwieldy, but it has been working for a library of our size.

Courtney, what does shared governance look like at Colgate?

Young:

It is safe to say that this is a work in progress, given the complex nature of our job classifications. The University Libraries employs library faculty (eleven, including myself), staff who are members of the bargaining unit (eighteen), exempt staff (one), non-exempt staff (one), and hourly wage staff (five).

My listening tour, which I mentioned earlier, gave me a glimpse into how our organization is staffed and the impact it has on the types of work we do. Library faculty and staff are all asked to serve on job searches to fill vacancies for library faculty, bargaining unit, and exempt staff committees.

Library faculty do a good portion of their governance work through monthly library faculty meetings. I discussed the possibility of these meetings being chaired by a librarian other than myself. After some discussion, we decided that I would continue as the convener.

All staff meetings generally take place on a monthly basis. Again, I serve as the convener but have experimented with involving more members of the faculty and staff on the agenda. Turning these meetings into conversations has proven to be difficult. One of my department heads had the idea to establish more standing committees and use these meetings as a place to share progress and gather feedback. Several committees and working groups were created with charges, and librarians and staff were invited to serve. Some chairs and/or committee members provided updates at these meetings, but other groups have not been sharing updates. We paused these groups after a year to determine which should continue in their current form, which should have revised charges and possibly membership, and which should be eliminated.

We also added to the staff meeting agendas the names of library faculty and staff who serve on other committees across the university and asked if anyone wanted to provide updates from those groups. The intent was to highlight that we are involved in work more broadly across the institution and highlight that these opportunities exist.

Garnar:

I think sometimes we just have to try different approaches to see what will work, knowing that we have to be willing to fail in order to find the right path forward.

Let's switch gears and talk about how we set expectations around communication and values. Want to go first?

Young:

Sure! Since the existing strategic plan ran through 2019, I started a new process in response to staff concerns about beginning 2020 without a plan. Modeled after my experience with strategic planning at the American Library Association for 2010 and 2015, I set up a library-wide retreat where we would focus solely on our next strategic plan.

Four faculty and staff breakout groups began the strategic planning process. To begin their work, the following questions were provided ahead of and at the meeting:

- How is your work connected to the pursuit of the Colgate libraries' mission?
- What gaps might there be between what we are doing now and the achievement of our mission?
- What opportunities does the University Libraries have to support Colgate's Third Century Plan? (Copies of the University Libraries' mission and Colgate's Third Century Plan[5] were made available.)

As a group, we all looked at the responses generated by the four groups during the first session and were asked to think about what they thought needed strong consideration for inclusion into the next strategic directions and what did not likely rise to the level of strong consideration for the plan. Following the faculty and staff retreat, department heads were asked to meet with their teams to further discuss the documentation that was generated at the all-staff planning session.

A draft of the developed Strategic Directions was presented at an All Staff meeting in November 2019, and the feedback received during that meeting and via email was considered and incorporated as appropriate into a revised draft presented at the January 2020 All Staff meeting. The final draft was forwarded to the provost and dean of the faculty and an associate dean in April 2020.

The strategic directions are: diversity, equity, and inclusion; expertise and services; inspired spaces; and resources for scholarship. These strategic directions were developed for the next three to five years. There was no opportunity to operationalize these due to the COVID-19 pandemic. It is very likely that we will do another planning process in the near future.

Garnar:

Strategic planning seems to be a constant demand for library leaders, and if I can share some information about our own process, it will provide some good context for how we think about both communication and values. When I came to Amherst, the provost told me that she wanted me to work on a strategic plan within the first year. Though we started the process with the help of a consultant, it wasn't going as well as I had hoped. I realized we needed to stop and think about the foundations of who we are and what we believe before we could talk about our hopes for the future. This meant updating our mission statement and adding both a values statement and a vision statement, starting with the values statement since we thought it was important for us to all be on the same page about the values we bring to our work. Through a collaborative, collective process that lasted a few months, we developed a statement with six main areas: communication and transparency; diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility; integrity and compassion; collaboration and creativity; stewardship and sustainability; and workplace well-being. To make sure that the values statement was not just words on our website, we have used it as the basis for a series of framing questions for when we are reviewing policies or considering adding a new committee. For example, one of the questions under the workplace well-being section of the committee framework is "How will the proposed committee or group impact library workload?" Groups using the framing questions have found them to be very helpful in preparing their proposals, and it does feel like we've found a way to keep our values front and center in our daily work.

As noted above, one of the six categories of values is communication and transparency. I've adopted a few practices to model these values. First, I send a daily email to the whole staff. It started during the pandemic and was a way for me to share both work-related information and personal tidbits so that folks could start to get to know me, especially since I was working from home for most of my first year. A few months in, I added a tagging system to all of my library-wide emails so that staff could prioritize what to read. In addition to the [Daily Martin] tag (a tongue-in-cheek nod to the college's Daily Mammoth newsletter, there's also [FYI], [Please read], [Action needed], and [URGENT]. Two years into this practice, at the request of some staff looking for a digest of news, I changed the Monday edition of the [Daily Martin] to the [Weekly Martin], which uses a standard template to highlight the important discussions from the previous week's leadership meeting and a review of upcoming events and meetings that week.

One of the most popular things I started doing was sharing my notes from my meetings with leadership groups outside of the library, including the department heads within the provost's division, the faculty library committee, and the college leadership council. As there has been a consistent concern about the lack of information coming from the upper administration that predates me, this practice has helped mitigate that concern, and we also have a new(ish) president who started doing the same thing with notes from senior leadership and trustee meetings. I know he didn't get the idea from me, but it certainly feels like validation of my practices.

Let's switch gears and move to our final topic, which is modeling authentic leadership through transparency and reflection. What are some ways you try to do that?

Young:

For me, this has been showing vulnerability as a leader. Being a library director during COVID-19 was challenging. I received no preparation in this role for this pandemic pivot. At the same time, we were all captive audiences to the many atrocities happening to African American men and women at the hands of police and citizens acting above the law. During one of our periodic Zoom staff meetings in June 2020, I took a point of personal privilege and addressed the staff. I recall speaking not only about how the university would begin giving us Juneteenth off, but how the deaths of so many Black people was as hard for me as existing in this pandemic moment. I was honest about how I worry not just for myself but also for my father, my brother, and my nephews. I think I ended with the hope that everyone, along with their friends and family, stay safe, not only from disease but also from the painful realities of racism in America.

My other vulnerable moment was about a year after we returned to campus. We had a number of staffing changes take place, including those in department head roles. At our first department heads meeting, I took a moment to acknowledge that things had been difficult as they supported the work of their teams, but I really appreciated all they did to move us forward. I also indicated that, just like them, I did not always know what to do during this time. From then on, we needed to move forward together and support each other. All of us are important to the mission of the university, and together we can make a real difference.

I learned through this that showing vulnerability as a leader begins and ends with purposeful, active communication.

Garnar:

I feel like my communication practices do a lot to demonstrate my commitment to transparency, such as the meeting notes and regular office hours I discussed earlier. I also take great care to share as much information as I can about any given situation and make it clear that I'll share what I can when I can, while also acknowledging that sometimes I have to sit on information until it's ready for wider distribution. As for reflection, I do my best to model authenticity and vulnerability, whether it's through musings in one of my "Daily Martin" emails about a problem I'm facing, being open about my fears and concerns about a situation we're facing (without causing a panic) at staff meetings and acknowledging when I don't have the answers and need my staff's help to figure things out. I've also shared some information about my own mental health journey so that folks know it's OK to talk about their struggles at work and to let them know I'm a human being just like them. My goal is to be the kind of leader who lifts up my colleagues, helps them find meaning in their work, and lets them know that I care about them as people.

Courtney, what are the key takeaways for our readers?

Young:

Communication is always the major challenge for any library/organization. It is the thing we must stay attentive to and, whenever possible, be forgiving around. It can be a challenge, especially for those in leadership roles, to intuit if communication is 1) working and 2) sufficient. If you are not sure that something has been heard and understood, follow up and gain the certainty you need. I have found that information needs to be made available in different formats in order to get most people to hear and understand it. This can feel like you're overcommunicating, but it can help you determine another strategy if someone still feels out of the loop.

The library director needs information as well. Communication is a two-way street, and the library staff need to share information with the director. It allows the director to be the strongest advocate possible for the library. As directors, we also need to ask for what we need. Teamwork is an inclusive term.

Throughout my career, I have championed the importance of training and professional development. During the pandemic, it became obvious to me that the ways in which our librarians and staff do their work are a lot more complicated than what is written in what is often a dated job description. The basic technology skills needed to attend meetings remotely through any application, an understanding of that software, and the network to do this were just a few of the barriers my librarians and staff faced. Some of my staff lived in rural areas where high-speed internet access wasn't available. In turn, this meant they had little more than a smartphone as a primary piece of technology in their homes. For librarians and staff whose work allowed them to provide resources or services from a remote location (reference, ILL, and course reserves), they spent a lot of time learning how to use and share online resources. This helped many support the work of students and faculty who were attempting to complete classes from home. Especially in these moments, the need for training, practice, and sharing that information was essential. It should not be abandoned now that we are back in our libraries with easier access to our collections.

Garnar:

Those are great points. I completely agree that communication is the number one challenge for any organization, and I'll just add that there will never be a single solution that meets everyone's communications preferences, so my solution has been to try a mix of approaches, depending on the situation, and select the ones that seem to work the best based on feedback and my own sense of how well the message is being understood. Another big takeaway I want to note is that while culture is hard to change and can't be changed alone, it will never change if the leader doesn't want it to. If we want to see a change in our library culture, we have to be committed to it, so don't give up! Finally, I'll say that being true to yourself is the most

important thing a leader can do. If we want people to feel like they can bring their whole selves to work, then modeling that kind of authenticity starts with us.

Courtney, thanks for this opportunity to learn from and reflect with you. Always a pleasure!

Young:

Likewise! Thank you, Martin.

Notes

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Thomas L. Dickens serves as the assistant dean Organizational Development and Culture for The Ohio State University Libraries. He holds a bachelor of science degree from Elmhurst College and a master of arts in higher education and student affairs from the University of Connecticut. In his current role, Dickens leads transformative efforts to foster a welcoming, supportive workplace and a vibrant organizational culture that enables employees to thrive. Reporting to the vice provost and dean of University Libraries, Dickens supports the university's shared values by collaborating with internal and university-wide stakeholders to recruit, retain, and develop a talented workforce advancing research, teaching, and learning. As a senior leader, he contributes to organizational strategy, resource allocation, and decision-making while spearheading programs, dialogues, and trainings that strengthen workplace culture. Focusing on sustained cultural transformation, this position ensures a cohesive approach to enhancing employee well-being and delivering an exceptional service experience to library users.

Gricel Dominguez is the chair of Information & Research Services at the Florida International University Hubert's Library in North Miami for nearly a decade. Her interests include slow librarianship, holistic leadership practices, and ways to encourage library ease among students.

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Jen Froetschel is the metadata services librarian at the George Washington University, as well as an instructor for the Fundamentals of Cataloging course offered by the CORE Division of ALA. Prior to joining GWU, she worked in a variety of different libraries and non-library settings. Her favorite MARC field is the 655.

Christina Fuller-Gregory is a librarian, writer, and equity-centered facilitator and practitioner. She was a 2017 American Library Association Emerging Leader and currently acts as program facilitator for the Emerging Leaders program. Christina has also acted as a committee member and chair of numerous library committees, including the ALA Committee on Diversity and the Public Library Association's EDISJ Committee, to name a few. In 2021, she was recognized for her work in the equity space by *Library Journal* when she was named a Mover & Shaker. She is a highly sought-after speaker and consultant, and her writing has been featured in publications including *PLA Magazine*, *Voya Magazine*, and *Library Journal*. Led by Fannie Lou Hamer's belief that "Nobody's free until everybody's free," Christina's research and writing are driven by a desire to see libraries develop strategies for weaving equity, diversity, and inclusion into the very fabric of their organizations.

Martin L. Garnar is the director of the Amherst College Library. His professional activities and speaking schedule reflect a profound inability to say no. A native New Yorker, Martin lives in western Massachusetts with his husband Mark and their impossibly cute miniature dachshunds.

Dr. Jolie O. Graybill is currently dean of libraries at North Dakota State University. Jolie's academic library career spans nearly twenty years and includes experience at three other academic libraries. Prior to joining NDSU, Jolie served as assistant director with the University of Minnesota Libraries, Minitex, where she was responsible for the Digital Initiatives & Metadata Education unit and the Minnesota Digital Library. While at the University of Nebraska-Lincoln Libraries, Jolie served in two different librarian positions, initially as multicultural services librarian, and then as image and multimedia collections coordinator. At Northern Arizona University's Cline Library, Jolie was an academic programs librarian and team leader for the Social & Behavioral Sciences team. Prior to academic libraries, Jolie worked in higher education as a cooperative extension educator at the University of Minnesota and as an extension educator at the University of Arizona.

Dawn M. Harris serves as the collection development coordinator at Texas A&M University-Central Texas, where she oversees collection development, acquisitions, and interlibrary loan. Prior to serving at A&M-Central Texas, she was the assistant director of Library Services at Killeen Public Library in Killeen, Texas. She holds a master of science in information studies

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Michelle Hendley is currently head of Collection Development, Resource Management and Sharing at James M. Milne Library, State University of New York at Oneonta. Additionally, she serves as the liaison to the departments of Political Science and Anthropology. Prior to becoming department head, Michelle served as a reference and instruction librarian for twenty years and was the instruction coordinator for thirteen years. As well as being a practicing librarian, Michelle has published articles on a range of topics, including the limitations of relying exclusively on circulation data to weed books, faculty study spaces, and undergraduate student citation behavior.

Ken Irwin (he/him) is a web services librarian at Miami University, the former co-chair of the Libraries' Commitment to Inclusive Excellence, and is a former co-chair of the libraries' DEI Committee. He serves on the ACRL Equity, Diversity, and Inclusion Committee and the ACRL Committee on Professional Values. He is committed to furthering the libraries' diversity, equity, inclusion, and accessibility goals. In his web-librarian hat, he is interested in developing open-source solutions to solve challenging library issues and to make the most of our resources.

Lorin Jackson, MA, MI (she/they), serves as the assistant director of the Holman Biotech Commons at the University of Pennsylvania and as an adjunct professor at Syracuse University's iSchool. Lorin has spent the past fifteen years championing inclusivity and diversity in educational, nonprofit, and library environments, with a particular focus on supporting individuals from underrepresented backgrounds. As a published author, Lorin's work highlights topics such as critical librarianship, trauma-informed practices, equitable access to library services, and cultivating compassionate leadership. In recognition of their contributions to the field, Lorin was among recipients of the Medical Library Association's President's Award in 2024 for her contributions to the Be Well Initiative.

Boutsaba Janetvilay is a tenured faculty librarian and the lead of the Metadata and Resource Description unit at Fresno State, where she also serves as a proud faculty advisor for the Lao Student Association. She also teaches Information Literacy online at Santa Rosa Junior College. As a dedicated community advocate, she serves on the boards of Wat Lao Saysettha in Santa Rosa and the Laotian American Community of Fresno. She plays a key role in organizing events that center on education, cultural preservation, scholarship fundraising, and community empowerment. Recently, she was honored by the City of Fresno for her contributions to the AAPI community and has secured a Fresno Art and Culture grant for the Laotian American Community of Fresno.

Dr. Aisha M. Johnson, associate dean for Academic Affairs and Outreach at Georgia Institute of Technology Library. An influential leader in both scholarship and practice, she champions access, inclusivity, and strategic leadership. Her mission is to advance the field by cultivating new and experienced professionals as scholar-practitioners and leaders who advocate for the underserved. Dr. Johnson authored *The African American Struggle for Library Equality* and has published extensively on representation and inclusion in library and information science (LIS). With contributions rooted in impact, she was dubbed the 2020 Distinguished Alumni of Florida State University's College of Communication and Information, iSchool for her research and scholarship. Subsequently, in 2021, the Association for the Study of African American Life and History recognized her work and impact with the Freedom Scholar Award. Most recently, she was recognized in the 2024 class of *Library Journal*'s Movers and Shakers.

Jermal Alleyne Jones is the associate director, EDIA Library at the University of Waterloo and co-founder of Next Gen Men (NGM), a team of staff and volunteers empowering boys (and men) to change the way they see, think, and act about masculinity. He is also a third-year PhD student in the Recreation and Leisure Aging, Health, and Wellbeing program. He studies the intersections between race (Black), ethnicity, gender (men), and ag(e)ing from an interdisciplinary lens.

Dr. Shannon D. Jones (she/her) is the director of libraries and chair of the Academic Affairs Faculty at the Medical University of South Carolina (MUSC) Libraries. She also serves as director of Region 2 of the Network of the National Library of Medicine. A leader in the Medical Library Association (MLA), Shannon was the 2022–2023 MLA president, during which she launched the Be Well MLA initiative to support member wellness. She co-founded the MLA Reads Book Club in 2018 to foster conversations on diversity, equity, and inclusion. Shannon is the co-editor of *Diversity and Inclusion in Libraries: A Call to Action and Strategies for Success and Cultural Humility in Libraries: A Call to Action and Strategies for Success*. She holds an EdD in educational leadership from Charleston Southern University, an MEd in adult learning from Virginia Commonwealth University, and an MLS from North Carolina Central University.

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Elizabeth Kerr (she/her) is the assistant dean of Professional and Continuing Education at the University of Cincinnati, where she is dedicated to broadening access to higher education through workforce development, lifelong learning, and continuing education programs. Previously, she served as the coordinator of Strategy, Assessment, and DEI at Miami University Libraries. During her time at Miami, she served as co-chair of both the libraries' DEI Committee and the development of the *Libraries' Commitment to Inclusive Excellence*.

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Russell Michalak, MLIS, is the director of the library and archives at Goldey-Beacom College. With over twenty years of experience across special and academic libraries and fifteen years in library administration, he authors the PosIT column in the *Journal of Library Administration* and frequently publishes and presents on AI, library leadership, and organizational culture. His books include *Onboarding 2.0: Methods of Designing and Deploying Effective Onboarding Training for Academic Libraries* (with Monica Rysavy) and *Toxic Dynamics: Disrupting, Dismantling, and Transforming Academic Library Culture* (with Trevor A. Dawes and Jon Cawthorne). His forthcoming edited volumes include *AI in Academic Libraries* (ACRL Press, with Karim Boughida) and *Organizational Learning, Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion in Academic Libraries* (with Maisha Carey). Michalak holds an MLIS from the University of Wisconsin-Madison and a bachelor's degree from Occidental College.

Meghan Musolff is the director of strategic planning at the University of Michigan Library. In this role, she provides leadership for all aspects of strategic planning, including the identification of areas in need of strategic attention, exploring ways to address these needs, and partnering with others in planning, implementation, and evaluation of library-wide change initiatives. Meghan is committed to fostering healthy planning practices at the library and provides guidance to colleagues in areas such as project management, systems thinking, change management, process design, and inclusive meeting facilitation. She received her MLIS from Dominican University and her MA in art history from Michigan State University.

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intersectionality and women of color in LIS, student research behavior, and feminist pedagogy in information literacy instruction. She was a 2013 ALA Emerging Leader, a participant in the 2014 Minnesota Institute for Early Career Librarians, the recipient of the 2018 JCLC Rising Star award for APALA, and in 2019 she received the ACRL WGSS Significant Achievement Award for her work on the book, *Pushing the Margins: Women of Color and Intersectionality in LIS*. She is also the immediate past president of the Asian Pacific American Librarian Association (APALA) and an ARL LCDP Fellow (2024–2025).

Mark A. Puente is associate professor and associate dean for organizational development at the Purdue University Libraries and School of Information Studies, leading the formation and implementation of an organizational development strategy designed through an equity lens. He previously served as the senior director of Diversity and Leadership Programs at the Association of Research Libraries (ARL). He has a broad range and depth of experience designing and managing programs focused on diversity recruitment and retention within libraries and archives, assessing and improving organizational climate, leadership development, racial equity, and numerous other topics. He has served on the faculty or on advisory groups to numerous leadership development programs such as the Association of Academic Health Sciences Libraries' Leadership Fellows Program and the Leading Change Institute. Puente is currently the co-director of the UCLA Senior Fellows Program. He is a graduate of the Knowledge River Program at the University of Arizona's iSchool and a former American Library Association (ALA) Spectrum Scholar.

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Elizabeth L. Wallis is professor and associate dean of University Libraries at Oakland University in Rochester, MI. She co-edited (as Elizabeth W. Kraemer) the book *Reconnecting Reading and Writing* (Parlor Press, 2013), and her scholarship has appeared in *The Journal of Academic Librarianship*, *The Reference Librarian*, and *College & Research Libraries*, among others. In addition to leading the libraries' Inclusion, Diversity, Equity, and Accessibility Committee, Wallis serves on the university's DEI Council. A citizen of the Cherokee Nation, she is currently co-chair of Oakland University's Native American Advisory Committee and advisor of the university's Native American Student Organization.

Mea Warren is the assistant head of Teaching and Learning at the University of Houston Libraries. She has been at the University of Houston since 2015, where she began her professional career as the natural sciences and mathematics librarian. Her scholarly work has focused on library outreach initiatives and planning, navigating promotion, and management of a new department.

Jeff Witt (he/him) currently serves the University of Michigan Library as the director of Organizational Development and has been with the UM Library since 2015. He has also served the UM Library as an interim director of HR and as a diversity and equity specialist. Beginning in 2024, Jeff has also taken on a part-time assistant ombuds role in the UM Staff Ombuds Office. He has earned two master's degrees—an MBA and a master of education—and has spent his twenty-five-plus-year career in higher education. Past positions have included assistant dean of students and assistant director of the Office of Equity & Diversity. Jeff is a lifelong learner and strives to continue growing in areas of particular interest and exploration, including leadership development, inclusive organizational strategy, anti-racism and allyship, LGBTQ issues, and disability issues.

Courtney L. Young is the university librarian at Colgate University. She has worked at four academic libraries with reference services and professional development at the heart of her work. She is passionate about the library and information science profession and has been fortunate enough to exclusively work in libraries. Courtney is a past president of the American Library Association and is looking forward to her next vacation in the Caribbean.